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UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA

Los Angeles

The Origin and Function of Female Divinity in Pre-Christian Germanic Europe

A dissertation submitted in partial satisfaction of the requirements for the degree Doctor of Philosophy in Indo-European Studies

by

Mary Lynn Wilson

1999

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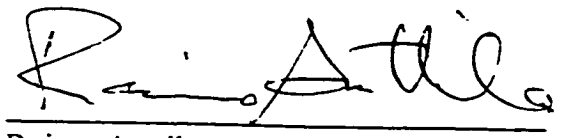
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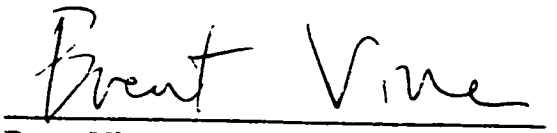
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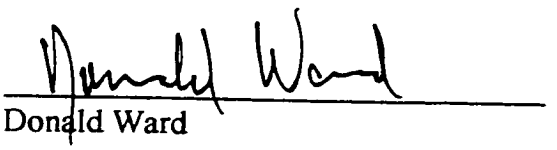
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To My Parents

Roselynn Faye Logsdon Wilson

and

Donald Bruce Wilson

For Their

Love

Support

and

Trust

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ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

I would like to thank my committee for their time and trouble. I would especially like to thank Dr. Raimo Anttila and Dr. Brent Vine for their detailed comments. I want to acknowledge the contributions of Maria Gimbutas. I appreciate the few years in which I was under her guidance. I also must thank Dr. Karlene Bley-Jones for reading my dissertation and offering extensive comments. Although all of these people contributed to the finished product, any errors are mine alone.

I want to thank the following people for their moral support: the entire staff of the Circulation Department of the University Research Library at UCLA, Sandy Beach, Willa Dallas, Richard and Suzanne Dickinson, Dr. Paul and Joyce Eyles, Naomi Morikawa, Mary Elaine Peirce, Nicholas Alexander Soloschenko, and Dr. John E. Thomson. I especially want to thank my parents, Roselynn Faye Logsdon Wilson and Donald Bruce Wilson, and my brother, Marshall Floyd Wilson, for their unconditional love and support in all of my endeavors.

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Wilson, Mary Lynn (May 1995). Winter and Death in Germanic Religion. Paper presented at the Seventh Annual UCLA Indo-European Conference, Los Angeles, California.

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ABSTRACT OF THE DISSERTATION

The Origin and Function

of Female Divinity

in Pre-Christian Germanic Europe

by

Mary Lynn Wilson

Doctor of Philosophy in Indo-European Studies

University of California, Los Angeles, 1999

Professor Christopher M. Stevens, Chair

Due to the scarcity of individual sources, the best approach to the questions of the origin and functions of female figures in pre-Christian Germanic is to use interdisciplinary sources. This approach helps fill in the gaps left when only one or two lines of inquiry are used.

When female figures of Germanic myth and folklore are examined and compared with one another, similar patterns of characteristics and functions appear. One of the most prevalent functions of these figures is related to death and the dead. Almost all of the figures seem to have some connection with death. Many of these figures can assume the shape of a bird or can fly through the air. These bird-like

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figures often have a close association with death or the dead.

Another important function of these figures is fertility and prosperity. The same figure that has connections with death will often have connections with fertility and prosperity. Several of these figures have functions relating to protection and the ancestors. Some of these figures have the ability to foretell the future. Some are associated with winter, and others are associated with the sun.

At least three possibilities exist for the origin of these female figures. They could be Indo-European, Old European, or influence from Celtic belief. Some of the aspects of these figures are clearly Old European and others are clearly Indo-European. The Celts were influenced by the same cultures, and their influence on the Germanic tribes only strengthened the influence of Old European and Indo-European cultures.

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I. INTRODUCTION

The names of Óðinn and Þór are familiar to most people even if they have never read any Scandinavian mythology. Many people are at least superficially aware of some of the traits and exploits of these gods. Students of religion, myth, folklore, history, or archaeology are probably also familiar with the other Norse male deities such as Loki, Týr, and Baldr. The adventurous, humorous, and tragic tales in which these deities participate embody the majority of Norse myth.

The female counterparts of these Norse male deities are often unknown to the casual reader. Females, in general, play little or no part in known Norse myth. When they do appear, they are often treated as booty or objects of desire. They take no real part in the action of the myths. Unlike the portrayals of Óðinn and Þór, who have complex personalities and whose strengths and weaknesses are exploited in the myths, the female deities appear flat and one dimensional.

There are several reasons for the lack of individuality of the Norse female deities. One of the most important factors is the source of the myths. The myths were mostly preserved by twelfth and thirteenth century scholars and monks, who wanted to preserve the heritage of their ancestors. These scholars and monks were naturally male and preserved traditions that seemed important to them. The stories

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about the male deities were probably more exciting and interesting to these male readers than stories that dealt with the goddesses.

Unfortunately, the problem of the preservation of female myths also can be traced back to an even earlier period. Many of the myths written down in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries were prose or poetic adaptations of earlier skaldic poetry. Skaldic poetry was popular at the courts of Scandinavian kings and noblemen from at least the ninth to thirteenth centuries. These poets composed poems based on the exploits of the resident nobleman and his band of warriors, and they entertained the warriors with stories of past greatness.

On cold winter evenings in medieval Norway, twenty or thirty men would sit around drinking and listening to the resident poet for entertainment. Which stories did the poet recite? He pleased his audience and related poems of past battles and exploits of the gods where bloodshed, humor, and gratuitous sex are the prevalent scenes. These are not the kind of stories where the female deities are going to appear to their best advantage.

Since the female deities play such a minute role in Norse mythology, they have received less attention and study than the male deities. The volumes of research, interpretation, comparison, and debate about the male deities is vast in comparison to what has been written about the female deities. Studies of the female Germanic deities are often an accompanying chapter or two in a work devoted to the

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Germanic gods. Scholars who did attempt to study the female deities often concentrated on one or perhaps two aspects of the evidence.

In this study, I take an interdisciplinary approach to the study of pre-Christian Germanic female deities, their functions, and their origins. I use historical, mythological, archaeological, linguistic, and folklore sources. I attempt to use the knowledge of several disciplines to formulate a coherent picture of the basic functions of pre-Christian female deities in Germanic area.

Definitions

In this study, I use the terms "deity" and "divinity" regularly. What I mean when I use these words are beings that have power over their environment, have the ability to transform themselves, have the ability to give or to take life, have the power to resurrect life, or any combination of these characteristics.

I use the term "Germanic" in this study. The word "Germanic" is generally a linguistic term meaning a language descended from Proto-Germanic; for example, English, German, Dutch, Icelandic, Swedish, Norwegian, or Danish. I use the word to designate the area in Europe where Germanic languages were and are spoken except for England. In other words, Continental and Scandinavian Europe where one of the Germanic languages is spoken today or was spoken in the past. This would encompass modern Iceland, Sweden, Norway, Denmark, Holland, Germany,

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Austria, parts of Switzerland, parts of France, parts of Belgium, parts of Poland, parts of the Czech Republic, and parts of Slovenia.

Time Depth

When were pre-Christian Germanic female deities actively worshiped? Since Germanic is a linguistic term denoting the language spoken, there is a built in time depth. The low end of the time depth has to be the accepted emergence of the Germanic languages from Proto-Indo-European. The consonant shifts that delineate Germanic from Proto-Indo-European have been linguistically dated to about 500 B.C.E. Any attempt to identify a culture as Germanic further back in time is useless because by definition, it then becomes a Proto-Indo-European culture. Historic and linguistic evidence makes it possible to estimate the emergence of the Proto-Germanic language to the Jastorf and Harpstedt cultures of the Iron Age.[1] This makes the safest lower date for the time depth roughly 500 B.C.E.

The upper date of the time depth is controlled by the pre-Christian aspect of the title. The problem is that different parts of Europe were converted to Christianity at different times and to different extents. Most of Germanic Continental Europe was Christianized by 800 C.E., and most of Germanic

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[1]J.P. Mallory, *In Search of the Indo-Europeans: Language, Archaeology and Myth* (New York: Thames and Hudson, 1991), pp. 86-87.

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Scandinavia was Christianized by 1200 C.E. I have purposely chosen late dates because the entire population did not accept Christianity totally and immediately.

The time depth for the worship of pre-Christian Germanic divinities is then 500 B.C.E. to between 800 or 1200 C.E. This is an expanse of at least 1300 years. There is no question that there was considerable variation of worship and religion during these 1300 years. If the area of Germanic culture at its height is considered to be all of Northwest Continental Europe and most of Central Europe, the expanse of area is vast. No one will ever be able to state the exact functions of deities covering hundreds of miles and 1300 years. It is an impossible task.

My objective is not to state that on Tuesday on the Jutland peninsula in 300 B.C.E. that such and such a ritual took place and such and such a goddess had certain exact powers and significance. My objective is to locate those features associated with Germanic female power that transcend individual settlements and chronological boundaries. What features appear to be constant or periodically reemerge in this area and time frame.

Since my goal is to locate continuity of belief, I use sources for comparison that pre and post date 500 B.C.E. and 1200 C.E. I have used archaeological data from the Neolithic and Bronze Age from the Germanic and adjoining areas of Europe. I think that the Neolithic material is relevant. Although the culture and language of the Germanic peoples were Indo-European, much of the substrate

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culture survived and flourished as a hybridized version of both Indo-European and substrate cultures especially in the remote corners of Europe.[2] I use archaeological data from areas adjoining the Germanic Area because the survival of artifacts and settlements or our ability to find them is lacking in the Germanic area during the Neolithic. Very little has survived. The main reason for the lack of evidence is probably that the culture utilized one of the most abundant natural resources available in this region: wood. Figurines, funerary paraphernalia, and everyday household goods made out of wood would normally perish within only a few generations. Other cultural areas adjacent to the Germanic Area; for example, Eastern Europe used clay, stone, and bone as their main material goods and much more has survived.

On the other end of the time continuum, I use folklore collected in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. Why do I consider it useful to compare nineteenth century oral tradition with beliefs from at least 800 C.E.? This is a time span of 1100 years. If the lower end of the time depth of 500 B.C.E. is used for comparison then the span is 2400 years. Folklore, for all of its universal motifs or perhaps because of its universal appeal and motifs, contains elements of ancient

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[2]See linguistic discussion in Edgar C. Polomé, "The Non-Indo-European Component of the Germanic Lexicon," in *o-o-pe-ro-si: Festschrift für Ernst Risch zum 75. Geburtstag*, Annemarie Etter (ed). (New York: Walter de Gruyter, 1986), pp. 661-671; and "The Indo-Europeanization of Northern Europe: The Linguistic Evidence," *The Journal of Indo-European Studies* 18 (1990) : 331-338.

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belief.[3] This is not to say that all folklore is ancient or that it is still in its pure ancient form. I am only suggesting that some elements of folktales and legends are very ancient. These ancient elements can be discerned when compared to other sources of information that contain the same elements. If one element appears in the myth of the culture, the figurines of a culture, and the later folklore of the culture; then there is probably some continuity of belief. Since I am looking for continuity of belief over time, I believe that not using comparative material from the Neolithic and folklore from the modern era would greatly deplete the store of knowledge at our disposal and would impose unreasonable restrictions on the study of proto-culture.

Interdisciplinary Approach

Mythology. The foundation of this study is the mythology of Scandinavia. Scandinavia was Christianized at a much later date than the rest of Germanic Europe. This means that in some areas pagan beliefs continued until writing was introduced to the area. Unfortunately, the surviving manuscripts of Scandinavian myth were not written down until the myths were in the process of being forgotten by the majority of the population. They were written down to preserve a dead

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[3]J.A. MacCulloch, "Folk-Memory in Folk-Tales," *Folklore* 60 (1949): 307-315.

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heritage. We only have a small fraction of the material preserved of what must have been a vital and living religion at one time.

The most famous preserver of Norse myth is Snorri Sturluson (1179-1241). He was an Icelander who had been fostered by Jón Loptsson, who at that time was the most powerful and one of the most learned men in Iceland. The estate at Oddi, where Snorri grew up, was a center of learning and was the place where one came to gain a knowledge of law, history, skaldship, and Latin. As an adult, Snorri became one of the most powerful and learned men of his generation.

Snorri Sturluson wrote what is commonly referred to as the *Prose Edda*. The *Prose Edda* actually consists of three major parts: the *Gylfaginning*, the *Skáldskaparmál*, and the *Háttatal*. The *Gylfaginning* tells many myths in a question and answer format. The *Skáldskaparmál* tells many myths by explaining why things are named as they are. The *Háttatal* is a poem about King Hákon and Earl Skúli Barðarson. I use the *Gylfaginning* and the *Skáldskaparmál* extensively in this study.

Snorri also wrote *Heimskringla*, which is the history of the kings of Norway. The first section of this work is called *Ynglinga saga* and consists of euhemerized myth. The gods become kings and chieftains fighting each other and others. This section also contains interesting mythological material that I have used. The *Prose Edda* and *Heimskringla* are trusted sources for Norse myth partially because Snorri

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had access to more ancient sources and partially because variants of some of the same myths are known from the *Poetic Edda* and the *Gesta Danorum.*

The *Poetic* or *Elder Edda* is an anthology of Norse mythological and heroic poetry and is actually compiled from two main manuscripts: the *Codex Regius* and the *Arnamagnaean Codex.* The *Codex Regius* contains 29 poems, and the *Arnamagnaean Codex* contains 6 poems. Most of the *Arnamagnaean Codex* corroborates poems in the *Codex Regius.* Both manuscripts are probably derived from one or more thirteenth century Icelandic manuscripts.[4] The *Codex Regius* is thought to have been written down about 1270, and the *Arnamagnaean Codex* is thought to have been written down in the fourteenth century. The majority of the poems were probably composed in the tenth century, but the poems were composed by different poets, at different times, and at different locations. Since some of the poems are retold in other sources, the basic traditions in the *Poetic Edda* are considered to be a good reflection of traditions in tenth century Scandinavia.

The *Gesta Danorum* is the history of the Danes written by Saxo Grammaticus. Saxo was a Christian monk writing in Latin between 1208 and 1220 C.E. In his introduction, Saxo states that he used ancient poems, inscriptions, and historical material collected by Icelandic scholars as his sources. The first nine

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[4]E.O.G. Turville-Petre, *Myth and Religion of the North: The Religion of Ancient Scandinavia*, (Westport, Connecticut: Greenwood Press, 1975), p. 12.

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books of the history seem to be a compendium of myth, legend, and religious practice. Saxo often presents variant versions of myths from the *Prose* and *Poetic Eddas* as history.

Since many of the myths are retold in the *Prose Edda*, the *Poetic Edda*, *Heimskringla*, and the *Gesta Danorum*; the reliability of these sources is on fairly solid ground. From the hints of other stories that are untold in these sources, we know that there was much more information that was not preserved. It must be remembered that all of our sources are late and have been contaminated with Christianity on some level. Both Snorri Sturluson and Saxo Grammaticus were Christians. The *Poetic Edda* was not recorded in its final form until long after Iceland was Christianized. When using these sources it is also necessary to remember that the traditions preserved are from approximately the same time period. The rituals, beliefs, and customs of Norse religion probably differed significantly from one area or village to another and from one century to the next.

Another primary source of Norse myth is the Icelandic Sagas. There are approximately 700 Icelandic Sagas, so it is difficult to talk about the Icelandic Sagas as one homogeneous group. The genre has many different styles and types. Some sagas are historical about saints, kings, and other great men; some are about ordinary people caught up in inter-family feuds; and others are fantastic and have a folkloric quality about them.

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The sagas were mainly written down in the thirteenth century by known and unknown authors. There has always been debate over the validity of the information in the sagas. Most of them take place in the tenth and eleventh centuries during the first few generations of settlement. The sagas seem to contain the religious beliefs and attitudes of the tenth century; however, it is often difficult to tell what is a genuinely ancient tradition and what is literary license by the author. When using the sagas as evidence of prehistoric beliefs and practices, it is important to remember that they are literary creations. Not everything in a saga happened; however, the trappings and backdrop to the main action of the story had to be believable to the audiences of the time and to later audiences. While the main action or side story in a saga might be fiction, the religious ritual and beliefs presented in the sagas are probably close enough to the actual ritual and beliefs; so people only a generation or two removed from these practices would find them believable within the context of the story. In other words, there must be some truth in the beliefs presented in the sagas; but as always caution is necessary.

History. Our knowledge of the Germanic tribes and their beliefs is dependent on contemporary Classical authors. While the Greeks and Romans, who wrote about the Germans did not speak their language and did not use modern ethnographic and anthropologic techniques to gather information, they did often

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know people who had been in contact with the Germans or had access to other written sources that have now been lost to us.

Tacitus is the most famous and useful Classical author who discusses Germanic culture and belief. Tacitus's most important works for studying the Germanic tribes are the *Germania*, the *Annals*, and the *Histories*. Tacitus was a Roman writer and historian who lived between 55 C.E. and 120 C.E. although the specific dates remain uncertain. He was not only a writer but also a senator, consul, and governor. Due to his political and familial connections, Tacitus probably learned a lot about the region of Germania and the people who lived there through second-hand accounts of friends and colleagues.

The *Germania* is basically an ethnography of Northern and Central Europe. Tacitus's purpose in writing the *Germania* is unknown, but he seems to be contrasting the decadence and decay of the Romans with the moral fortitude and vigor of the Germans. Since Tacitus appears to have a hidden agenda, everything he says about the Germans must be impartially analyzed. Is he stating a fact, or is he trying to make a point about the Roman way of life, or both? Some scholars have speculated about the validity of the *Germania*; however, several of Tacitus's statements have recently been backed up with archaeological evidence. For instance, in chapter 38 of the *Germania* Tacitus states that the Suevians twisted their hair back and tied it in a knot. In 1948, a head was found of a man with his hair

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twisted and tied in a knot on the side of his head.[5] Tacitus's information in this instance was proved correct through archaeological evidence.

The *Annals* tell of the events that took place between 14 C.E. to 68 C.E. This period covers from the death of Augustus to the death of Nero. The *Histories* tell of the events from 68 C.E. to 96 C.E. This was a very momentous time for the Roman Empire. While Tacitus is not concentrating on the Germans in these works, information about them is told while he is describing the events, wars, and civil strife of the period.

Other Classical authors who I use in this study are only mentioned once or twice. They include Plutarch, Suetonius, Julius Caesar, and Ptolemy. Plutarch and Suetonius both wrote biographies of Roman Emperors. Some mention is made in passing about Germanic culture by both of these authors. Both were very learned men and both had access either to people who knew of the events first hand or to historic archives. Julius Caesar wrote about his Gallic Wars partly for publicity; however, he did encounter some Germanic peoples especially in the Rhine area. Although he was trying to make a name for himself as a general, he had no reason to falsify the small amount of ethnographic data in his book. Ptolemy was a

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[5]P.V. Glob, *The Bog People: Iron-Age Man Preserved,* trans. Rupert Bruce-Mitford (Ithaca, New York: Cornell University Press, 1969), p. 117, see figure 41.

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geographer and attempted to make a map of Europe. In the process, he describes the placement of different Germanic tribes.

Native Histories. During the Middle Ages, many of the Germanic peoples wanted to preserve their history. These histories were all written by Christian churchmen who attempted to chronicle contemporary historical events, events of the previous few generations, and the ancient past. These works were written in Latin, and their purpose was to preserve the history of the people.

Gregory of Tours wrote the *Historia Francorum* in the sixth century C.E. The *Historia Francorum* tells the history of the Franks from biblical times to 591 C.E. Since Gregory was the bishop of Tours from 573 C.E. and his family was very prominent in politics and in the church, his history of contemporary events is considered to be very reliable. He was an eyewitness to many of the events that he relates from at least 575, and sometimes he was a major participant. Since he talks about the ordinary people of Tours, the happenings, and gossip; the Historia Francorum presents the beliefs of sixth century Franks.

Other important native historians are Jordanes and Paul the Deacon. Jordanes wrote the *Getica de origine, actibusque Getarum* detailing the history of the Goths and Paul the Deacon wrote the *Historia Langobardorum* detailing the history of the Lombards. Both contain native folklore about the prehistoric period of the peoples.

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Linguistics. I use linguistic sources throughout this study. By linguistic sources, I mean that I attempt to reconstruct the meaning of the names of several goddesses to shed light on their function. The meaning of a word can be reconstructed by working backwards into time to find the Indo-European root of the word. Once the root is found, then the linguist can look for modern or early modern equivalents of the same root. The known meanings of the modern words are then gathered. These words tend to have a basic concept in common although their modern meanings might sometimes seem to be quite divergent. When applied to names of goddesses, the common concept among a group of words might explain a basic function or association that a particular goddess had.

The process is based on demonstrated sound rules and has been an academically accepted form of research for at least the last 150 years. The discovery of the existence of the Indo-European language family is generally credited to Sir William Jones in 1796. Jones was an educated English gentleman who was well acquainted with both Latin and Greek. While living in India, he decided to learn Sanskrit, which is the ancient language of India. Jones noted that the roots of the verbs and the grammatical construction of Latin, Greek, and Sanskrit were very similar. He hypothesized that Greek, Latin, Gothic, Celtic, and Old Persian might have had the same origin as Sanskrit. This insight was greatly expanded upon by scholars in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries.

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The different branches of Indo-European were identified as Greek, Armenian, Indo-Iranian, Balto-Slavic, Germanic, Italic, Celtic, Albanian, Tocharian, and Anatolian. Each section of the language family was studied individually and for how it fit into the Indo-European Family. What isoglosses different languages shared and how one sound in one language always reflected another sound in another language. Lists of words that were related in different languages were complied and different theories of reconstruction were put forth. Correspondences between different languages were noted and used to reconstruct Proto-Indo-European roots. Proto-Indo-European is a reconstructed language that hypothetically would be similar to the language spoken by the Indo-European peoples before they migrated out of their homeland; eventually lost contact with each other; and over time, formed their own languages on their shared linguistic inheritance. Since Proto-Indo-European roots are not attested anywhere in the written record, they are always preceded by an asterisk to signify that the form is hypothetical. An example of the similarity between words in different Indo-European languages can be found in Table 1.

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TABLE 1

INDO-EUROPEAN CORRESPONDENCES

PIE	Greek	Latin	Gothic	O Irish	Sanskrit	English
*oinos		ūnus	ains	oin		one
*duwō	δύω	duo	twai		d(u)vā	two
*treyes	τρεῖς	trēs	þreis	tri	trayas	three
*k^{w}etwores	τέτταρες	quattuor	fidwōr	ceth(a)ir	čatvāras	four
*penk^{w}e	πέντε	quīnque	fimf		pañča	five

Source: Adapted from Oswald J.L. Szemerényi, *Introduction to Indo-European Linguistics* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1996), p. 222.

Table 1 shows that the same basic word with minute changes can be seen across the spectrum of Indo-European language. The correspondences between these languages have been basically worked out and agreed upon by scholars so that reconstruction of the Proto-Indo-European root is almost like working out a mathematical equation.

Regular and accepted correspondences from Proto-Indo-European and Proto-Germanic, the hypothetical language spoken before the break up and dispersal of the Germanic tribes, Old High German, and Common Scandinavian have been used for the reconstructions in this study. Any deviations from accepted correspondences are noted. The handbooks that I mostly referred to while attempting linguistic

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reconstruction are *Introduction to Indo-European Linguistics* by Oswald Szemerényi, *A History of the German Language* by John Waterman, *Althochdeutsche Grammatik* by Wilhelm Braune, *The American Heritage Dictionary of Indo-European Roots* edited by Calvert Watkins, *An Introduction to Old Norse* by E.V. Gordon, *Indogermanisches Etymologisches Wörterbuch* by Julius Pokorny, *The Scandinavian Languages: An Introduction to Their History* by Einar Haugen, *Introduction to the Scandinavian Languages* by M. O'C. Walshe, and *Altnordisches Etymologisches Wörterbuch* by Jan de Vries.

Archaeology. The archaeological sources that I use in this study are figurines and rock engravings from the Bronze and Iron Ages from the Germanic Area; figurines, drawings, and funerary artifacts from the Neolithic and the Bronze Ages from the areas adjacent to the Germanic Area; information regarding the deposition and death of the bog bodies of Northwestern Europe; and the matronae statuary from the first and second centuries C.E. from Roman occupied Europe.

The reason that I incorporate archaeological sources in this study is to supplement the written and linguistic data with real artifacts that people living in the past actually touched, cherished, worshiped, and constructed. In the case of the bog bodies, the people themselves can be studied minutely for appearance, cause of death, and diet.

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Folklore. In this study, I use sources from Germanic legends and fairy tales. Legends and fairy tales are very different types of folklore. Legends tell a story about an unusual event or person. The action of the story takes place at a specific time and place. The time, place, and people involved are usually mentioned by name. The fairy tale takes place at an unknown time: "once" and at an unknown place: "a kingdom far, far away." The people are rarely given proper names and are called "the princess" or "the prince." Fairy tales are more anonymous than legends. This lends them to all kinds of interpretation.

I mainly use fairy tales and legends to show a continuity of belief from ancient times to the modern era. The fairy tales I use are from the Brothers Grimm nineteenth century collection of *Kinder und Haus Märchen.* I mainly use"Fletcher's Fowl," "The Drummer," "The White Bride and the Black Bride," and "The Little Men in the Woods." Fairy tales are notoriously difficult to interpret because the same motif can be used across a wide area with few or many changes. It is impossible to point to the oldest, most original version of a tale. Another problem is that different versions influence each other in a myriad of ways.

I hope to avoid these problems. I am not looking for the oldest variant of any of these tales. I also do not care about how different versions have influenced these tales. What is important to me is that elements of the fairy tales can be found in

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myth. I use fairy tales to collaborate with other evidence not to base a theory on them.

The primary sources used in this study are interdisciplinary and date from different time periods. If plotted on a time line as in Table 2, the sources for this study span approximately 7000 years. The diversity of disciplines and time periods graphically illustrates that any conclusions drawn from this study indicate a continuity of belief over time.

Secondary Sources

In this study, I have attempted to use mainly primary source to remain faithful to the source material. The secondary sources which I have used have shaped my view of Germanic religion in various ways and to different extents.

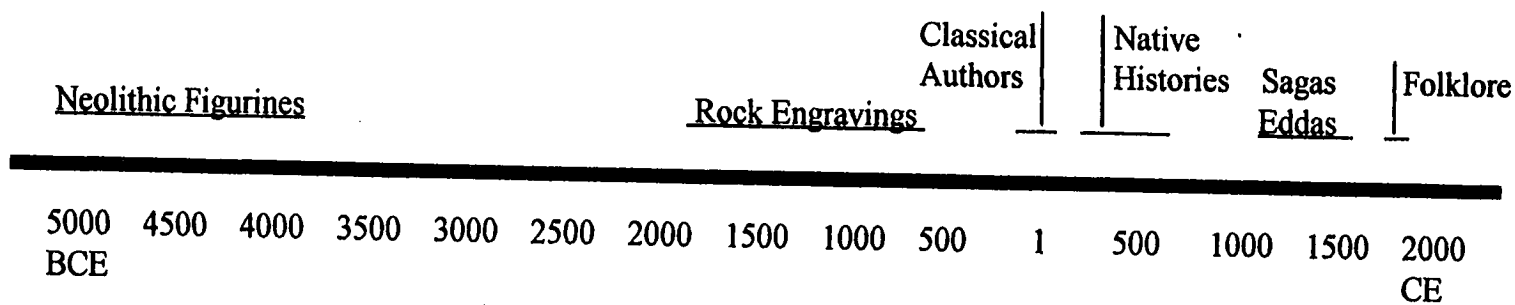
Jacob and Wilhelm Grimm. Jacob and Wilhelm Grimm were the great nineteenth century collectors of folklore and legends. Jacob is known for his contributions to comparative linguistics and for his four volume *Deutsche Mythologie.* In this study, I mainly use their Kinder und Haus Märchen and their collection of German legends. Since the Grimms did not use modern folklore

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TABLE 2

CHRONOLOGY OF SOURCE MATERIAL



Source: Primary

collection methodology, there is some controversy over the sources of the collection.[6] The main concern is if the collection actually reflects the stories of the German peasantry or the stories of the well-educated middle class. Since I only use these stories to show continuity of belief over time, I feel that using these collections is appropriate.

Viktor Waschnitius. In the first decade of the twentieth century, Waschnitius collected all of the available material about the Perhte/Holle figure. He collected material from all over continental Germanic Europe. He organized the material into dialect areas. This organization allows the material from a given area to be studied and the material from different and distant dialect areas to be compared. In the chapter on the Perhte/Holle figure, I use the material in Waschnitius's collection extensively.

Hilda Ellis Davidson. Hilda Ellis Davidson is a prolific scholar of Scandinavian Religion. Davidson's work mainly concentrates on the Norse myths found in the Eddas, the Sagas, and Saxo Grammaticus. She is interested in the Norse pantheon as a whole, and only a portion of each book concentrates on female divinity. Her more recent works have used some archaeological material to support her theories. Davidson's major concern is the Scandinavian material and comparison

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[6]Linda Dégh, "Grimm's Household Tales and Its Place in the Household: The Social Relevance of a controversial Classic," *Western Folklore* 38 (1979), pp. 83-103.

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between Scandinavian and Celtic belief. Her works, which have influenced me the most, are *The Road to Hel, Gods and Myths of Northern Europe*, *The Lost Beliefs of Northern Europe*, and *Myths and Symbols in Pagan Europe*.

E.O.G. Turville-Petre. Turville-Petre's work consists of a close reading of the primary sources and comparison of different variants and traditions. His scholarship is almost solely based on Scandinavian mythology. He uses almost no archaeology or linguistics. His work is a good source for variant traditions and primary source material. I have mainly used his *Myth and Religion of the North*.

P.V. Glob. Glob's books *The Mound People* and *The Bog People* are based on the interpretation of Danish archaeological finds. Both books examine the mummified burial and "sacrificial" remains of people in the Bronze and Iron Age cultures of Denmark. He describes the deposition, clothing, artifacts, last meal, and cause of death of these people. From this information, he speculates on the meaning of the rituals involved using Scandinavian myths. I often agree with his conclusions and mostly use his work for the detailed information on the mummified remains.

Jan de Vries. In *Altgermanische Religionsgeschichte*, de Vries presents the ideas of previous scholars on all aspects of Germanic and Scandinavian religious practices. The scope of the work is huge, and it is a vast store house of theories and ideas. Only a portion of the whole work concentrates on female divinity, but he

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discusses archaeology, mythology, linguistics, and folklore. He rarely offers his own interpretation of the material, but one often can discern with which theory he agrees.

Lotte Motz. Motz deals with both Germanic and Scandinavian material. In the *Beauty and the Hag*, she concentrates on the Scandinavian mythic material although she does use some archaeology to support her theories. In the "Winter Goddess," she concentrates on interpreting the folklore material presented in the collection by Waschnitius. She works closely with the primary sources. While we work with the same sources, we often draw different conclusions.

Marija Gimbutas. Marija Gimbutas was an extremely prolific archaeologist and writer. I studied with Marija Gimbutas for two years, and many of her ideas and theories have influenced me. I have studied her theory of Indo-European invasions into Old Europe. I believe that her theories are the most convincing of any that I have read, and her theories best explain the archaeology, linguistics, and mythology of the Indo-Europeans. I use her works to extend the time depth of my study into the Neolithic to show continuity of belief.

Organization

This study is structured very simply. The second chapter discusses the goddess Nerthus, who is recorded in Tacitus. Within this chapter, I use archaeology, linguistics, and mythology to support Tacitus's statements about Nerthus. In the next

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two chapters, I examine the goddesses of Norse myth. I explain what the mythic material says about each deity, and I use archaeology, linguistics, and folklore to expand on the functions of the different goddesses. I also compare the goddesses to each other to see if any of them have related traits.

In chapter 5, I concentrate on the semi-divine beings of Norse myth: the Norns, Valkyries, and *Dísir*. Again, I set out the myths that each are involved in and use linguistics, literary sources, and folklore to confirm the general functions of these beings while comparing them to each other and the Norse goddesses. In chapter 6, I rely on the archaeological and linguistic evidence of the *matronae* statuary. The iconography associated with the *matronae* is interpreted and the functions of some of the *matronae* are reconstructed from their names.

In chapter 7, I rely on the folklore evidence of the Germanic figures of Frau Perhte and Frau Holle. These figures play an important role in the winter celebrations of Germany, Austria, and Switzerland. While most of the evidence is from folk tradition, I also use linguistics. I then compare the Perhte/Holle figure with the Norse goddesses. In the eighth chapter, I discuss all the evidence presented and summarize my findings and interpretations of the functions and characteristics of pre-Christian Germanic female beings. In chapter 9, I discuss the possible origins of these beings. I examine the archaeological record and search for their possible origins in Indo-European, Neolithic, and Celtic belief.

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II. NERTHUS

Tacitus

The most famous Germanic goddess is Nerthus. All the information that we know about her is from chapter 40 of Tacitus's *Germania*. In chapter 40, Tacitus names several tribes that existed in the Northwestern corner of Continental Europe. These tribes would have lived in modern day Denmark, Holland, and Schleswig-Holstein. He describes the annual journey and rites associated with the goddess Nerthus.

> nec quicquam notabile in singulis, nisi quod in commune Nerthum, id est Terram matrem, colunt eamque intervenire rebus hominum, invehi populis arbitrantur. Est in insula Oceani castum nemus, dicatumque in eo vehiculum, veste contectum; attingere uni sacerdoti concessum. is adesse penetrali deam intellegit vectamque bubus feminis multa cum veneratione prosequitur. laeti tunc dies, festa loca, quaecumque adventu hospitioque dignatur. non bella ineunt, non arma sumunt; clausum omne ferrum; pax et quies tunc tantum nota, tunc tantum amata, donec idem sacerdos satiatam conversatione mortalium deam templo reddat. mox vehiculum et vestis et, si credere velis, numen ipsum secreto lacu abluitur. servi ministrant, quos statim idem lacus haurit.[1]

> None of these tribes have any noteworthy feature, except their common worship of Nerth[us], or mother-Earth, and their belief that she interposes in human affairs, and visits the nations in her vehicle. In an island of the ocean there is a sacred grove, and within it a consecrated vehicle, covered over with a garment. Only one priest is permitted to touch it. He can perceive the presence of the goddess in this sacred

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[1]P. Cornelius Tacitus, *Germania*, interpreted, edited, and translated by Allan A. Lund (Heidelberg: Carl Winter, 1988), p. 100.

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> recess, and walks by her side with the utmost reverence as she is drawn along by heifers. It is a season of rejoicing, and festivity reigns wherever she deigns to go and be received. They do not go to battle or wear arms; every weapon is under lock; peace and quiet are known and welcomed only at these times, till the goddess weary of human intercourse, is at length restored by the same priest to her temple. Afterwards the vehicle, the vestments, and, if you believe it, the divinity herself, are purified in a secret lake. Slaves perform the rite, who are instantly swallowed up by its waters.[2]

This passage contains several statements that are important for the study of Nerthus: 1) several tribes worshiped Nerthus; 2) she had a sacred grove on an island in the ocean; 3) only one priest could perceive the presence of the goddess, and only he could travel with her and touch her; 4) she traveled around in a wagon; 5) a truce was declared during the sacred time of her journey, and this was a time of rejoicing; 6) the goddess and all of her accouterments were purified in water after her journey; and 7) all of her attendants were drowned after this rite. If each point is taken individually, the passage can be methodically analyzed for collaboration from other sources.

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[2]Tacitus, *The Complete Works of Tacitus*, trans. Alfred John Church and William Jackson Brodribb, ed. Moses Hadas, (New York: The Modern Library by Random House, 1942), p. 728.

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Several Tribes Worshiped Nerthus

Several tribes worship Nerthus. This statement is difficult to prove because of the absence of written records from the period; however, there is ample archaeological evidence that goddesses were worshiped in Northwestern Europe in the Bronze and Iron Ages. There is a gradual increase of the deposition of female objects throughout the Danish Bronze Age. According to Glob, at the beginning of the Bronze Age the finds consist almost totally of male objects. In the second part of the Bronze Age, male objects represent about 40% of the finds; and in the fifth and sixth periods only 25% and 10% respectively. By the end of the Bronze Age, female objects consist of 90% of the finds.[3] The popularity of goddess worship in the late Bronze Age can be seen in the proliferation of goddess figurines. Some of the best examples are from the Northwest corner of Europe where Tacitus places the center of Nerthus worship. I have provided a brief description of some of the best preserved goddess figurines in Northwestern Europe. Map 1 shows the site location of these goddess figurines.[4]

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[3]P.V. Glob, *The Bog People: Iron-Age Man Preserved*, trans. Rupert Bruce-Mitford, (Ithaca, New York: Cornell University Press, 1969 reprint ed. 1988) p. 157.

[4]The site location on the map of each figurine is designated by the number of the figure that protrays the figurine. For example, Figure 1 is 1 on the map.

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MAP 1

DISTRIBUTION OF BRONZE AND IRON AGE GODDESS FIGURINES
IN NORTHERN EUROPE



1. Fårdal, Denmark
2. Kaiserberg, Germany
3. Grevensvænge, Denmark
4. Fangel, Denmark
5. Viksø, Denmark
6. Not Shown
7. Nymbølle Foerlev, Denmark

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Figurines. Throughout the Bronze Age, there is a gradual increase of female oriented objects deposited in bogs. Since bogs and lakes were favorite places for sacrificial hoard depositions, it can be assumed that these objects were placed in the bog as tribute for one or many goddesses. The figurine found at Fårdal in Jutland, Denmark, wears a necklace and has large eyes that are overlaid with gold. The goddess is kneeling. Her left hand is on her right breast, and her right arm is raised with her hand curled as if it once gripped something. She wears a short, corded skirt like those recovered from the mound graves of the Danish Bronze Age. The corded skirt was basically a skirt that had one cord at the hem and one at the waist. Cords were loosely strung from the hem to the waist. The length of the skirts appear to be to about mid-thigh. (Figure 1)

At Kaiserberg in Holstein, Germany, a knife handle, which was shaped in the form of a goddess, was found. The figure is wearing only a corded skirt, necklace, and large earrings. The earrings are out of proportion with the rest of the figure. She is holding a small bowl in both hands as if offering it to someone. (Figure 2)

Most of the find from Grevensvænge in South Zealand, Denmark, was lost. Drawings of the figurines exist from the end of the eighteenth century. There were three goddess figures dressed only in corded skirts and necklaces. They were all bending backwards with their feet together and their hands touching the ground on

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FIGURE 1

FIGURINE FROM FÅRDAL IN JUTLAND, DENMARK



Source: Adapted from a photograph in P.V. Glob, *The Mound People: Danish Bronze-Age Man Preserved*, trans. Joan Bulman, (Ithaca, New York: Cornell University Press, 1974), See Figure 64.

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FIGURE 2

FIGURINE FROM KAISERBERG IN HOLSTEIN, GERMANY



Source: Adapted from a photograph in *The Mound People*. See Figure 65.

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either side of their heads. The posture of these figurines is similar to some of the figures in the rock drawings from Bohuslän, Sweden.[5] (Figure 3) Some of the Bohuslän rock drawings depict human figures back-flipping off or over ships.

From Fangel on Funen, Denmark, a goddess figurine was found deposited in a bog with a large number of female ornaments including neck rings, wrist rings, and a wheat sickle. The figurine is completely naked, wearing only a necklace and earrings. Her hands are on her breasts. (Figure 4) The goddess figurine found in a bog at Viksø, Denmark, is standing. There is an incision between her legs to emphasize her vulva. Her hands are placed on her chest under her breasts. She is naked except for a double necklace. (Figure 5)

All of the female figurines mentioned have bare breasts. Three figurines, the goddesses from Fårdal, Fangel, and Viksø, draw special attention to their breasts by touching one, both, or holding them from underneath. Most of the female figures wear a corded skirt or, in two cases, are completely naked. Evidence of various configurations of the corded skirt has been found throughout Europe and can still be seen as the aprons on folk costumes from Eastern Europe. Barber has convincingly argued that these corded skirts probably signaled that a girl was available, "still a virgin,

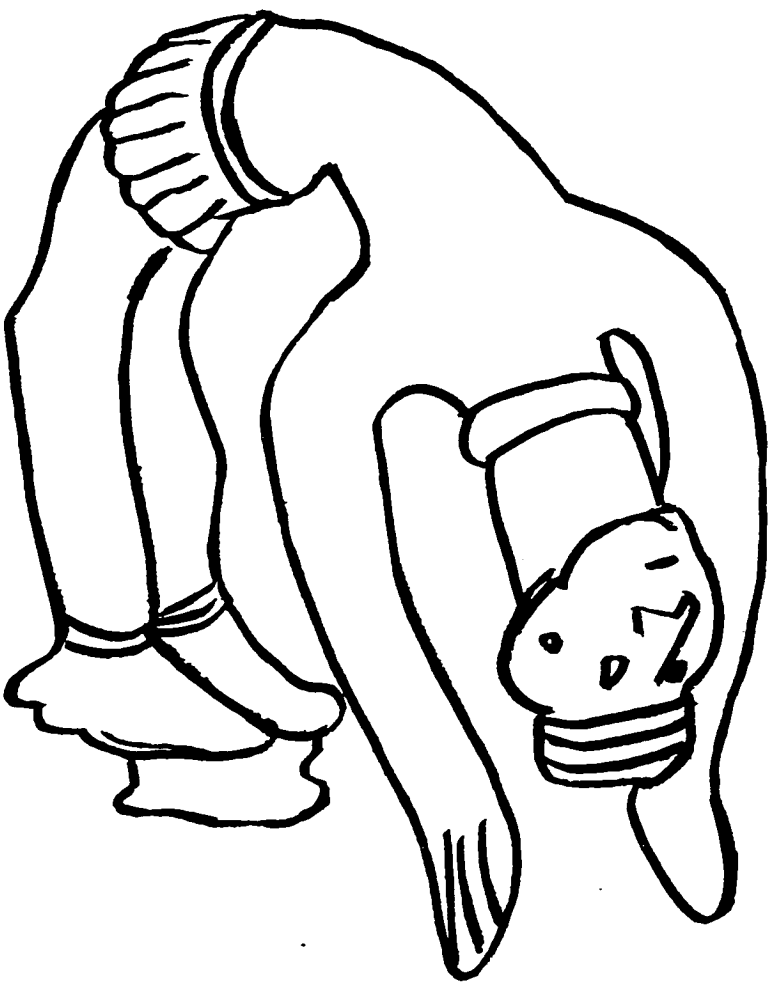
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[5]For illustration of rock drawings see Peter Gelling and Hilda Ellis Davidson, *The Chariot of the Sun and Other Rites and Symbols of the Northern Bronze Age*, (New York: Frederick A. Praeger, Publishers, 1969), See Figs. 20b,c,f,g.

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FIGURE 3

FIGURINE FROM GREVENSVÆNGE IN ZEALAND, DENMARK

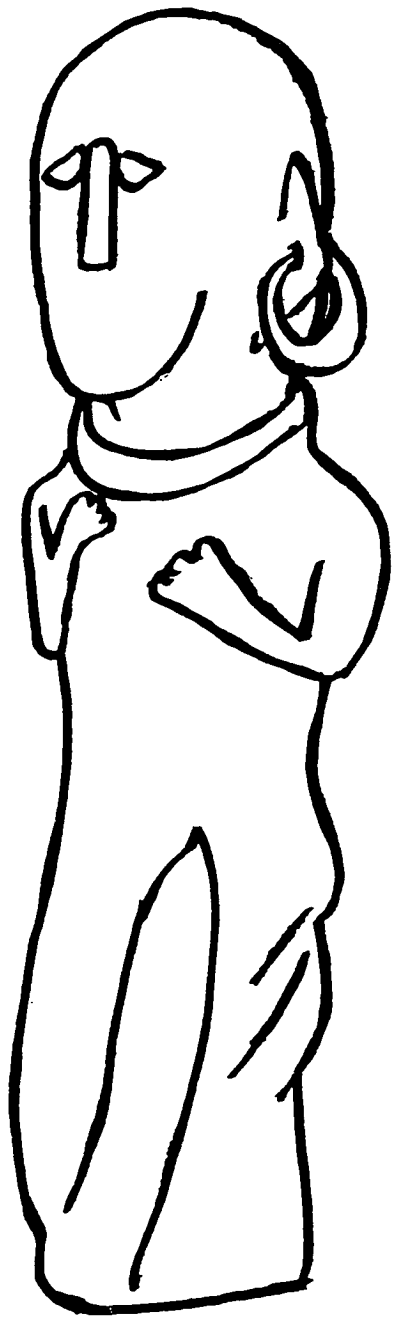


Source: Adapted from a photograph in *The Mound People*. See Figure 67.

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FIGURE 4

FIGURINE FROM FANGEL ON FUNEN IN DENMARK

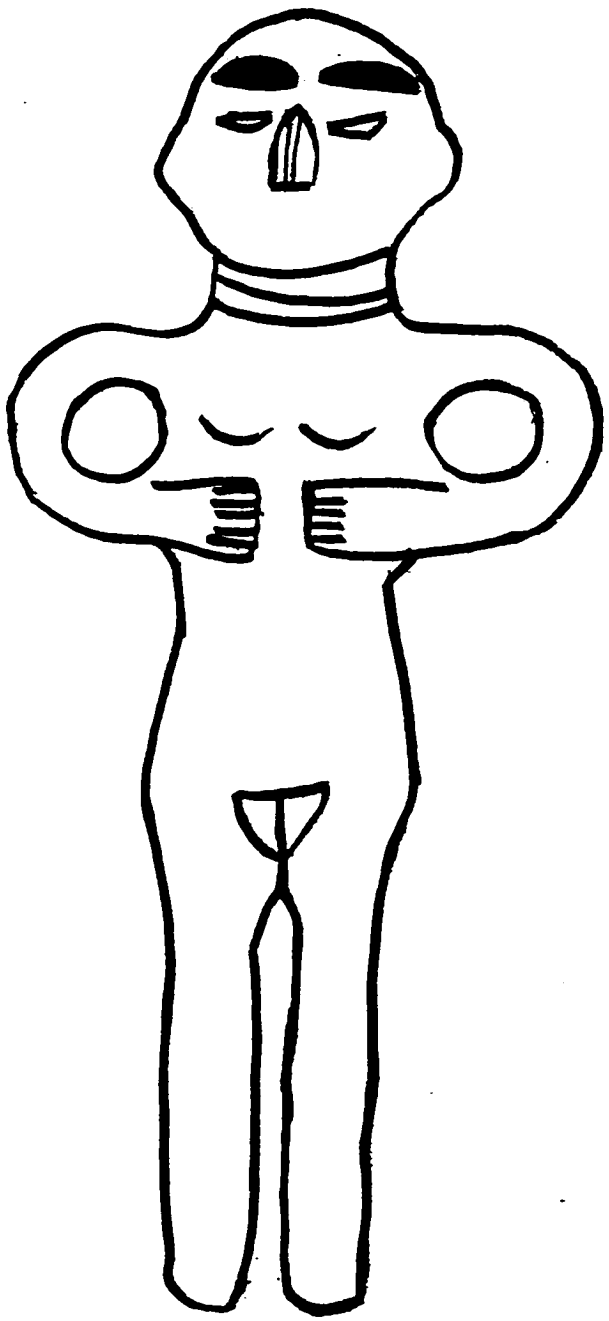


Source: Adapted from a photograph in *The Mound People*. See Figure 68.

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FIGURE 5

FIGURINE FROM VIKSØ IN DENMARK



Source: Adapted from a photograph in *The Bog People.* See Figures 52, 53.

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still without child, or still without a regular mate."[6] The naked figurines have their vulva emphasized by incisions. All of the female figurines discussed above wear a necklace. The goddess figurines of the Neolithic throughout Europe prominently wear a necklace.[7] Freyja, the Norse goddess known to us through the *Eddas*, is associated with the acquisition and wearing of a necklace. The attribute of a necklace appears to have been an insigne of divine female status. Many of the bogs where figurines were found contained hundreds of neck-rings that were probably dedicated to the goddess as offerings. The attribute of a necklace is not the only clue that these figurines represent goddesses. The kneeling position of some of these figurines has been called the "enthroned position", and the touching of breasts a characteristic of fertility deities.[8]

The female figurines recovered from the Northern Iron Age are cruder and more schematic than those of the Bronze Age. Amulets, which Glob suggests were worn as brooches, have been found across Denmark. The amulets consist of two main types.

---

[6]Elizabeth Wayland Barber, *Women's Work: The First 20,000 Years Women, Cloth, and Society in Early Times*, (New York, New York: W.W. Norton & Company, 1994), pp. 42-70.

[7]Marija Gimbutas, *The Civilization of the Goddess: The World of Old Europe*, (San Francisco: Harper Collins Publishers, 1991), p. 299.

[8]Gro Mandt, "Searching for Female Deities in the Religious Manifestations of the Scandinavian Bronze Age, in "*Words and Objects: Towards a Dialogue Between Archaeology and History of Religion*, ed. Gro Steinsland (Oslo: The Institute for Comparative Research in Human Culture, 1986), p. 116.

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Some have a small head, a long neck with a necklace, three large cones forming an upside down triangle, and a base ending with small feet. The triangle configuration gives the appearance of a female breast and bulging belly. The second type consists of a small head, a necklace, and one cone in the middle that tapers into a vaguely serpentine base. (Figure 6) Although these amulets are very schematic, they are definitely female. The cone shapes emphasize the breasts and abdomen of the amulets. Their shape is reminiscent of the shape of a pregnant female.

In the bog at Foerlev Nymbølle in Jutland, Denmark, a nine-foot-long, cloven oak branch was found under a pile of stones and a bunch of flax. The innate shape of the wood is definitely feminine. It has two long and slender legs that end in hips rounded by cutting away the back of the upper thigh on both sides. The legs join at the fork in the branch. At the underside of the fork, an incision has been made to emphasize the vulva. The rest of the figure is the trunk of the body coming straight off the fork. This schematic figure is without head, breasts, and arms; yet it still manages to convey the suggestion of the female form.[9] This figure was found in the same bog with a wooden club, several ski-like planks, pots, bones of domesticated animals, and a human shoulder blade. (Figure 7)

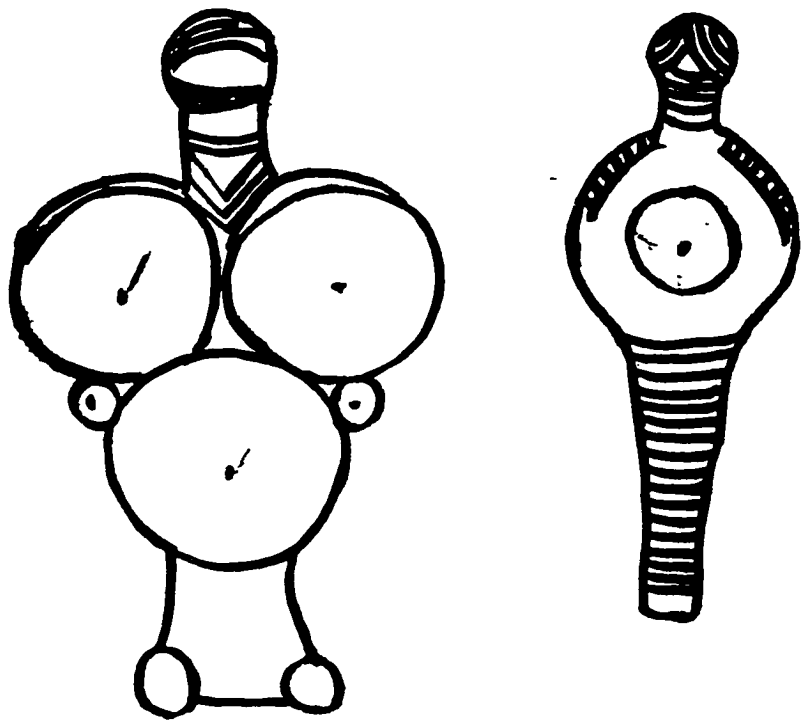
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[9]P.V. Glob, *The Bog People*, p. 180.

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FIGURE 6

IRON AGE AMULETS FROM ACROSS DENMARK

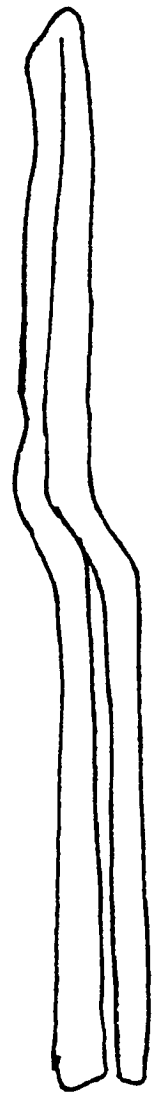


Source: Adapted from a photograph in *The Bog People*. See Figure 57.

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FIGURE 7

FIGURINE FROM FOERLEV NYMBØLLE
IN JUTLAND, DENMARK



Source: Adapted from a photograph in *The Bog People*. See Figure 71.

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This bog was apparently a place of offering. The emphasis of the vulva of the oak figure underscores its femininity. The oak branch is a goddess figurine made from nature with only limited human intervention. Its placement in the bog and the other apparent offerings in the bog indicate that it was once an offering to the goddess.

Several finds were made in the context of ritual offerings or hoards. Female ornaments, and in one case a sickle, were found in conjunction with the figurines. Most of the figurines were either naked or bare breasted. This emphasis on the female breasts and genitalia in conjunction with ritual offerings and hoards suggest that these figurines were offered to the goddess of fertility for a bountiful harvest, personal fertility, or both. The appearance of these figurines in the approximate area of Nerthus worship prove the existence of a goddess cult during the Bronze and Iron Ages.[10] While none of these figurines could ever be called Nerthus; their deposition, postures, and attributes suggest that their function was probably similar to Nerthus's function.[11]

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[10]ibid., p. 156.

[11]See pages 43-52 for a explanation of Nerthus' function as a fertility goddess.

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Nerthus Had a Sacred Grove on an Island in the Ocean

Tacitus states that Nerthus's sanctuary was located on an island in a sacred grove. In this grove, Nerthus with her wagon waits for the priest to declare it time for her sacred journey. Several places have been suggested for this island. Denmark, Norway, Sweden, and Northern Germany have had their proponents.[12] Any islands, or prehaps peninsulas, in these areas would probably be suitable. Exactly where her island was we will probably never know.

That Nerthus had a sacred grove is not surprising. Several times in the *Germania* Tacitus mentions a grove that is sacred to a certain deity or tribe.[13] The Scandinavian folk belief in land spirits who can bring luck or destruction is tied to the ancient belief that the land itself is alive and must be sacrificed to and appeased.

Only One Priest Could Perceive the Presence of, Touch, or Travel with the Goddess

"Only one priest could perceive the presence of the goddess." How did the priest know it was time to go on the sacred journey? Was there a certain annual star alignment, was the sun at a particular angle, did a specific plant bloom or sprout

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[12]For a discussion of Nerthus' sancuary see Edgar C. Polomé, "A propos de la déesse Nerthus," *Latomus* 13 (1954) : 165-200.

[13]See *Germania*, chapters 7, 9, 39, and 43.

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shoots? These questions will never be conclusively answered, and we can only speculate on the correct answer. How was Nerthus represented? Was there a figurine like one of the many found in the Northwestern European bogs representing her? Did a plant, animal, or perhaps a person symbolize her? Again, we can only pick our favorite theory because the true answer has been lost over time. That only one priest could perceive the goddess suggests that the time of the annual journey was signaled by a natural event either astronomically or agriculturally. I agree with Polomé who thinks that she must have been represented as a blossoming plant. The flowering of the plant would indicate that she was ready to begin her journey, and the wilting of the flowers would indicate that she was ready to return to her grove.[14]

Nerthus Traveled Around in a Wagon

Archaeological finds and later German and Norse traditions support many of Tacitus's statements. The remains of broken ceremonial wagons in peat bogs lend credence to Tacitus's claims that Nerthus had a ceremonial vehicle. Fragments of two beautifully made wagons thought to date from the third century C.E. were found in a

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[14]Edgar C. Polomé, "Some Aspects of the Cult of the Mother Goddess in Western Europe," *Vistas and Vectors: Essays Honoring the Memory of Helmut Rehder*, Jennings and Schulz-Behrend (eds), (Austin: University of Texas, 1979), p. 199.

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peat bog in western Denmark at Dejbjerg.[15] These wagons and the ornately carved wagon found in the Oseberg ship burial, which dates from the ninth century C.E., prove the existence of ceremonial vehicles and might resemble Nerthus's wagon.[16]

Tacitus's account of Nerthus's journey can be corroborated by a comparison with Freyr, a later Scandinavian wagon deity. Nerthus and Freyr have many similar traits. According to chapter 4 of *Ynglinga Saga,* Freyr is the son of Njörðr and an unnamed Vanic goddess. Freyr was responsible for the fertility and prosperity of his worshipers and often traveled around the countryside in a wagon.

The comic adventures of Gunnar Helming, who impersonated Freyr, are told in *Flateyjarbók* in its version of the *Óláf saga Tryggvasonar.* Gunnar, a young Norwegian, goes to Sweden and comes to a temple of the god Freyr. At this temple, a very attractive young woman serves as the priestess. She is called the wife of Freyr. Gunnar and the priestess become intimate, and Gunnar is invited to tag along during

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[15]Hilda Ellis Davidson, *The Lost Beliefs of Northern Europe* (New York: Routledge, 1993), p. 133 and Hilda Ellis Davidson, *Gods and Myths of Northern Europe* (London: Pelican Books, 1964; reprint ed., New York: Penguin Books, 1990), p. 95. For a picture of the Osberg wagon see Colleen Batey, Helen Clarke, R.I. Page, and Neil S. Price, *Cultural Atlas of the Viking World,* ed. James Graham-Campbell (Oxfordshire, England: Andromeda Oxford Limited, 1994), p. 42.

[16]Hilda Ellis Davidson, *Gods and Myths of Northern Europe*, p. 95 and Johannes Brøndsted, *The Vikings*, trans. Kalle Skov (Baltimore, Maryland: Penguin Books, 1965), p. 281.

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Freyr's annual autumn journey around the land. Everyone but Gunnar and the priestess abandon the journey when a blizzard strands the wagon on a mountain road.

Gunnar and the priestess continue on their way leading the wagon containing an image of Freyr. When Gunnar sits down to rest, the priestess threatens that Freyr will attack him if he does not arise. Gunnar remains seated, and Freyr gets down from his wagon and fights with Gunnar. The fight is equally matched, but Gunnar calls on the god of King Olaf [Christ] for help. With Christ's help, he is able to best Freyr. Gunnar destroys Freyr's image, puts on the adornments of the god, and impersonates him.

When Gunnar, disguised as Freyr, arrives at a feast, everyone is delighted that the god can eat and drink with his worshipers. Gunnar demands valuables instead of human sacrifice which delights the worshipers even more. The season is a good one, and within a few months it becomes known that Freyr's wife is pregnant.

This story mocks the simpleness of the Swedes and is completely fictional; however, it shows a common knowledge and acceptance of an annual procession that promoted peace and fertility. In this procession, an image of Freyr traveled with a priestess who was considered his wife. Human sacrifice was expected and considered an acceptable way to insure prosperity. Freyr appears to be the male mirror image of Nerthus. Freyr and Nerthus insure peace, prosperity, and fertility. Both deities travel with an attendant of the opposite sex, and both are connected with human sacrifice.

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In chapter 10 of the *Ynglinga Saga* in *Heimskringla*, Snorri states that during Freyr's reign as King of the Swedes; there were good harvests and peace. After Freyr became sick, his advisors made a great burial mound with a door and three windows insuring that only a few people could see him. When Freyr died, he was secretly placed in the mound; and the Swedes were told that he was still alive. This secret was kept for three years. The people offered tribute at the mound; and peace, prosperity, and good seasons continued. Even after death, Freyr continued to provide for his people.

In the *Gesta Danorum*, written in the late twelfth and early thirteenth centuries by Saxo Grammaticus, the fifth book tells about the Danish king Froði III. During Froði's reign, there had been peace and prosperity. When Froði died, his nobles had him embalmed. They feared trouble both at home and abroad if news of his death became known. To keep their secret, the nobles took the embalmed Froði about in a wagon as if he were an old man without full possession of his faculties. Like the story of Freyr above, the death of a bountiful peace-loving king was kept secret from his subjects. As long as the secret was kept, peace and prosperity continued.

The similar traditions of Nerthus and Freyr speak of a continuation of cult stretching several hundred years: the ceremonial viewing and blessing of the fields and people by the supreme fertility deity often accompanied by a priest or priestess of the opposite sex. The time of the blessing is unknown, but it probably coincided with late autumn or winter when such a procession would be the most beneficial and powerful.

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Nerthus and Freyr are not the only deities associated with an annual journey. In a German legend recorded in the nineteenth century by the Grimm brothers, Frau Holla is said to annually wander around the countryside bestowing fertility on the fields.[17] Although this legend was recorded in the nineteenth century; Frau Holla, like Nerthus almost two thousand years before her, annually traveled around a certain area and brought fertility and prosperity.

Processions to ensure prosperity also took place near Cologne in Germany and at Autun in France. The twelfth century *Chronicum Rudolfi* gives an account of a procession that took place in 1133 C.E. in the towns west of Cologne. A figure was taken from town to town in a cart accompanied by a multitude of people and song. This procession was celebrated for more than twelve days and often went into the night.

> *Est genus mercenariorum, quorum officium est ex lino et lana texere telas, hoc procax et superbum super alios mercenarios vulgo reputatur, ad quorum procacitatem et superbiam humiliandam et propriam injuriam de eis ulciscendam pauper quidam rusticus ex villa nomine Inda hanc diabolicam excogitavit technam. Accepta a judicibus fiducia et a levibus hominibus auxilo, qui gaudent jocis et novitatibus, in proxima silva navem composuit, et eam rotis suppositis affigens vehibilem super terram effecit, obtinuit quoque a potestatibus, ut injectis funibus textorum humeris ex Inda Aquisgranum traheretur. Aquis suscepta cum utriusque sexus grandi hominum processione: nihilominus*

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[17] Jakob and Wilhelm Grimm, *The German Legends of the Brothers Grimm*, ed. and trans. Donald Ward, (Philadelphia, PA: Institute for the Study of Human Issues, 1981) Legend #4 - "Mother Holla's Pond."

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> *a testoribus Trajectum est provecta, ibi emendata, malo veloque insignita Tungris est inducta, de Tungris Los.*[18]
>
> In the forest near Inda a ship-like "vehiculum" or vessel was built and wheels were affixed to it. Ropes were attached to the vessel and weavers drew it through the countryside accompanied by a giant procession of women and men. The vessel was drawn first to Aachen, then to Maestricht, Tongres, Looz, and so on. The people drawing the vessel had the right to prevent others from coming too near the internal part of the ship. Everywhere crowds came out to greet it with great joyfulness and songs of triumph.[19]

Who or what the figure was is unknown. The most that I can say is that it was probably of pagan origin. This procession took place in 1133 C.E. The masses of Western Europe had been converted to Christianity, at least superficially, for a couple hundred years; but many of the deep-rooted rural beliefs had not yet been supplanted by Christian rites.

The purpose of the ritual is not stated. All we know is a ship-shaped wagon was pulled through several towns by weavers, and a large number of people followed behind the wagon. This ship-wagon was greeted by the towns with joy and songs were sung. Since the weavers are emphasized by their pulling of the wagon, the purpose might be

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[18]Jacob Grimm, *Teutonic Mythology*, trans., James Steven Stallybrass, (Peter Smith: Gloucester, Mass., 1976), p. 259.

[19]*Rodulfi Chronicon Abbatiae S. Trudonis*, book 11. trans. Pamela Berger in *The Goddess Obscured: Transformation of the Grain Protectress from Goddess to Saint* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1985), pp. 77-78.

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to insure a bountiful harvest of flax. The whole rite may be tied to the ship, perhaps as an offering for good weather or smooth sailing so that the weavers' wares could reach foreign markets. It should be mentioned that in chapter 9 of *Germania*, Tacitus states that some of the Suevi made sacrifices to Isis. He then vaguely mentions that the image of Isis is "fashioned like a light galley."[20] Roman authors often used the names of known gods and goddesses to refer to unfamiliar deities of foreigners. This image was probably not of Isis, but an image of a Germanic goddess with Isis-like qualities. The mention of Isis connected with a ship-like image and the procession containing a 'daemon' and a ship suggests that the procession was related to some form of goddess worship.

The purpose of the rite, however, is not as important as its existence. When compared to the journeys of Nerthus and Freyr, there are several similarities. A pagan image was driven around in a wagon. The person or people in charge of the wagon controlled access to this image. The wagon was met with great joy, and a spirit of celebration was prevalent wherever it went.

Gregory of Tours in chapter 76 of his *Liber in Gloria Confessorum* relates that during the life of Saint Symphorian (c. 180-280 C.E.), a statue of Berecynthia was carried around in a cart in the city of Autun in France.

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[20]Tacitus, *The Complete Works of Tacitus*, p. 713.

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> Ferunt etiam in hac urbe simulachrum fuisse Berecinthiae, sicut sancti martyris Simphoriani passionis declarat historia. Hanc cum in carpento pro salvatione agrorum ac vinearum suarum misero gentilitatis more deferrent, adfuit supradictus Simplicius episcopus, haud procul aspiciens cantantes atque saltantes ante hoc simulachrum . . .[21]
>
> Some say that there was a statue of Berecynthia in this city [of Autun], just as the history of the suffering of the martyr St. Symphorianus relates. In accordance with the pitiful custom of pagans the people brought this statue on a wagon for the preservation of their fields and vineyards. The aforementioned bishop Simplicius was present, and not far away he watched them sining and dancing before the statue.[22]

There is a striking similarity between the accounts of Nerthus's, Freyr's, and Berecynthia's journey. Each had a statue or something that signified the presence of the deity. This representation was carried in a wagon around the fields to insure prosperity and fertility. Wherever the wagon went, the people stopped their everyday activities and celebrated with song and dancing.

At the time that this rite was purported to have taken place (180-280 C.E.), the Germanic tribes had not yet infiltrated this far into Gaul. This would make this procession Celtic in origin. Whether the origin of this rite is Celtic, Germanic, or

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[21]Bruno Krusch, ed., *Gregorii Episcopi Turonensis Miracula et Opera Minora* in Monumenta Germaniae Historica Scriptorum Rerum Merovingicarum v. 1.1, (Impensis Bibliopolii Hahniani: Hannover, 1885), reprint ed., 1969, p. 343.

[22]Gregory of Tours, *Glory of the Confessors*, trans. Raymond Van Dam, in Translated Texts for Historians Latin Series IV, (Liverpool University Press: Liverpool, 1988)

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predates both cultures is not important considering the intermingling of peoples and ideas that took place in Western Europe at this time. The Celts and the Germans have many features that are strikingly similar. These similarities could be due to a fluid exchange of ideas between the two cultures, the subordination of one culture by the other, or the existence of a cultural substrate with the same basic ideas in both areas. The importance of this procession is that it shows that the same religious rite was practiced from Denmark to France at about the same time.

Although not a procession with idol, wagon, and revelers; the establishment of the island of Zealand by the Norse goddess Gefjun is in somewhat the same vein as the above examples. In *Gylfaginning* (1) and chapter 5 of *Ynglinga Saga*, Snorri tells how the King of the Swedes offered to reward Gefjun with as much land as she could plow in a day. With the help of her four sons who were oxen, she was able to carve out the circumference of present day Lake Mälar in Sweden. She then dragged the plot of land down to the present day location of Zealand in Denmark. The similarity between the rites of the wagon deities and the story of Gefjun is that a deity encircles a specific area; and through the process of encircling this area, prosperity and fertility are brought to the area. In this myth, Gefjun does not only bring prosperity to a region, she is responsible for the creation of the land. The basis of this myth could be in a fertility ritual similar to that associated with Nerthus and Freyr.

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These processions from France, Germany, and Scandinavia indicate a widespread continuance of a fertility-promoting, ritual procession that, in one form or another, was practiced for almost two thousand years.[23] The persistence of this ritual speaks for its importance in the life of ordinary people whose existence was dependent on the capriciousness of the weather, the abundance of their crops and animals, the fortunes of war, and the inevitability of disease. Bad weather or war could lead to crop failure, with crop failure your livestock died off and the family became more susceptible to disease. Famine and death was often one miscalculation away. If one small rite could put you in favor with the powers of prosperity and fertility, then you continued to perform this rite year after year in the hope that it would do some good.

A Truce Was Declared and It Was a Time of Rejoicing

Tacitus states that it is a season of rejoicing, and festivity reigns wherever she deigns to go and be received. They do not go to battle or wear arms; every weapon is

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[23]Pamela Berger in *The Goddess Obscured*, pp. 31-36, mentions the similarity of traditions between Nerthus, Berecynthia, and the "daemon" near Colonge. Turville-Petre in *Myth and Religion of the North*, pp. 165-171, mentions the similarity between the Nerthus and Freyr passages. Hilda Ellis Davidson in *The Lost Beliefs of Northern Europe*, pp. 115-117, mentions the similarity of similarity of traditions between Nerthus, Holle, Brigid, and the Virgin Mary.

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under lock; peace and quiet are known and welcomed only at these times. That the time of the deity's journey among the people was a period of rejoicing is evident from the above passages related to the journeys of other divine beings. Most of the passages mention the rejoicing of the people and a spirit of celebration. However, none of the passages mention that the journey of the deity was a time of peace when all weapons were put away. *Vatnsdœla Saga* recounts the adventures of Ingimund and his family. Ingimund was a priest of Freyr, and he set up a temple dedicated to Freyr in Northwest Iceland. The saga states that no one was allowed to take weapons into the temple, or the violator had to forfeit them. Although a prohibtion against weapons in temples is common in most cultures, this is the only time such a rule is mentioned in Norse sources. The ordinance is similar to Tacitus's statement that all weapons had to be put away during Nerthus's journey. If the similarity between Nerthus's and Freyr's annual journey is taken into consideration, the prohibitions concerning weapons in Freyr's temple and during Nerthus's journey are almost identical. Both prohibitions indicate that the deity of fertility and prosperity demanded peace in his or her presence.

The Goddess and All of Her Accouterments Were Purified in Water

Tacitus states that after the journey the vehicle, vestments, and the divinity were purified in a secret lake. The ritual washing or dipping of sacred objects in water

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is a cross-cultural phenomenon. Water is one of the most important elements in most if not all religious systems. Water purifies, renews, and heals. In *Patterns of Comparative Religion,* Mircea Eliade discusses the preeminence of water in religious thought and symbolism.

> Immersion in water symbolizes a return to the pre-formal, a total regeneration, a new birth, for immersion means a dissolution of forms, a reintegration into the formlessness of pre-existence; and emerging from the water is a repetition of the act of creation in which form was first expressed. Every contact with water implies regeneration: first, because dissolution is succeeded by a "new birth", and then because immersion fertilizes, [and] increases the potential of life and of creation.[24]

The purpose of washing the goddess, the wagon, and the vestments is to rid her and her paraphernalia of the taint of human contact. The purification of the goddess and her accouterments revitalizes and renews the goddess's powers after she has expended them in her journey. This purification prepares her for the next time she is needed. Similar ceremonies were carried out in the Middle East, Greece, and Crete since the bathing of the goddess of fertility and agriculture was common.[25] Even into the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, Catholics immersed a crucifix or a statue of Mary into water to end a drought and promote rain.[26] As with the procession ritual, the

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[24]Mircea Eliade, *Patterns in Comparative Religion*, trans. Rosemary Sheed, (New York, New York: Sheed & Ward, 1958), pp. 188-189.

[25]ibid., p. 195.

[26]ibid., p. 196.

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immersion of a deity in water was a very old tradition that the common person thought was essential for the survival of the family or village. The symbolism involved in this ritual is basic and cuts across religious and cultural boundaries.

All of Her Attendants Were Drowned After this Rite

Tacitus states that after the purification ritual, the slaves were swallowed up by the waters of the lake. It is assumed that the slaves were drowned. Why were these slaves drowned? Were they drowned because they knew the location of the secret lake, they touched the goddess, they were a sacrifice to the goddess, or did all three reasons play a role in their demise? All three reasons probably played a role. If there was a secret lake that was sacred to the goddess, the priest might not want everyone to know its location and importance. Offerings to the goddess might be placed there, and the priest could have feared that enemies would plunder the offerings. Dead slaves do not tell anyone were they have been. In washing the goddess and her paraphernalia in the lake, the slaves would have had to touch either the goddess or her things. Since the priest is the only one allowed to touch the goddess, this desecration of her by slaves might have been punishable by death. Tthe reason for their deaths might be a human sacrifice to the goddess to appease her and persuade her to continue to bring prosperity

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and fertility to the region. The death of the slaves could conveniently fulfill all three functions.

There is some evidence of bodies of murdered people in the bogs of Northwest Europe. In his surveys of bog body finds, Dieck has recorded over 1800 bog bodies in Europe. At least 65 of the bodies were from Sweden and Norway, 415 from Denmark, 600 from Germany, and 55 from the Netherlands.[27] The majority of the bog body finds are located in Northwest Europe. This fact might be due to the existence of extensive bogs in this area or might be due to cultural practice. The datable finds were deposited in the bogs mostly between 100 B.C.E. and 100 C.E or during the Iron Age and the Roman Period. The Danish Bog Bodies mostly date from the Early Neolithic into the Viking Age, the bog bodies from the Netherlands mostly date from the Late Iron Age and the Roman Period, and the bog bodies found in western Lower Saxony mostly date from the Late Iron Age and the Roman Period.[28] These statistics indicate that the

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[27]W.A.B. van der Sanden, "Bog Bodies on the Continent: Developements since 1965, with Special Reference to the Netherlands," in *Bog Bodies: New Discoveries and New Perspectives,* eds. R.C. Turner and R.G. Scaife (London: British Museum Press,), pp. 148, 152; and C.S. Brigg and T.C. Turner, "The Bog Burials of Britain and Ireland," in *Lindow Man: The Body in the Bog,* eds. I.M. Stead, J.B. Bourke, and Don Brothwell (London: British Museum Press, 1986), pp. 157-158. Van der Sanden cautions that Dieck's numbers might be inflated since some of the bodies are based on legend or on vague and unspecified sources, p. 152.

[28]van der Sanden, pp. 148, 149, and 157.

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deposition of bodies in lakes and marshlands is a phenomenon of the Northwest European Iron Age.

These bodies are of special interest because of their extraordinary preservation. The soil-acid in the water together with the complete elimination of air tanned the skin and the hair of the bodies. The state of preservation of the bodies depends on the amount of soil-acid in the water. If the right amount of soil-acid was in the water, the bones are preserved. If there was too much soil-acid, then only the skin is preserved. Some of the finds are datable. Carbon-14 measurements of preserved body parts and pollen analysis are a few of the methods used to date the modern finds. To date the older finds, one must rely on the clothes worn, the artifacts associated with the body, and the level of peat at which the body was found. The cause of death can be assessed fairly accurately since many of the bodies have the skin and/or bones intact.

There are various reasons for bodies to end up in bogs: accidental, those who wandered in; foul-play, those who were murdered and their bodies hidden; penal, those who were punished for a crime; and sacrificial, those who were offered in sacrifice to the deities of fertility. While bodies in each of these categories have been found, those bodies which might be sacrificial in nature interest us here.

The similarity between modes of sacrifice and modes of punishment makes distinguishing the two in the archaeological record nearly impossible. It is possible that

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criminal punishment and sacrifice were indistinguishable in this period, since those punished for an offense could be used at the same time as a sacrifice to placate the deity offended by the crime. This supposition is made even more plausible by Julius Caesar in Book 4, Chapter 16 of The Gallic War when he mentions that the Gauls would sacrifice criminals to their gods.

Several bog bodies have been found in circumstances that might be considered sacrificial.[29] I have individually listed finds that appear to be suspiciously sacrificial in nature. An overview of these finds supports the possibility that Nerthus's slaves could have been drowned in a lake at least partially as a sacrifice to her. Map 2 indicates the sites where bog bodies have been found.[30]

Hanging or Strangulation. One of the most famous bog bodies is the Tollund Man. The body was discovered in 1950 in Tollund Fen in Jutland, Denmark. It is dated to the Early Iron Age and was deposited in an old peat-cutting. The body was naked

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[29]C.S. Briggs, "Did They Fall or Were They Pused? Some Unresolved Questions about Bog Bodies," in *Bog Bodies,* eds. R.C. Turner and R.G. Scaife, pp. 168-182. In this article, Briggs suggests possible alternative explanations for the apparant straguations, stab wounds, slit throats, deapitation, and forced drowning deaths found among the bog bodies. Briggs suggests that a lot of the damage to the bodies could have been done in an attempt to rescue the person trapped in the bog or later by a peat cutter.

[30]The number following the information about each bog body is the location number of that find on the map.

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MAP 2

LOCATIONS OF MENTIONED BOG BODY FINDS



1. Tollund Fen, Denmark
2. Borre Fen, Denmark
3. Bolkide, Denmark
4. Lykkegård Fen, Denmark
5. Bunsok, Germany
6. Domland Fen, Germany
7. Juthe Fen, Denmark
8. Bred Fen, Denmark
9. Hingst Fen, Germany
10. Damendorf, Germany
11. Werdingerveen, Holland
12. Nebelgård Fen, Denmark
13. Ravnholt, Denmark
14. Stidsholt Fen, Denmark
15. Roum Fen, Denmark
16. Kohlmoor, Germany

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except for a cap and a belt. There was a skin rope around his neck. The rope formed a noose and could be tightened from the back. Medical experts examined the body and decided that the Tollund Man had been hung but not strangled. His last meal was a grass and seed gruel, which consisted mostly of knotweed (pale persicaria).[31](1)

In 1946, a male body was found in Borre Fen in Himmerland, Denmark. The naked body had been deposited in an old peat-cutting around the first century B.C.E. The head had been crushed and the right thigh bone was broken. A hemp rope fastened in a slip knot was around his neck. A large birch branch laid across the body. His last meal consisted of a gruel similar to that of the Tollund Man.[32](2)

At Bolkide on the island of Als in Denmark, two bodies were found side by side. The remains of a rope found with them might suggest hanging or strangulation.(3) In Lykkegård Fen in East Jutland in Denmark, a male body was found with a rope around its neck.[33](4)

In 1790 at Bunsok in southern Ditmarsh in Schleswig-Holstein in Germany, a body of undetermined sex was found. The body was naked with a two foot long braided band around its neck. The body had been caged in the bog. There were six

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[31]P.V. Glob, *The Bog People*, p. 18-36.

[32]ibid., p. 86-90.

[33]ibid., p. 96.

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vertical birch poles, three at the head and three at the feet. Around these vertical poles were three parallel horizontal sticks and poles driven in at the sides.[34](5)

In 1952 a naked male body was found in Domland Fen, south of Eckerförde in Schleswig-Holstein in Germany. The body was in an old peat-cutting under eight pieces of wood between 7 and 9 inches in diameter. The body was pinned in the bog by forked branches that had been sharpened and driven into the ground. His arms were bent and crossed his chest. He probably had been strangled by a thin flexible hazel branch that lay across his neck.[35](6)

Drowning. In 1835 in Juthe Fen in central Jutland, Denmark, a female body was found. At her knees and elbows, wooden crooks had been driven tightly into the earth. At her chest and abdomen, strong branches had been bent across as clamps and more wooden crooks were used to hold down the ends of the branches.[36] Swelling around her knee indicated that she had apparently been pinned in the bog while still alive.(7)

In 1942 in Bred Fen, in Storarden, Denmark, a naked female body was found deposited on an old peat cutting. There were no external signs of violence, but she was tied with her body doubled over and wrapped in a cloth with only her head

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[34]ibid., p. 105.

[35]ibid., pp. 114-116.

[36]ibid., p. 74.

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showing.[37](8) In 1903 in Hingst Fen, near Kreepen, in Germany, a naked female body was found. The body was doubled over with her arms apparently held at her knees. Found with the body, and probably the means by which she was bound, was an iron ring, two hoops of willow twigs, and two oak pickets. Three stones, each weighing around twenty-five pounds, were placed on the body.[38](9)

Stabbing. Near Damendorf in the Eckernförde district in Schleswig-Holstein, Germany, a male body was found. The body lay naked under a cloak with other garments at his feet. Only his skin and hair are preserved. There is an inch long split near his heart which might be the cause of death.[39](10)

In June 1904 at Werdingerveen in the province of Drenthe in Holland, two bodies were found together. The bodies lay naked on their backs with one resting on the other's outstretched arm. Only the skin is preserved on the body with the outstretched arm; and in the region of its heart, there was something that looked like a

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[37]ibid., p. 82.

[38]ibid., p. 107.

[39]ibid.

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wound.[40](11) At one time thes bodies were thought to be a male and a female. Recent analysis of these bodies has indicated that both are male.[41]

Throat Slit. In 1952 in Nebelgård Fen, near Grauballe in Jutland, Denmark, a naked male body was found. Pollen analysis and carbon 14 dating placed his death between 210 C.E. and 410 C.E. He had been placed in an old peat cutting. His throat had been cut nearly ear to ear. His last meal was a gruel similar to the one the Tollund Man ate except it contained a hint of small bone fragments and mammalian hairs, which might indicate some meat content.[42](12)

In 1773 on Fyn in the district of Ravnholt, Denmark, a male body was found. He was naked except for a cap. There was no trace of binding; however, his arms were crossed behind his back as if tied. It is possible that his throat had been cut since his skin was intact except for beneath the chin where bone could be seen. Small twigs and branches covered the body.[43](13)

Decapitation. In 1859 in Stidsholt Fen, in Vendsyssel, Denmark, a female head was found. The head had been decapitated by a tool which cut through the third and

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[40]ibid., p. 110.

[41]W.A.B. van der Sanden, "Bog Bodies on the Continent," in *Bog Bodies*, eds. R.C. Turner and R.G. Scaife, p. 154.

[42]Glob, *Bog People*, pp. 37-62.

[43]ibid., p. 66.

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fourth vertebrae. The hair was twenty inches long and tied in a knot to which a thirty inch woven band was attached. The find is undated.[44](14)

In 1942 in Roum Fen in Himmerland, Denmark, a female head was found wrapped in sheepskin. The head had been severed between the second and third cervical vertebrae. Ancient clothing and artifacts had been found in the same bog at an earlier date.[45](15)

In 1948 in Kohlmoor to the south-east of Osterby in Schleswig-Holstein, Germany, a male head was found wrapped in a cape of roe-deer hide. The head had been severed from the body by a sharp implement which cut the second cervical vertebra. The left side of the head was fractured. The hair was arranged in a knot on the right side.[46](16)

The violent deaths of these people could have been sacrificial in nature. This is not to say that all of these people were sacrifices. I am sure that some of them were lone travelers with too many valuables and not enough sense. Others probably broke the law or a social taboo and were punished for their actions. However, I feel confident that some if not most were sacrificial victims for the following reasons. Bogs were a

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[44]ibid., p. 98.

[45]ibid., p. 100.

[46]ibid., p. 116.

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common place to offer sacrifices to deities. This is demonstrated by the hundreds of finds of jewelry, coins, weapons, tools, houseswares, and clothing deposited throughout Northern Europe. Many of these items were broken or deliberately destroyed before they were deposited. A well-documented bog deposition site is Thorbjerg in Denmark. This bog was used as a place of offering from at least 100 B.C.E. to 300 C.E. The types of items deposited change slowly over time. Pottery which often contained some type of animal remains including bones, butter, or milk was deposited from about 100 B.C.E. to about 100 C.E. Weapons and war gear were deposited from about 150 C.E. to about 250 C.E. Coins were deposited about 200 C.E., and brooches were deposited from about 100 C.E. to about 300 C.E.[47] All of these items did not end up in the same place by accident. They were deliberately deposited in a bog. The most likely reason for this placement is as offerings to a deity or deities. Since bog bodies are also placed in bogs, they are probably also offerings to a deity or deities. All of the bog bodies mentioned in this study did not die of natural causes. They were killed or "broken" as many of the inanimate objects left in offering were. The last meals of the bog people were apparently eaten in the winter. Glob has suggested that this would make the bodies offerings for a fertile and prosperous spring. The evidence suggests that

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[47]Malcolm Todd, *The Northern Barbarians 100 BC - AD 300*, (Basil Blackwell: New York, 1987), pp. 167-175.

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Tacitus's description of the drowning of Nerthus's slaves is extremely plausible. It is also possible that the drowning of the slaves provided an annual sacrifice to her.

Linguistics

Except for the information that Tacitus provides for us, we really have no other information on Nerthus. There are no inscriptions dedicating a temple to her, and none of the later literary evidence mentions her name. While Nerthus is never mentioned again, the god Njörðr plays a major role in several stories in Scandinavian mythology. In *Ynglinga Saga* in *Heimskringla,* the story of the war between two divine groups (the Vanir and the Æsir) is told. After the war, hostages are exchanged as a sign of good faith. Njörðr is one of the hostages that the Vanir send the Æsir. We are told that while living with the Vanir, Njörðr was married to his sister. The incestuous relationship between brother and sister appears to be normal for the Vanir. Njörðr's wife/sister is unnamed in the text, but speculation among scholars has pointed to Nerthus.

The reason that Nerthus and Njörðr have been paired together is that their names are linguistically almost identical. As shown in Table 3, the structure of the root is identical. All of the consonants are exactly the same. The difference in the vowel is that one has a diphthong and one has a single vowel. The discrepancy in the vowel might be easily explained. Njörðr's name appears often in Norse sources, there is little

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TABLE 3

COMPARISON OF THE NAMES OF NJÖRÐR AND NERTHUS

Njörðr < *Njorth- < *Neorth- < *Neurth- <*Nerth-u-z

OR

Njörðr < *Njarth- <* Nearth-[39] <*Nerth-u-z

COMPARED WITH

Nerthus <*Nerth-u-z

Source: Primary

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[39]E.V. Gordon, *An Introduction to Old Norse* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1983), p. 274. "It is usually assumed that the u-fracture of e was ea>ja>jö and jo by u-mutation; but the rival view that the original u-fracture was eu > eo > jo > jö is also possible."

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doubt that the spelling is correct. The problem is Nerthus's name. Her name is attested only in Tacitus. Tacitus did not travel to Northern Germania, watch a wagon procession, and ask the natives how to spell the goddess's name. He got his information second or third hand. The person he got his information from probably was not a native Germanic speaker. Even if his information is only one person removed from the source, the informant would have interpreted the name of an unfamiliar goddess in the context of his own language. If the informant's first language was Latin, the consonants would not have been a problem to understand and remember. The vowel would have been more difficult. There are certain vowel combinations that appear in Germanic languages that do not appear or are not common in Latin. Add to this fact, the difficulty of determining if someone is using a diphthong in ordinary speech, especially if you are not a native speaker. The informant probably interpreted the vowel in the easiest way possible that made sense to him given his linguistic background. This is the simplest explanation for the discrepancies between the vowels in these names.

The pairing of Njörðr and Nerthus led deVries to mention a theory that was first suggested by F.R. Schroder.[49] This theory is that the original deity of the Nerthus - Njörðr and the Skaði - Ullr pair (mentioned later) was a deity who was both male and

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[49]Jan de Vries, *Altgermanische Religionsgeschichte*, 2 vols. Grundriss der Germanischen Philologie (Berlin: Walter de Gruyter & Co., 1957), §561.

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female. Later the deity was split into two single-sex deities. I find this idea very interesting, and I would like to build onto the idea. Instead of seeing the original deity as being both male and female, I visualize this being as a self-generating female deity like the Earth. A single female diety makes more sense than a single male diety. Women give birth and men do not. A female deity could create life herself.

If one follows Marija Gimbutas's theories on European religion before the arrival of the Indo-Europeans, a self-generating female deity in Northern Europe is possible.[50] With the arrival of the Indo-Europeans and their belief in a masculine ordered world, the goddess was split into at least two deities: one male and one female. Each deity then performed traditional Indo-European sexual-specific structured roles in society. The goddess came to be associated with women, children, the home, and food production. The male deity came to be associated with warriors, war, the king, sailing, hunting, and magic.

Summary

Nerthus appears to have been a locally important goddess in Northwestern Europe. The existence of goddess worship in this period and in this region is evident from the abundance of goddess figurines that have been found. The existence of a

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[50]See chapter nine for Marija Gimbutas's theories on Old European religion.

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sacred grove is very plausible in the context of Germanic religious practices of the time. Nerthus's wagon procession is only one instance in a continuance of cult surrounding a wagon procession of different deities with different names. These deities appeared to have brought prosperity and fertility to the fields, family, and village. The continuance of this cult for at least two thousand years speaks for its importance to the common people. The attendance of the goddess by a priest, the rejoicing associated with her journey, and the declared truce are all supported by the reports of other wagon processions. The purification of the goddess in the lake appears to have been a typical rite associated with the renewal of power. The drowning of the goddesses' slaves appears to have been a sacrifice to her for the prosperity of the coming year. Nerthus's name and the name of the Old Norse god Njörðr appear to be identical in form. The linguistic connection between the two names might suggest that at one time only one deity existed. With the advent of the Indo-Europeans, the single deity was split into a male and female form; so both could perform gender specific functions typical of this culture.

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III. FREYJA

Freyja is the goddess on whom we have the most information in the Norse myths. Unfortunately, the information we have is meager, and what we do know is often abstruse, superficial, and contradictory. In *Gylfaginning* (23), Snorri says that Freyja is the most renowned of the goddesses. In chapter 10 of the *Ynglinga Saga* in *Heimskringla,* Snorri states that "Freyja kept up the sacrifices for she was the only one among the godheads who survived."[1] According to Snorri, the worship of Freyja outlasted the advent of Christianity longer than the worship of any of the other Norse deities. The question to ask is why. Why did sacrifices to Freyja persist when the worship of Óðinn, Þórr, and Freyr disappeared?

If we strictly read the sources, the amount of ink expended on the escapades and adventures of Óðinn, Þórr, and Freyr is at least quadruple of that expended on Freyja. We have archaeological evidence of talismans in the likeness of Þórr and Freyr but none in the likeness of Freyja. What was special to the cult of Freyja that allowed it to continue side by side with Christianity after belief in the male Norse gods died out? Either the cult of Freyja offered something that Christianity did not

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[1]"*Freyja hélt þá upp blótum því að hún ein lifði þá eftir goðanna*" Snorri Sturluson, *Heimskringla*, Bergljót S. Kristjánsdóttir, Bragi Halldórsson, Jón Torfason, and Örnólfur Thorsson (eds). (Reykjavík: Mál og menning, 1991); and Snorri Sturluson, *Heimskringla: History of the Kings of Norway*, trans. Lee M. Hollander (Austin: University of Texas Press, 1991), 14.

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provide; or Freyja was deemed necessary to the survival of the individual, family, and/or village; or a combination of both.

The information that we have about Freyja does not totally explain her importance. The *Eddas* mostly discuss her sexuality and desirability.[2] Other information about her is mentioned in passing. Her relationship to Óðinn, prosperity, *seiðr*, death, and birds all seem to play a part in her cult. Only if each passage about her is minutely examined, can we expect a complete picture of Freyja's cult.

As stated in the introduction, the Norse myths that have been passed down to us were poetry conceived and delivered by male court poets. These poets attempted to please an audience consisting mainly of male warriors and noblemen. The interest of the audience was in battle; ancient wars; and comic, naughty adventures. The poems we have and the handbooks written by Snorri, to preserve these poems, would be the modern day equivalent of a few programs from the history channel, a few prime-time situation comedies, and a couple of soap operas. From this patchwork of information, we can not expect to understand the nuances of cultic practice and belief. We especially can not expect to understand the cult of the Norse goddesses, who are barely mentioned in the sources.

It is stated several times that Freyja is the daughter of Njörðr and the sister of Freyr. She is one of the Vanir. The main body of Norse gods is called the Æsir.

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[2]*Lokasenna, Sörla Þattr, Hyndluljód, Skáldskaparmál,* and *Gylfaginning.*

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Near the beginning of time, the Vanir and the Æsir fought a series of wars. In order to bring about a lasting peace, hostages were exchanged by both sides. The Vanir sent Njörðr, Freyr, and Freyja as hostages of peace. In *Skáldskaparmál* (28, 44), Snorri states that the skaldic poets called Freyja the *Vanadís*, the *Vanabrudr*, or the *Vanagod*. These would translate as the *dís* of the Vanir, the bride of the Vanir, and the goddess of the Vanir. We do not have any sources remaining that call her these names, so we must trust Snorri that these were once Freyja's titles.

Freyja's Sexuality

In chapter 4 of *Ynglinga Saga* in *Heimskringla*, Snorri states that Freyja's father Njörðr was married to his sister; and Freyr and Freyja were the children of this union. Snorri quickly adds that it was the custom among the Vanir for siblings to marry. Freyja's incestuous beginning is only the first of several scandalous sexual peculiarities that are related in the stories about her. In stanzas 30-32 of the *Lokasenna*, Loki accuses Freyja of being a whore and of sleeping with her brother Freyr.

Loki qvað:
„Þegi þú, Freyia! þic kann ec fullgerva
era þér vamma vant;
ássa oc álfa, er hér inni ero
hverr hefir þinn hór verið.“

Freyia qvað:
„Flá er þér tunga, hygg ec, at þér fremr myni
ógott um gala;

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reiðir ro þér æsir oc ásynior,
hryggr muntu heim fara."

Loki qvað:
„Þegi þú, Freyia! þú ert fordæða
oc meini blandin mioc,
síztic at bræðr þínom stóðo blíð regin,
oc mundir þú þá, Freyia, frata."[3]

Loki said:
"Be quiet Freyja! That you are not faultless
I have plain proof:
all the elves and Æsir assembled here
have had you for a whore."

Freyja said:
"Your lying tongue will turn back on you
the evil charms it chants:
the gods are angry, the goddesses too-
you will go home gloomy."

Loki said:
"Be quiet, Freyja! You are a foul witch
and brew baleful poisons;
the gods found you in bed with your own brother.
Freyja when you farted."[4]

In this passage, Loki states that Freyja has had sex with all of the gods and all of the elves. He then adds that she also had sex with her own brother. Freyja does not really deny the first accusation. She simply states that if Loki continues to lie and abuse the gods that he will be sorry. No one else in the assemblage of gods comes to

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[3]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codes Regus nebst verwandten Denkmälern*, edited by Gustav Neckel. (Heidelberg: Carl Winter, 1983), pp. 102-103.

[4]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1990), p. 77.

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her rescue either, except in the next stanza, when her father changes the subject. In this passage, Freyja is portrayed as sexually promiscuous. She is so totally without restraint that she even has sex with her own brother.

In the poem *Hyndluljóð* in *Flateyjarbók*, the giantess Hyndla accuses Freyja of leaping around at night like Heidrun cavorting with a herd of goats. (Heidrun is a nanny goat that lives near Valhalla.) Freyja threatens Hyndla after Hyndla taunts her. Hyndla, then, states that many had found their way under Freyja's apron. Freyja never denies Hyndla's accusations; instead, Freyja attempts to intimidate Hyndla into silence.

Earlier in the same poem, Freyja cajoles Hyndla to come to *Valhall*a with her. Freyja tells Hyndla to get her wolf since Freyja's boar Hlidisvín can not carry them both. Hyndla then states that the boar is Freyja's lover, Ottar. Hyndla then says that Freyja rides her lover on the road to Valhalla. This passage has a double meaning and the innuendo would have been evident to the Scandinavian audience. By saying that she is riding her lover, the innuendo is that Freyja is having sex with him. Again Freyja is portrayed as promiscuous and without sexual restraint.

Another sexual escapade of Freyja concerns the *Brísingamen.* Several of the stories about and the allusions to Freyja contain references to the *Brísingamen.* The sources are inconclusive about whether this piece of jewelry is a necklace or a belt. In the poem *Þrymskviða* 13 and 19 and Snorri's *Gylfaginning* 34 and *Skáldskaparmál* 20, it is called the *Brísingamen,* which means "necklace of the Brisings." In the

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poem Haustlöng, it is called *Brísings girði,* which means "belt of the Brisings." Freyja probably owns a necklace and not a belt since the majority of the sources agree it is a necklace and because goddess figurines from the Neolithic and from later periods all wear necklaces to signify their divinity.[5]

The story of Freyja's acquisition of the *Brísingamen* is told in the *Sorla Þattr.* Four dwarfs made the *Brísingamen.* When Freyja saw it, she had to have it. She offered to buy it from the drawfs, but they did not want gold and silver in exchange for their craftsmanship. The dwarfs told Freyja that they would give the necklace to her if she would have sex for one night individually with each of them. Freyja spent one night with each dwarf, and they gave her the necklace. This story shows Freyja exchanging sex for gain with beings, whom the poem makes clear she finds repulsive.

In each of the above stories about Freyja's sexual appetites, Freyja is not portrayed as the victim. She appears to want and need sexual relations with men as much as they want her; however, there are other stories that portray Freyja as an object of obsession. In these stories, Freyja is an object of lust. Giants want to possess her, and she is unwilling to have sex with the males vying for her. In the poem *Þrymskviða,* the giant Þrym steals Þórr's hammer. In return for the hammer,

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[5]Both male and female figurines wear necklaces in the Neolithic. Gimbutas hypothesizes that the necklace might be symbolic of the goddesses or gods. See Marija Gimbutas, *The Goddesses and Gods of Old Europe: Myths and Cult Images 6500-3500BC* (University of California Press: Los Angeles, 1982), p. 44.

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Þrym wants to marry Freyja. Freyja refuses to marry the giant, so Þórr dresses up in Freyja's clothes, wears a veil, and borrows the *Brísingamen* to wear. Þórr's disguise convinces the giant that he is Freyja, and Þórr is then able to kill the giant and reclaim his hammer.

In *Gylfaginning* (42), the Æsir make a deal with a giant. If the giant can build a stronghold for them in one winter; then as his reward, they will give him Freyja. When it appears that the giant was going to have the stronghold finished in time, the gods have Loki impersonate a mare in heat and distract the giant's stallion, so the giant can not fulfill his part of the bargain. In *Skáldskaparmál* (24), the drunk giant Hrungnir threatens to kill all of the gods except Sif and Freyja, whom he threatens to carry home with him. The Æsir are unable to pacify him until Þórr arrives and kills him.

In three different stories, Freyja is an object of lust and obsession. Whenever giants feel that they have some leverage over the gods, they demand Freyja. Although we are told that she is a powerful goddess; she is treated as booty, ransom, and payment.

In the Norse myths, Freyja is portrayed as sexually amoral. She has had sex with her brother and all the gods and elves. She is openly accused of rutting like a goat in the night. She exchanges her sexual favors for gain, and she is lusted after by most if not all of the males with whom she comes in contact. This type of rampant

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sexuality is usually associated with fertility goddesses.[6] Although her sexuality is not in any way compared with the fertility of the fields, animals, or people in the myths; this might be due to the audience at which the stories were aimed. The warriors listening to these stories during a hard evening of drinking were probably more interested in sex for sex's sake than in fertility.

Óðinn and Óðr

In *Gylfaginning* (35), Freyja is said to be the wife of Óðr. We never actually meet Óðr in any of the sources. He is always away on long journeys, and Freyja weeps tears of gold for him. Óðr is mentioned at the end of the poem *Hyndluljóð* when the giantess tells Freyja that Óðr has always loved her. We are told in *Gylfaginning* that Freyja searched for Óðr in many strange lands. In *Sorla Þattr* Freyja is portrayed as the mistress of the chieftain Óðinn.

Ultimately Óðinn and Óðr appear to be the same being.[7] Both words are derived from the same root: Proto-Germanic **Wōð-*.[8] De Vries states that Óðr is an

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[6]For an analysis of sexuality, fertility, and agriculture see Mircea Eliade, *Patterns in Comparative Religion*, §83-139.

[7]Lotte Motz, *The Beauty and the Hag*, p. 97.

[8]We know that there was a 'w' before the 'o' because of the English cognate Wodan. In Old Norse the glide 'w' disappeared except before non-round vowels.

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older u-stem from the same root as Óðinn.[9] The Modern German word *Wut* has descended from this root. *Wut* means "rage, fury, frenzy." This seems a particularly appropriate name for Óðinn who is the god of magic and whom berserkers worship. Óðinn and Óðr are two different aspects of the same god. Freyja is portrayed as the mistress of one and the wife of the other.

Prosperity

Freyja is surrounded by imagery of opulence and prosperity. She always wears the beautiful and shining *Brísingamen.* Freyja has two daughters. Their names are Hnoss and Gersemi: both names mean "jewel." We are told that Freyja wept tears of gold; in fact, Freyja's tears is a kenning for gold. A kenning is a term used in Germanic poetry when a poet does not state the exact word that he needs in a situation, but instead he uses a poetic allusion or a metaphor.

Freyja wears a shining beautiful necklace, her children are jewels, she cries gold drops, and she is beautiful. All of her beauty and riches indicate that Freyja is a goddess of prosperity. She is the dispenser of wealth and all good things. In *Gylfaginning,* Snorri states that one of the names that Freyja is called is Gefn.[10] Gefn is related to the name for the goddess Gefjun and derives from the Germanic

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[9]Jan de Vries, *Altnordisches Etymologisches Wörterbuch,* p. 416.

[10]Snorri Sturluson, *The Prose Edda,* trans. Jean I. Young, 59.

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root **ghebh-* and means "Giver."[11] Freyja is associated with wealth and prosperity, and she is called the Giver. All of this evidence points to a goddess who, when pacified, distributes all of the things that make life pleasurable and comfortable.

Seiðr

In chapter 4 of *Ynglinga Saga* in *Heimskringla,* Snorri states, "It was she [Freyja] who first taught the Æsir magic such was practiced among the Vanir."[12] This magic was called *seiðr.* What exactly *seiðr* was, and what ceremonies it involved are unknown to us. The myths mention it but do not really describe it. In chapter 7 of *Ynglinga Saga,* Snorri tells us all that we are directly told about *seiðr.*

> *Óðinn kunni þá íþróttir svo að mestur máttur fylgdi og framdi sjálfur, er seiður heitir, en af því mátti hann vita örlög manna og óorðna hluti, svo og að gera mönnum bana eða óhamingju eða vanheilindi, svo og að taka frá mönnum vit eða afl og gefa öðrum. En þessi fjölkynngi, er framið er, fylgir svo mikil ergi að eigi þótti karlmönnum skammlaust við að fara og var gyðjunum kennd sú íþrótt.*[13]
>
> Oðinn had the skill which gives great power and which he practiced himself. It is called *seiðr*, and by means of it he could know the fate of men and predict events that had not yet come to pass; and by it he

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[11]See chapter four for the linguistic explanation.

[12]"Hún [Freyja] kenndi fyrst með Ásum seið sem Vönum var títt." Snorri Sturluson, *Heimskringla,* Kristjánsdóttir, Halldórsson, Torfason, and Thorsson (eds), p. 9; Snorri Sturluson, *Heimskringla*, trans. Lee M. Hollander, p. 8.

[13]Snorri Sturluson, *Heimskringla,* Kristjánsdóttir, Halldórsson, Torfason, and Thorsson (eds), p. 11.

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> could also inflict death or misfortune or sickness, or also deprive people of their wits or strength, and give them to others. But this sorcery is attended by such wickedness that manly men considered it shameful to practice it, and so it was taught to priestesses.[14]

The ceremonies involved in the practice of *seiðr* were somehow disgraceful for manly men. The word used to describe *seiðr* was *erg*. *Erg* appears to mean lewd behavior especially of a homosexual nature. Scholars have long wondered what these ceremonies must have contained. The practice of *seiðr* was very ancient and was primarily considered women's magic. *Ynglinga Saga* itself states that *seiðr* was taught primarily to priestesses. This female magic might have contained acts of ritual sex or simulated sex acts where the person conducting the ceremony took the female role. This could have been considered homosexual activity when men participated. It might also be true that the person had to dress in a certain ritual manner that was obviously feminine. In chapter 43 of the *Germania*, Tacitus tells of a ceremony practiced by certain German tribes.

> *apud Nahanarvalos antiquae religionis lucus ostenditur. praesidet sacerdos muliebri ornatu, sed deos interpretatione Romana Castorem Pollucemque memorant. ea vis numini, nomen Alcis. nulla simulacra, nullum peregrinae superstitionis vestigium; ut fratres tamen, ut iuvenes venerantur.*[15]

> Among these last is known a grove of immemorial sanctity. A priest in female attire has the charge of it. But the deities are described in Roman language as Castor and Pollux. Such, indeed, are the attributes of the divinity, the name being Alcis. They have no images,

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[14]Snorri Sturluson, Heimskringla, trans. Lee Hollander, p. 11.

[15]Tacitus, *Germania*, Allan A. Lund (ed)., p. 102.

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> or, indeed, any vestige of foreign superstition, but it is as brothers and as youths that the deities are worshipped.[16]

This passage shows that men performing ceremonies dressed as women was not unknown to the Germanic peoples and could be a continental form of *seiðr*. Whatever *seiðr* consisted of, it was considered wicked and disgraceful behavior for a man. Even Óðinn's greatness is somehow tainted by his participation in and knowledge of *seiðr*.

The Icelandic Sagas also have some information on *seiðr* but not much. In the poem *Völuspá*, a *völva* retells past events and foretells events in the future. In stanzas 7-8 and 21-24, she relates the story of the wars between the Vanir and the Æsir.[17] The poem is difficult to understand, and the meaning of the stanzas is dense and complicated. In this passage, the wars seem to be caused by the Æsir's treatment of a *völva* who practiced *seiðr*.

Hittuz æsir á Iðavelli,
þeir er hörg oc hof há timbroðo;
afla lögðo, auð smíðoðo,
tangir scópu oc tól gorðo.

Teflðo í túni, teitir vóro,
var þeim vættergis vant ór gulli,
unz þriár qvómo þursa meyiar,
ámátcar mioc, ór iotunheimom.

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[16]Tacitus, *Complete Works of Tacitus*, p. 730.

[17]I have followed Patricia Terry's and Paul Schach's organization of this very difficult poem because the poem reads and flows better with this organization.

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Þat man hon fólcvíg fyrst í heimi,
er Gullveigo geirom studdo
oc í höll Hárs hana brendo;
þrysvar brendo, þrysvar borna,
opt, ósialdan, þó hon enn lifir.

Heiði hana héto, hvars til húsa kom,
völo velspá, vitti hon ganda;
seið hon, hvars hon kunni, seið hon hug leikinn,
æ var hon angan illrar brúðar.

Þá gengo regin öll á röcstóla,
ginnheilög goð, oc um þat gættuz,
hvárt scyldo æsir afráð gialda
eða scyldo goðin öll gildi eiga.

Freygði Óðinn oc í fólc um scaut,
þat var enn fólcvíg fyrst í heimi;
brotinn var borðveggr borgar ása,
knátto vanir vígspá völlo sporna.[18]

Then the Æsir in Idavöll
built altars, temples, high timbered halls,
set up forges to fashion gold,
strong tools and well-shaped tongs.

Sitting in meadows, smiling over game boards.
they never knew any need of gold,
but there came three maidens monstrous to look at,
giant daughters of Jotunheim.

She remembers war, the first in the world.
Countless spears were cast at Gullveig,
her body burned in Oðinn's hall;
three times burned, three times born,
again and again, yet even now alive.

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[18]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, pp. 2, 5-6.

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Witch [Heið] was her name in the halls that knew her,
a sorceress [völva], casting evil spells;
she used magic [seiðr] to ensnare the mind,
a welcome friend to wicked women.

Then the mighty gods met to give judgement,
the mighty gods took counsel together:
should the Æsir accept great losses,
or all the gods be given what was due?

Oðinn's spear shot into the host-
that was the first war fought in the world.
The wall of Asgard proved too weak-
the victory was won by Vanir magic.[19]

The above passage appears to explain the beginning of the war between the Æsir and the Vanir. An exact sequence of events is difficult to interpret from the *völva's* disjointed, poetic style. A tentative time-line of events can, however, be constructed. The Æsir appear to be living an idyllic existence without need or greed until three monstrous giant women come into their land. One of the women appears to be named Gullveig. The entrance of these women into the Æsir's land seems to trigger violence. The Æsir attempt to kill Gullveig with spears. The Æsir continually fail to kill Gullveig with conventional weapons. They resort to fire: nature's destructive force. They burn her body three times, but Gullveig does not die. She is reborn anew. Since they can not kill Gullveig, the Æsir decide to declare war on the Vanir. Apparently, the three women are from the Vanir. The war is fought and the Æsir lose due to the Vanir's use of magic.

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[19]*Poems of the Elder Edda,* trans. Patricia Terry, pp. 2-3.

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At this point it is obvious that the Æsir are not dealing with a mortal woman or a giant but with a divine being. Gullveig cannot be killed by spears or fire. She is simply born again. The stanza after the attempted murder defames her. She is called a witch and a *völva.* She casts evil spells, and she is said to use *seiðr* to control minds. Here is a female deity with power. She is not from the Norse pantheon, so her power and divine being are denigrated. She is blamed for and called evil.

Why the Æsir attack Gullveig is not clear. We are not told of her power until after there are several attempts to kill her. One reason might be her name. Gullveig is a compound of two words *gull* and *veig. Gull* is the Old Norse word for "gold." *Veig* is an Old Norse word with several meanings. It can mean "strength, power, force, or strong drink." Gullveig then means "greed" or "gold lust." Gullveig's name and the reference in stanza 10 to the Æsir not ever having a need for gold indicate that the Æsir might have attempted to kill Gullveig out of greed.

The Æsir are minding their own business when three women come to their land. At least one of these women is fabulously wealthy. In true Viking tradition, the Æsir attempt to kill the women and steal their gold. When their murder attempts go awry, they decide to declare war on the women's tribe.

Gullveig appears to be a fertility goddess. Her ability to be burned and then born again points to a continually renewing force, such as a fertility goddess. Her name indicates that she is also a goddess of prosperity. Gullveig is also a

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practitioner of *seiðr*. In this poem, *seiðr* is practiced by a woman, probably a fertility goddess of great power. She can use that power to control people's minds; and perhaps, it is what protects her from the Æsir's attempts to kill her.

Another account of the use of *seiðr* takes place in *Örvar-Odds Saga*. In chapter 2, Odd's foster-father invites a *seiðkona* to predict the future. As she predicts the futures for all present, Odd hides because he does not want to know the future before it happens.

> *Nú ferr Ásmundr við inn fimta mann ok býðr völunni á Berurjóðr; hon tók því vel ok kvez koma mundu, ok þann sama aptan kemr hon þar með öllu liði sínu. Ingjaldr gengr í mót henni með fjölmenni ok leiðir hana í skála, ok efnaz þar veizla fögr . . . Ingjaldr ok völvan ætluðu til seiðar mikils um nóttina; gekk hon þá út með liði sínn, er aðrir gengu til svefns, ok efldi seið. Um morgininn eptir gekk Ingjaldr til frétta við heiði ok spurði, hversu seiðrinn hefði gengit.*[20]
>
> Asmund went off and invited the sorceress to the feast, and she accepted and came with her following. Ingjald went to meet her with his men and invited her into the hall. Then they got things ready for the performance of the witchcraft on the following night. After the meal was over, people went to sleep, but the prophetess and her company went to carry out their night-rituals. In the morning Ingjald came to see her and asked how the witchcraft had turned out.[21]

Ingjald and Asmund have their futures told and then:

> *Ásmundr gengr til sætis síns. Þá fór þannveg öll alþýða manna, ok sagði hon slíkt hverjum, sem fyrir var lagt. Allir una þar vel við. Ingjaldr bóndi þakkaði henni sitt starf.*[22]

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[20]*Örvar-Odds Saga*, edited by R.C. Boer, (E.J. Brill: Leiden, 1888), p. 11.

[21]*Seven Viking Romances*, trans. Hermann Pálsson and Paul Edwards, p. 28.

[22]*Örvar-Odds Saga*, edited by R.C. Boer, (E.J. Brill: Leiden, 1888), p. 13.

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> Then Asmund went back to his seat, and the rest of the household went in turn to the prophetess. She told each of them what the future held for him, and they were all pleased with their prospects. Then she predicted the weather for the following winter and a lot more that was not previously known. Ingjald thanked her for her prophecies.[23]

The *seiðkona* sees Odd hiding and says that she will give him a prophecy, too. He threatens to beat her with a stick if she does.

> *Œgðu eigi mér, Oddr á Jaðri!*
> *elda skíðum, þótt ýmist geipum;*
> *saga mun sannaz, sú er segir völva,*
> *öll veit [hon] manna ørlög fyrir.*[24]
>
> You'd better not try
> to bully me, Odd,
> with your bit of bough.
> even though I babble:
> the words of a witch
> were wise, you'll see,
> foretelling the future
> and the fate of all.[25]

In this passage the power of the *seiðkona* is simply that of prophecy. She is asked to the farm, and has an entourage that helps her prepare for the ceremony. Preparation for the ceremony takes place at night after the rest of the household has gone to sleep.

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[23]*Seven Viking Romances*, trans. Hermann Pálsson and Paul Edwards, p. 29.

[24]*Örvar-Odds Saga*, edited by R.C. Boer, (E.J. Brill: Leiden, 1888), p. 15.

[25]*Seven Viking Romances*, trans. Hermann Pálsson and Paul Edwards (New York: Penguin Books, 1985), pp. 28-29.

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In *Landnámabók*, a *seiðkona* named Þuriðr filled the fjord with herring during a bad crop year. In this instance, *seiðr* appears almost to be a nature magic that controls animals. Here the *seiðkona* is a positive force in the community. In the first two passages, the women who practiced *seiðr* are also called *völvas*. The myths and sagas have several stories concerning the power of *völvas*. I will give some of the more detailed examples of these since they might shed more light on the role of the seeress and sorceress (*völva* and *seiðkona*) in Icelandic society and belief.

In chapter 3 of *Eiríks Saga Rauði*, the saga about Greenland and voyages to North America, a woman who is called a *litil-völva* makes prophecies.

> *Í þenna tíma var hallæri mikit á Grœnlandi; höfðu menn fengit lítit fang, þeir er í veiðiferðir höfðu farit, en sumir ekki aptr komnir. Sú kona var þar í byggð, er Þorbjörg hét; hon var spákona ok var kölluð lítil-völva. Hon hafði átt sér níu systr, ok váru allar spákonur, en hon ein var þá á lífi. Þat var háttr Þorbjargar um vetrum, at hon fór at veizlum, ok buðu þeir menn henni mest heim, er forvitni var á at vita forlög sín eða árferð; ok með því at Þorkell var þar mestr bóndi, þá þótti til hans koma at vita, hvé nær létta myndi óárani þessu, sem yfir stóð. Býðr Þorkell spákonunni heim, ok er henni þar vel fagnat, sem siðr var til, þá er við þess háttar konum skyldi taka. Var henni búit hásæti ok lagt undir hana hœgindi; þar skyldi í vera hœnsafiðri.*[26]
>
> At this same time there was a great famine in Greenland; men who had gone out fishing caught poor catches, and some never came back. There was a woman there in the Settlement whose name was Þorbjorg; she was a seeress and was called the Little Sibyl. She had had nine sisters, all of them seeresses, but now only she was left alive. It was Þorbjorg's practice in the winter to attend feasts, and those men in particular invited her to their homes who were curious to

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[26]*Eyrbyggja Saga, Brands Þáttr Örva, Eiríks Saga Rauða, Grœnlendinga Saga, Grœnlendinga Þáttr,* in *Íslenzk Fornrit* vol. 4, Edited by Einar Ól. Sveinsson and Matthías Þórðarson, (Hið Íslenzka Fornritafélag: Reykjavik, 1935), p. 206.

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> know their fate or the season's prospects. Because Þorkel was the leading householder there it was thought to be his responsibility to find out when these hard times which now troubled them would cease, so he invited her to his home, and a good reception was prepared for her, as was the custom when a woman of this kind should be received. A high-seat was made ready for her, and a cushion laid down, in which there must be hen's feathers.[27]

Þorbjorg's clothing and paraphernalia are detailed in this saga. She carries with her a staff with a knob that was ornamented in brass on it. The staff had stones just below the knob. She also had a big skin pouch on her belt in which her magic charms were kept. As in the *Landnámabók* example, this woman is asked to the feast during a time of crisis. People wanted to know when the famine would end. She is treated with respect and a high seat is made ready for her. She is then shown the farm and the house. After dinner, the assembly asks her what her opinion is, and she tells them that she will have answers for them the next morning.

> *En um morgininn, at áliðnum degi, var henni veittr sá umbúningr, sem hon þurfti at hafa til at fremja seiðinn. Hon bað ok fá sér konur þær, er kynni fræði þat, sem til seiðsins þarf ok Varðlokur hétu. En þær konur fundusk eigi. Þá var leitat at um bœinn, ef nökkurr kynni. Þá segir Guðríðr: "Hvárki em ek fjölkunnig né vísindakona, en þó kenndi Halldís, fóstra mín, mér á Íslandi þat kvæði, er hon kallaði Varðlokur."*[28]

> But on the morrow, towards the end of the day, she was fitted out with the apparatus she needed to perform her spells. She asked too to procure her such women as knew the lore which was necessary for the spell, and bore the name *Varðlokur* or Spiritlocks. But no such

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[27]*Eirik the Red and Other Icelandic Sagas*, trans. Gwyn Jones, (New York: Oxford University Press, 1980), pp. 133-134.

[28]*Eyrbyggja Saga, Brands Þáttr Örva, Eiríks Saga Rauða*, p. 207-208.

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> women were to be found, so there was a search right through the house to find whether anyone was versed in these matters. 'I am unversed in magic, neither am I a prophetess,' said Gudrid then, 'but Halldis my foster-mother taught me in Iceland the chant which she called *Varðlokur*.'[29]

Gudrid is unwilling at first to take part in a heathen ritual, but she is pressured by the others so that the ceremony can take place.

> *Slógu þá konur hring um hjallinn, en Þorbjörg sat á uppi. Kvað Guðríðr þá kvæðit svá fagrt ok vel, at engi þóttisk heyrt hafa með fegri rödd kvæði kveðit, sá er þar var hjá. Spákonan þakkar henni kvæðit ok kvað margar þær náttúrur nú til hafa sótt ok þykkja fagrt at heyra, er kvæðit var svá vel flutt, -- "er áðr vildu við oss skiljask ok enga hlýðni oss veita. En mér eru nú margir þeir hlutir auðsýnir, er áðr var ek dulið, ok margir aðrir."*[30]
>
> The women now formed a circle round the platform on which Þorbjorg was seated. Gudrid recited the chant so beautifully and well that no one who was present could say he had heard a chant recited in a lovelier voice. The seeress thanked her for the chant, adding that many spirits had been drawn there now who thought it lovely to lend ear, the chant had been so admirably delivered--spirits 'who before wished to keep their distance from us and give us no hearing. And now many things are apparent to me which earlier were hidden from me as from many others.'[31]

Þorbjorg then was able to tell the assembled people that the famine would end soon, and the sickness that was infecting people would also soon be gone. She then told the individual futures of several of those present. She was then sent for by another house, and she went off.

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[29]*Eirik the Red and Other Icelandic Sagas*, trans. Gwyn Jones, p. 135.

[30]*Eyrbyggja Saga, Brands Þáttr Örva, Eiríks Saga Rauða*,p. 208.

[31]*Eirik the Red and Other Icelandic Sagas*, trans. Gwyn Jones, p. 136.

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This passage portrays the *völva* as a prophetess. She needs a special chant to be sung for her to perform her magic. Only women take part in the ceremony, but the men watch and ask questions. The *völva* receives her knowledge from the spirit world that only she can perceive. We also have Christians taking part in the ceremony, so they can find out when the current famine will end and what their fates will be.

Another interesting feature is the staff which the *völva* carries. A *seiðstafr* along with bones and a brooch was found under the floor boards of a church in chapter 76 of *Laxdæla Saga.* These were thought to have belonged to a witch and were reburied in a more isolated area. In chapter 44 of *Vatnsdæla Saga,* a woman of "foresight and knowledge" gives Þorkel her black cloak and her *stafsproti.* He is to use her staff to tap Gudmund's cheek three times. This causes Gudmund to lose his memory, so a settlement can be made in a murder case.[32] These staffs are reminiscent of the magic wands of folklore, and are probably the direct ancestors of them.

Völvas could apparently also find people in the present as well as foresee the future. In *Hrólfs Saga Kraka,* King Froði searches for his nephews after he killed his brother and took over the kingdom. The king wanted to kill his nephews also, but they had friends who hid them well. The king resorts to using a *völva* to find them.

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[32]Katherine Morris, *Sorceress or Witch? The Image of Gender in Medieval Iceland and Northern Europe* (New York: University Press of America, 1991), p. 47.

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> *Völva ein var þar komin, sem Heiðr hét; hana bað Fróði konungr at neyta listar sinnar ok vita, hvat hún kynni at segja til sveinanna; gerði hann þá gilda veizlu í móti henni ok setti hana á seiðhjall einn háan. Konungr spyrr þá, hvat hún sæi til tíðinda -- "Þvi at ek veit, sagði hann, at nú mun mart fyrir þik bera, ok sé ek nú mikla gæfu á þér ok svara mér sem skjótast."*[33]
>
> A wise woman had come there, by the name of Heið, and King Froði bade her use her magic arts and see what she could report concerning the boys. He prepared a feast against her coming, and set her on a high scaffold for her spell-making. Then the king asked her what she could see that was worth telling. 'For I know,' he told her, 'that many things will now be revealed to you, and I observe omens of great good fortune in you, so answer me, sorceress, as fast as you can.'[34]

As in *Eiríks Saga Rauði,* a seat on a high platform or perhaps stage was fashioned for the *völva.* There is a feast planned for her visit, and she is asked to answer a specific question. The *völva* apparently played an important role in Icelandic society. Since some of the *völvas* in our sources also practice *seiðr*, it is possible that the two are related. Since Freyja was the person who brought *seiðr* to the Æsir, and *seiðr* was taught to priestesses; the cult of Freyja probably played an important role in the practice of *seiðr* by the *völvas.*

Prophecy seems to have been a particularly female attribute in Icelandic society. The practice of women predicting the future is ancient in the Germanic world. In chapter 8 of the *Germania,* Tacitus relates how the Germans thought that women had a particular gift for prophecy.

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[33]*Hrólfs Saga Kraka og Bjarkarímur,* edited by Finnur Jónsson (S.L. Møllers: Copenhagen, 1904), p. 11.

[34]*Eirik the Red and Other Icelandic Sagas,* trans. Gwyn Jones, p. 227.

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> inesse quin etaim sanctum aliquid et providum putant, nec aut concilia earum aspernantur aut responsa neglegunt. vidimus sub divo Vespasiano Veledam diu apud plerosque numinis loco habitam; sed et olim Auriniam et compluris alias venerati sunt, non adulatione nec tamquam facerent deas.[35]
>
> They even believe that the sex [female] has a certain sanctity and prescience, and they do not despise their counsels, or make light of their answers. In Vespasian's days we saw Veleda long regarded by many as a divinity. In former times, too, they venerated Aurinia, and many other women, but not with servile flatteries, or with sham deification.[36]

Tacitus and the poet Statius both mention Veleda.[37] Veleda was a seeress of the Bructeri tribe who foretold the victories of the Germans over the Romans in 69 C.E. According to Book 4, Chapter 65 of Tacitus's *The Histories*, Veleda lived in a high tower; and no one was allowed to speak directly with her. Veleda's relatives apparently acted as messengers and conveyed the questions and answers to and from her.[38] After the defeat of the Germans, Veleda entered the service of the Roman Emperor.

Veleda and Aurinia are not the only German seeresses mentioned by name. Cassius Dio (67.5.3) notes that in 91 C.E. the virgin Ganna and King Masyos of the Semnones were honored by the Emperor Domitian at Rome, and then they went

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[35]Tacitus, *Germania*, Allan A. Lund (ed)., p. 76.

[36]Tacitus, *Complete Works of Tacitus*, p. 713.

[37]Tacitus, *Hist.* (4, 61, 4), (4, 65, 4), (5, 22, 5), and (5, 24, 5); and Statius, *Silvae* (I, iv, 89).

[38]Tacitus, *Complete Works of Tacitus*, p. 639.

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back to their homeland. Cassius Dio describes Ganna as the successor of Veleda. Suetonius in chapter 14 of *Vitellius* tells of a Chattian woman whom Vitellius asked to tell the future. She prophesied that he would have a long and secure reign if he outlived his mother. Paying heed to the seeress's advice, Vitellius starved his mother to death after she fell sick.

Several sources only mention generic wise women and attempt to describe the rituals they used to foresee the future. Plutarch, in chapter 19 of his work on Julius Caesar, mentions that German warriors were influenced by the prophecies of wise women. Plutarch states that wise women foretold the future "by observing the eddies in the rivers, and by finding signs in the whirling and in the noise of the water."[39] While some women used water to forecast the future, others used blood. Strabo in *Geography* (7.2) describes how the seeresses of the Cimbric tribe wore white robes and walked barefoot. The seeresses placed wreaths on prisoners of war and led them to large cauldrons. There the women slit the prisoners' throats, and from the pouring blood they would forecast the future. Others would slit open the body and inspect the entrails in order to make a prophecy.

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[39]"ἔτι δὲ μᾶλλον αὐτοὺς ἤμβλυνε τὰ μαντεύματα τῶν ἱερῶν γυναικῶν, αἳ ποταμῶν δίναις προσβλέπουσαι καὶ ῥευμάτων ἐλιγμοῖς καὶ ψόφοις τεκμαιρόμεναι προεθέσπιζον," Plutarch's Lives, trans. Bernadotte Perrin, (Harvard University Press: Cambridge, Massachusetts, 1971), p. 488. Plutarch, *Fall of the Roman Republic: Six Lives by Plutarch*, trans. Rex Warner (New York: Viking Penguin, 1984) p. 263.

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Later native German and Scandinavian historians also mention women with unusual powers. Jordanes, in chapter 24 of *Getica de origine, actibusque Getarum*, tells how Filimer, one of the early kings of the Goths, found witches among his people. Filimer expelled these women, and they were forced to wander the countryside. Later they became the forbearers of the Huns. Jordanes never reports why these women were considered witches; however, the word "witches" itself denotes that these women were thought to control certain powers and were held in awe.

In book 1 chapter 3 of *Historia Langobardorum*, when Paul the Deacon mentions the first known leaders of the Langobards, he states that their mother's name was Gambara. "She was a woman of the keenest ability and most prudent in counsel among her people, and they trusted not a little her shrewdness in doubtful matters."[40] Paul's account of the respect which Gambara was held is reminiscent of Tacitus's statement that the counsels of women were not despised. While both of these passages do not directly mention prophecy, the women mentioned were considered exceptional and powerful.

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[40] *"Horum erat ducum mater nomine Gambara, mulier quantum inter suos et ingenio acris et conciliis provida; de cuius in rebus dubiis prudentia non minimum confidebant."* Societas Aperiendis Fontius Rerum Germanicarum Medii Aevi (eds), *Monumenta Germaniae Historica: Scriptores Rerum Langobardicarum et Italicarum.* p. 49; Paul the Deacon, *The History of the Lombards*, trans. William Didley Foulke, ed. Edward Peters (Philadelphia, Penn: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1974).

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Gregory of Tours in *Historia Francorum* mentions three instances in which women were believed to have unusual powers. Gregory was writing of events in the late sixth century. Each passage deals with a woman who appears to have the ability to see the future or the immediate past.

In book 8 section 31, Gregory of Tours reports that a woman warned the citizens of Paris of a huge fire three days before the city burned down. In book 5 section 14, while telling of Merovech's hiding in the Church of Saint Martin at Tours, Gregory adds that one of Merovech's men had sent for a "certain woman who was supposed to have the power of prophecy."[41] When she was asked to foretell the future; she revealed the year, day, and hour of King Charibert's death. She also foretold the future of the man who sent for her.

In book 7 section 44, Gregory of Tours tells how a woman in Verdun, who had a gift of prophesy, earned so much money that her masters set her free. She had the ability to immediately pinpoint who had robbed someone, and what they did with the stolen goods. Gregory states that "Every day she acquired more and more gold

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[41] *"Tunc direxit Gunthchramnus puerum ad mulierem quandam sibi iam cognitam a tempori Chariberthi regis, habentem spiritum phitonis ut ei quae erant eventura narraret."* Gregorii Episcopi Turonensis, *Historiarum Libri Decem*, vol 1, Books 1-5. Rudolf Buchner (ed). (Wissenschaftliche Buchgesellschaft: Darmstadt, 1964), p. 302; Gregory of Tours, *The History of the Franks*, trans. Lewis Thorpe (New York: Viking Penguin 1974), pp. 269-270.

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and silver, and she would walk about so loaded with jewelry that she was looked upon by the common people as a sort of a goddess."[42]

Gregory's woman of Verdun and Veleda were both treated as deities by the people. The awe accorded those with the ability to accurately predict the actions ofothers appears to have been commensurate with the awe rendered to a deity. These women were given gifts and offered presents as one would offer a sacrifice to a deity.

In *Gesta Danorum,* Saxo Grammaticus relates several instances when a seeress is called in to help with a particular problem. Book 7 (182) relates the same story that is told in *Hrólfs Saga Kraka.* King Froði does not believe that his nephews are dead and wishes to find where they are hidden. He summons a woman with the ability to use incantations to call to her hands something at a distance, which is visible to her alone. She tells Froði that a man named Regni was bringing up Froði's nephews. For secrecy, the boys were given dog names. When the boys feel themselves pulled out to the wise woman's gaze, they fill her lap with gold. With this bribe, she feigns illness and collapses.

In Book 8 (235), the Hellespontines decided that they did not have a large enough force to attack Jarmerik's stronghold and consulted a witch named Guthrun.

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[42] *"Congregabat cotidie aurum argentumque, procedens in ornamentis, ita ut putaretur esse aliquid divinum in populis."* Gregorii Episcopi Turonensis, *Historiarum Libri Decem,* vol. 2, Books 6-10. Rudolf Buchner (ed). (Wissenschaftliche Buchgesellschaft: Darmstadt, 1964), p. 105; Gregory of Tours, *The History of the Franks*, trans. Lewis Thorpe, pp. 426-427.

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Her magic made the defenders blind and turned their weapons against one another. In Book 9 (255), Regner decided to storm Saxony. At first, he had good luck. Then a dwarfish woman who was a soothsayer warned Charles, the King of the Franks, that Sivard's fleet was moored at the mouth of the Seeve river. Her prophecy saved the day for the Franks.

These passages show that king and warrior used the knowledge and power of seeresses in war and politics. In the first two passages from the *Gesta Danorum,* a seeress's help is requested. Similar to the cases of Veleda, the Chattian woman, the woman at Tours, and the woman of Verdun; these women use their powers on request and are accorded great respect. They are a useful tool both for society and for a particular leader.

The tradition of women with powers of prophecy can be traced back into ancient times. This tradition was strong in the mythology, literature, and history of the Germanic peoples. The Franks, Danes, Norsemen, Cimbri, and other Germanic peoples have recorded testament of women with power helping individuals, villages, and kings with their knowledge. Freyja's connection to *seiðr* and *seiðr's* connection to prophecy might help explain why her cult continued while the cults of the male gods faded away with the entrance of Christianity. These seeresses were powerful and held an honored place in society.

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Death

Freyja has several associations with death and the dead. In *Gylfaginning* (24), Snorri relates Freyja's connection to death.

> *En Freyja er ágætust af Ásynjum. Hon á þann bœ á himni er Fólkvangar heita, ok hvar sem hon ríðr til vígs þá á hon hálfan val, en hálfan Óðinn, svá sem hér segir:*
>
> *Fólkvangr heitir,*
> *en þar Freyja ræðr*
> *sessa kostum í sal.*
> *Hálfan val*
> *hon kýss á hverjan dag,*
> *en hálfan Óðinn á.*[43]
>
> But Freyja is the most renowned of the goddesses. She owns that homestead in heaven known as Fólkvangar, and whenever she rides into battle she has half the slain and Oðinn half, as it says here:
>
> Fólkvangar's where
> Freyja decides
> who shall sit where in the hall;
> half the slain every day
> she chooses
> and Oðinn has half.[44]

The Eddic poem *Grímnismál* repeats the same information as the *Gylfaginning*. In chapter 78 of *Egils Saga*, Egil's daughter threatens to commit suicide saying, "I shall

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[43]Snorri, Sturluson, *Edda: Prologue and Gylfaginning,* edited by Anthony Faulkes, (Clarendon Press: Oxford, 1982), p. 24.

[44]*The Prose Edda of Snorri Sturluson,* trans. Jean I. Young, p. 53.

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take no food until I sup with Freyja"[45] insinuating that when she died, she would go to Freyja.

The passage from *Gylfaginning* positions Freyja equal to Óðinn if not superior to him. Not only does she receive half the slain each day as Óðinn does, but she gets to choose which ones she wants first. In the passage from *Egils Saga*, it is unclear why a woman committing suicide would go to Freyja at her death. Is it because women go to her, or is it because suicides go to her? It might be that 'to sup with Freyja' was a cliché that meant to die, but we have no other attestations of it.

In *Sörla Þattr* in *Flateyjarbók*, Óðinn is furious with Freyja for having sex with dwarfs to obtain the *Brísingamen*. He arranges to have the necklace stolen as she sleeps. When she demands her necklace back, he gives her an ultimatum. He will only return her necklace if she will use her spells to stir up war and to give new life to the corpses left on the battlefield. Óðinn wants the armies to fight, die, rise and fight again in perpetuity.

In this story, Freyja is portrayed as having more power over the dead than Óðinn. Even with all of his great powers, he must blackmail Freyja to raise the dead for him. Freyja's intimate connection with death gives her cult a more serious dimension. This connection to death might help explain the longevity of her cult.

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[45] *"Engan hefi ek náttverð haft, ok engan mun ek, fyrr en at Freyju."* *Egils Saga Skalla-Grímssonar* in *Íslenzk Fornrit* vol. 2, edited by Sigurður Nordal, (Hið Íslenzka: Reykjavik, 1933); *Egil's Saga*, trans. Hermann Pálsson and Paul Edwards, (New York: Penguin Books, 1976), p. 203.

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People's funerary beliefs usually tend to remain conservative. It is not unbelievable that good Christians might hedge their bets at death. They might have followed the rituals involved in the cult of Freyja and the cult of the new Christian God. Having dual faith in both Norse deities and the Christian deity was not unknown in Medieval Scandinavia. In *Landnámabók*, we are told that Helgi the Lean believed in Christ, but he consulted Þór for voyages and in difficult times.[46] It is equally as possible for people to believe in Christ and to continue to invoke Freyja when someone died.

Bird/Woman[47]

In two different stories, we are told that Freyja had a feather form that she could loan out. In stanza 3 of *Þrymskviða*, the Eddic poem in which Þórr's hammer is stolen, Þórr asks Freyja if Loki can borrow her feather coat, so he can search for Þórr's hammer. " 'Freyja, will you lend your feather coat to Loki?/ To find my hammer he will have to fly.' "[48] In the *Skáldskaparmál* (3), Snorri tells the story of the kidnapping of Iðunn and her apples. Loki was blamed for allowing the

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[46]*The Book of Settlements: Landnámabók*, trans. Hermann Pálsson and Paul Edwards (Manitoba: University of Manitoba Press, 1972), §218.

[47]It is unlikely that the hen feathers used to fill the völva's seat pillow in the *seiðr* ritual mentioned in *Eiriks Saga Rauða* was associated with the bird/woman complex. Feathers were a common stuffing for pillows and bedding.

[48]*"Muntu mér, Freyja, fiaðrhams ljá,/ef ec minn hamar mættac hitta?" Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 111; *Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, p. 85.

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kidnapping to take place, so he offered to attempt to regain Iðunn and her apples. "He grew so frightened that he said he would go after Iðunn into Giantland if Freyja would lend him her falcon coat."[49] In both instances, Loki borrows Freyja's bird form. No other deity appears to own one although we are told that Óðinn could shape change. Freyja seems to be the only deity who possesses an ornithological form in the Eddas. Her feather coat seems to be conceived of as some sort of cloak or shift. This garment turned whoever wore it into a bird. The same idea seems to be behind the swan shapes found in *Völundarkviða.*

In the prose section of *Völundarkviða*, Völundr and his two brothers capture three Valkyries, who are spinning thread by a lake, and marry them. They capture the Valkyries by stealing their swan shapes. Without their swan shapes, the Valkyries apparently cannot fly away.

> *Bræðr vóru þrír, synir Finnakonungs. Hét einn Slagfiðr, annar Egill, þriði Völundr. Þeir scriðo oc veiddo dýr. Þeir kvómo í Úlfdali oc gerðo sér þar hús. Þar er vatn, er heitir Úlfsiár. Snemma of morgin fundo þeir á vatzströndo konor þriár, oc spunno lín. Þar vóro hiá þeim álptarhamir þeira. Þat vóro valkyrior. Þar vóro tvær dætr Hlöðvés konungs, Hlaðguðr svanhvít oc Hervor alvitur, in þriðia var Ölrún Kiárs dóttir af Vallandi. Þeir höfðu þær heim til scála með sér. Fécc Egill Ölrúnar, enn Slagfiðr Svanhvítrar, enn Völundr Alvitrar. Þau bioggo siau vetr. Þá flugo þær að vitja víga oc qvómo eigi aptr.*[50]

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[49]"*En er hann varð hræddur þá kvaðst hann myndu sækja eftir Iðunni í Jötunheima ef Freyja vill ljá honumvalshams er hún á.*" Snorra Sturlusonar, *Edda,* Heimir Pálsson (ed), p. 80; *The Prose Edda of Snorri Sturluson,* trans. Jean I. Young, pp. 98-99.

[50]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius,* p. 116.

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> There were three brothers who were the sons of a Finnish king. One was called Slagfid, another Egil, the third Volund. They were out on snowshoes after game. They came to Wolfdales and built themselves a house there. Early one morning they found on the shore three women who were spinning flax. Their swanskins were lying beside them. They were valkyries; two were daughters of King Hlodver, Hladgud the Swan White and Hervor the Wise, and the third was Olrunn, the daughter of Kjar from Valland. The brothers took them home. Egil married Olrunn; Slagfid, Swan White; and Volund, Hervor. They lived together for seven years. Then the valkyries flew away to go to battles, and did not come back.[51]

In this passage the women have swanskins instead of a feather coat, but the concept appears to be exactly the same. They remain in human form until they put on their swan skins; then they become birds. In stanza 155 of *Hávamál*, which consists of wise sayings, we are told, "Any time I see witches sailing the sky/the spell I sing sends them off their course/when they lose their skins/they fail to find their homes."[52] This passage also seems to suggest that in order for these witches to fly; they needed some kind of skin, perhaps something like Freyja's feather form. Without these skins, they are unable to fly. In stanza 6 of *Helreið Brynhildar,* Brynhild talks of her girlhood. "The fearless king let our feather cloaks fall -- we were eight sisters -- under an oak."[53] Each of these passages makes a reference to

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[51]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, p. 97.

[52]*"ef ec sé túnriðor leica lopti á: ec svá vinnc, at þeir villir fara sinna heim hama, sinna heim huga" Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 43; *Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, pp. 36-37.

[53]*Lét hami vára hugfullr konungur, átta systra, undir eic borit" Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 220; *Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, p. 190.

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women who can fly using some kind of skin, coat, or cloak. The concept of women who could change into birds or fly with the help of a special garment must have been accepted and commonly known.

Old Norse poetry is not the only source that tells of women who have special clothing that allow them to fly. In the story "The Drummer" in Grimms' *Kinder- und Hausmärchen*, a drummer found three pieces of fine linen lying beside a lake. He put one piece in his pocket and walked away. That night while he was lying in bed, he heard someone call to him.

> *Er horchte und vernaahm eine leise Stimme, die ihm zurief "Trommeler, Trommeler, wach auf." Er konnte, da es finstere Nacht war, niemand sehen, aber es kam ihm vor, als schwebte eine Gestalt vor seinem Bett auf und ab. "Was willst du?" fragte er. "Gib mir mein Hemdchen zurück," antwortete die Stimme, "das du mir gestern abend am See weggenommen hast." "Du sollst es wiederhaben," sprach der Trommler, "wenn du mir sagst, wer du bist." "Ach," erwiderte die Stimme, "ich bin die Tochter eines mächtigen Königs, aber ich bin in die Gewalt einer Hexe geraten und bin auf den Glasberg gebannt. Jeden Tag muß ich mit meinen zwei Schwestern im See baden, aber ohne mein Hemdchen kann ich nicht wieder fortfliegen.*[54]
>
> "Drummer, drummer, wake up!." Since it was pitch black, he could not see anyone, but it seemed to him that a figure was hovering above his bed. "What do you want?" he asked. "Give me back my little blouse that you took from me this evening by the lake." the voice answered. "I'll return it to you," the drummer said, "if you tell me who you are." "Ah," replied the voice. "I'm the daughter of a mighty king, but I've fallen under the spell of a witch and have been sentenced to live on the glass mountain. Every day I bathe in the lake with my two sisters, but without my little blouse I cannot fly back to

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[54]Jakob and Wilhelm Grimm, *Kinder- und Hausmärchen*, (Munich: Winkler, 1966), pp. 782-783.

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> the mountain. My sisters have already flown away, but I've been forced to stay behind. I beseech you to give me back my little blouse.[55]

The enchanted princess in this tale apparently has the same kind of outfit as Freyja and the valkyries. All three have some sort of outfit that allows the wearer to fly. The concept behind this costume is a simple explanation for the ability to transform oneself into a bird. Everyone knows that people can not fly. The problem then was to explain why in certain myths and stories some women could fly. This explanation was rendered by the existence of these garments that enabled the wearer to fly. The reasoning behind these garments proves that at some preliterate time some women, probably divine beings, were conceived of as part-bird and part-woman.

After Christianity was adopted, certain traits of the goddesses and Valkyries were inherited by witches. In North European folklore, witches have the ability to turn themselves into birds. In Germany, a sportsman once shot at some wild geese and hit one. When he reached the place were the bird had fallen, there sat a naked woman who was unharmed, and whom he knew very well.[56]

In Denmark, at Østrel on the road between Aalborg and Thisted, a huntsman frequently saw a hare or wild duck, but he was never able to hit one when he shot at them. One day he took a silver button off his jacket and shot at the duck. He hit the

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[55]Jacob and Wilhelm Grimm, *The Complete Fairy Tales of the Brothers Grimm*, trans. Jack Zipes, (New York: Bantam Books, 1992), p. 606.

[56]Jacob Grimm, *Teutonic Mythology*, 4 vols., trans. James Steven Stallybrass (Gloucester, Mass: Peter Smith 1976), Vol. 3, p. 1098. From Mone's Anz. 6, 395.

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duck, and it flew to a nearby farm and hid in the hen house. The hunter ran to the farm and told the farmer what had happened. He was told to go to the kitchen and have the maid collect his duck. When he went into the kitchen, there was a hideous old woman sitting by the fire. She was wearing only one shoe, and blood was streaming down her leg from a wound. She said that she got hurt by falling and cutting herself. The huntsman knew that he had shot a witch and ran away.[57]

These two nineteenth-century stories about witches who could turn themselves into birds show a continuation of the belief that powerful women could transform themselves at will. The ability of witches to transport themselves from place to place by flying on broomsticks might be a remnant of the belief that powerful women had bird-like characteristics and the ability to fly. The Christian context of these stories necessitates that women with this type of power must be evil; however, the essential facts have remained unchanged since the time of Freyja's cult. Women with powers outside of the normal sphere have the ability to transform themselves into birds.

During the Bronze and Iron Ages, bird ornamentation on funerary objects was frequent. The use of bird figures in ornamentation is characteristic for the Urnfield culture of Central Europe from about 1500 B.C.E. Bird figures were

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[57]*Scandinavian Folktales, ed., trans.* Jacqueline Simpson (New York: Viking Penguin 1988), p. 154. From J.M. Thiele, *Danmarks Folkesagn* (Copenhagen: 1843), Vol. 2 pp. 103-4. Reidar Th. Christiansen, *The Migratory Legends* (Helsinki: 1958), "The Witch Who Was Hurt" 3055.

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engraved or bossed on bronze vessels made into buttons, and used as decoration on miniature ritual vehicles. The bird motif has been associated with sun worship.[58] Several of these bird figures are associated with circular ornamentation which is often related to sun symbolism. The bird figures on minature vehicles have been compared to the horse in the Trundholm Sun Chariot from Zealand in Denmark. The solar symbolism on certain items is undeniable, but categorizing all bird firgures as a feature of sun worship is unmerited. Several of the Urnfield bird figurines are in the context of burial, disposal of the dead, or part of grave goods.

Several small ritual bird-powered vehicles have been found in Iron Age contexts. One bronze vehicle from Potsdam consists of three wheels of equal size. Each wheel has four spokes. All the wheels are in a row on the same axle. Attached between the wheels is a fork-shaped handle. The two tines of the fork continue beyond the axle in upward curves. The ends of the tines are curved forward with flapping wings atttached at the apex of the curve. The overall impression is of flying birds pulling a chariot. On each tine, near the back of the wheels, sits a bird on a pole. Each bird sits on a center pole facing forward. On the handle of the fork sit two identical birds, one near the crook in the fork and the other near the end of the handle. The end of the handle has a small horizontal hole through it. (Figure 8)

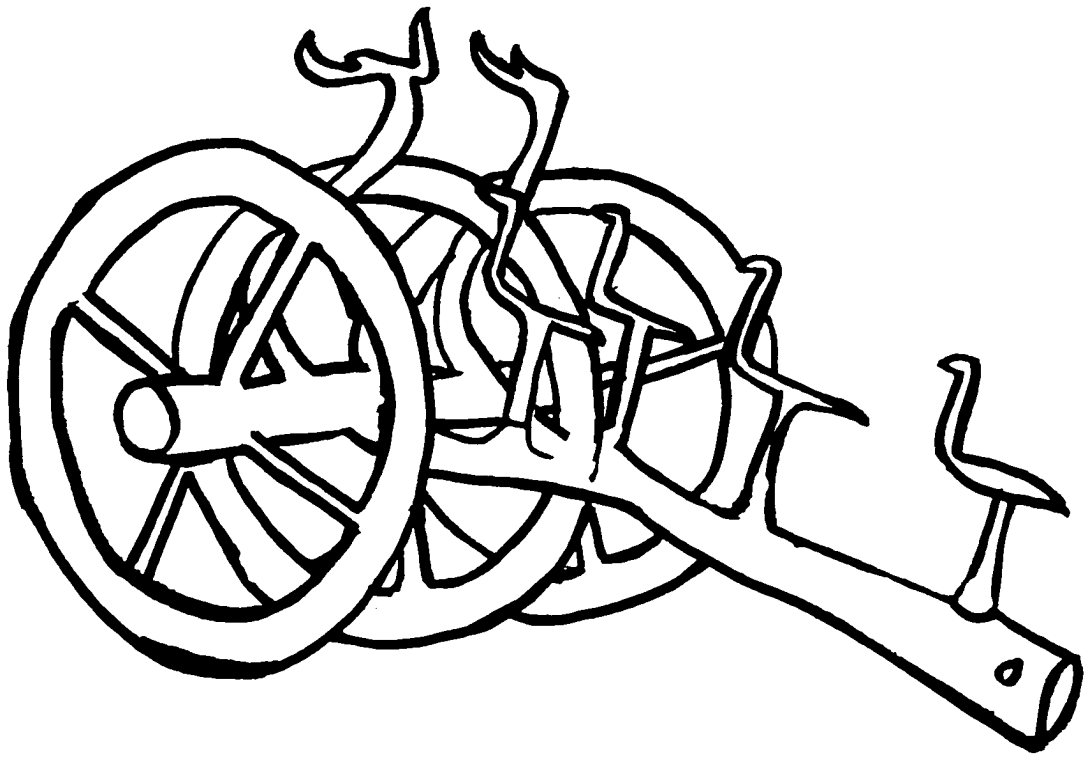
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[58]Georg Kossack, *Studien zum symbolgut der Urnenfelder- und Hallstattzeit Mitteleuropas*, in *Römisch-Germanische Kommission des Deutschen Archäologischen Instituts zu Frankfurt A.M. Römanisch-Germanische Forschungen*, vol. 20 (Berlin: Walter de Gruyter, 1954), p. 50.

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FIGURE 8

BRONZE, BIRD-POWERED RITUAL VEHICLE FROM POTSDAM



Source: Adapted from a photograph in J.M. Coles and A.F. Harding *The Bronze Age in Europe: An Introduction to the Prehistory of Europe c. 2000-7000BC* (London: Methuen, 1979). See Plate 16. From Eiche, Potsdam - Bronze, 20 cm in length.

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The miniature vehicle from Burg-Cottbus in Germany dated to about 1250 B.C.E. is similar to the above vehicle. The axle and wheel arrangement are identical to the Potsdam vehicle. Again a fork-shaped handle is attached to the axle. In this vehicle the tines of the fork continue to curve upward from the axle and after they reach an apex, curve slightly down again and end in a point. The overall impression is that of long-necked birds with beaks. These birds also are flapping their wings. There are two birds sitting on poles on the tines between the wheels. They have the same long neck and beak that the front figures do. At the end of the handle sits an identical bird on a pole. The handle also has a small horizontal hole in it. (Figure 9)

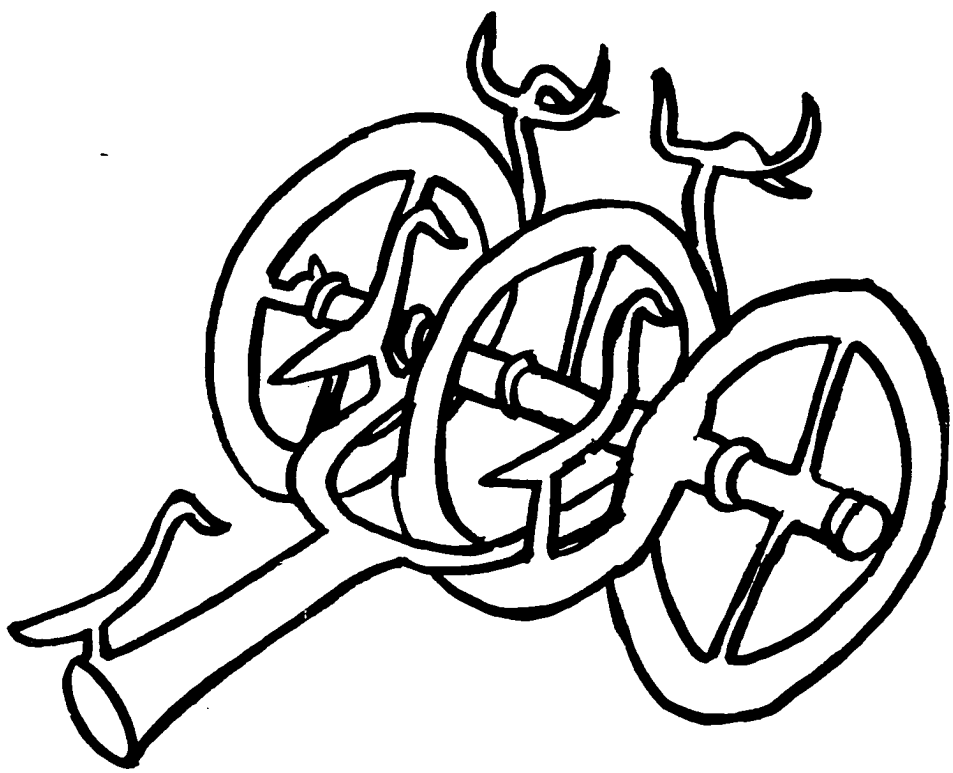
Another type of vehicle which is fairly common in the north European Iron Age is a small cauldron on wheels. The cauldron from Skallerup, Zealand in Denmark contained a cremated male body. The undercarriage of the cauldron sits on two rails which turn up in the back and the front. On the end of each rail sits an aquatic bird. The two birds in the front face forward, and the two birds in the rear face backward. At evenly spaced intervals, around the rim of the cauldron, triangular-shaped objects dangle on a chain. (Figure 10)

A similar cauldron dating from about 1250 B.C.E. was found at Acholshausen, west of Ochsenfurt, Germany. It was discovered in a stone chambered tomb which contained the ashes of a man between 40-50 years of age. The vehicle consists of four wheels with four spokes each. The undercarriage is X shaped with the cauldron sitting in the middle of the X. The cauldron is shaped like

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FIGURE 9

BIRD-POWERED, RITUAL VEHICLE FROM BURG-COTTBUS, GERMANY



Source: Adapted from a photograph in Herbert Schutz, The Prehistory of Germanic Europe (New Haven, Conn: Yale University Press, 1983). See Figure 96.

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FIGURE 10

BIRD-DECORATED, WHEELED CAULDRON FROM SKALLERUP IN ZEALAND



Source: Adapted from a photograph in J.M. Coles and A.F. Harding, *The Bronze Age in Europe*. See Figure 187.

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a child's top. The top of the cauldron has a circular chimney-like opening in the middle. At the four points where the undercarriage meets the axles, birds with long curved necks sit facing away from the cauldron. (Figure 11)

The sites where these miniature vehicles have been found are indicated on Map 3.[59] These vehicles appear in context with the burial and disposal of the dead. They apparently had a ritual function. These vehicles could have functioned as the vehicles which took the dead to the underworld. The ornithologic decoration must also have had a ritual and/or religious significance since it is consistently found with these vehicles. These vehicles emphasize an association between birds and death.

Several of the tales in Grimms' *Kinder- und Hausmärchen* continue an association between women and birds and birds and death. "Fichter's Bird" in Grimms' *Kinder- und Hausmärchen* portrays a girl who has the ability to resurrect the dead and transform herself into a bird. "Fichter's Bird" is basically the Bluebeard story. In this story a wizard disguises himself as a beggar and kidnaps pretty girls.

One day the wizard comes to a house where three girls live with their parents. He kidnaps the eldest daughter and takes her to his magnificent house. There, he gives her all she desires. He leaves on a trip and gives her the keys to the house. He tells her that she can go into every room but one, which she is forbidden to enter on pain of death. He gives her an egg, and he tells her to take care of it and

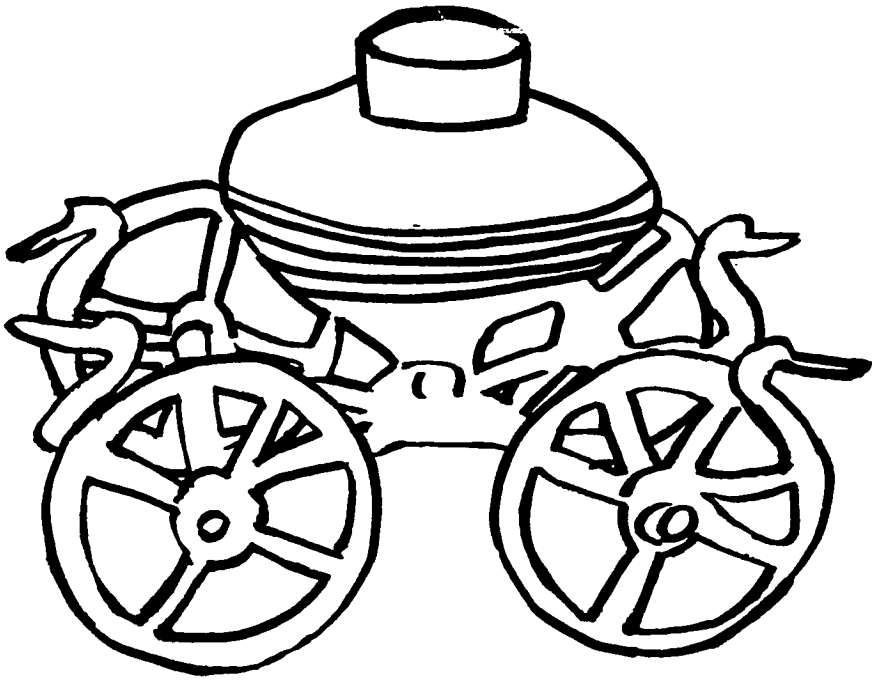
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[59]The figure number of each vehicle designates the location of the site on the map.

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FIGURE 11

BIRD-DECORATED, WHEELED CAULDRON
FROM ACHOLSAUSEN, GERMANY



Source: Adapted from a photograph in Herbert Schutz, *The Prehistory of Germanic Europe*. The vehicle is 17.6cm long and 12 cm high. See Plate 2c.

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carry it everywhere. After he leaves, she explores the whole house except for the forbidden room. When she cannot withstand her curiosity, she opens the door. In the middle of the room is a bloody basin with human body parts scattered around it. The egg that she is carrying accidentally falls in the basin, and she cannot get the blood off it. When the wizard returns, he sees the bloody egg and knows that she has disobeyed him. He pulls her into the room and chops her into pieces with an axe.

He then kidnaps her middle sister, and the same sequence of events happens. Later, he kidnaps the youngest sister. After he gives the youngest sister the keys and the egg, she places the egg in a safe place and explores the house. When she goes into the forbidden room, she sees the pieces of her hacked up sisters. She gathers up all the pieces and puts them in order. When no more parts are missing, the pieces begin to grow together, and her sisters come back to life.

When the wizard comes back and sees that there is no blood on the egg, he assumes that the girl has not entered the forbidden room. He declares that they will be married. She asks him to take two baskets of gold to her parents, but the baskets contain her sisters instead of gold. While he is gone, she takes a skull and puts ornaments and a wreath on it and places it in her window. She then dips herself in a barrel of honey and then rolls in the feathers from a feather bed, so she looks like a bird. She leaves the house and meets some wedding guests who say, "O, Fichter's bird, how come you are here?" "I come from Fichter's house quite near." "And what is the young bride doing?" "She swept from cellar to garret, and now she's peeping

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from the window." The girl also meets her bridegroom and exchanges the same words with him. After all the wedding guests have arrived, her brothers burn the house down.[60]

This story is very bizarre and probably very old. While it basically retells the Bluebeard story, it also contains other elements. At the end of the story, the youngest girl has the power to resurrect her dead sisters by skillfully rearranging their pieces; and she transforms herself into a bird. The elaborate explanation of her dipping herself in honey and rolling in feathers is a justification for her shape-changing. She escapes the house by placing a skull in the window and decorating it, so everyone will think it is her. The youngest girl has the attributes of a goddess, the power of regeneration and transformation. The skull, which is supposed to impersonate her, could be a sign of her connection to death and the dead. Initially this story may have been about a goddess; and over time as belief waned or was supplanted, the story was elaborated upon and changed. Fichter's bird, like Freyja, the Valkyries, and the witches, is a powerful woman who can assume the form of a bird. Fitcher's bird is both a healer and a bringer of death. She resurrects her sisters; and in the end, she causes the death of the wedding guests. These are the attributes of a goddess.

---

[60] *"du Fitchers Vogel, wo kommst du her?" "Ich komme von Fitze Fitchers Hause her." "Was macht denn da die junge Braut?" "Hat gekehrt von unten bis oben das Haus, und guckt zum Bodenloch heraus."* Jakob and Wilhelm Grimm, *Kinder- und Hausmärchen*, p. 260; Jacob and Wilhelm Grimm, *The Complete Fairy Tales of the Brothers Grimm* trans. Jack Zipes, pp. 167-171.

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Several stories in Grimms' *Kinder- und Hausmärchen* portray the dead as birds. In "The White Bride and the Black Bride," the White Bride is traveling on her way to marry a king with her evil stepmother and her evil stepsister. Her stepmother and stepsister push her out of the carriage and into the middle of a river. As the White Bride sinks, a snow-white duck arises from the water. The stepsister takes the White Brids's place and marries the king. The duck swims up the gutter into the castle's kitchen and asks after her stepsister. The duck comes to the castle's kitchen two nights in a row. On the third night, the king is waiting for her and cuts off the duck's head with his sword. Then the duck turns into the beautiful White Bride. This is a story of transformation and resurrection. When the White Bride drowns, she is immediately transformed into a duck. In duck-form, she attempts to find her murderer. When the king cuts off the duck's head, the duck is transformed into the resurrected White Bride.

The Grimms' tale "The Three Little Men in the Wood" tells practically the same story, but the duck is not killed. A girl, with an evil stepmother and an evil stepsister, marries a king and becomes queen. After the queen has been married a year, she gives birth to a son. When her stepmother hears this, she goes to the castle with her own daughter for a visit. One day when the king is out, the stepmother throws the queen, her stepdaughter, out a window into a stream. The stepmother then places her own daughter in the queen's bed. That night a duck swims up the gutter and into the castle's kitchen. She asks about the king, her guests, and the

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baby. The duck then takes the shape of the queen and nurses her child. After nursing, she turns back into a duck and swims away. This happens two nights in a row. On the third night, she asks the king to swing his sword over her three times. She is then transformed into the queen again.

In both of these tales a girl is either immediately resurrected as a bird when she drowns or transforms herself into a bird during a time of danger. She is transformed back into human form through the death or symbolic killing of the bird. These girls' ability to transform themselves into ducks is similar to the abilities of Freyja, the Valkyries, the witches, and Fichter's bird. All can alternate between human and bird form when necessary.

These stories, the Icelandic myths, and the archaeological evidence all point to a close and continual connection between birds, death, and feminine power. From the Bronze and Iron Age ornamentation associated with death, to Freyja who can transform herself into a bird and has dominion over half of the slain, to the confused accounts in nineteenth-century German folktales about girls who can transform themselves into birds and resurrect others or themselves from death; there is a continual and central theme that connects them all: a female with divine powers is associated with death and can assume the form of a bird.

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Names

In the *Gylfaginning* (35), Snorri provides a list of names that Freyja was called. A study of the meaning of some of her names might give some insight into her cult. "Freyja has many names, and the reason for this is that she gave herself several when she went to look for Óðr among peoples she did not know. She is called Mardöll, Hörn, Gefn, and Sýr."[61]

The name Freyja is from Proto-Germanic **Frau-jō* which means "Lady."[62] This would make Freyja's name a generic title: the Lady. This is similar to the Christian name for God: the Lord. This type of generic and all encompassing title is perfect for a deity with multiple functions and supreme importance.

The name Mardöll has been linked to the word *marr* which means "sea" in Old Norse.[63] A connection between Freyja and the sea is nonexistent in the sources we have. It would be better to derive Mardöll from the Old Norse word *marr* which has many meaning. One of its meanings is "mew." A mew is a type of sea gull.

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[61] *"Freyja á mörg nöfn, en sú er sök til þess at hon gaf sér ýmis heiti er hon fór með ókunnum þjóðum at leita Óðs. Hon heitir Mardöll ok Hörn, Gefn, Sýr."* Snorri Sturluson, *Edda*, edited by Anthony Faulkes, p. 29; *The Prose Edda of Snorri Sturluson*, trans. Jean I. Young, p. 59.

[62] Old Norse *ey* < Proto-Germanic *au*.

[63] de Vries, *Altgermanisches Religionsgeschichte* §554. de Vries relates the name to the name of the god Heimdallr. He suggests that she stands in a similar relationship with the sea as Heimdallr. H.R. Ellis Davidson, *Gods and Myths of Northern Europe*, (New York: Penguin, 1964), p. 116.

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This would continue Freyja's connection with birds and her ability to transform herself into a bird.

The name Hörn has been linked to the word *hörr* which means "linen" or "flax."[64] This would connect Freyja to the production of flax and linen. This production of cloth was a life-time occupation for women before the Industrial Age. The growing of the flax, the threshing and retching of the flax, the spinning of it into tread, and the weaving of cloth demanded hours and hours of work. A connection of the main female deity to this essential and life-long, female occupation is understandable.

The name Gefn was discussed earlier in this chapter and will be discussed in more detail in the next chapter. The name derives from the Germanic root **ghebh-* which means "to give". The name Sýr means "sow." In Old Norse the word for sow is *sýr*, so the meaning of this name is fairly obvious. Freyja has several connections to hogs. She rides a boar. Pigs are an animal connected with fertility and plenty. Like Freyja, sows mate indiscriminately. In chapter 45 of the *Germania*, Tacitus describes how the Suevians venerate the mother of the gods. "They worship the mother of the gods, and wear as a religious symbol the device of a wild boar. This serves as armor, and as a universal defense, rendering the votary of the goddess safe

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[64]de Vries, *Altgermanisches Religionsgeschichte* §556.

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even amidst enemies."[65] Images of helmets have been found from the Bronze Age with an image of a boar on the top. The many connections between Freyja and swine make the name Sýr a reasonable name for her.

Freyja's many names seem to mark her as a prosperity goddess. She is "the Giver" and "the Lady." She has associations with cloth making, birds, and pigs. In general, her names indicate a being who has the ability to improve life.

Middle East Hypothesis

In *The Beauty and the Hag,* Lotte Motz devotes a chapter to the discussion of Freyja. Half of this chapter is a comparison between Freyja and goddesses of the Middle East, specifically Anat-Astarte and Inanna-Ishtar. Motz compares Freyja's ability to fly, her connection to death, her carriage pulled by cats, her overt sexuality, her act of prostitution to obtain the *Brísingamen,* her lack of a functional husband, and her tears of gold to the Middle Eastern goddesses who are winged, delight in carnage, have carriages pulled by lions, are overtly sexual, have ritual prostitution performed in their honor, wear beautiful jewelry, have no functional husband, and weep for a lost lover. She maintains that Freyja conforms more to the Middle Eastern/Mediterranean goddess models than she does to the goddess North European models.

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[65]*matrem deum venerantur. insigne superstitionis formas aprorum gestant; id pro armis omnium: quae tutela securum deae cultorem etiam inter hostis praestat.* Tacitus, *Germania,* Allan L. Lund (ed).; Tacitus, *Complete Works of Tacitus,* p. 731.

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> Freyja, however, shows no relation to the northern landscape; the strong sexuality of her persona, her aspect of a harlot, would have to be derived from a region in which sexual desire and fulfillment were exalted, as had happened in the Mediterranean. The tale of the goddess in her sorrow parallels the tales of the grieving divinities of the ancient world. These legitimize and sanctify through their lamentations the experience of suffering and loss. Freyja's carriage, drawn by 'cats', evokes the image of the carriage of Cybele, drawn by lions and, like the eastern goddesses, Freyja is the daughter and sister of important ruling deities. . . In the view of this study Freyja is part of a configuration which developed in many places, and also in the Germanic provinces, and thus she shares qualities with northern spirits. Her striking features, however, she owes to the imperious goddesses of the Middle East.[66]

I find it very difficult to agree with Motz's conclusions about Freyja. The distance between the Middle East and North West Europe is vast with a lot of geographical features in the way. To cause a change in the sacral characteristics of one of the main goddesses in the pantheon, there would have to be continual long-term contact between the two cultural areas. Motz mentions that if trade goods could originate in the Middle East and make their way to the Germanic peoples so too could ideas of an overtly sexual goddess. However, trade goods do not alter the belief system of people. The changing of the character of a goddess does alter their belief system. I find her conclusions implausible. The major similarities between Freyja and the Middle Eastern goddesses do not represent a direct link between the Freyja and the Middle East. These similarities (sexuality, sorrow for a lost lover,

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[66]Lotte Motz, *The Beauty and the Hag: Female Figures of Germanic Faith and Myth* (Vienna: Fassbaender, 1993), p. 110

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and beautiful jewelry) are more likely archtypes of a certain type of goddess to which Freyja and several Middle Eastern goddesses belong.

It is more likely that we are dealing with archetypes that span cultures. Freyja's connection with death can easily be connected to the continual cycle of agricultural life. Freyja's overt sexuality is also part of this construct. The act of intercourse itself is a kind of purification and rebirth. Before the time of easily obtained contraceptives, there was always the possibility that sex would lead to birth. Freyja's sexuality does not have to be a borrowed trait. All of the major Norse goddesses are accused of amoral sexual behavior.[67] In Freyja's case, we have a record of some of the stories related to her sexuality. With the other goddesses, all that we have left is innuendo and vague references to lost myths.

Summary

Why did Freyja's cult last longer than all of the other Norse deities? Freyja's cult was connected to prosperity. She was the goddess of riches. She was beautiful, cried tears of gold, her daughters were jewels, and one of her names means "the Giver." If Freyja was appeased, then prosperity in the coming year was assured. Prosperity was related to the fertility of the fields, livestock, and family. Freyja's connection with sexuality also boosted the fertility of the community.

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[67]See chapter three for details.

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Freyja's cult was associated with *seiðr*. The practice of *seiðr*, at least partly, was associated with the art of prophesy. Women who practiced this art were called upon during times of crisis to foretell when things would improve. In Germanic culture, there appears to be a very ancient association between women and prophetic powers. Even after Christianity became the major religion of the area, people still called on seeresses to foretell the future. Freyja's relationship to this tradition of prophesy probably helped to keep her cult alive.

Freyja has several connections with death. She chooses half the slain each day; and in one story, she raises the dead. Freyja also has the ability to transform herself into a bird. There is a long and continual relationship between birds, death, and goddesses in Europe. In the Bronze and Iron Ages, there are a lot of artifacts that have avian decorative motifs which are associated with death. In German folklore, there are several folk tales that portray a female antagonist who can transform herself into a bird and can raise the dead. Freyja's connection to this long tradition probably also led to the longevity of her cult.

I think that Freyja's cult survived the longest of all the Norse deities because she was a multifaceted deity whose basic functions were extremely important to the community and the individual. Her importance in continuing the prosperity of the community, the tradition of female prophesy, and her connections to the ancient belief in a goddess associated with birds and death made it difficult for the new Christian religion to take over her cult. Years after Christianity was adopted, the

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more conservative and cautious people would continue Freyja's cult alongside Christ's.

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IV. FRIGG, GEFJUN, IÐUNN, SKAÐI, GERÐR, AND OTHERS

Freyja is not the only goddess for whom we have textual evidence. There is at least one complete myth which tells of the exploits of Frigg, Gefjun, Iðunn, Skaði, and Gerðr. We have evidence for lost myths and suggestions of cult for other less known figures, such as, Þorgerðr, Ran, Hel, Sif, Fulla, Nanna, Sigyn, and Hyrrokkin. The evidence for these figures is fragmentary, and it must be carefully studied within the context of Germanic belief.

Frigg

Frigg is mentioned several times in the sources as Óðinn's wife. She is always in the background, but she usually says and does very little. We know she was worshiped because the word for Friday is derived from her name. In Old High German the word for Friday is *friatac*, in Old English *frigedaeg*, and in Old Frisian *frigendei*. Friday is a translation of the Latin *dies Veneris* 'the day of Venus'. Presumably, the goddess most comparable with Venus was chosen to give her name to this day in the Germanic languages. If Frigg was the goddess that was the most comparable with Venus, then this information gives us some insight to the character and function of Frigg in pre-literate times. Frigg's connection with Venus suggests that she was an important goddess with associations with love, spring, and beauty.

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In *Gylfaginning* (35), Snorri lists the goddesses. "The foremost is Frigg. She owns that dwelling known as *Fensalir*, and it is the most magnificent."[1] The name of Frigg's dwelling translates as "Bog Hall." *Fensalir* connects Frigg with marshy and low lying areas. This connection with fens and bogs brings to mind the many sacrifices which were made in lakes and bogs during the Bronze and Iron Ages.[2] A tenuous connection might even be made between the worship of Frigg and the offerings of rings and other items found in the bogs of Northwest Europe.

Infidelity. Like Freyja, Frigg is accused of amoral sexual behavior. In stanza 26 of the poem the *Lokasenna*, Loki baits Frigg by accusing her of infidelity.

Loki qvað:
„Þegi þú, Frigg, þú ert Fiorgyns mær
oc hefir æ vergiorn verið,
er þá Véa oc Vilia léztu þér, Viðris qvæn,
báða í baðm um tekit.“[3]

Loki said:
"Be quiet, Frigg, Fjorgyn's daughter,
you were born mad for men:
Vidrir's wife has wound her arms
around both Ve and Vili."[4]

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[1]"*Frigg er œzt. Hon á þann bœ er Fensalir heita ok er hann allvegligr.*" Snorri Sturluson, *Edda*, edited by Anthony Faulkes, p. 29; *The Prose Edda of Snorri Sturluson*, trans. Jean I. Young, p. 59.

[2]See the second chapter for a summary of bog body finds that might be sacrifices.

[3]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 101.

[4]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, p.76.

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The same story is more clearly told in chapter 3 of *Ynglinga Saga* in *Heimskringla*.

> *Óðinn átti tvo bræður. Hét annar Vé en annar Vílir. Þeir bræður hans stýrðu ríkinu þá er hann var í brottu. Það var eitt sinn, þá er Óðinn var farinn langt í brott og hafði lengi dvalist, að Ásum þótti örvænt hans heim. Þá tóku bræður hans að skipta arfi hans en konu hans Frigg gengu þeir báðir að eiga. En litlu síðar kom Óðinn heim. Tók hann þá við konu sinni.*[5]
>
> Oðinn had two brothers. One was called Vé, and the other was Víli. These, his brothers, governed the realm when he was gone. One time when Oðinn was gone to a great distance, he stayed away so long that the Æsir thought he would never return. Then his brothers began to divide his inheritance; but his wife Frigg they shared between them. However, a short while afterwards, Oðinn returned and took possession of his wife again.[6]

Loki calls Frigg man mad and blames her for her adultery with her husband's brothers. The passage from *Ynglinga Saga* seems to give her no will of her own and portrays her as powerless. Whichever way was the case in the original story, the fact remains that Frigg did commit adultery with both of Óðinn's brothers. These references to a lost myth portray Frigg as sexually amoral.

Prophesy. In the *Gylfaginning* (20) and in stanza 29 of the *Lokasenna*, we are told that Frigg knows the future; but she does not tell it to anyone. "Frigg can see what the future holds, she just does not say so."[7] This tells us that Frigg had the

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[5]Snorri Sturluson, *Heimskringla*, Kristjánsdóttir, Halldórsson, Torfason, and Thorsson.

[6]Snorri Sturluson, *Heimskringla: History of the Kings of Norway*, p. 7.

[7]*"ørlög Frigg hugg ec at öll viti/þótt hon siálfgi segi." Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 102; *Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, p. 77.

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same power as a *völva*. This power makes her comparable to the seeresses who where held in esteem by the people and sought after by kings. This might also hint that Frigg had some knowledge of *seiðr* since the ability to look into the future is closely tied with the practice of *seiðr*.

Protection. Frigg is portrayed as a protecting goddess when she attempts to protect her son from his fated death. In *Gylfaginning* (49), we are told the story of how Óðinn's and Frigg's son Baldr was killed. Baldr began to have dreams foretelling his own death. He told them to the Æsir, and they decided to take preventive measures.

> *Frigg tók svardaga til þess at eira skyldu Baldri eldr ok vatn, járn ok alls konar málmr, steinar, jörðin, viðirnir, sóttirnar, dýrin, fuglarnir, eitr, ormar. En er þetta var gert ok vitat, þá var þat skemtun Baldrs ok Ásanna at hann skyldi standa upp á þingum en allir aðrir skyldu sumir skjóta á hann, sumir höggva til, sumir berja grjóti. En hvat sem at var gert, sakaði han ekki, ok þótti þetta öllum mikill frami. En er þetta sá Loki Laufeyjarson þá líkaði honum illa er Baldr sakaði ekki. Hann gekk til Fensalar til Friggjar ok brá sér í konu líki. Þá spyrr Frigg ef sú kona vissi hvat Æsir höfðusk at á þinginu. Hon sagði at allir skutu at Baldri, ok þat at hann sakaði ekki. Þa mælir Frigg: 'Eigi munu vápn eða viðir granda Baldri. Eiða hefi ek þegit af öllum þeim.' Þá spyrr konan: 'Hafa allir hlutir eiða unnit at eira Baldri?' Þá svarar Frigg: 'Vex viðarteinungr einn fyrir vestan Valhöll. Sá er mistilteinn kallaðr. Sá þótti mér ungr at krefja eiðsins.' Því næst hvarf konan á brut.*[8]

> Frigg exacted an oath from fire and water, iron and all kinds of metals, stones, earth, trees, ailments, beasts, birds, poison and serpents, that they would not harm Baldr. . . When Loki, Laufey's son, saw that, however, he was annoyed that Baldr was not hurt, and he went disguised as a woman to *Fensalir* to visit Frigg. Frigg asked this

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[8]Snorri Sturluson, *Edda*, Anthony Faulkes (ed), p. 45.

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> woman if she knew what the Æsir were doing at the assembly. She answered that they were throwing things at Baldr, moreover he was not being hurt. Frigg remarked: "Neither weapons nor trees will injure Baldr; I have taken an oath from them all." The woman asked: "Has everything sworn you an oath to spare Baldr?" Frigg replied: "West of Valhalla grows a little bush called mistletoe, I did not exact an oath from it; I thought it too young." Thereupon the woman disappeared.[9]

After hearing Frigg's admission, Loki manipulates events so that Baldr is killed by an arrow of mistletoe. In this passage, Frigg is both the protector of Baldr and the indirect cause of his death. While she has practically insured against anything harming him, she tells the wrong person what his weakness is. After Baldr's death, Frigg is portrayed as a sorrowing goddess. In stanza 33 of the poem *Völuspá*, the *völva* tells Óðinn:

> *Þó hann æva hendr né höfuð kembði,*
> *áðr á bál um bar Baldrs andscota;*
> *enn Frigg um grét í Fensölom*
> *vá Valhallar-- vitoð ér enn, eða hvat?*[10]
>
> From the same plant which seemed so frail
> the fatal shaft came to Hod's hand;
> and Frigg wept in Fensalir
> For Valhalla's sorrow. Seek you wisdom still?[11]

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[9]*The Prose Edda of Snorri Sturluson*, trans. Jean I. Young, pp. 80-81.

[10]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 8.

[11]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, p. 4.

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In stanza 41 of the same poem, we are told that Frigg's second sorrow is when Óðinn is killed at *Ragnarök*. These passages portray Frigg as a weeping/sorrowing goddess. Frigg is the grieving wife and mother of Old Norse myth.

Name. Frigg's name derives from Proto-Germanic **frijjō*.[12] **Frijjō* derives from Proto-Indo-European **priio-* which is the verbal adjective form of **pri-* meaning "to love".[13] This would give it the meaning of "beloved". In Sanskrit, the noun *priyā-* derives from the same root and is "sound for sound" the same as Frigg.[14] The word *priyā* means "beloved one" or "spouse". By analogy with the Sanskrit, Scheller suggests that Frigg's name probably meant "wife".

Summary. Except for these few instances, we know very little about Frigg. From the information that we do have, some conclusions can be drawn. I agree with H. R. Davidson,[15] that Frigg and Freyja are different aspects of the same goddess. They are both known for their weeping. Freyja weeps for her missing husband, and Frigg weeps for her dead son. They are both married to the same man Óðinn/Óðr. They both are accused of amoral sexual behavior. Frigg is portrayed as the wife of Óðinn, but she appears to have little or no power of her own. Freyja seems to belong

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[12]Holtzmann's Law is the sharpening of geminate glides; thus Proto-Germanic *jj* becomes *ggj* in North Germanic.

[13]Meinrad Scheller, *Vedisch priyâ- und die Wortsippe frei, freien, Freund* (Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1958), pp. 101-103.

[14]Meinrad Scheller, *Vedisch priyâ- und die Wortsippe*, pp. 101-103.

[15]H.R. Ellis Davidson, *Gods and Myths of Northern Europe*, p. 123.

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to no man. Although we hear that Óðr is her husband, he does not appear in any of the stories. There is also the curious alliteration of their names: Frigg - Freyja. The meaning of their names are titles and are similar. Freyja is "the Lady" and Frigg is "the Wife." I think that at one time they were considered to be part of the same being or entity.

Gefjun

Gefjun is well known for creating the island of Zealand in Denmark, but not much else is known about her. What we do know about Gefjun is partially contradictory and obscure. The story of how Zealand was formed is told in both the *Gylfaginning* (1) and in chapter 5 of *Ynglinga Saga* in *Heimskringla.*

> *Gylfi konungr réð þar löndum er nú heitir Svíþjóð. Frá honum er þat sagt at hann gaf einni farandi konu at launum skemtunar sinnar eitt plógsland í ríki sínu þat er fjórir øxn drœgi upp dag ok nótt. En sú kona var ein af Ása ætt. Hon er nefnd Gefjun. Hon tók fjóra øxn norðan ór Jötunheimum, en þat váru synir jötuns ok hennar, ok setti þá fyrir plóg. En plógrinn gekk svá hart ok djúpt at upp leysti landit, ok drógu øxninir þat land út á hafit ok vestr ok námu staðar í sundi nokkvoru. Þar setti Gefjun landit ok gaf nafn ok kallaði Selund.*[16]
>
> King Gylfi ruled the lands that are now called Sweden. It is told of him that he gave a plowland in his kingdom, the size four oxen could plow in a day and a night, to a beggar-woman as a reward for the way she entertained him. This beggar-woman, however, was of the family of the Æsir; her name was Gefjun. From the north of Giantland she took four oxen and yoked them to a plow, but those were her sons by a giant. The plow went in so hard and deep that it loosened the land and the oxen dragged it westwards into the sea,

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[16]Snorri Sturluson, *Edda*, Anthony Faulkes (ed), p. 7.

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> stopping in a certain sound. There Gefjun set the land for good and gave it a name, calling it Zealand.[17]

In this passage, Gefjun is credited with the creation of the main Danish island. She received it partially as a reward and partially through guile. She was to receive as much land as she could plow with a team of four oxen in a day and a night. She cheated by using oxen that were giants. Gefjun cut out a huge piece of land and then dragged it to another place and connects it to the Earth so that it could not be moved. She created Lake Mälar in Sweden and the island of Zealand in Denmark at the same time. In this myth, Gefjun is portrayed as the creator and giver of land.

In *Gylfaginning* (35), when Snorri lists the goddesses, he says of Gefjun,"she is a virgin, and women who die unmarried serve her."[18] The *Gylfaginning* passage appears to contradict some of the information in the *Heimskringla* story. In the *Heimskringla* story, Gefjun has four sons that are oxen from a liaison with a giant. In the *Gylfaginning* passage, we are told that Gefjun is a virgin. There seems to be two different traditions represented. In *Gylfaginning,* Gefjun is portrayed as a goddess of death. She receives a portion of the dead since all unmarried women served her after they died.

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[17]*The Prose Edda of Snorri Sturluson*, trans. Jean I. Young, p.29.

[18]"Hon er mær, ok henni þjóna þær er meyjar andask." Snorri Sturluson, *Edda*, Anthony Faulkes (ed), p. 29; *The Prose Edda of Snorri Sturluson*, trans. Jean I. Young, p. 59.

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In stanzas 20-21 of the *Lokasenna*, Loki baits Gefjun by discussing how she had sex with a young man to obtain a necklace, and Óðinn reveals that Gefjun can see into the future.

Loki qvað:
"Þegi þú, Gefion! þess mun ec nú geta,
er þic glapþi at geði:
sveinn inn hvíti, er þér sigli gaf,
oc þú lagðir lær yfir."

Óðinn:
"Œrr ertu, Loki, oc ørviti,
er þú fær þér Gefion at gremi,
þviat aldar ørlög hygg ec at hon öll um viti
iafngorla sem ec."[19]

Loki said:
"Be quiet, Gefjun! I will give you
reason to rage:
I know a youth who gave you a necklace--
you laid a leg over him!"

Oðinn said:
"Loki, you are insane, you have lost your mind
to anger Gefjun;
she can tell of times to come
as clearly as I can."[20]

Loki accuses Gefjun of prostituting herself to a youth for a necklace. Again the information that Gefjun is a virgin is contradicted in this passage. Óðinn then tells us that Gefjun can see the future. This means that both Frigg and Gefjun share the

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[19]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 100.

[20]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, pp. 75-76.

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ability to see into the future. We also learn that Gefjun, like Freyja, traded sex for a necklace. This is all the information we have about Gefjun.

Gefjun shares several characteristics in common with Freyja, and she shares other characteristics with Frigg. I think that Gefjun, Freyja, and Frigg make up a trinity of goddesses that were once part of the same entity or a triad that represented the whole. Triads of goddesses were very popular in Continental Germanic Europe during the Iron Age. The *matronae* monuments often portray triads or multiples of three goddesses under one name. This triad of goddesses would have had a relationship of interlocking functions and closely related names. Gefjun's name is closely related to one of Freyja's many names: Gefn. Both Gefjun and Gefn are derived from the Germanic root **ghebh-*. In North Germanic the letter 'f' was used to represent the sound 'bh' in medial and final position. This letter was probably pronounced as a bilabial [β]. Norse Gefjun can be derived from Proto-Germanic**geb-jōn*. This root means "to give". Both Gefjun and Gefn mean "the Giver."[21]

Freyja and Gefjun both trade sex for a necklace. Freyja had sex with four dwarfs, and Gefjun had sex with a youth. Since they traded sex for a necklace, they both now own a necklace. Necklaces are ubiquitous for female deities in Neolithic Europe, and all of the North European goddess figurines from the Bronze Age also wear a necklace. The necklace was a symbol of the divine female. Gefjun receives

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[21]Jan de Vries, *Altnordisches Etymologisches Wörterbuch*, p. 160.

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all unmarried women who die, Freyja chooses half the slain each day. This makes them both goddesses of the dead. With Freyja, Gefjun shares a name, sex for gain, a necklace, and a portion of the dead.

Gefjun and Frigg can both see into the future. They both might be connected to Freyja through this trait because Freyja was the deity who taught *seiðr* to the Æsir. One of the powers of *seiðr* was apparently the ability to see into the future and prophecy. Gefjun, Frigg, and Freyja are all mothers. Frigg is the mother of Baldr, Gefjun is the mother of four giant oxen, and Freyja has two daughters who are jewels. However, Frigg's son Baldr is the only one who plays a role in any of the myths. We only hear about Gefjun's and Freyja's children. At one time, these three goddesses might have formed a trinity: the wife/mother, the unattached but sexually active woman, and the virgin. Each goddess would symbolize a period in a woman's life. The many correspondences between these goddesses seem to indicate that they once represented slightly different aspects of the same deity. Table 4 provides a more graphic presentation of the relationships between these goddesses.

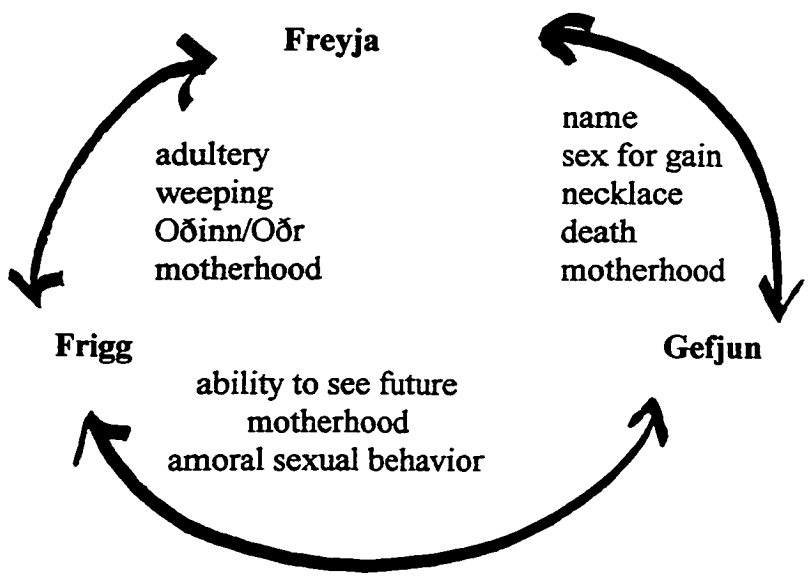
Iðunn

We have very little information about Iðunn. We really only have one myth and a brief mention in the *Lokasenna*. Iðunn is in charge of the apples of eternal youth. The gods had to eat these apples, or they would grow old and die. Iðunn's apples are mentioned twice; once in *Gylfaginning* (26) and once in *Skáldskaparmál*

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TABLE 4

COMPARISON OF CHARACTERISTICS BETWEEN
FREYJA, FRIGG, AND GEFJUN



Source: Primary

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(2,3). The passage from *Gylfaginning* tells us that Iðunn was the wife of the god Bragi.

> *Bragi heitir einn. Hann er ágætr at speki ok mest at málsnild ok orðfimi. Hann kann mest af skáldskap, ok af honum er bragr kallaðr skáldskapr, ok af hans nafni er sá kallaðr bragr karla eða kvenna er orðsnild hefir framar en aðrir, kona eða karlmaðr. Kona hans er Iðunn. Hon varðveitir í eski sínu epli þau er goðin skulu á bíta þá er þau eldask, ok verða þá allir ungir, ok svá mun vera allt til ragnarøkrs.*[22]
>
> One [god] is called Bragi. He is famous for wisdom and most of all for eloquence and skill with words; he knows most about poetry, and from him poetry gets its name, and from his name the man or woman who can use words better than others is called a poet. His wife is Iðunn. She keeps in her box the apples the gods have to eat, when they grow old, to become young again, and so it will continue up to *Ragnarök.*[23]

I agree with Davidson that Bragi is probably just another name for Oðinn since Oðinn is well known for his wisdom, knowledge, and poetry.[24] In this passage, we are introduced to the idea that Iðunn has guardianship over the apples of eternal youth. In *Skáldskaparmál* (2,3), Snorri relates the story of the kidnapping of Iðunn and her apples. Through a series of mishaps, Loki is at the mercy of the giant Þjazi. Þjazi demands that Loki bring him Iðunn and her apples if he wants to live. Loki agrees, and Þjazi sets him free.

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[22]Snorri Sturluson, *Edda*, Anthony Faulkes (ed), p. 25.

[23]*The Prose Edda of Snorri Sturluson*, trans. Jean I. Young, p. 54.

[24]H.R. Ellis Davidson, *Gods and Myths of Northern Europe*, p. 164.

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En að ákveðinni stundu teygir Loki Iðunni út um Ásgarð í skóg nokkurn og segir að hann hefur fundið epli þau er henni munu gripir í þykja, og bað að hún skal hafa með sér sín epli og bera saman og hin. Þá kemur þar Þjassi jötunn í arnarham og tekur Iðunni og flýgur braut með og í Þrymheim til bús síns. En æsir urðu illa við hvarf Iðunnar og gerðust þeir brátt hárir og gamlir.[25]

At the time agreed on, Loki enticed Iðunn out from Ásgarð into a wood, telling her that he had found some apples she would prize greatly and asking her to bring her own with her for comparison. Then the giant Þjazi came there in the form of an eagle, and seizing Iðunn flew away with her to his house in Þrymheim. The Æsir, however, were much dismayed at Iðunn's disappearance, and they soon grew old and grey-haired.[26]

When the gods discover that Iðunn and her apples are gone and the circumstances of her departure, they demand that Loki retrieve Iðunn and her apples from the giant. Loki borrows Freyja's falcon form and flies off to rescue Iðunn. Loki flies to Giantland and finds that Þjazi is out on his boat, and Iðunn is alone at the giant's dwelling. Loki turns her into a nut and carries her home to Ásgarð in his mouth.

In this myth, Iðunn is the keeper of eternal youth and life. She has control and access to the apples which keep the gods young and immortal. Many scholars have considered this myth to be borrowed from another source. The Greek story of Hesperides has been mentioned as a possible source and so have several Irish myths. The problem is that the date for the cultivation of edible apples in Northern Europe is unknown; however, apples do not have to be edible for humans for them to be

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[25]Snorra Sturlusonar, *Edda*, edited by Heimir Pálsson, p. 80.

[26]*The Prose Edda of Snorri Sturluson*, trans. Jean I. Young, pp. 98-99.

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considered edible for gods. I can see no reason why Iðunn has to have been borrowed from another culture. Other inedible plants have symbolized fertility, for example, the rowan or yew fruit.[27] The ability to eat the fruit is not as important as the time of the fruit's appearance, and when the tree flourishes. Apple trees blossom in the spring with pretty, bright flowers. In the summer, the leaves are full and green. In the early fall, apple trees are full of brightly colored fruit. In the winter, the trees lose all of their leaves and become just bare branches. This cycle of bursting with beautiful life in the spring, full green life in the summer, the production of life in the fall, and death in the winter graphically illustrates the cycle of agricultural life that a fertility deity represents.[28]

The apples are not the only thing that Þjazi wants. He also demands Iðunn. Þjazi's kidnapping of Iðunn is reminiscent of the giants that demand Freyja in exchange for something that the Æsir want or need.[29] This would make Iðunn desirable in her own right, not just because of her apples. This myth seems to represent Iðunn as a goddess with the power to renew life. Iðunn's name might be related to the Old Norse word *id* "to work, to do" and Proto-Germainic **wunjō*. Derivitatives of the Proto Germanic in Modern German would be *Wonne* meaning

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[27]Jan de Vries, *Altgermanische Religionsgeschichte* v. 2, § 559.

[28]For more information about the linguistic background of the word *apple*, see Eric Hamp, "The North European Word of 'Apple'" *Zeitschrift für Celtische Philologie* 37 (1979): pp. 158-166.

[29]See chapter three.

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"joy, bliss"; in Modern English winsome; and in Middle English *wen* meaning "joy, bliss". This might give Iðunn's name the meaning of "One who brings/works joy".

In stanza 17 of the *Lokasenna*, Loki taunts Iðunn about having sex with her brother's murderer.

Loki qvað:
"Þegiðu, Iðunn! þic qveð ec allra qvenna
vergiarnasta vera,
síztu arma þína lagðir, ítrþvegna,
um þinn bróðurbana."[30]

Loki said:
"You have heard from me no hateful words
here in Ægir's hall;
you have locked your arms in love
around your brother's bane."[31]

We have no other attestation of this myth, so interpreting it is almost impossible. We do not know if the lover Loki refers to is Iðunn's husband or another. This passage does tell us that Iðunn was more than just the keeper of the apples. There must have been at least one other myth about her.

This is all the information that we have in the sources about Iðunn. She was the guardian of the apples of eternal youth. Her husband was called Bragi, which was probably another name for Óðinn, and she had sex with her brother's murderer. The only information that can be thoughtfully interpreted is the apple myth. Here she appears as the goddess of renewal.

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[30]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 100.

[31]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, p. 75.

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Skaði

Skaði is mentioned in a couple of different sources. The most comprehensive information about her is in the story of her attempt to avenge her father's death and her marriage to Njörðr. In *Skáldskaparmál* (3), after Snorri tells of the theft and recovery of Iðunn's apples, he tells about the death of the giant Þjazi, who stole Iðunn and her apples. Skaði is the daughter of Þjazi. When Skaði hears of her father's death, she decides to seek vengeance on the Æsir.

> *En Skaði, dóttir Þjassa jötuns, tók hjálm og brynju og öll hervopn og fer til Ásgarðs að hefna föður síns. En æsir buðu henni sætt og yfirbætur og hið fyrsta að hún skal kjósa sér mann af ásum og kjósa að fótum og sjá ekki fleira af. Þá sá hún eins manns fætur forkunnarfagra og mælti: "Þennan kýs eg. Fátt mun ljótt á Baldri!" En það var Njörður úr Nóatúnum. Það hafði hún og í sættargjörð sinni að æsir skyldu það gera er hún hugði að þeir skyldu eigi mega, að hlægja hana. Þá gerði Loki það að hann batt um skegg geitar nokkurrar og öðrum enda um hreðjar sér, og létu þau ýmsi eftir og skrækti hvorttveggja við hátt. Þá lét Loki fallast í kné Skaða, og þá hló hún. Var þá gjör sætt af ásanna hendi við hana. Svo er sagt að Óðinn gerði það til yfirbóta við hana að hann tók augu Þjassa og kastaði upp á himin og gerði af stjörnur tvær."*[32]
>
> Now giant Þjazi's daughter Skaði took helmet, coat-of-mail and a complete outfit of weapons and went to Ásgarð to avenge her father. The Æsir, however, offered her compensation and damages, and first that she should choose a husband from amongst the Æsir and choose him by his feet without seeing any more of him. Then she saw a very beautiful pair of feet and said: 'I choose this one; there's nothing that is ugly about Baldr!' -- but that was Njörðr of Nóatún. A further condition was that the Æsir should make her laugh -- which she thought would be impossible. When Loki, however, by his tricks succeeded in doing this their reconciliation was complete. We are

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[32]Snorra Sturlusonar, *Edda*, edited by Heimir Pálsson, p. 81.

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told that Oðinn compensated her by taking Þjazi's eyes and throwing them up into the sky, making of them two stars.[33]

Skaði dresses up like a valkyrie with helmet, mail, and weapons to confront the Æsir. This passage marks her as a woman of action. She does not sit around and wait for things to happen around her. She is an instigator. Instead of vengeance the Æsir offer her compensation for her father's death. Compensation for killing or injuring someone is a very old Germanic tradition.

The Æsir compensate Skaði by allowing her to choose a husband from among them by only looking at their feet. This curious detail might be somehow connected to the many pairs of engraved feet found in the Scania and Bohuslän Bronze Age Rock engravings. Pairs of feet, both bare and shod, are scattered amid the engravings of ships and cultic scenes. The feet probably signify the presence of a deity. The feet themselves might have some cultic significance that is lost to us now. Gelling and Davidson have suggested a connection to the engravings of foot prints and the engravings of sun disks because of their similar structure.[34]

Skaði chooses the most beautiful pair of feet, and she and Njörðr are married. In *Gylfaginning* (23), we are told that the marriage was not a happy one.

Skaði vill hafa bústað þann er átt hafði faðir hennar--þat er á fjöllum nokkvorum þar sem heitir Þrymheimr--en Njörðr vill vera nær sæ.

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[33]*The Prose Edda of Snorri Sturluson*, trans. Jean I. Young, p. 99.

[34]Peter Gelling and Hilda Ellis Davidson, *The Chariot of the Sun: and Other Rites and Symbols of the Northern Bronze Age* (New York: Frederick A. Praeger, Publishers, 1969), pp. 39-42, Figs. 18 - 19.

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Þau sættusk á þat at þau skyldu vera níu nætr í Þrymheimi, en þá aðrar níu at Nóatúnum . . . Þá fór Skaði upp á fjallit ok bygði í Þrymheimi ok ferr hon mjök á skíðum ok með boga ok skýtr dýr. Hon heitir öndurguð eða öndurdís.[35]

Skaði wanted to have the homestead her father had had, on some mountains in the place called Þrymheim, but Njörðr wanted to be near the sea. They came to an agreement that they should be nine nights in Þrymheim and then another nine at Nóatún. . . Then Skaði went up the mountain and lived in Þrymheim, and she goes about a great deal on skis and with her bow and arrow shoots wild animals. She is called Snow-shoe goddess [öndurdís], or Snow-shoe divinity [öndurgoð].[36]

Snorri tells us that she was called the Snow-shoe goddess or Snow-shoe divinity, and this gives us a clue to her function and cult. In this passage, Skaði is portrayed as a winter goddess. She lives on a mountain. She spends a lot of time on her skis or snow shoes and hunts animals with her bow and arrows. She is the huntress on skis and snowshoes who can not survive at sea level. From these two stories, we have the marriage of the goddess of winter and the hunt to the god of the sea and prosperity.

There may be a connection between Skaði and the god Ullr. Skaði is called the *öndurdís* and Ullr is called the *önduráss*. We have very little information about Ullr. His cult seems to have been important in preliterate times since we have many place names that can be traced to him. We have almost no information about him in our sources. De Vries has suggested that this pairing can not be coincidental. He suggests that Ullr and Skaði might form a mythic pair like Nerthus and Njörðr.

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[35]Snorri Sturluson, *Edda,* Anthony Faulkes (ed), pp. 23-24.

[36]*The Prose Edda of Snorri Sturluson,* trans. Jean I. Young, p. 52.

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Skaði's name has a masculine form, and this has led several scholars to equate Skaði and Ullr as the same being. As mentioned in chapter 1, de Vries seems to think that Nerthus and Njörðr are the same being but have mysteriously undergone a sex change from male to female. He suggests the same phenomena for Skaði and Ullr.[37] As I discussed in chapter two, I see no reason why a sex change is necessary. I think that at one time Nerthus and Njörðr and perhaps Skaði and Ullr were the same deity. They were probably a female goddess who could generate life either by herself or with a seasonal lover. With the advent of the Indo-Europeans into the Germanic region, the religious world transformed. The masculine, sky gods of the Indo-Europeans became supreme, and the goddess-centered religion of the substrate was pushed aside or changed. One way the substrate religion could have changed was to give the goddess a male counterpart with her same name.

In chapter 8 of *Ynglinga Saga* in *Heimskringla,* Snorri tells us that Skaði was also married to Óðinn.

> *Njöður fékk konu þeirrar er Skaði hét. Hún vildi ekki við hann samfarar og giftist síðan Óðni. Áttu þau marga sonu. Einn þeirra hét Sæmingur . . . Til Sæmings taldi Hákons jarl hinn ríki langfeðgakyn sitt.*[38]
>
> Njörðr married a woman who was called Skaði. She would not have intercourse with him, and later married Oðinn. They had many sons.

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[37]Jan de Vries, *Altgermanische Religionsgeschichte* v. 2, § 561.

[38]Snorri Sturluson, *Heimskringla*, Kristjánsdóttir, Halldórsson, Torfason, and Thorsson, pp. 12-13.

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> One of them was called Sæming. . . Earl Hákon the Mighty reckoned his pedigree from Sæming.[39]

In this passage, Skaði is married to Óðinn, and she is considered an ancestress of one of Norway's great families. There is one other major mention of Skaði in our sources. In stanzas 51-52 of the *Lokasenna*, more information about Skaði is given.

Skaði qvað:
"Veiztu, ef fyrstr oc øfstr vartu at fiorlagi,
þá er ér á Þiaza þrifoð:
frá mínom véom oc vöngom scolo
þér æ köld ráð koma."

Loki qvað:
"Léttari í málom vartu við Laufeyiar son,
þá er þú léz mér á beð þinn boðit;
getið verðr oss slícs, ef vér gorva scolom
telia vömmin vár."[40]

Skaði said:
"If, when it came to killing Þjazi,
you were first and foremost,
from my house and holy temples
you will have cold counsel."

Loki said:
"You spoke more sweetly to Laufey's son
when you lay beside me in bed.
There's a tale well worth the telling,
if we are all to air our faults!"[41]

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[39]Snorri Sturluson, *Heimskringla*, trans. Lee M. Hollander, p. 12.

[40]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 106.

[41]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, pp. 80-81.

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In this passage, Skaði mentions that she had holy temples. This would suggest that there was a cult dedicated to Skaði and some kind of worship of her. The rites of her cult have been lost to us, but it probably had something to do with snow, winter, and hunting. In the next stanza, Loki states that Skaði has been his lover. This would make her an adulteress whether she was married to Njörðr or Óðinn. In the *Lokasenna,* Loki accuses every goddess that has been mentioned, except Nerthus who is not included in the Eddas, with extra-martial sexual behavior.

Skaði's name is a masculine noun meaning "loss," "damage" in Old Norse. The meaning of her name might be linked to the power of winter with its blizzards, food shortages, and, in the northern regions, minimal sunlight.

From our sources, Skaði appears to be a goddess of winter. She is called the snow-shoe goddess and might have ties to the god Ullr. She is portrayed as the wife of both Njörðr and Óðinn and as the lover of Loki. She seems to have had a cult that worshiped her and temples dedicated to her.

Gerðr

Other than being mentioned once in a while as Freyr's wife, there is only one myth that concerns Gerðr. This myth concerns Freyr's sudden lust for Gerðr, and Skírnir's threats to insure Gerðr's compliance to Freyr's demands. The same myth appears in *Gylfaginning* (37) and the poem *Skírnismál.* In *Gylfaginning* (37), Snorri tells us how Freyr became besotted with Gerðr.

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Gymir hét maðr, en kona hans Aurboða. Hon var bergrisa ættar. Dóttir þeira er Gerðr er allra kvenna er fegrst. Þat var einn dag er Freyr hafði gengit í Hliðskjálf ok sá of heima alla, en er hann leit í norðrætt þá sá hann á einum bœ mikit hús ok fagrt, ok til þess húss gekk kona, ok er hon tók upp höndum ok lauk hurð fyrir sér þá lýsti af höndum hennar bœði í lopt ok á lög, ok allir heimar birtusk af henni.[42]

There was a man called Gymir whose wife Aurboða was of the family of cliff giants. Their daughter is Gerðr, who is an exceedingly beautiful woman. One day Freyr had gone to Hliðskjálf and was looking out over the whole world, he looked towards the north and saw in one place a large and beautiful dwelling. To this house went a woman; and, when she raised her arms to open the door, they illuminated the sky and sea, and the whole world grew bright from her.[43]

The same information is given in stanza 6 of *Skírnismál.*

Freyr qvað:
"Í Gymis görðom ec sá ganga
méf tíða mey;
armar lýsto, enn af þaðan
alt lopt oc lögr.[44]

Freyr said:
"In Gymir's court I saw going by
the one I love;
so white were her arms
they lit the sky and sea.[45]

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[42]Snorri Sturluson, *Edda*, Anthony Faulkes (ed), pp. 30-31.

[43]*The Prose Edda of Snorri Sturluson*, trans. Jean I. Young, p. 61.

[44]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 70.

[45]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, p. 51.

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In these two passages, we learn that Gerðr's arms are a source of light.[46] When she raises her arms the sea and sky are illuminated. To add to this light imagery, we are told in stanza 8 of *Skírnismál* that Skírnir must ride through a ring of fire to reach Gerðr. The ring of flames surrounding Gerðr's dwelling and her ability to illuminate the sky and sea suggest that she is a solar deity. She might symbolize the dawn or summer.

In stanza 20 when Skírnir reaches Gerðr, he then has to convince her to become Freyr's lover. At first, he offers her eleven golden apples and a gold ring that creates a ring just like it every nine days, but Gerðr refuses him.

Gerðr qvað:
"Epli ellifo ec þigg aldregi
at mannzcis munom,
né við Freyr, meðan occart fior lifir,
byggiom bæði saman."[47]

Gerðr said:
"Eleven apples will never be enough
to make me change my mind:
Freyr will never enjoy my favor
as long as we are both alive."[48]

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[46]Miriam Robbins Dexter, "Dawn-Maid and Sun-Maid: Celestial Goddesses among the Proto-Indo-Europeans," in *The Indo-Europeanization of Northern Europe,* Martin Huld and Karlene Bley-Jones (eds). p. 241. Dexter mentions that Gerðr is a possible sun goddess.

[47]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p.73.

[48]*Poems of the Elder Edda,* trans. Patricia Terry, stanza 20, p. 53.

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After Gerðr makes it clear that she wants nothing to do with Freyr, Skírnir begins to resort to threats. He threatens to cut off her head and to kill her father. These threats do not move her, so Skírnir begins to talk about torture.

Ara þúfo á scaltu ár sitia,
horfa heimi ór, snugga heliar til;
matr sé þér meirr leiðr enn manna hveim
inn fráni ormr með firom.

At undrsiónom þú verðir, er þú út kømr,
á þic Hrímnir hari, á þic hotvetna stari!
víðkunnari þú verðir enn vorðr með goðom,
gapiðu grindom frá!

Tópi oc ópi, tiosull oc óþoli,
vaxi þér tár með trega!
Seztu niðr, enn ec mun segia þér
sváran súsbreca
oc tvennan trega.[49]

Where eagles perch you will have your place,
high above the world you will long for Hell;
you will find your food more loathsome
than snakes seem to men.

You will be a wonder when you come out
monsters to marvel at, men to mock!
You will be far more famous than Heimdall;
you will gape behind bars.

You will rage and weep, wailing for mercy
as your tears swell with your sorrow!
Sit down and listen to what I have to say
of awful anguish, twofold torment.[50]

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[49]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, pp. 74-75.

[50]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, stanzas 27-29, p. 54.

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Skírnir continues to tell Gerðr how miserable her life will be and how much the gods hate her. He then states that no male anywhere will ever want her. To finish off his curse, he tells her about how she will live in Hel, and he begins a magic spell.

Hrímgrímnir heitir þurs, er þic hafa scal,
fyr nágrindr neðan;
þar þér vílmegir á viðar rótom
geita hland gefi!
Œðri dryccio fá þú aldregi,
mær, af þínom munom,
mær, at mínom munom.

Þurs ríst ec þér oc þriá stafi,
ergi oc æði oc ópola;
svá ec þat af ríst, sem ec þat á reist,
ef goraz þarfar þess.[51]

The giant Hrimgrimnir shall have you for his own,
your husband in Hel;
there among the tree roots wretched slaves
shall give you goat piss!
Nothing else shall you ever drink,
maiden, by your own will, maiden by my will.

"I cut a giant-rune, and carved three others:
frenzy, lewdness, and lust,
but I will erase each one I wrote
if they are not needed."[52]

As Skírnir pauses in his spell, Gerðr gives in and decides that she will become Freyr's lover.

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[51]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 76.

[52]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, stanzas 35-36, p. 55.

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Gerðr qvað:
"Heill verðu nú heldr, sveinn, oc tac við hrímkálki,
fullom forns miaðar!
þó hafða ec þat ætlað, at myndac aldregi
unna vaningia vel."[53]

Gerðr said:
"To your health, fair youth! Accept this foaming cup
filled with fine mead!
I never believed that I could be
so fond of Freyr."[54]

After this stanza, Gerðr sets up a time and a place where she will met Freyr.

This poem has been interpreted by many scholars as the marriage of the male sky god to the female earth deity.[55] Freyr is regarded as a sky diety because the name of his messenager (Skírnir) can be derived from the Norse word *skírr* meaning "shining". Gerðr is regarded as a diety of the earth because her name is derived from the Norse word *garðr* meaning "field". The problem I have with this interpretation is that Freyr is not really a sky god and Gerðr is not really portrayed as an earth deity. Freyr is a fertility deity who has an annual wagon procession and brings fertility and peace to the fields and his worshipers. Freyr is basically an earth deity. Gerðr seems to be portrayed as a solar deity. When she raises her arms the sea and sky are illuminated, and she is surrounded by a ring of flames. I interpret this myth as the

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[53]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 76.

[54]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, stanza 37, pp. 55-56.

[55]See Jan de Vries, *Altgermanische Religionsgeschichte* v. 2, § 560; H.R. Ellis Davidson, *Gods and Myths of Northern Europe*, pp. 92-93; E.O.G. Turville-Petre, *Myth and Religion of the North*, p. 174.

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marriage between the male earth deity and the female solar deity, maybe the goddess of the dawn or summer. Nothing else about the story suggests that Gerðr is related to the earth or agriculture.

Gerðr's name is derived from the Old Norse word *garðr* which means "fence," "enclosure,""farmyard." This has led scholars to infer that her name would mean something like "field" or "farm."[56] A fence or farmyard is a protected enclosure. Skírnir must ride through a ring of fire to get to Gerðr's house. In stanza 8, Skírnir asks Freyr to lend his horse, so Skírnir can "ride through the ghostly ring of flickering flames."[57] When Skírnir arrives at Gerðr's house in stanza 17, she asks who he is and why he rode "over raging flames to reach this hall?"[58] These two stanzas indicate that Gerðr's house was enclosed by a ring of flame. I suggest that instead of Gerðr's name meaning "field", her name meaning "enclosure" indicates this fiery enclosure around her home and emphasizes her connection to the sun.

Another interpretation of Gerðr's name might be "protection" since a fence or enclosure often surrounds and protects a homestead, farm, or village from both two and four legged raiders. If Gerðr's name means "protection" and Skaði's name means

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[56]Jan de Vries, *Altnordisches Etymologisches Wörterbuch* (Leiden: E.J. Brill, 1977), p. 164.

[57]"*Mar gefðu mér þa, þann er mic um myrqvan beri, vísan vafrloga" Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius,* p. 71; *Poems of the Elder Edda,* trans. Patricia Terry, p. 51.

[58]"*hví þú einn um komt eikinn fúr yfir, ór salkynni at siá?" Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius,* p. 71; *Poems of the Elder Edda,* trans. Patricia Terry, p. 73.

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"damage, loss"; then Norse myth has both a goddess of summer, light, and protection and a goddess of winter, darkness, and danger.

From the sources that we have, Gerðr appears to symbolize the marriage of the goddess of the dawn with the god of earth and fertility. All of the imagery in the poem that describes Gerðr is connected to light. Nothing in the sources point to a connection with the earth.

Less Well Documented Goddesses

Ran. Ran is the wife of the sea god Ægir. She does not really play a part in the *Eddas*. She is mentioned in two sagas. In chapter 54 of *Eyrbyggja Saga*, it is stated that if a drowned man attended his own funeral, he was well received by Ran. In chapter 6 of *Friðþjófs Saga* during a bad storm at sea, a leader gives his men gold coins so that Ran will welcome them. In both these passages, Ran appears to personify death by drowning. There seems to be no evidence of a cult in her name.

Hel. Hel is portrayed as the daughter of Loki and a giantess. She is one of Loki's hideous children. In *Gylfaginning*(34), Snorri relates how Óðinn threw Hel into *Niflheim* and gave her rule over nine worlds if she would share her provisions with those who came to her. Her plate is called Hunger and her knife Famine. We are told that all wicked men go to Hel, and that men who die of disease or old age go to her. She is pictured as half black and half flesh colored. Hel, herself, does not play a pivotal role in any of the myths.

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In *Gylfaginning* (49) after Baldr's death, Hermóð rides to Hel and asks her to release Baldr. Hel agrees to release Baldr if everything dead and alive weep for his return. The Æsir ask everything to weep Baldr out of Hel, and everything does but one giantess. Þökk, a giantess sitting in a cave, says:

Þökk mun gráta
þurrum tárum
Baldrs bálfarar.
Kyks né dauðs
nautka ek karls sonar:
haldi Hel því er hefir.[59]

Þökk will weep
dry tears
at Baldr's embarkation;
the old fellow's son
was no use to me
alive or dead,
let Hel hold what she has.[60]

It is Þökk, who the poem explains is Loki in disguise, and not Hel that thwarts the gods' attempt to cheat death and release Baldr. Hel seems to be more of a personification of death than a real goddess because she never does anything in the myths. Hel is more of a place than a being.

Nanna. In *Gylfaginning* (32), Snorri tells us that Nanna was the wife of Baldr and the daughter of Nep. Her son by Baldr was Forseti, who was known to reconcile legal disputes. At Baldr's funeral, Nanna's heart broke and she died. She

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[59]Snorri Sturluson, *Edda*, Anthony Faulkes (ed), p. 48.

[60]*The Prose Edda of Snorri Sturluson*, trans. Jean I. Young, p. 84.

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was then put on Baldr's funeral ship and burned with him. From Hel, Nanna sent gifts to Frigg and Fulla.[61] This is all of the information that we have for Nanna. She appears to be little more than an accessory for Baldr. She died at Baldr's funeral and was burned with him. This probably indicates that she committed suttee. Suttee is the Indo-European practice of ritual suicide.[62] When one's husband died, a good wife threw herself on his pyre. Nanna appears as the epitome of the Indo-European good wife.

Sigyn. Sigyn is another figure who seems to be the idealized wife. In *Gylfaginning* (50), we are told that she is the wife of Loki, and her son by Loki is named Narvi. When the Æsir bind Loki, they tear apart his son Narvi and use his entrails to tie Loki over the edges of three stones. The Æsir, then, hang a poisonous snake over Loki's face. Loki's wife Sigyn sits by him and holds a basin to catch the drops of poison.[63] This is all of the information that we have on Sigyn. She appears as the dutiful wife and seems to have no myths of her own.

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[61]*The Prose Edda of Snorri Sturluson*, trans. Jean I. Young, pp. 55, 82, 83.

[62]Karlene Jones-Bley, "Defining Indo-European Burial" *Varia on the Indo-European Past: Papers in Memory of Marija Gimbutas*, eds. Miriam Robbins Dexter and Edgar C. Polomé, (Journal of Indo-European Studies Monograph No. 19), (Institute of the Study of Man Inc.: Washington D.C., 1997)pp. 202-204.

[63]*The Prose Edda of Snorri Sturluson*, trans. Jean I. Young, pp. 55, 85.

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Sif. Sif is Þórr's wife. In *Gylfaginning* (31), Snorri tells us, "Ull, Sif's son and Þórr's stepson, is one of them [gods]."[64] In *Skáldskaparmál* (17), the giant Hrungnir becomes very drunk and threatens to kill all of the Æsir except Freyja and Sif who he will take home with him. In *Skáldskaparmál* (43), Snorri tells us why a kenning for gold is Sif's hair.

> *Loki Laufeyjarson hafði það gert til lævísi að klippa hár allt af Sif. En er Þór varð þess var tók hann Loka og myndi lemja hvert bein í honum áður hann svaraði þess að hann skal fá af svartálfum að þeir skulu gera af gulli Sifju hadd þann er svo skal vaxa sem annað hár.*[65]
>
> Once, for a joke, Loki, Laufey's son, cut off all of Sif's hair, but when Þórr got to know this he seized Loki and would have broken every bone in his body, had he not sworn to persuade the dark elves to make hair from gold for Sif that would grow like other hair.[66]

Sif's beautiful gold hair is reminiscent of the tow of flax or the pale gold of the beard of wheat. That her hair is real gold connects her to prosperity and wealth. In stanzas 53 - 54 in the *Lokasenna,* we are told of Sif's adultery with Loki.

> *Þá gecc Sif fram oc byrlaði Loca í hrímkálki mioð oc mælti:*
> *"Heill ver þú nú, Loki, oc tac við hrímkálki,*
> *fullom forns miaðar,*
> *heldr þú hana eina látir með ása sonom*
> *vammalausa vera."*
>
> *Hann tóc við horni ok dracc af:*
> *"Ein þú værir, ef þú svá værir,*

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[64]"Ullr heitir einn, sonr Sifjar, stjúpsonr Þórs." Snorri Sturluson, Edda, p. 26; *The Prose Edda of Snorri Sturluson*, trans. Jean I. Young, p. 55.

[65]Snorra Sturlusonnar, *Edda*, Heimir Pálsson (ed), p. 128.

[66]*The Prose Edda of Snorri Sturluson*, trans. Jean I. Young, p. 108.

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vor oc gröm at veri;
einn ec veit, svá at ec vita þicciomc,
hór oc af Hlórriða,
oc var þat sá inn lævísi Loki."[67]

She said:
"Hail to you Loki! Lift the gobblet
full of fine mead!
Then one alone among the Æsir
you can find blameless."

He took the goblet and said:
"You would be my choice, could we believe you
a man-hating woman;
but one at least know it is not a lie
to call Hlorridi cuckold,
and that is your crafty Loki!"[68]

This passage indicates that there was another myth about Sif of which we have no record. Like the other goddesses mentioned above, Sif is accused of amoral sexual behavior. She does not contradict Loki in the poem, but the rest of the Æsir warn him not to anger Þórr.

Sif's name appears to be the singular of the Old Norse noun *sifjar* "related, affinity." The Proto-Germanic root would have been **seþ-*. Cognates in German and English would be German *Sippe* meaning "clan, kin" and English "sib" which means "a blood relative, kin" and with an obsolete meaning of "peace, amity, concord." The more common English noun from the same root is "sibling". Sif

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[67]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 107.

[68]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, p. 81.

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would probably mean something like "clan, kin, peace". This would make Sif the goddess of the family and maybe the ancestors.

The information about Sif that we have indicates that she is a goddess related to the wheat, flax, and prosperity with her golden hair and through her name to the family. Other than this, little else can be said about Sif and her place in Germanic myth.

Fulla. Fulla is only mentioned a few times in our sources, and always in relationship with Frigg. In *Gylfaginning* (35), Snorri states "she, too, is a virgin and wears her hair loose and a golden band round her head. She carries Frigg's little box and looks after her shoes and knows her secrets."[69] After Baldr's death and Nanna's suttee, Nanna sends presents from Hel back to Frigg and Fulla with Hermóð. Other than this tiny bit of information, we know nothing about Fulla. Her name obviously appears related to the Old Norse word *fullr* meaning "full, filled." The Proto-Germanic root would have been **ful-* which was derived from the zero grade of the Indo-European root **plē-*. A cognate in Latin would be *plenus*, English "plenitude." This would make Fulla a goddess of prosperity and perhaps fertility.

Þorgerðr. Þorgerðr often called Þorgerðr Hölgabruðr was probably a goddess. She is mentioned in several sources under various names including Þóra and Gerðr. The sources that mention her are often confusing and very hostile toward

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[69]"*Hon er en mær ok ferr laushár ok gullband um höfuð. Hon berr eski Friggjar ok gætir skóklæða hennar ok veit launráð með henni.*" Snorri Sturluson, *Edda*, p. 29; *The Prose Edda of Snorri Sturluson*, trans. Jean I. Young, p. 59.

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her. She is always associated with Earl Hákon Eiríksson and his family. To add to the confusion, Earl Hákon's wife was named Þóra. She was the daughter of Skagi Skoptason, and it is often nearly impossible to discern to which Þóra the sources are referring. Earl Hákon was an extremely powerful figure in Scandinavia in the late tenth century. He was very supportive of traditional Norse religion and was King Óláf Tryggvason's[70] greatest obstacle in the Christianization of Norway.

Most of the references to Þorgerðr come from the *Flateyjarbók* version of the *Óláfs saga Tryggvasonar* and in the *Færeyinga Þáttr* also in *Flateyjarbók*. In the *Flateyjarbók* account of Earl Hákon's battle with the *Jómsvíkingar*, Earl Hákon prays to Þorgerðr Hölgabruðr and offers a human sacrifice. She refuses to help him in the battle until he offers to sacrifice his twelve-year-old son Erlingr. She then caused a huge hail storm and shot arrows from every finger. Due to her intervention, Earl Hákon wins the battle.

In *Færeyinga Þáttr*, Earl Hákon and his friend Sigmundr Brestisson go into the temple of Þorgerðr Hölgabruðr.[71] It is very rich and full of gold and silver ornaments. There are other gods there, but at the far end is a beautifully dressed

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[70]Óláf Tryggvason was the king of Norway from 964-1000 C.E. He attempted to bring Christianity to Norway by burning pagan temples and by attacking prominent pagans.

[71]Nora Chadwick, "Þorgerðr Hölgabruðr and the Trolla Þing: A Note on Sources," in *The Early Cultures of North-West Europe: H.M. Chadwick Memorial Studies*, ed. Cyril Fox and Bruce Dickins (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1950).

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woman. Earl Hakon tells his friend to place a gift of silver before her. If Þorgerðr is favorable toward him, she will allow him to take a ring from her finger.

Þorgerðr is mentioned in chapter 88 of *Njáls Saga* when her temple is burnt down. While Earl Hákon was at a feast, Hrapp the Killer went to the temple which had a statue of Þorgerðr Hölgabruðr. The statue was as big as a fully-grown man. The statue wore a huge gold bracelet on its arm and had a linen hood over its head. Hrapp stole the jewelry and hood from the statue. He then stole the jewelry from the statues of Þórr and Irpa. Hrapp, then, dragged the statues outside, stripped them of their vestments, and set the temple on fire.

The destruction of another of Þorgerðr Hölgabruðr's temples is mentioned in the *Flateyjarbók* version of the *Óláf saga Tryggvasonar.* This temple was located in Trondheim. King Óláf Tryggvason first destroys a temple dedicated to Freyr at Forsta. He then goes to Þorgerðr's temple which is magnificent. She is dressed beautifully. The King strips her of her gold and silver adornments. He then ties her to his horse's tail, splits her image with a club, and burns her together with an image of Freyr.[72]

From these sources Þorgerðr seems to have been an important goddess in Trondheim, which is in the northern part of Norway. She has control over the weather and is a useful ally in war. She accepts human sacrifice, and her temples

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[72]Nora Chadwick, "Þorgerðr Hölgabruðr and the Trolla Þing: A Note on Sources," in *The Early Cultures of North-West Europe*, p. 407.

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are very wealthy. Due to the confusing nature of the sources and Nora Chadwick's convincing argument that several sources have confused the goddess with the wife of the Earl, I do not want to delve any deeper into the study of Þorgerðr and her cult at this time.[73]

Hyrrokkin. Hyrrokin is mentioned in *Gylfaginning* (49). She is the only being who can launch Baldr's funeral ship.

> *Hringhorni hét skip Baldrs. Hann var allra skipa mestr. Hann vildu goðin fram setja ok gera þar á bálför Baldrs. En skipit gekk hvergi fram. Þá var sent í Jötunheima eptir gýgi þeiri er Hyrrokkin hét. En er hon kom ok reið vargi ok hafði höggorm at taumum þá hljóp hon af hestinum, en Óðinn kallaði til berserki fjóra at gæta hestsins, ok fengu þeir eigi haldit nema þeir feldi hann. Þá gekk Hyrrokkin á framstafn nökkvans ok hratt fram í fyrsta viðbragði svá at eldr hraut ór hlunnunum ok lönd öll skulfu. Þá varð Þórr reiðr ok greip hamarinn ok myndi þá brjóta höfuð hennar áðr en goðin öll báðu henni friðar.*[74]
>
> Baldr's ship was called Ringhorn, it was a very large ship. The gods wanted to launch it and to build Baldr's funeral pyre on it, but they could not move it at all. They sent to Giantland then for the ogress called Hyrrokkin. And when she came -- she was riding a wolf with vipers for reins -- she jumped off her steed and Oðinn called to four berserkrs to guard it, but they were unable to hold it fast till they struck it down. Then Hyrrokkin went to the prow of the vessel and at the first shove launched it in such a way that the rollers burst into flame and the whole world trembled. Þórr became angry then and

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[73]For a very detailed account of the problems surrounding the study of Þorgerðr see Nora Chadwick, "Þorgerðr Hölgabruðr and the Trolla Þing: A Note on Sources,"in *The Early Cultures of North-West Europe.*

[74]Snorri Sturluson, *Edda,* Anthony Faulkes (ed), p. 46.

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seizing his hammer would have cracked her skull had not all the gods begged protection for her.[75]

The image of Hyrrokin riding a wolf and using snakes for reins is a peculiar one; however, there is a stone in Hynnstad in Skåne in southern Sweden with an engraved image of a woman riding a wolf with snakes for reins.[76] The image on this stone seems to prove the genuiness of this tradition.

Hyrrokin is portrayed as extremely strong. The wolf that she controls enough to ride is too wild for four berserkrs to control. She is also the only person strong enough to push Baldr's ship into the water. Strength does not seem to be the real reason that the Æsir send for Hyrrokkin. She is portrayed as the only person who can start the funeral. Hyrrokin was probably originally a goddess of death. Her portrayal as exceedingly strong is not surprising since no one can break free of death. She rides a wolf. The wolf is one of the animals that scavenges the battle field after a fight and eats the unburied dead. The snakes that she uses for reins are also connected with death. Snakes live underground and shed their skin. These facts have imbued them with chthonic symbolism. They symbolize the underworld and regeneration. This myth is the only information that we have for Hyrrokkin except for her name. The first half of Hyrrokkin's name is related to the Old Norse noun

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[75]*The Prose Edda of Snorri Sturluson*, trans. Jean I. Young, p. 82.

[76] Jan de Vries, *Altgermanisches Religionsgeschichte* v. 2, p. 225. See Tafel XIX

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hyrr which means "fire."[77] The second half of her name is probably related to the past participle of the Old Norse verb *rjúka* meaning "to emit smoke, to reek."[78] The name *hyrr-rokinn* probably means something like "fire that has smoked or cooled off." I completely agree with Motz who beleives Hyrrokin's name was probably somehow connected with the funeral pyre since Hyrrokin has associations with both fire and funerals.[79]

Summary

The Norse female deities can be arranged into three distinct groupings: deities with similar functions and characteristics to Freyja, deities that appear to be personifications, and deities that seem to have unique functions. Frigg and Gefjun appear to be different aspects of the goddess Freyja. Freyja and Gefjun share a name, motherhood, sex for a necklace, and control over the dead. Frigg and Gefjun share motherhood, amoral sexual behavior, and the ability to see the future. Frigg and Freyja share adultery, a husband, motherhood, and weeping. The three goddesses seem to form a trinity that illustrates the different aspects of a woman's life: virgin; sexually active, unattached woman; and wife.

Iðunn, Sif, and Fulla appear to be related to the Freyja complex of goddesses. Both Iðunn and Sif are connected with prosperity and seem to be tangentially related

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[77]Lotte Motz, *The Beauty and the Hag*, p. 82.

[78]Jan de Vries, *Altnordisches Etymologisches Wörterbuch*, p. 276.

[79]Lotte Motz, *The Beauty and the Hag*, p. 82.

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to Freyja. Iðunn provides long life for the gods through her care of the apples of eternal youth. These apples seem to symbolize life itself. Iðunn's husband is Bragi, which might be another name for Óðinn. Iðunn, like Freyja, is an asset to steal, and she is accused of adultery. These characteristics place Iðunn in the same basic category as Freyja.

Sif's hair of gold is related to flax and breaded wheat. She is accused of adultery like many of the other major goddesses. Sif's name is related to the concepts of clan, kin, and peace. These characteristics seem to place Sif in the same basic category as Freyja. Little is known about Fulla except for her name. Her name is related to plentitude. Fulla's name seems to be related to the prosperity inherent in Freyja's cult.

Ran, Hel, Nanna, and Sigyn all seem to be personifications. Ran and Hel both are goddesses of death; however, Ran and Hel do not appear to have any real power or any real cult. They are the personifications of drowning and death; they are not true powerful goddesses. Nanna and Sigyn are personifications of the Indo-European good wife. Both women stand by their man without thought of the consequences for themselves. Nanna commits ritual suicide on her husband's death, and Sigyn spends her life protecting her husband from dripping poison.

Þorgerðr, Skaði, Gerðr, and Hyrrokin appear to be unique beings who are not directly related to the cult of other Norse goddesses. Þorgerðr's cult was prevalent in northern Norway in Trondheim. Þorgerðr's cult seems to be intimately linked with

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the family of Earl Hákon. She could control the weather, turn the tide of battle, had temples, and demanded human sacrifice. The stories about Þorgerðr are extremely biased against her and confused due to the similarity of her name and the name of Earl Hákon's wife. The sources portray Þorgerðr as a protective goddess who needs continual expressions of devotion in the form of precious goods or human sacrifice.

Skaði is portrayed as a winter goddess. She is called "the Snow-Shoe Goddess". She goes fully armed around the mountainous areas of the North on skis and snowshoes. She had temples dedicated to her. Skaði was married to both Njörðr and Óðinn at different times. Skaði is the only goddess in the sources that takes control of her life. The other goddesses appear to allow the action of the myths to take place around them. They react to situations. At the death of her father, Skaði confronts the gods and demands compensation for her loss. She is allowed to choose a husband from the gods by looking at their feet. She is unhappy with her marriage to Njörðr. The sources maintain that the conflict in their marriage was where to live: in the mountains, which was Skaði's natural habitat; or at the coast, which was Njörðr's. The inability of the two deities to manage a workable compromise emphasizes Skaði's intrinsic relationship with the snow covered mountains of the north. She can not survive anywhere else. Skaði's name appears to mean "loss," "damage." The meaning of her name is probably linked with the danger inherent in winter. Winter would have been very long and extremely difficult in the northern and mountainous regions of Scandinavia. Winter was the

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time of short days, freezing cold, slow starvation, and livestock depletions. It would be natural for the goddess of winter to have a name that symbolized the hardship of the season.

Gerðr appears to be a solar deity. The world is illuminated when she raises her arms, and Skirnir must pass through a ring of fire to reach her. Gerðr is forced into an unwanted marriage with Freyr by Skirnir's threats. The myth of Gerðr and Freyr seems to tell the story of the forced marriage of the female solar deity to the male fertility deity.

Hyrrokkin is a giantess, who the Æsir need to help with the funeral of Baldr. Hyrrokkin is the only being, who can push Baldr's ship into the sea for its funeral-pyre voyage. She rides a wolf with snakes for reins. Four berserkrs can not control her wolf. Hyrrokkin is a goddess of death. She is portrayed as extremely strong, but then nothing is stronger than the unbreakable hold of death. Hyrrokkin's name seems to be related to the Old Norse word for "fire" and could be related to the use of fire in the cremation of the remains of the dead.

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V. NORNS, VALKYRIES, AND OTHERS

The Norns, Valkyries, and other lesser known figures such as the *dísir*, *fylgjas*, and *hamingjas* play important roles in Norse myth. By the time of our sources, the distinctions between these beings are very blurred; and it is difficult, in some cases, impossible to tell one from another. All of these beings are portrayed as female and intimately connected with human society especially on the level of the individual.

Norns

References to the Norns appear several times in our sources. The Norns appear in groups of three, and they are always referred to in the plural. In stanzas 19-20 of the Eddic poem *Völuspá,* we are told where the Norns live and their names. The same information is given by Snorri in *Gylfaginning* (15).

Asc veit ec standa, heitir Yggdrasill,
hár baðmr, ausinn hvítaauri;
þaðan koma döggvar, þærs í dala falla,
stendr æ yfir, grœnn, Urðar brunni.

Þaðan koma meyiar, margs vitandi,
þriár, ór þeim sæ, er und þolli stendr;
[Urð héto eina, aðra Verðandi
--scáro á scíði--, Sculd ina þriðio;]
þær lög lögðo, þær líf kuro
alda bornom, ørlög seggia.[1]

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[1]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 5.

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There is an ash tree-- its name is Yggdrasil-
a tall tree watered from a cloudy well.
Dew falls from its boughs down into the valleys;
ever green it stands beside the Norns' spring.

Much wisdom have the three maidens
who come from the waters close to that tree;
they established laws, decided the lives
men were to lead, marked out their fates.[2]

These two passages both place the Norns' spring at the base of the World Tree. Both passages state that the Norns come from the spring. In other words, they live in the waters of the spring. The poem states that the water is cloudy; and later in *Gylfaginning* (16) we are told, "that water is so sacred that everything that comes into the spring becomes as white as the skin that lies within the eggshell."[3] These statements give the impression that the spring is full of milk and not water. The allusion to the skin within the eggshell immediately brings to mind images of birth.

The names of the three maidens are Urð, Verðandi, and Skuld. Urð is the past participle of the Old Norse verb *verða* which means "to happen, to take place." This would give Urð the meaning "that which has taken place, what has happened" or "the past." Verðandi is the present participle of the Old Norse verb *verða*. This would give Verðandi the meaning of "what is happening" or "the present." The noun

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[2]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, p. 3.

[3]*"En þat vatn er svá heilagt at allir hlutir þeir sem þar kona í brunninn verða svá hvítir sem hinna sú er skjall heitir, er innan liggr við eggskurn."* Snorri Sturluson, *Edda*, Anthony Faulkes (ed), p. 19; *The Prose Edda of Snorri Sturluson*, trans. Jean I. Young, pp. 45-46.

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skuld in Old Norse means "debt."[4] This would loosely give the names of the Norns the meanings of past, present, and what is owed or prehaps fated.[5] The names of the Norns span time. They control the past, the present, and the fate of the future. No one is beyond their control or grasp. From the moment of birth until death, each person's life was controlled by the Norns.

The Norns' connection to the birth of children seems to have been a strong one. Stanzas 2-4 of the poem *Helgakviða Hundingsbana in fyrri* connect the Norns to the spinning of fate. This would be a natural image because the process of making cloth took up every spare moment of a woman's life. The image of women spinning thread would have been entrenched in the minds of the audience.

Nótt varð í bœ, *nornir qvómo,*
þær er öðlingi *aldr um scópo;*
þann báðo fylki *frægstan verða*
oc buðlunga *beztan þiccia.*

Snero þær af afli *ørlögþátto,*
þá er borgir braut *í Brálundi;*
þær um greiddo *gullin símo*
oc und mána sal *miðian festo.*

Þær austr oc vestr *enda fálo,*
þar átti lofðungr *land á milli;*
brá nipt Nera *á norðrvega*
einni festi, *ey það hon halda.*[6]

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[4]Jan de Vries, *Altnordisches Etymologisches Wörterbuch*, p. 506.

[5]ibid., pp. 506-507, 635-636, and 655; H. R. Ellis Davidson, *Myths and Symbols in Pagan Europe*, p. 164.

[6]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 130.

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The Norns came to the house that night
those who would fashion the prince's fate;
great fame, they said, would mark his future,
he would be called the best of kings.

Then they wound the threads of fate,
in Bralund's castle where the hero was born,
gathered the strands into a golden rope,
and made it fast in the moon's high hall.

East and west they hid the ends;
the prince's lands lay in between.
Neri's sister went to the north
and fastened one end to hold forever.[7]

The Norns arrive the night that the great hero Helgi is born. They determine his fate and then spin it into a rope of gold. They string this rope across his realm and fix one end to hold forever. This might mean that while he will die, his fame will live forever. This poem again mentions that the Norns come at the birth of a person and at that moment determine that person's fate for life.

Belief in women coming at the birth of a child to determine its fate must have been very strong. In the eleventh century, Burchard the Bishop of Worms ordered that those who believed in the Parcae, who come at the time of a child's birth and can predict the future of the child, should be punished. He also forbad women to keep a covered table ready for the Parcae at certain times of the year.[8] If the Bishop had to go so far as to forbid the practice and belief in women coming to

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[7]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, p. 115.

[8]Jan de Vries, *Altgermanische Religionsgeschichte* v. 2, § 530.

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determine the fate of a child, then the belief must have been wide spread and prevalent even in the eleventh century.

Other than at birth, the Norns are usually mentioned in the context of imminent death or when someone needs to blame someone else for a situation. At the end of the poem *Hamðiamál* in stanzas 28 - 30, two brothers are facing death at the hands of their enemies.

> Af væri nú haufuð, ef Erpr lifði,
> bróðir occarr inn böðfrœcni, er við á braut vágom,
> verr inn vígfrœcni --hvöttomc at dísir--,
> gumi inn gunnhelgi --gorðomz at vígi--.
>
> Ecci hygg ec ocr vera úlfa dœmi,
> at vit mynim siálfir um sacaz,
> sem grey norna, þau er gráðug ero
> í auðn um alin.
>
> Vel höfom við vegit, stöndom á val Gotna,
> ofan, eggmóðom, sem ernir á qvisti;
> góðs höfom tírar fengið, þott scylim nú eða í gær deyia,
> qveld lifir maðr ecci eptir qvið norna.[9]
>
> Hamdir said:
> "The king's head would be off if Erp were alive,
> that man of courage we killed on our way,
> a consecrated warrior-- the Norns compelled me--
> we shed the blood of our brother.
>
> "We should not act like savage wolves
> tearing at each other,
> like dogs that the Norns deprive of food,
> wild in the woods.
>
> "We have fought a good battle; like eagles on a branch

[9]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius,* pp. 273-274.

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we stand on dead warriors our swords struck down.
We must die, now or later, but our deeds have won us fame;
no man sees the night when the Norns have spoken."[10]

In these stanzas, Hamðir blames the Norns for his current predicament. It is the Norns' fault that he killed his half-brother. They decreed it. He was only doing what was fated for him. In the second stanza, the Norns do not only decide the fate of mankind but also animals. They are the ones to decide which dogs starve. In the last stanza, Hamðir basically states that if the Norns decree it is your time to die, there is no way you will survive. In these stanzas, the Norns are portrayed as all-powerful beings. They are in control of everyone's actions. Their decrees cannot be vetoed or side-stepped.

The Norns are not talked about at length in any other passages. Other references to the Norns are usually by people who are unhappy with their lives or to hint at someone's death. In stanza 15 of the poem *Grimnismál,* when Óðinn tells a king that he will die soon; Óðinn says that the Norns do not smile on him. In stanza 2 of the poem *Reginsmál,* Loki is talking to a fish who says, "Long ago a foul Norn fixed as my fate to spend my life swimming."[11] In stanza 11 of the poem *Fáfnismál,* Fáfnir tells Sigurd, "You are destined by the Norns' decree to find a fool's fate."[12] In

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[10]*The Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, p. 238.

[11]"*aumlig norn scóp oss í árdaga, at ec scylda í vatni vaða." Edda: Die Lieder des codex Regius*, p. 174; *The Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, p. 145.

[12]"*Norna dóm þú munt fyr nesiom hafa/oc ósvinnz apa." Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 182; *The Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, p. 154.

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stanza 7 of *Sigurðarkviða in scamma,* Brynhild mourns, "Yet I am wrong to speak such words-- Gundron is his wife, and I am Gunnar's; never will the Norns free us from longing."[13] A runic inscription from a church in Borgund near Søgne in Norway contains the words "The Norns determine the good and the bad, they determined for me great grief."[14]

In the above passages, the Norns seem to be the beings to blame when your life is not going well or something terrible has happened. Personal responsibility does not exist. The Norns have already decided on your actions and the outcome. There is nothing you can do to change your fate. In poetry, the Norns' name became synonymous with "fate". By the time of our sources, the Norns seem to be more of a cliché than real spirits that demand worship and belief. This apparent superficial belief in the Norns probably speaks for the ancientness of the belief in them.

The reproaches of the Bishop of Worms in the eleventh century indicate that there was a basic belief in the Norns as birth attendants. The Norns attended the birth of every child and determined the child's fate. Some form of this belief continued and apparently flourished long after the conversion to Christianity. Beliefs surrounding childbirth, because of the always present danger to the child and mother, would have been very conservative and not prone to change.

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[13]*"Orð mæltac nú, iðromc eptir þess,/qván er hans Guðrún, enn ec Gunnars;/liótar nornir scópo oss langa þrá." Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius,* p. 208; *The Poems of the Elder Edda,* trans. Patricia Terry, p. 179.

[14]Jan de Vries, *Altgermanische Religionsgeschichte* v. 1, § 192.

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Valkyries

By the time of our sources, there are several different conceptions of Valkyries. Some sources depict them as dignified Amanzonian figures that ride into battle on behalf of a favorite. Other sources depict them as blood-thirsty, demonic creatures. Sometimes they seem to be the spiritual companion and lover of the hero. The number of Valkyries is also uncertain. In *Helgakviða Hjörvarðssonar*, nine Valkyries are mentioned. In *Darraðarljóð*, twelve Valkyries are mentioned. In *Grímnismál*, thirteen Valkyries are named. In other words, the sources do not agree on the number, role, and form of the Valkyries, so it is no surprise that our view of them is confused and kaleidoscopic.

The word *Valkyrja* is a compound of the noun *valr* "the slain" and the verb *kjósa* "to choose, to pick." *Valkyrja*, then, means "the one who chooses or picks the dead."[15] Davidson mentions that in Old English the equivalent word is *wælcyrge* which in Latin texts is a gloss for the Furies, the war-goddess Bellona, and the Gorgon.[16] These glosses present a contemporary picture of the Valkyries as frightening, bloodthirsty beings.

In *Gylfaginning* (36), Snorri portrays the Valkyries as the handmaidens of Óðinn.

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[15]Jan de Vries, *Altnordisches Etymologisches Wörterbuch*, p. 641.

[16]H.R. Ellis Davidson, *Myths and Symbols in Pagan Europe: Early Scandinavian and Celtic Religions* (Syracuse, New York: Syracuse University Press, 1988), p. 93.

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Enn eru þær aðrar er þjóna skulu í Vallhöll, bera drykkju ok gæta borðbúnaðar ok ölgagna. Svá eru þær nefndar í Grímnismálum:

Hrist ok Mist
vil ek at mér horn beri,
Skeggjöld ok Skögul,
Hildr ok Þrúðr,
Hlökk ok Herfjötur,
Göll ok Geirahöð,
Randgríð [Ranngríð] ok Ráðgríð
ok Reginleif.
Þær bera einherjum öl.

Þessar heita valkyrjur. Þær sendir Óðinn til hverrar orrostu. Þær kjósa feigð á menn ok ráða sigri. Guðr ok Rota ok norn in yngsta er Skuld heitir ríða jafnan at kjósa val ok ráða vígum.[17]

There are, moreover, others whose duty it is to serve in Valhalla, carry the drink round and look after the table service and ale-cups. Their names in the *Lay of Grímnir* are as follows:

Hrist and Mist
I want to bring me the horn,
Skeggjöld and Skögul,
Hild and Þrúð,
Hlökk and Herfjötur,
Göll [Giöll] and Geirahöð,
Randgríð and Ráðgríð,
and Reginleif.
These bear ale to the Einherjar.

These are called Valkyries. Oðinn sends them to every battle, and they choose death for the men destined to die, and award victory. Guð and Rota and the youngest Norn Skuld always ride to choose the slain and decide battles.[18]

The names of the Valkyries in this passage are mainly related to battle and war.[19]

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[17]Snorri Sturluson, *Edda*, p. 30.

[18]*The Prose Edda of Snorri Sturluson*, trans. Jean I. Young, p. 61.

[19]Hrist is from the verb *hrista* meaning "to shake". Mist is from the noun *missa* meaning "loss". Sceggiöld is from the noun *skeggja* meaning "halbred" and the noun *öld* meaning "age" or "time". This would give Sceggiöld the meaning "halbred or

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The Valkyries are portrayed in this passage partially as glorified barmaids and partially as goddesses of death. They serve drinks at *Valhalla*, Óðinn's hall. An engraved memorial stone from Alskog Tjängvide, Gotland, Sweden, has been dated to the eighth century C.E. This stone depicts Óðinn riding his eight-legged horse. In front of his horse is a female figure holding a drinking horn. This female figure is usually interpreted as a Valkyrie.[20] This probable depiction of a Valkyrie gives validity to the details in this passage.

The Valkyries go to battles and insure that the warriors fated for death actually die. It is unclear in the *Lay of Grímnir* passage if the Valkyries decide who is fated to die, Óðinn decides who is fated to die, or some other power, such as the Norns, decides who is to die. It is only stated that the Valkyries are at battles to ensure what is fated happens.

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battle-ax age". Scögul is from the noun *skökull* meaning "trace of a harness". Hildi is from the noun *hildr* meaning "battle". Þrúði is from the adjective *þrúðinn* meaning "strong". Hlöcc is from the noun *hlökk* meaning "clash, battle". Herfiotur is from the noun *herr* meaning "army" and the noun *fjöturr* meaning "fetter, shackle". This would give Herfiotur the meaning of "army fetterer". Göll is from the verb *gjalla* meaning "to scream, to shriek". Geirölul is from the noun *geirr* meaning "spear" and the adjective *ölr* meaning "drunk". Randgríð is from the noun *rann* meaning "large house" and the noun *gríð* meaning "truce". Ráðgríð is from the noun *ráð* meaning "advice, counsel" and the noun *gríð* meaning "truce". Reginleif is from the plural noun *regin* meaning "the gods" and the verb *leifa* meaning "to leave, to abandon" and could mean "the one abandoned by the gods".

[20]For a picture of the stone see H.R. Ellis Davidson, *Myths and Symbols in Pagan Europe: Early Scandinavian and Celtic Religions* (Syracuse, New York: Syracuse University Press, 1988), plate 2b.

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The Norn Skuld is mentioned at the end of the *Lay of Grímnir* passage as one of the Valkyries who always rides into battle. The inclusion of Skuld as a Valkyrie blurs the distinction between Norns and Valkyries. Our sources seem to differentiate between the functions of Norns and Valkyries, but here it is clearly stated that at least one of the Norns was also a Valkyrie. Skuld's name, which means "debt" or "what is owed," could explain her function as both a Norn and a Valkyrie. When a child is born, the Norns fortell and seal the fate of the child. After one's fate is determined by the Norn's, that fortold fate becomes almost like an obligation that must be fulfilled. When a warrior's fated death happens in battle, the Valkyries collect the debt.

The Valkyries are not only concerned with death, but they also can mentor great warriors and assit them in battle. The three Helgi poems of the *Poetic Edda* concern the hero Helgi and his Valkyrie lover. The poem *Helgakviða Hjörvarðzsonar*, which appears to take place first, explains how the hero Helgi received his name and his sword.

> *Hiorvarðr oc Sigrlinn átto son mikinn oc vœnan. Hann var þögull; ecci nafn festiz við hann. Hann sat á haugi; hann sá ríða valkyrior nío, oc var ein göfugligust. Hon qvað:*
>
> *"Sið mundu, Helgi, hringom ráða,*
> *rícr rógapaldr, né Röðulsvöllom*
> *--örn gól árla--, ef þú æ þegir,*
> *þóttu harðan hug, hilmir, gialdir."*[21]

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[21] *Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 142.

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Hjorvard and Sigrlinn had a strong and handsome son. He never spoke much, and no name would stick to him. He was sitting on a grave-mound when he saw nine valkyries riding. The noblest-looking of them said:

"Helgi the warrior, you will wait a long time
to own gold rings or Rodulsfells
if you keep silence, though eagles shrieked early,
prince, and of courage you give proof."[22]

Helgi demands a gift to go with his name and the Valkyrie tells him where he can find a wonderful sword. A prose section between stanzas 10 and 11 states that this Valkyrie continued to help Helgi during his life.

Eylimi hét konungr. Dóttir hans var Sváva. Hon var valkyria oc reið lopt oc lög. Hon gaf Helga nafn þetta oc hlífði hánom opt síðan í orrostom.[23]

King Eylimi had a daughter called Svava. She was a valkyrie, and rode through the air and over the sea. It was she who gave Helgi his name, and afterwards she often helped him in battles.[24]

Helgi seems unaware of the help that Svava gives him until a giantess mentions it. Helgi has killed the father of Hrimgerd, a giantess. Hrimgerd demands that Helgi have sex with her as compensation for the death of her father.

"Vaki þú, Helgi, oc bæt við Hrímgerði,
er þú lézt höggvinn Hata;
eina nótt kná hon hiá iofri sofa,
þá hefir hon bölva bætr."

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[22]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, stanza 7, pp. 105-106.

[23]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 143.

[24]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, p. 106.

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"Loðinn heitir, er þic scal eiga, leið ertu mannkyni;
sá býr í Þolleyio þurs,
hundviss iotunn, hraunbúa vestr;
sá er þér macligr maðr."

"Hina vildo heldr, Helgi, er réð hafnir scoða
fyrri nótt með firom;
margullin mær mér þótti afli bera;
hér sté hon land af legi
oc festi svá yðarn flota.
Hon ein því veldr, er ec eigi mác
buðlungs mönnom bana."

"Heyrðu nú, Hrímgerðr, ef ec bæti harma þér,
segðu gørr grami:
var sú ein vættr, er barg öðlings scipom,
eða fóro þær fleiri saman?"

"Þrennar níundir meyia, þó reið ein fyrir,
hvít und hiálmi mær;
marir hristuz, stóð af mönom þeira
dögg í diúpa dali,
hagl í háva viðo;
þaðan kømr með öldom ár;
alt var mér þat leitt, er ec leitc."[25]

Hrimgerd said:
"Wake up, Helgi, pay your debts to Hrimgerd-
your hand struck down Hati;
one night in bed as the prince's bride
and I will be quite content."

Helgi said:
"Lodin will lie with you, loathsome as you are,
Þoll is the hairy one's home;
he is very wise and the worst of giants,
a man fit for you to marry."

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[25]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 145-146.

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Hrimgerd said:
"Helgi would prefer the one who watched the harbor
all night among the men;
a shining maiden, mightier than I,
she stepped ashore from the sea-
that is how your fleet was made fast.
It is her fault that Hrimgerd failed
to kill the king's son."

Helgi said:
"Hrimgerd, I will give you something for your grief,
but you must tell me more:
did one valkyrie visit my ship,
or did many travel together?"

Hrimgerd said:
"Three times nine they came, but one commanded,
a white maid wearing a helmet;
their long-maned horses tossed their heads-
all this I looked at and loathed."[26]

Another prose section interrupts the flow of the poem to tell us that Helgi married Svava.

> *Helgi konungr var allmikill hermaðr. Hann kom til Eylima konungs oc bað Svávo, dóttur hans. Þau Helgi oc Sváva veittuz várar oc unnuz furðo mikit. Sváva var heima með feðr sínom, enn Helgi í hernaði. Var Sváva valkyria enn sem fyrr.*[27]
>
> King Helgi was a great warrior. He visited King Eylimi and asked for the hand of his daughter Svava. Helgi and Svava exchanged vows, and the love between them was very great. Svava stayed at home with her father while Helgi waged war. Svava was still a valkyrie as before.[28]

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[26]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, stanzas 25-29, pp. 109-110.

[27]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 147.

[28]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, p. 110.

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Later, Helgi is fatally wounded, and Svava comes to him before his death. Helgi asks her to marry his brother after he dies.

The Valkyrie in this story plays several roles. A group of nine Valkyries appear to the yet unnamed Helgi. The leader of the band gives Helgi his name and tells him where to find a great sword. This Valkyrie leader was Svava. In this part of the poem, Svava acts almost as a mentor to the young Helgi. She gives him his adult name and starts him on the road to manhood by telling him where to find his sword. Later, we are told that she helped him in battles. Helgi is told by a giantess that twenty-seven Valkyries came to one of his battles, but only one Valkyrie made his ships sail faster. This allowed Helgi and his men to escape unhurt. In this section of the poem, Svava is Helgi's protectress. Helgi then marries Svava. At the end of the poem, Helgi lies dying and asks Svava to marry his brother. Here, Svava is Helgi's human lover and wife. Although the text still calls her a Valkyrie, one of Helgi's men must go to Svava at home and inform her that Helgi is dying. She is not present to protect him. Svava is described as a "shining maiden," she wears a helmet, and rides a horse over land and sea.

In the poem *Helgakviða Hundingsbana in fyrri,* another Helgi, who is apparently the reincarnated Helgi from the prior poem, is born. He is a great warrior. After one of his battles, he meets a troop of Valkyries.

Þá brá lióma af Logafiollom,
enn af þeim liómom leiptrir qvómo;
[sá þar mildingr meyiar ríð a hávar]

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þá var und hiálmom á Himinvanga
Brynior vóro þeira blóði stocnar.
Enn af geirom geislar stóðo.

Frá árliga ór úlfiði
döglingr at því dísir suðrœnar,
ef þær vildi heim með hildingom
þá nótt fara; þrymr var álma.[29]

A great light shone from Logafells
and in its brilliance lightning flashed.
The warriors saw women riding
tall under helmets at Himinvanga;
their shining byrnies were stained with blood,
and from their spears shot gleaming flames.

As soon as he left the lair of wolves
Helgi spoke to the southern maidens:
would they go home with the warriors
that very night? They heard the noise of battle.[30]

The Valkyrie Sigrun, who is apparently Svava reborn, answers that they do not have time to stop and drink with the warriors. Sigrun's father has promised that she should marry Hodbrodd who she insinuates is a weakling. She all but dares Helgi to challenge Hodbrodd for her hand. Helgi then prepares for war and assembles a huge fleet of ships. As the fleet sails to Hodbrodd's stronghold, a storm hits. Sigrun protects the ships and the men from harm.

Enn þeim siálfom Sigrún ofan,
fólcdiorf, um barg oc fari þeira;
snøriz ramliga Rán ór hendi

---

[29]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 132.

[30]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, stanzas 15-16, p. 117.

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giálfrdýr konungs at Gnipalundi.[31]

Sigrun the valkyrie, above them in the sky,
rescues the ships and saved the warriors,
wrenched from Ran's hands the horses of the deep,
and turned their prows toward Gnipagrove.[32]

When the fleet arrives, Helgi challenges Hodbrood to a battle. During the battle the Valkyries help Helgi to victory.

Kómo þar ór himni hiálmvitr ofan
--óx geira gnýr--, þær er grami hlífðo;
þá qvað þat Sigrún --sárvitr flugo,
át hálo scær af Hugins barri--:

"Heill scaltu, vísi, virða nióta,
áttstafr Yngva, oc una lífi,
er þú felt hefir inn flugartrauða
iofur, þann er olli ægis dauða.

Oc þér, buðlungr, samir bæði vel
rauðir baugar oc in ríkia mær;
heill scaltu, buðlungr, bæði nióta
Högna dóttur oc Hringstaða,
sigrs oc landa; þá er sócn lokit."[33]

The warrior maidens who watched over Helgi
swept down from the sky as spears rang louder;
these words spoke Sigrun, the wound-wise valkyrie,
while wolves were feasting on ravens' food:

"Long life to the prince! Be glad and prosper,
a rightful king commanding hosts;
you have felled the flight-hating lord,

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[31]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 134.

[32]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, stanza 30, p. 119.

[33]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, pp. 138-139.

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Hodbrodd, the bane of baneful foes.

"Prince, you shall have a worthy prize:
red-gold rings and a royal maiden.
In health and happiness you shall have
Hogni's daughter and Hringstead too,
triumph and lands; the fight is finished."[34]

In this poem, the Valkyries are portrayed as mounted on horses that can fly over land and sea. They wear helmets and chain mail and carry spears. Sigrun is the catalyst that sends Helgi into battle. At the same time, she and the other Valkyries keep him and his men safe during a storm at sea and during the battle. It seems to be implied that Sigrun and the other Valkyries helped Helgi during the first battle of the poem before Helgi had met Sigrun. When the two meet, the Valkyries are described as having blood-stained chain mail and carrying flashing spears. Here the Valkyries seem to almost fight along side our hero. They participate in the carnage and violence of battle.

In the third Helgi poem, *Helgakviða Hundingsbana önnor*, the same basic story is told as in *Helgakviða Hundingsbana in fyrri.* Helgi meets the Valkyrie Sigrun, who is promised to Hodbrodd. Helgi promises that she will never have to marry Hodbrodd. Helgi prepares for war; then he seeks out Hodbrodd.

> *Helgi samnaði þá miclom scipaher oc fór til Frecasteins, oc fengo í hafi ofviðri mannhætt. Þá qvómo leiptr yfir þá, oc stóðo geislar í*

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[34]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, stanzas 54-56, p. 122.

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scipin. Þeir sá í loptino, at valkyrior nío riðo, oc kendo þeir Sigrúno. Þá lægði storminn, oc qvómo þeir heilir til lanz.[35]

Helgi assembled many warships and sailed to Freka Stone. At sea they were in great danger from a violent gale. Lightening flashed from above, striking the ships. Then they saw nine valkyries riding through the sky; one of them was Sigrun. The storm abated, and the ships came safely to land.[36]

Helgi and his warriors win the battle with Singrun's help. After the battle is over, Sigrun gloats over Hodbrodd's body. She rejoices in the victory. Then, Helgi tells her that he has killed her father and other kinsmen in the fight, and she grieves for her family. Helgi and Sigrun marry and have children. Sigrun's only surviving brother Dag kills Helgi. Dag tells Sigrun of Helgi's death. A grave mound is raised over Helgi, and one day a bondwoman sees Helgi riding toward the barrow with many men. The bondwoman tells Sigrun what she saw. Sigrun visits Helgi in the grave. He and his men, then, ride away never to be seen again.

This poem represents Sigrun more as the mortal lover and wife of Helgi than as a powerful Valkyrie. Her life is dictated by her father, husband, and then her brother. She is portrayed as a powerful being only in the prose passage quoted above where she and other Valkyries appear to control the weather. In this poem, the Valkyries are again portrayed as riding through the sky on horses.

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[35]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 154.

[36]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, prose interlude between stanzas 16 and 17, pp. 127-128.

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Valkyries are portrayed extremely differently in the poem *Darraðarljóð* quoted in chapter 157 of *Brennu-Njáls Saga*. In this poem about the battle of Clontarf, the Valkyries seem to take joy in carnage. One day a man walked by a woman's dwelling, and he peeked in the window. There he saw women weaving on a loom. The loom weights were the heads of men, and men's intestines were used for the weft and warp. While weaving, the women chanted:

Vindum vindum
vef darraðar
þar er vje vaða
vígra manna
látum eigi
líf hans faraz
eigu valkyrjur
vals um kosti.

þeir munu lýðir
löndum ráða
er útskaga
áðr um byggðu
kveð ek ríkum gram
ráðinn dauða
nú er fyrir oddum
jarlmaðr hniginn.

ok munu írar
angr um bíða
þat er aldri mun
ýtum fyrnaz
nú er vefr ofinn
enn völlr roðinn
munu um lönd fara
læspjöll gota.

nú er ógurligt
um at litaz
er dreyrugský
dregr með himni
mun lopt litat
lýða blóði
er sóknvarðar
syngja kunnu.

vel kveðu vjer
um konung ungan
sigrhljóða fjöld
syngjum heilar
enn hinn nemi
er heyrir á
geirfljóða hljóð
ok gumum segi.

ríðum hestum
hart út berum
brugðnum sverðum
á braut hjeðan.[37]

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[37]*Njála*, (Kaupmannahöfn: Hjá Thiele, 1875), pp. 365-366.

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Let us now wind
Where the warrior banners
Let his life
Only the Valkyries

The web of war,
Are forging forward.
Not be taken;
Can choose the slain.

Lands will be ruled
Who once inhabited
We pronounce a great king
Now an earl

By new peoples
Outlying headlands.
Destined to die;
Is felled by spears.

The men of Ireland
That will never grow old
The web is now woven
The news of disaster

Will suffer a grief
In the minds of men.
And the battlefield reddened;
Will spread through lands.

It is horrible now
As a blood-red cloud
The heavens are stained
As the Valkyries

To look around,
Darkens the sky.
With the blood of men,
Sing their song.

We sang well
For the young king;
Let him who listens
Learn it well

Victory songs
Hail our singing!
To our Valkyrie song
And tell it to others.

Let us ride our horses
With swords unsheathed,

Hard on bare backs,
Away from here.[38]

In this poem, the Valkyries are portrayed as goddesses of death. They choose who dies when, and they delight in the carnage of battle. They are weaving the fate of the battle and of men in this poem. The imagery is reminiscent of the Norns who weave the fate of men. The ferocious bloodthirstiness of the Valkyries in this passage is

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[38]*Njals Saga*, trans. Magnus Magnusson and Hermann Pálsson, (New York: Penguin Books, 1960), pp. 349-351. Stanzas 5-10 are quoted.

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repelling and frightening. This portrayal of the Valkyries is in stark contrast to the handmaidens of Óðinn mentioned in *Gylfaginning;* and the beautiful, stately, mounted women represented in the Helgi poems.

The reason for the dichotomy in the portrayal of Valkyries might be a product of the different time depths of the sources. The number of references that connect the Valkyries to death and battle suggest that in pre-literary times, there was a belief in female beings who came to the battle field, selected the warriors to die, and collected the dead. Any beings with this type of power would be portrayed as monstrous and evil since no one wants to die. By the time that our written sources were recorded, the active belief in the Valkyries appears to have died out. They become literary devices, and their image becomes "white washed". The reason for their demotion from goddesses of death to figureheads might be the general acceptance of Christianity in Scandinavia.

In chapter 81 of *Haralds saga Sigurðarsonar* in *Heimskringla,* one of King Harald's men dreamed of a great battle in England before they set out on an expedition.

> *Þórður er maður nefndur er var á skipi því er skammt lá frá skipi konungs. Hann dreymdi um nótt að hann þóttist sjá flota Haralds konungs fara að landi, þóttist vita að það var England. Hann sá á landinu fylking mikla og þótti sem hvorirtveggju byggjust til orustu og höfðu merki mörg á lofti en fyrir liði landsmanna reið tröllkona mikil og sat á vargi og hafði vargurinn mannshræ í munni og féll blóð um kjaftana. En er hann hafði þann etið þá kastaði hún öðrum í munn honum og síðan hverjum að öðrum en hann gleypti hvern. Hún kvað:*

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Skóð lætr skína rauðan
skjöld er dregr að hjaldri.
Brúðr sér Aurnis jóða
óför konungs görva.
Sviptir sveiflannkjafta
svanni holdi manna.
Úlfs munn litar innan
óðlát kona blóði
og óðlát kona blóði.[39]

One night he dreamed that he saw King Harald's fleet sailing towards land, and he knew that this was England. Ashore he could see a great battle array, and both armies then made ready for battle, with a host of banners flying. In the front of the defending army there was a huge ogress riding a wolf, and the wolf was carrying a human carcass in its mouth, with blood streaming down its jaws; and as soon as the wolf had eaten the first corpse, she hurled another into its mouth, and then another and another, and the wolf gulped them all down. The ogress was chanting:

The ogress flaunts her crimson
Shield as battle approaches;
The troll-woman sees clearly
The doom awaiting Harald.
With greedy mouth she rends
The flesh of fallen warriors;
With frenzied hand she stains
The wolf's jaws crimson-
Wolf's jaws red with blood.[40]

This ogress seems to represent the goddess of death. A huge frightening woman rides a wolf. Wolves are strong ferocious beasts that often scavenged the battle field and mauled the dead and almost dead bodies. The ogress is feeding the wolf corpse

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[39]Snorri Sturluson, *Heimskringla*, edited by Kristjánsdóttir, Halldórsson, Torfason, and Thorsson, p. 676.

[40]*King Harald's Saga: King Harald Hardradi of Norway*, trans. Magnus Magnusson and Hermann Palsson, (New York: Penguin Books 1966), p. 140.

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after corpse. These corpses appear to be the dead after the battle. There is blood dripping from the wolf's mouth. This graphic imagery presents a frightening picture of war and death. Although this ogress is never called a Valkyrie, she appears to be choosing which bodies to feed the wolf. This repelling and bloody portrayal of the ogress is comparable to terrifying Valkyries of the poem *Darraðarljóð.* In both passages, the Valkyries and the ogress appear to delight in the carnage and violence of war and death.

There are several different contrasting images of Valkyries in our sources; however, in each portrayal, the Valkyries are either concerned with the welfare or death of the men involved in battle. In the *Gylfaginning,* the Valkyries appear as waitresses in *Valhalla* and as the guarantors that who is fated to die will die. In the Helgi poems, a Valkyrie appears as the protector of an individual hero and as the wife and lover of the same hero. In the poem *Darraðarljóð,* the Valkyries appear as grotesque figures of death and violence. The abundance of images that are present in the sources suggest that belief in Valkyries had waned and that they were mainly literary beings by the time of our sources. The more primitive depictions of bloodthirsty goddesses of death might stem from an earlier tradition that survived in the oral poetry that was passed down through the generations.

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Other Protective Beings

There are three other types of protective beings: the *dísir*, the *fylgja*, and the *hamingja*. Belief in these beings is confused and apparently waning by the time of our sources. Due to their contradictory and confused representation in our sources, not much constructive can be said about these beings within the context of this study.

Dísir. The *dísir* appear to be a group of divine feminine beings without individual names. These beings are almost always referred to in the plural as the *dísir*. The singular *dís* is rarely used although Freyja is called the *Vanadís* and Skaði is called the *öndurdís*. In these two instances, the word apparently means goddess.[41] The only other reference to one *dís* is in chapter 29 of *Ynglinga Saga* in *Heimskringla*.

> *Aðils konungur var að dísablóti og reið hesti um dísarsalinn. Hesturinn drap fótum undir honum og féll og konungur af fram og kom höfuð hans á stein svo að hausinn brotnaði en heilinn lá á steininum. Það var hans bani. Hann dó að Uppsölum og er þar heygður.*[42]
>
> One time King Aðils attended the sacrifice to the dísar and rode his horse about the hall of the goddess. The horse stumbled and fell, and the king was thrown. His head struck a rock so that his skull broke,

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[41]Jan de Vries, *Altnordisches Etymologisches Wörterbuch*, p. 77.

[42]Snorri Sturluson, *Heimskringla*, edited by Kristjánsdóttir, Halldórsson, Torfason, and Thorsson, p. 33.

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> and his brain spilled on the rock and he died. This happened at Uppsala, and a burial mound was thrown up for him.[43]

It is impossible to associate this *dís* with any named goddess. She could be Freyja, Skaði, one *dís* representing all of the *dísir*, or a local unnamed goddess. The exact personage will always remain open to speculation. The important point of the passage is that a king died in the sanctuary of the *dís*. While the incident is clinically reported in our source, this accident sounds almost like a sacrifice. The death of a king in the sanctuary of a goddess is too coincidental to be an accident. One interpretation of this passage would be that the king was offered to the *dís* as a sacrifice.

There is evidence of a *dísablót* (sacrifice to the *dísir*) and a *dísaþing* (assembly of the *dísir*). In the introduction of *Hervar's Saga*, Starkaðr Áluðrengr kidnapped a king's daughter while she was reddening the *hörgr* with sacrificial blood at the *dísablót*.[44] In chapter 44 of *Egils Saga*, King Eirik and Queen Gunnhild travel to Atley Island for the *dísablót*.[45] From the sequence of events in the saga, this *dísablót* apparently took place in the autumn. In chapter 6 of *Víga Glúms Saga*, the

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[43]Snorri Sturluson, *Heimskringla*, trans. Lee M. Hollander, p. 33.

[44]Jan de Vries, *Altgermanische Religionsgeschichte* §528.

[45]*Egils Saga*, trans. Hermann Pálsson and Paul Edwards, (New York: Penguin Books, 1976), p. 100.

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dísablót took place at Vigfuss between mid-October and the beginning of winter.[46] The *dísablót* appears to have consisted of a blood sacrifice and involved feasting and a great deal of drinking.

The word *dísaþing* means the assembly of the *dísir*. In Iceland, assemblies were held four times a year. At assembly, legal cases were tried, goods were sold, young people met with the opposite sex, and family and friends came together. In Sweden, the *dísaþing* was held in February. Into the sixteenth century, a *distinget* and *distingsmarknad* were held in February at Candlemass.[47]

The sacrifice to the *dísir* apparently took place at late autumn or the beginning of winter while the assembly of the *dísir* took place in February toward the end of winter. These two occasions bracket winter. Winter is the harshest season especially in the North. There is little sunlight, it is extremely cold, and the family had to live on food stored up from the fall harvest. The short days, long dark nights, the cold, and the dwindling supplies would all be cause for great anxiety in the population. The timing of the *dísablót* and the *dísaþing* suggest that the *dísir* are deities connected to the renewal of light, warmth, and vegetation.

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[46]In her book *The Road to Hel: A Study of the Conception of the Dead in Old Norse Literature*, Hilda Ellis Davidson states that this *dísablót* took place at the beginning of winter (page 136) and Jan de Vries in his book *Altgermanische Religionsgeschichte* states that this *dísablót* took place in mid-October (§528).

[47]Lotte Motz, *The Beauty and the Hag*, pp. 70-71.

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There are many place names in Norway and Sweden that reflect the antiquity of the cult and worship of the *dísir*. In Norway, there are several places called Disin and Dísavin. In Sweden, there is a Diseberg, Disevid, and a Disdsen.[48] These place names seem to be very ancient and speak for the antiquity of the cult of the *dísir*.

There is evidence that the *dīsir* might be connected to the ground and earth. According to a nineteenth century Icelandic clergyman, certain stones and rocks in Northwestern Iceland were called *Landdísasteinar* or Stones of the Land *dísir*. These stones were left undisturbed. Children were forbidden to play on or around them and farmers did not mow around them.[49] In Norway, certain stone piles are called *Disahrøys* or Stone pile of the *Dísir*.[50] This connection between the *dísir* and stones seems to indicate that the *dísir* lived within the earth or in stones, were easily frightened, and might retaliate against humans when they felt threatened or not respected.

The *dísir* also seem to have functioned as protectresses of certain men. In chapter 8 of *Ásmundar Saga Kappabana*, Ásmundr has a dream before a big battle.

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[48]Jan de Vries, *Altgermanische Religionsgeschichte* §528. Disin is attested at least five times. Dísavin is attested in Aker, Nes, South Odalen, Vang, and Modum. Diseberg and Disevid are attested in East Gotland, and Disdsen is attested in Bohuslän.

[49]G. Turville-Petre, "A Note on the *Landdísir*" *Early English and Norse Studies: Presented to Hugh Smith in Honour of his Sixieth Birthday*, ed. Arthur Brown and Peter Foote (Methuen & Co: London, 1963), pp. 196-201.

[50]ibid.

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He dreams that armed women come to him to assure him that they will help him in the battle the following day. They state that they are *spádísir* or prophesy *dísir*. In chapter 15 of *Hálfs Saga*, Utsteinn brags that his *dísir* will help him in the upcoming battle. His opponent responds that Hálf's *dísir* are dead, and that his *dísir* vanquished Hálf's *dísir* in his dream. In chapter 22 of *Þorsteins Saga Víkingssonar*, Sindri the dwarf promises Þorsteinn that Sindri's *dísir* will protect Þorsteinn on his journey.

In these passages, the *dísir* seem to have a protective function. In the first two instances, the portrayals of the *dísir* are very similar to the portrayal of Valkyries in the later sources. Both Valkyries and *dísir* are depicted as armed women who protect men in battle. The *dísir* seem somehow to be attached to individual men in each passage mentioned; however, they appear to be transferable from one person to another.

The *dísir* appear to have some function in connection with death. There are three slightly different versions of the story of Þiðrandi's death. The story is told in chapter 23 of *Þiðrandi Þáttr ok Þórhalls*, the *Flateyjarbók* version of *Óláf Saga Tryggvasonar*, and in chapter 46 of *Njals Saga*. Þiðrandi is the son of Hallr, who is one of the first men in Iceland to become a Christian. Þiðrandi is not a Christian. There is a feast at the house of Hall, and several people have gathered. Þorhall the *spámaðr* was there, and he felt that something terrible was going to happen. It was

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the feast of the winter nights, and an ox was slaughtered. Þorhall warned everyone not to go outside that night.

When everyone was asleep, there was a knock on the door. Þiðrandi opened the door and heard the sound of galloping horses. To the north, he saw nine armed women. They were clad in black and riding towards him with their swords drawn. To the south, he saw nine armed women clad in white. When the women in black reached him, they attacked him. He tried to fight them off, but he was fatally wounded. Þorhall the *spámaðr* interpreted these events to mean that the women were the attendant spirits of Þiðrandi's family. The black *dísir* represented the old religion and the white *dísir* the new religion. When the black *dísir* learned that there would soon be a change in religion, they took Þiðrandi as their compensation. This story presents the *dísir* as hostile beings who will attack when threatened. The attendant spirits of his family kill Þiðrandi when they feel that the new religion is taking over. His death is a kind of last sacrifice to them.

In chapter 7 of *Hervarar Saga*, the wife of King Harald kills herself in the hall of the *dísir* after her husband is killed in a battle. This passage is reminiscent of King Aðil's apparently accidental death in the sanctuary of the *dís*. The wife of King Harald appears to commit suttee, ritual suicide, after the death of her husband in the hall of the *dísir*. The Queen seems to offer herself as a sacrifice to the *dísir*.

In the poem *Atlamál in groenlenzco*, Glaumvor, the wife of Gunnar, tells her husband about her dream before he leaves on a journey.

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"Á hugða ec hér inn renna at endilöngo húsi,
þyti af þiósti, þeystiz uf becci;
bryti fœtr yera brœðra hér tveggia,
gerðit vatn vœgia; vera mun þat fyr necqvi.

Konor hugðac dauðar koma í nótt hingat,
vœrit vart búnar, vildi þic kiósa,
byði þér brálliga til beccia sinna;
ec qveð aflima orðnar þér dísir."[51]

Glaumvor said:
"I saw a river running through the hall.
It roared in anger, rushed between the benches.
and both you brothers had your legs broken;
nothing stopped the waters-- that must mean something.

"I saw dead women here in the darkness;
dressed in fine clothing; they came to summon you,
bade you hasten to their halls' benches.
I think the dísir have gone from you forever."[52]

In this passage, the *dísir* are dead. This might make them female ancestors of the person or family that they protect. If the *dísir* are ancestresses of a person or family; this would explain their plurality, their attachment and protection of certain individuals, and their connection to certain piles of stones which might be ancient grave markers.

In the sources, the *dísir* have a multiplicity of functions. They act as protectors, seem to have a connection with the earth and the vegetation cycle, and have connections with death or the dead. The *dísir* represent the female ancestors of

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[51]*Edda: Die Lieder des Codex Regius*, p. 251.

[52]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, stanzas 25-26, p. 218.

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a person, family or settlement. This would explain the namelessness of the deities and their plurality. Their connection to individual and families[53] would explain the absence of a national cult. Every person, every family, and perhaps every settlement had their own *dísir*. The *dísablót* would have been a private sacrifice to the particular *dísir* who have a relationship with you and your family.

This ancestor cult provided protection for family members and demanded offerings in the late autumn and winter, which traditionally has been the time that the dead walk the earth and interfere with the lives of mortals.[54] The fertility aspect of the cult is probably simply a by-product of the protection aspect. What better way to protect a family than to insure the fertility of the family's fields and livestock.

Fylgja. In the sagas, *fylgjas* take two forms: animal or human female. When the *fylgja* takes animal form, the form is associated with the character or standing of the person with whom it is associated. *Fylgjas* can be bears, wolves, goats, cattle, oxen, horses, or birds. In several stories, the *fylgja* of a man is portrayed as a woman who seems to be protective of him.

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[53]See chapter 8 of *Ásmundar Saga Kappabana*, chapter 15 of *Hálfs Saga*, chapter 22 of *Þorsteins Saga Víkingssonar*, chapter 23 of *Þiðrandi Þáttr Þórhalls*, and chapter 46 of *Njals Saga*.

[54]Mircea Eliade, *Patterns in Comparative Religion*, trans. Rosemary Sheed (Sheed & Ward: New York, New York 1958), pp. 349-354.

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In the Eddic poem *Helgaqviða Hjörvarðzsonar*,[55] Helgi's brother Heðinn travels through the woods on Yule Eve. In the woods, he meets a troll-woman riding a wolf with snakes for reins. She offers to stay with Heðinn, but he declines. She threatens that he will pay for this when he drinks from the sacred cup. That evening when everyone makes vows and drinks from the sacred cup, Heðinn vows that he will have Svava, Helgi's wife. Heðinn is appalled by his vow, and he goes to Helgi and tells him what happened. Helgi interprets the events for Heðinn. Helgi says that Heðinn has seen Helgi's *fylgja*. This means that Helgi will die soon and that on his death, Heðinn should marry Helgi's wife.

In chapter 11 of *Hallfreðar Saga*, Hallfreðr becomes fatally ill while at sea. Before he dies, a woman clad in chain mail appears walking on the water behind the ship. Hallfreðr recognizes his *fylgjukona*, and he tells her that their relationship is at an end. The woman asks Hallfreðr's brother if he will receive her, and he says no. She then asks Hallfreðr's son who receives her, and she disappears.

In *Draumr Þorsteins Síðu-Hallssonar*, Þorsteinn is visited by three women in a dream. These women warn him that his thrall is plotting his death. These women come to him three times. The third time, they ask him where they should go after his death. He tells them to go to his son. The women say that they will not be with his son long and then prophesy his son's death.[56] In chapter 36 of *Vatnsdœla Saga*,

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[55]*Poems of the Elder Edda*, trans. Patricia Terry, pp. 110-112.

[56]Hilda Ellis, *The Road to Hel*, p. 131.

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another Þorsteinn is warned in a dream that a sorceress is plotting his death at a gathering. In his dream, a woman "who had attended him and his family" (*er fylgt hafði þeim frændum*)[57] issued the warning. After this woman touched his eyes, Þorsteinn became ill and missed the gathering. In chapter 4 of *Völsunga Saga*, Signý's *kynfylgja* warns her against her forthcoming marriage.

The *fylgja* is usually invisible but appears immediately before death or as a warning of impending death, danger, or disaster. In each instance, the *fylgja* either signals the coming death of her associate or warns her associate of danger. The *fylgja* does not appear to die with her associate. The *fylgja* can be passed on to another on one's death but seems to remain within the same family. In *Hallfreðar Saga*, the *fylgja* attempts to join with her associate's brother and then his son. In *Draumr Þorsteins Síðu-Hallssonar*, the women go to their associate's son. In *Vatnsdœla Saga*, the woman is associated with Þorsteinn's family. In *Völsunga Saga*, the being is called a *kynfylgja*, a "kin *fylgja*." These examples show that *fylgjas* appear to belong to a single family. There does not seem to be any cult associated with the fylgja, and there are no place names associated with them.

The word *fylgja* seems to be related to the Old Icelandic verb *fylgja* which means "to follow" or "to accompany and to the Old Icelandic noun *fylgja* which means "afterbirth." Turville-Petre believes that this would connect the *fylgja* to the soul since in some cultures the afterbirth was considered the unborn twin of the

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[57]ibid., p. 131.

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child.[58] This is a very interesting argument; however, I think that it is more likely that noun *flygja* meaning "afterbirth" is related to the verb *fylgja* meaning "to follow". The basic meaning of the noun would then be "the following", which is what the afterbirth does: follow the birth of the child. Since the *fylgja* follows a person around and protects that person, the noun *fylgja* also is derived from the verb "to follow". Both nouns are actually the same noun used in different contexts.

Fylgjas can take animal or human female form. They appear to follow a person throughout life, but a person can only see them in times of danger or imminent death. They appear in dreams to forewarn a person about possible danger. They do not die with the person with whom they are associated, but enter into a relationship with another person of the same family.

Hamingja. The *hamingja* appears to be invisible and without form. Only in *Víga-Glúms Saga* does the *hamingja* take a female form. In *Víga-Glúms Saga*, Glúmr sees a huge woman in a dream. She comes toward him and he invites her into his house. Glúmr interprets this dream to mean that his grandfather has died. This woman is his grandfather's *hamingja* who is now going to live with him. In all of the other instances when the *hamingja* is mentioned, the *hamingja* seems to be the word encompassing someone's luck or lucklessness. The passage from *Víga-Glúms Saga*, seems to confuse the *hamingja* with the *fylgja*.

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[58]E.O.G. Turville-Petre, *Myth and Religion of the North*, p. 228.

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Summary

There are many problems involved in the study of the Norns, Valkyries, *Dísir*, *Fylgja*, and *Hamingja*. The functions of these beings overlap, and there is not a clear-cut division between these beings. Each being is associated with the individual. The Norns come to a person at birth and set the fate and death of that person. The Valkyries, in some sources, become the mentor, lover, and wife of a hero. The *dísir*, *fylgjas*, and *hamingjas* appear to be associated with one person throughout his or her adult life. Each of these beings contributes to the continued well being of the individual. The Valkyries and *dísir* actively protect their associate while the *fylgja* warns of danger and possible death. The *dísir*, *fylgjas*, and *hamingjas* can apparently be handed down from one family member to another at death. The Norns foretell the death of a person at birth and are blamed for the bad things that happen. The Valkyries actively choose who dies in battle. The *dísir* can kill people, demand sacrifice, and are considered dead themselves. The *fylgja* warns her associate of death and leaves her associate before death. The hamingja also leaves her associate at death to form a relationship with another. In Table 5, I have listed each type of being along with the functions which that being performs in the sources to graphically show how closely related the functions of all of these beings are.

The relationships between these beings are confusing and blurred in the sources; however, it is clear that most of these beings have some connection with

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TABLE 5

THE FUNCTIONS OF NORSE FEMALE PROTECTIVE BEINGS

	Norns	**Valkyries**	**Dísir**	**Fylgja**	**Hamingja**
Associated with the Individual	X	X	X	X	X
Remains in the family		X	X	X	X
Protection		X	X	X	
Associated with Death	X	X	X	X	
Armed		X	X		
Nameless			X	X	X

Source: Primary

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protection and death. The multipicity of female beings involved in protection and death in Norse religion might be due to the individuality of this belief. If each family or village had its own female beings acting as protectors and associated with death, the names and functions of these beings would be different in different parts areas.

There appears to have been a continual belief in a female being or beings who protected an individual throughout life and who had the power to decide the time of death. The female being who protected the life of the individual was probably considered to have a familial relationship with the individual whom she protected. She might be an ancestress of the individual or might have been bequeathed to an individual at the death of a family member. A female being of some kind also seems to be in charge of death. In the preceding chapters, I mentioned that Freyja, Gefjon, Hel, and Ran all received a portion of the dead. Since the Norns, Valkyries, *dísir*, and fylgjas also have connections with death, it appears evident that the world of the dead and the decision of who should die was believed to be in the hands of the goddesses and female semi-divine beings.

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VI. *MATRONAE*

The *matronae* are images of female deities. They are called *matronae* because this is the name they are usually given in the Latin inscriptions that accompany the images. These images appear in the form of reliefs on monuments and altars dedicated to the *matronae*. These monuments were primarily made out of bronze, stone, or terracotta. While the *matronae* monuments can be found in all parts of Roman occupied Europe, the Rhine valley has the highest concentration of *matronae* monuments. The monuments have been dated from approximately 50 C.E. to 250 C.E. The monuments in the south usually appeared at an earlier date than the monuments in the north.

The word *matrona* is a Latin noun meaning "a married woman, a noble lady." The reliefs are of women usually either alone or in triads although there are some instances where there are pairs or a group of four or more women. The most common presentation is with three women either sitting or standing together in a row. The two women on the edges are usually wearing distinctive headgear indicating that they are married while the middle woman has the loose hairstyle of a maiden.

Many of the monuments have dedications. The dedications span most of the levels of Roman society. Both men and women are mentioned as dedicators. The

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economic status of the dedicators includes those in the lower, middle, noble, and senatorial classes. Many of the dedications are by men in the military.

When the name of the *matronae* is given in the dedication, the root of the name can be traced to either Proto-Celtic or Proto-Germanic. The Northwestern-continental corner of the Roman Empire was inhabited by both Germanic and Celtic tribes. Germans and Celts from the frontiers made up a large part of the Roman legions during the early Empire, and they appear to have spread the *matronae* cult throughout the outposts of the Empire.

The *matronae* monuments appear to be a Roman expression of the native Northwest European, localized goddess cults. Whether these goddesses were primarily Celtic and were later adopted by the Germanic peoples, were primarily Germanic and were later adopted by the Celtic peoples, or were simply a Northwest European phenomenon which transcended linguistic boundaries is debatable. There are no *matronae* monuments outside the boundaries of the Roman Empire. There are *matronae* monuments on the left side of the Rhine, but there are few on the right. This does not mean that the same fundamental beliefs did not exist in the Germanic areas outside the boundaries of the Empire. The absence of *matronae* monuments in non-Roman Germanic areas only indicates that the Roman tradition of personifying deities in human form is either unknown, or the technology needed to create these monuments is unknown in these non-Roman areas.

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Rhine Area

There are at least 825 *matronae* dedications in the Ubii Area.[1] The Ubii were a Germanic tribe which protected the Roman border on the Rhine. They lived in the area between the Sieg River and the Main River; therefore, they would today live approximately between Cologne and Frankfurt. The capital of the Ubii Area was *Oppidum Ubiorum* which is known today as Cologne. The dedications in this area are dated from between 166 - 235 C.E.[2] See Map 3 for the distribution of *matronae* monuments mentioned in this chapter.

In the Ubii Area, usually three female figures are grouped together in a trinity. The women are usually sitting on a bench. The two flanking women usually wear caps, and the figure in the middle has the shoulder-length hair of an unmarried girl.[3] The appearance of the female figures is very un-Roman. The clothing worn by the female figures is apparently the native dress of the area. These figures are dressed in ankle-length, belted garments which are worn over a petticoat with a cloak and a mantle. The mantle touched the ground in the back and draped across

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[1]Heinz Günter Horn, "Bilddenkmäler des Matronenkultes im Ubiergebiet," *Matronen und verwandte Gottheiten: Ergebnisse eines Kolloquiums veranstaltet von der Göttinger Akademiekommission für die Altertumskunde Mittel- und Nordeuropas* (Cologne: Rheinland-Verlag GMBH, 1987), p. 34.

[2]Christopher B. Rüger, "Beobachtungen zu den epigraphischen Belegen der Muttergottheiten in den lateinischen Provinzen des Imperium Romanum," *Matronen und verwandte Gottheiten*, p. 22.

[3]Heinz Günter Horn, p. 36.

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MAP 3

GEOGRAPHIC DISTRIBUTION OF MENTIONED *MATRONAE* MONUMENTS



▲ = 40 or more monuments
■ = 15 - 20 monuments
▬ = 10 - 14 monuments
+ = 5 - 9 monuments
• = 1 - 4 monuments

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the figures' chest. Ninety-five percent of these figures wear a necklace.[4] Necklaces on female figures often indicate divine status.

Iconography

The iconography associated with the *matronae* in the Ubii Area is mainly agriculturally oriented. These female figures often hold in their hands baskets with fruit and nuts such as apples, pears, quince, and walnuts. Sometimes these female figures hold bundles of wheat, bunches of grapes, bouquets of flowers, or loaves of bread. The sides of the stones are almost always decorated with ornamental vegetation and birds including peacocks and cranes. Animals are also sometimes portrayed. The most common animal is the dog, but other animals also occasionally appear. The attributes of the deities seem to indicate that they represented the powers of protection, fertility, and prosperity.[5]

Linguistics

Many of the dedication names on the stones from the Ubii Area can be traced to Proto-Germanic roots. The names that end in the dative plural *-ms* or *-mis* and with the suffixes *-nehiae*, *-neihiae*, or *-henae* are usually Germanic in origin.[6] The

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[4]ibid., pp. 36, 45-46.

[5]ibid., pp. 45-46.

[6]Jan de Vries, *Altgermanische Religionsgeschichte*, v.2, §523.

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names of these deities have been interpreted in several ways. Some appear to be the names of tribes or rivers. Others appear to be named for their powers or function.[7]

Tribal Names. Some of the goddesses to whom the stones are dedicated are obviously names of Germanic tribes that are mentioned in Tacitus or Ptolemy. There are stones dedicated to *Matres Frisiavae paternae, Matres paternae Hiannanef, Matres Suebae, Matres Treverae, Matres Vangiones, Matribus Suebis Sidinis*, and *Matres Hamavehae.*[8] The stone dedicated to *Matres Frisiavae paternae* can be translated as the "Mothers of the ancestors of the Frisians." The Frisians were a Germanic tribe on the coast of modern Holland. *Matres paternae Hiannanef* is most likely translated as "the Mothers of the ancestors of the Kannanefates." The Kannanfates were a Germanic tribe living on the coast west of the Frisians. *Matres*

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[7]For an alternative interpretation, see the work of Theo Vennemann especially "Linguistic Reconstruction in the Context of European Prehistory," *Transactions of the Philological Society* 92 (1994) : 215-284; "Die indoeuropäischen Orts-und Matronennamen mit f, þ, h und die Spätindogermanisch," *Akten der IX. Fachtagung der Indogermanischen Geschellschaften 5. bis 9 Oktober 1992 in Zürich*, (Wiesbaden: Ludwig Reichert, 1994), pp. 403-426; and "Dativing the Divison between High and Low Germanic: A Summary of Arguments," *Language Change and Language Structure: Older Germanic Languages in a Comparative Perspective* (=Trends in Linguistics, Studies and Monographs, v. 73), Berlin: Mouton de Gruyter, 1994, pp. 271-303. For a refutation of Vennemann's theories, see Christopher M. Stevens, *On the Bifurcation and Repression Theories of Germanic and German.* In: Journal of Indo-European Studies Monograph Series 29, (Washington, D.C.: Institute of Man, 1998.)

[8]de Vries, *Religionsgeschichte*, §523; Siegfried Gutenbrunner, *Die germanischen Götternamen der antiken Inschriften.* (Saale: Niemeyer, 1936) [= Rheinische Beiträge und Hülfsbücher zur germanischen Philologie und Volkskunde, 24.], pp. 177-178.

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Suebae is certainly "the Mothers of the Swabians," who are mentioned numerous times by Tacitus. The *Matres Treverae* are obviously "the Mothers of the Treveri," a Germanic tribe located in Tacitus's time on the Mosel River. *Matres Vangiones* were "the Mothers of the Vangiones." The Vangiones were a Germanic tribe, which was located on the lower Rhine. The dedication *Matribus Suebis Sidinis* is probably best translated as "to the Swabian Sidinae Mothers". The Sidones or Seidines were a Germanic tribe mentioned in Ptolemy's *Geography.* This tribe was located on the lower Oder River. The *Matres Hamavehae* are probably "the Mothers of the Chamavi." The Chamavi were a Germanic tribe who lived near the Ems River.[9]

It is worth noting that instead of being called *matronae*, the goddesses named for tribes are called *matres* which is Latin for "mothers." I agree with de Vries that these goddesses where probably considered to be Mother Goddesses and that they were fundamentally different from the more common *matronae.*[10] The adjective *paternae* in some of the dedications supports this supposition. *Paternae* is the vocative plural form of the Latin adjective meaning "O ancestors." The *matres* must have been considered ancestresses of the tribe and protectors of the tribe's welfare.

Rivers. Several of the goddess names in the *matronae* dedications appear to be derived from river names. The name *Albiahenae* seems to be related to the name

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[9]de Vries, *Religionsgeschichte,* §523; and Günter Neuman, "Die germanischen Matronen-Beinamen," *Matronen und verwandte Gottheiten,* pp. 111, 117-118.

[10]de Vries, *Religionsgeschichte,* §523.

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of the Elbe River.[11] Germanic *a* becomes *e* in Old High German due to primary umlaut, and the *e* remains an *e* into New High German. The *l* and *b* of Germanic remain *l* and *b* into New High German. The *-ahenae* is suffix found on many of the Matronae stones.

The goddess name *Renahenae* appears to be related to the river Rhine.[12] In Old High German, the Rhine is spelled *rīn*. The *r* remains the same from Germanic to New High German. The *e* in the Latin inscription and the *ī* in Old High German can be explained by Celtic pronunciation of Latin *ē*.[13] Old High German *ī* eventually becomes New High German *ei* as in Modern German *Rhein*. The *n* in Germanic remains an *n* into New High German.

The goddess name *Nersihenae* appears to be related to the river Niers, which is a tributary of the Maas River.[14] The Old High German form of this river is *Nersa*.[15] The goddess name *Aumenahenae* is related to the river name *Aumenau*.[16]

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[11]de Vries, *Religionsgeschichte*, §523; Neuman, p. 110; and Gutenbrunner, pp. 189-190.

[12]de Vries, *Religionsgeschichte*, §523; and Neuman, p. 110.

[13]Wilhelm Braune, *Althochdeutsche Grammatik*, ed. Hans Eggers (Tübingen: Max Niemeyer Verlag, 1975), §37, Note 2.

[14]de Vries, *Religionsgeschichte*, §523; Neuman, pp. 110-111; and Gutenbrunner, pp. 164-165.

[15]de Vries, *Religionsgeschichte*, §523 and Gutenbrunner, pp. 178-180.

[16]Neuman, p. 110 and Gutenbrunner, p. 129.

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The *Aumenau* river is in the Naussau area. In Old High German, the name was spelled *Oumena.*[17] Germanic *au* becomes *ou* in Old High German and becomes *au* in New High German. The *men* syllable remains the same throughout Germanic to New High German.

Rivers contained water to drink and to nourish people, stock animals, and plants. Rivers provided fish and shellfish to eat. Rivers also acted as natural borders and were the most reliable form of transportation and commerce. Almost every major city in the Roman Empire was on the coast of a sea or lake or was on the banks of a river. Rivers were extremely important politically, economically, and nutritionally. The *matronae* who personified the river probably were considered to live in the river or on its banks. The *matronae* of a river probably were worshipped and offerings were made to them, so they would maintain and continue this source of food, protection, and commerce.

Prosperity. Many of the *matronae* appear to be named for what they do or for their powers. Several of the *matronae* contain the root *gabi-*: *Gabiae, Alagabiae,* and *Garmangabis.* All of these names probably derive from a feminine *-jo* stem built on the Proto-Germanic root **gab-* meaning "give." The suffixed root would then be **gabia-* meaning "female givers." The *matronae* name *Gabiae* would simply be translated as "Female Givers." *Alagabiae* would translate as "Female Givers of Everything" since the prefix *Ala-* is related to the Modern German indefinite

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[17]Neuman, p. 110 and Gutenbrunner p. 192.

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pronoun *alle* meaning "all, everything." *Garmangabis* probably means "the German Givers."[18] These goddesses were probably considered deities of prosperity and fertility. Their names are reminiscent of the Norse goddess Gefjun and Freyja's alias Gefn, both of which mean "the Giver." The functions of these two Norse goddesses and these *matronae* were probably very similar. Both Gefjun and Freyja were considered goddesses of prosperity, who dispensed the good things in life to their worshipers.

Neumann suggests that the name of the *matronae Gavadie* is probably related to the Gothic noun *wadi* meaning "pledge, wager," the Gothic verb *gawadjon* meaning "to get engaged," and the Old Norse noun *veð* meaning "entrusted goods." He hypothesizes that this would mean that the *matronae* entrusted to humans something which belongs to them, perhaps a field.[19] I suggest that instead of the *matronae* entrusting humans with something that the *matronae* are the entrusted ones. The name *Gavadie* would then be translated as "the entrusted ones." The *matronae* are the ones entrusted with the welfare of humans.

Neumann presents two different etymologies for the name of the *matronae Fachinehae* or *Fahineihae*. He first derives the name from the Indo-European root **pak-* meaning "fastener, catch." The Proto-Germanic root would have been **faχ-*.

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[18]de Vries, *Religionsgeschichte,* §524; Neuman, p. 111; Gutenbrunner, p. 90-92.

[19]Neumann, p. 119 and Gutenbrunner, pp. 158-159.

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This would give the name the meaning of "the fasteners, the holders." The other etymology that he presents is related to the Gothic noun *faheþs* meaning "joy," the Gothic verb *faginon* meaning "to be glad, to rejoice," the Old Saxon verb *fahjan* meaning "to satisfy," and the Old English verb *fægen* meaning "to bring joy". This would give the name the meaning of "the joyful ones."[20]

Horn believes that the name of the *matronae Lubicae* comes from the Proto-Germanic root **lubja-* meaning "medicine, remedy, cure" and is related to the Old High German noun *luppi* meaning "poison, magic."[21] If this is the root of the name, then the name means something like "the healing ones". I am not certain that this is the correct root. I think that this name might just as easily be derived from the Indo-European root **lbh-* meaning "to care, desire, love." The Proto-Germanic would have been **lubō-*[22] and related to the Old English noun *lufu* meaning "love" and the Old High German verb *liuben* meaning "to make love." This would give the name the meaning of "the loved ones" or "the loving ones."

The name of the *matronae Afliae* appears to mean the "the strong ones" or "the powerful ones." The name seems to be related to the Old Norse noun *afl* and the Old English noun *afol*. Both nouns mean "might, power." De Vries suggests that

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[20]Neumann, p. 118 and Gutenbrunner, p. 187.

[21]Isabella Horn, "Diskussionsbemerkung zu Ikonographie und Namen der Matronen," *Matronen und verwandte Gottheiten*, p. 156.

[22]Indo-European -bh- to Proto-Germanic -b- is a regular correspondence. See Oswald Szemerényi, *Introduction to Indo-European Linguistics*, p. 57.

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the name could mean "the strengthening ones," which is also possible.[23]

Death. There is some disagreement on the meaning of the name of the *matronae Arvagastae*. De Vries presents the meaning "charitable giving," Horn presents the meaning "the hospitable ones," and Neumann presents the meaning "the generous entertaining."[24] The meaning of the root *gast-* is almost certainly from the Indo-European word **ghos-tí* meaning "stranger, guest, host" and has something to do with the reciprocal hospitable relationship between host and guest. All of the interpretations of the name reflect the meaning of this word although none mention the meaning of the prefix *arva-*.

The most reasonable explanation seems to be that it is related to the Old Norse noun *erfi*, which is sometimes spelled *ærue*, meaning "funeral feast" or the Old Norse verb *erfa* meaning "to commemorate with a funeral feast." Proto Germanic *a* becomes Common Scandinavian *e* with i umlaut. In Common Scandinavian a medial *f* was often written for the bilabial [β]. The name would then mean something like "the hospitable ones at a funeral feast." This might suggest that the function of the *matronae Arvagastae* was connected with funerals and death instead of purely with hospitality.

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[23]de Vries, *Religionsgeschichte*, §525 and Gutenbrunner, p. 162.

[24]de Vries, *Religionsgeschite*, § 525; Isabella Horn, p. 156; Neumann, p. 111; and Gutenbrunner, p. 165.

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The name of the *matronae Audrinehae* can be found with the variations of *Authrinehae* and *Autriahenae*. De Vries translates the name as "the divine help bestowing,"[25] and Horn translates the name as "fate weavers."[26] I agree with Horn that the name must be related to the Old Norse noun *auðr* meaning "fate, death" since the correspondence between *Authr-inehae* and *auðr* is exact. Horn goes a step further in her interpretation than I would. She mentions that the Indo-European root would be **audh-* or **awedh-* meaning "fabric, weave." She then takes the meaning of the Indo-European root and the Old Norse noun and puts the meaning together as "fate weavers." This would connect the matronae Authrinehae with the Norns and the Valkyries who are both represented as weavers of fate in our sources.[27] While Horn's interpretation fits culturally, there is no reason to believe that both the Indo-European and Norse meanings of the word would be valid in Proto-Germanic times. I would prefer to either interpret this name as "the weavers" from the Indo-European meaning or as "the dead ones" from the Old Norse noun.

Magic. De Vries suggests that the name of the *matronae Mahlinehae* means "the court place" from the Old High German noun *mahal* meaning "court."[28] I am not certain that this is the correct root. It seems equally probable to me that the root

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[25]de Vries, *Religionsgeschichte*, §524 and Gutenbrunner, pp. 185-186.

[26]Isabella Horn, p. 156.

[27]See Chapter 4.

[28]de Vries, *Religionsgeschichte*, § 525 and Gutenbrunner, pp. 182-183.

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is related to the Old Saxon verb *mahlian*, the Gothic verb *maþljan*, and the Old English verb *maðelian*, *mæðlian*, or *mælan*; which all mean "to speak." The name would then mean something like "the speaking ones." These *matronae* might have been thought of as oracles.

Horn suggests that the *matronae Saitchamiae*'s name might mean "the enchanting or magical disguised ones."[29] The root *sait-* is probably related to the Old Norse noun *seiðr* meaning "magic" especially female magic dealing with prophesy.[30] Proto-Germanic *ai* becomes *ei* in Common Scandinavian. The second root in the name is *ham-*, and it appears to be related to the Old Norse noun *hamr* meaning 'cover, skin, figure', the Old English noun *ham* meaning "shirt," and the Middle High German noun *ham* meaning "cover, skin, net." I suggest that the name means something like "the ones with the magical skin." This name would be connected to the stories of Freyja, the Valkyries, and other folkloric figures who have what is called a magical skin, shirt, or shift. When they wear this outfit, they are able to fly and are often transformed into the shape of a bird usually a swan but sometimes a falcon.[31]

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[29]Isabella Horn, p. 156 and Gutenbrunner, pp. 163-164.

[30]See chapter 3 for a discussion of *seiðr*.

[31]See chapter 3 for a discussion of these beings.

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Aufaniae

The *matronae Aufaniae* appear to have had the widest sphere of influence. Altars to the *Aufaniae* have been found in Bonn, Nettersheim, Cologne, Zülpich, Xanten, Jülich, Mainz, Nimwegen, Lyon, and Carmona. The dedications were made between 166 - 235 C.E. by centurion, equestrian, and senatorial families.[32] The *matronae Aufaniae* almost always appear in a triad dressed in the usual Ubii Area manner. The name *Aufaniae* appears to be derived from the Proto-Germanic root **fanja-* meaning "swamp, fen, marsh." The name would be related to the Gothic noun *fani*, Old High German *fenna, fenni*, and Old Saxon *fenni* all meaning "swamp, fen."[33] Neumann suggests that the *au-* prefix is related to the adjective Proto-Germanic **auþja-* meaning "far off, remote isolated," and the New High German adjective *öde* meaning "deserted, bleak" is derived from the Proto-Germanic **auþja-*.[34] The meaning of the name *Aufaniae* would then be "the ones of the remote fen." I agree that the root fan- is probably derived from the Proto-Germanic root *fanja-, and that it means "fen, swamp."

It seems natural that the name of a Germanic goddess triad is related to bogs, fens, and marshes. The name of the home of the Norse goddess Frigg is *Fensalr*, which means "hall of the fen or bog hall." Hundreds of bog bodies have been found

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[32]Rüger, p. 22.

[33]Neumann, p. 114 and Gutenbrunner, pp. 159-161.

[34]Neuman, p. 114-115.

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in Northwestern Europe, and many of them were probably sacrificial offerings. There is also a close connection between Germanic goddesses and water. The Norns live in or near a pond and Nerthus as annually washed in a lake in which her slaves were drowned. Another explanation for a goddess being closely related to a bog might be that bog bodies were found sporadically in prehistoric times. The occasional finding of a well-preserved body in a bog might be attributed to a goddess who received the dead and prepared them for renewal.

Nehalennia

Nehalennia is not called *matronae*; but *deae* or goddess. This distinction might reflect a difference in the size of her cult. Over 20 altars have been found which contain dedications to her. All of the readable dedications refer to her in the singular except one that shows her as part of a triad.[35] The altars mainly come from the island of Walchern near Domberg, but more altars have been found near Zierikzee. Both Domberg and Zierikzee are in Zeeland in Holland. The island of Walchern is at the mouth of the Rhine River.

The dedications appear to have been made mainly by tradesmen and sailors of Germanic origin. The iconography of these monuments is very similar to that of

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[35]Edgar C. Polomé, "Two Etymological Notes," *Sprachwissenschaftliche Forschungen: Festschrift für Johann Knobloch*, ed. Hermann Ölberg, Gernot Schmidt, and Heinz Bothien; in *Innsbrucker Beiträge zur Kulturwissenschaft*, vol. 23, 1985, p. 311.

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the *matronae* monuments. On nineteen of the monuments, the goddess is seated on a high-backed chair. By her side is usually a sitting dog that may be a greyhound. On her other side there often is a basket of fruit. The basket usually contains apples, pears, or pomegranates and ears of wheat. She often holds a basket of fruit in her lap. She is usually dressed in a long tunic and cloak with a cape covering her pinned-up hair. In a few monuments, *Nehalennia* is portrayed standing on a ship with the steering oar in her hand.[36]

Scholars are mainly in agreement over the interpretation of *Nehalennia*'s iconography.[37] She was probably a fertility and prosperity goddess. The baskets of fruit and ears of wheat signify the bounty that she gives. Her connection with ships and the sea may be the reason for her dedicators mainly being tradesmen and sailors. She might have controlled the weather and the safety of cargo and men at sea. The position of her sanctuary on the island of Walchern at the mouth of the Rhine River might signify her control over the river or access to the sea.

Her portrayal on a ship might also signify her connection with death. The ship she is guiding could also be a funeral ship on its way to the afterlife. The Norse believed in placing great warriors and leaders into ships and setting them aflame as

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[36]ibid., p. 311.

[37]Edgar C. Polomé, "Two Etymological Notes," *Sprachwissenschaftliche Forschungen*, p. 312. Polomé cites Siegfried Gutenbrunner, *Die germanischen Götternamen der antiken Inschriften* (Max Niemeyer: Halle 1936); Ada Hondius-Crone, *The Temple of Nehalennia at Domburg* (J. M. Meulenhoff: Amsterdam 1955); and Jan de Vries, *Altgermanische Religionsgeschichte* v. 2.

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they sailed out of sight like at Baldr's funeral. Many graveyards have been found in which the graves were shaped into the outlines of ships.[38] Another practice was to bury a person in a ship under a burial mound. Sutton Hoo, the Gokstad Ship, and the Osberg Ship are the most famous examples of this practice. In Northern European, there appears to have been an intimate connection between ships and death.

I agree with Detter and Polomé that the root *nehal-* is probably related to the Greek noun *νεκυς* meaning "death" and the Latin verb *necare* meaning "to kill" since there is a close match between the two words. Polomé also suggests a relationship with the Greek noun *νεκρός, νέκυς* meaning "corpse." He proposes that this construction with *ρ* makes a parallel construction with *l* possible.[39] This interpretation would closely connect *Nehalennia*'s name with death even though her iconography appears to be associated with prosperity.

There is a strong connection between the deities of fertility and prosperity and the deities of death. Freyja is the goddess of prosperity in the Norse pantheon; however, she also receives half the dead from the battlefield each day. The goddess

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[38]For a good picture of one of these cemeteries, see James Graham-Campbell, *Cultural Atlas of the Viking World* (Andromeda Oxford Limited: Oxfordshire 1994), pp. 70-71. Photo of cemetery at Lindholm Høje in northern Jutland.

[39]Edgar C. Polomé, "Two Etymological Notes," *Sprachwissenschaftliche Forschungen*, pp. 313-314 and Ferd Detter, "Nahanarvali," *Zeitschrift für deutsches Altertum*, vol. 31, 1887, p. 207-8. Polomé suggests that this root might be related to the Old Norse *Naglfar* meaning "ship of the dead".

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Gefjun, whose name literally means "the giver," was the goddess to whom all unmarried women went at the time of death. This makes the fertility and prosperity goddess the purveyor of life and death.

Nehalennia must have been an important goddess at one time. The number of altars dedicated to her testify to this fact. She was a goddess who had control over the quality of life and the death of her worshippers.

Hludana

There are at least five monuments dedicated to the goddess *Hludana.* These monuments were found in Xanten, Nijmegen, Calcar, Münstereifel, and Friesland. De Vries suggests that the root **kluto-* meaning "famous" is the linguistically perfect match and that *Hludana's* name would mean something like "full of fame."[40] De Vries does make a connection between the name of the goddess *Hludana;* the Norse goddess *Hlóðyn; and* the folklore figures *Frau Holle, Frau Holda,* and the *Holden.* I agree that there is definitely a linguistic connection between these beings; however, I am not sure that de Vries has suggested the correct root. I think that the name *Hludana* is derived from the zero grade of the Indo-European root **kel-* meaning "covering, hidden" and also perhaps "protected." To form Hludana, the root **kl-* would have to be suffixed by *-to.* In Proto Germanic, the word was probably **χulþa-*. This word would have been transcribed into Latin as **hulda-*. The names

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[40]de Vries, *Religionsgeschichte* v. 2, §546.

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of the folkloric figures *Frau Holda* and the *Holden*, who will be discussed in depth in the next chapter, can also be explained by the same root. In Old High German, the word would become **holda-*. The *u* becomes an *o* due to breaking before the *a*. The linguistic makeup of the name *Holda* remains consistent into New High German. The names of the Norwegian *huldre*, the Norse giantess *Huld*, and the Norse goddess *Hlóðyn*, the mother of *Þór*, can also be explained by this root.

In North Germanic, *þ* in medial and final position was written as *ð*,[41] and the *ð* of Proto Germanic becomes a *d* after *l*. In Norwegian and Old Norse, the root would become *huld-* which would give Norwegian *huldre* and Old Norse *Huld*. In the name *Hlóðyn*, metathesis has taken place transposing the position of the *l* and the vowel. Since the *ð* is not immediately following the *l*, the *ð* is retained. The change from *u* to *o* can be explained by the fluctuation of *u* and *o* in different Norse dialects.[42] The lengthening of the *o* to *ó* might be explained by the disappearance of *l* after *o* when metathesis took place.[43] The Proto-Indo-European root **kl-* without a suffix would explain the names of the folklore figures of Frau Holle and the Hollen.

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[41]Einar Haugen, *The Scandinavian Languages: An Introduction to Their History* (Harvard University Press: Cambridge, Massachusetts 1976), p. 155.

[42]E.V. Gordon, *An Introduction to Old Norse*, ed. A.R. Taylor (Claredon Press: Oxford 1983), p. 271, §32.

[43]". . . vowels are lengthened to compensate for disappearing consonants . . ." Einar Haugen, *The Scandinavian Languages*, p. 154.

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The meaning of the root was probably "covering, hidden, protected." Related words in different Germanic dialects can be found in the full, o-, and zero grades of the root **kel-*.[44] In the zero grade of the root, the related words are the Old High German, Old Saxon, and Old English verb *helan* meaning "to conceal;" the Gothic noun *hulundi* meaning "cave;" and Gothic *huljan*, Old Norse *hylja*, and Old High German *hullen* meaning "to veil, to disguise." In the o-grade of the root, the related words are Gothic *halja*, Old High German *hella*, Old Saxon *hellia*, Old English *hell*, Old Norse *Hel*, and New High German *Hölle* all meaning "the underworld, place of the dead." Other words derived from the o-grade of the root are Old High German and Old Saxon *halla* and Old English *heall* which all mean "hall," and Old Norse *höll* meaning "big house." In the full grade of the root, the related words are Old High German *hāla* and *hāli*, Middle High German *hœle*, and Old Norse *hœli* all meaning "concealment, concealing, hiding place."[45]

The meanings of these related words can be used to hypothesize the meaning of the name of the goddess *Hlundana*. The meanings of hall, hiding place, cave, to disguise, underworld, and place of the dead seem to evoke a dark, covered, secure place or a person who lives there. The name *Hlundana* probably means something

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[44]Since the root is **kel-*, an original Indo-European *e* is the basis of the full grade, an original Indo-European *o* is the basis of the o-grade, and an original Indo-European syllabic liquid is the basis of the zero grade. Oswald Szemerényi, *Introduction to Indo-European Linguistics*, pp. 83-85.

[45]Julius Pokorny, *Indogermaniches Etymologisches Wörterbuch* (A. Francke AG Verlag: Bern 1989), pp. 553-554.

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like "the one who lives underground." This would be a perfect name for a chthonic goddess.

Summary

The *matronae* appear to have been local goddesses with generally limited areas of influence. Each tribe, settlement, valley, or geographic region had its own or several *matronae*. The movement of peoples, especially the Germanic soldiers of the Roman Empire spread the cults throughout the Empire. The multiplicity of the *matronae* indicate that their worship was private and limited to a specific group or groups. Unlike the Norse goddesses where Freyja has incorporated most of the female divine functions, the continental *matronae* appear to have diverse functions and to be worshiped on a smaller scale.

Turville-Petre has suggested that the cult of the *dísir* of Norse myth and the cult of the *matronae* are associated. Both appear to be ancestral women of the tribe or family and appear to have some association with prosperity and death.[46] While I agree that worship of the *dísir* and the *matronae* is related, I believe that the *matronae* represent the full spectrum of Germanic goddesses. Some appear to be the ancestresses of a tribe or family, others offer prosperity, some offer protection, and some appear to receive dead and deal with the mysteries of death. There appear to

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[46]E.O.G. Turville-Petre, *Myth and Religion of the North*, pp. 226-227.

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be several similarities in function and name between the *matronae* and female beings of Norse myth and German folklore.

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VII. THE PERHTE/HOLLE FIGURE

In German folklore, a woman appears at the beginning of winter. She has different names in different areas, but generally she is known as Frau Perhte in the south and Frau Holle in the central and northern areas of Germanic Europe. The figure's once divine status is evident from her name, her appearance, the time of her appearance, the food offerings left for her, her control of winter weather, her enforcement of work prohibitions, and her ability to punish and reward.

Name

Perhte. The figure goes by many names, but she basically has the same function in most areas. She is most often called Perht, Perhte, Perscht, Persch, or Perchthe.[1] The differences in spelling between these names can be explained by slight pronunciation differences and the lack of a standardized spelling of her name.

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[1]Viktor Waschnitius, *Perht, Holda and verwandte Gestalten: Ein Beitrag zur deutschen Religionsgeschichte* (Sitzungsberichte der Kais. Akademie der Wissenschaften in Wien. Philosophisch-Historische Klasse. Vol. 174, N. 2) (Wien: Alfred Hölder, 1913). For Perht or Perhte, see pages 26-28 in Karinthia; pages 29-33 in Eisacktal, Wipptal, Pustertal, Laien, and Virgental bei Wandeschmatrei; pages 35-36 in Achental, Tiers, and Villnös in Tyrol; page 48 in Wardhofen a. Ybbs; pages 56-57 in Salzburg; page 70 in Switzerland; page 102 in Voigtland; and page 120 in Egerland. For Perscht, see pages 50-51 in Lower Austria. For Persch, see pages 54 in Heidermoos in Innviertal in Austria. For Perchthe, see pages 97-98 and page 104 in Cosdorf and Rödern; page 99 in Neidenberg near the Saale; and page 100 in Jüdwein and Orlegau.

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She is also sometimes called Bercht, Berhte, Berscht, or Berta.[2] Her name in some areas begins with a *p* and in other areas begins with a *b*. This can be explained be the High German consonant shift. See Map 4 for the geographic distribution of the Perhte/Holle figure.

Upper or High German is spoken in the Alpine areas, Middle German is spoken in the Rhine Area, and Low German is spoken in the lowlands in the North. There are transition areas between these distinct groups where a mixture of High and Middle German or Middle and Low German is spoken. The High German consonant shift took place most thoroughly in the Southernmost Alpine areas. The Indo-European consonants *bh, dh,* and *gh* become *b, d, g* in Proto-Germanic. In Middle and Low German areas, these sounds are written as *b, d,* and *g*. In the Upper German dialects, the pronunciation of these sounds in all positions shifts to *p, t,* and *k* respectively; therefore, this figure is called Perhte in Upper German dialect areas and Berhte in Middle and Low German dialect areas. There are several variations on the Perhte/Berhte name including: Perchtlgoba, Perchtl, Pehtrababa, Pehtra, Perchega, Pertega, Berchtl, Berchhöldere, Butzenberc, Bergda, Sperta, and Eisenberta.[3] Several of these variations have a liquid, *l* or *r*, following the basic root

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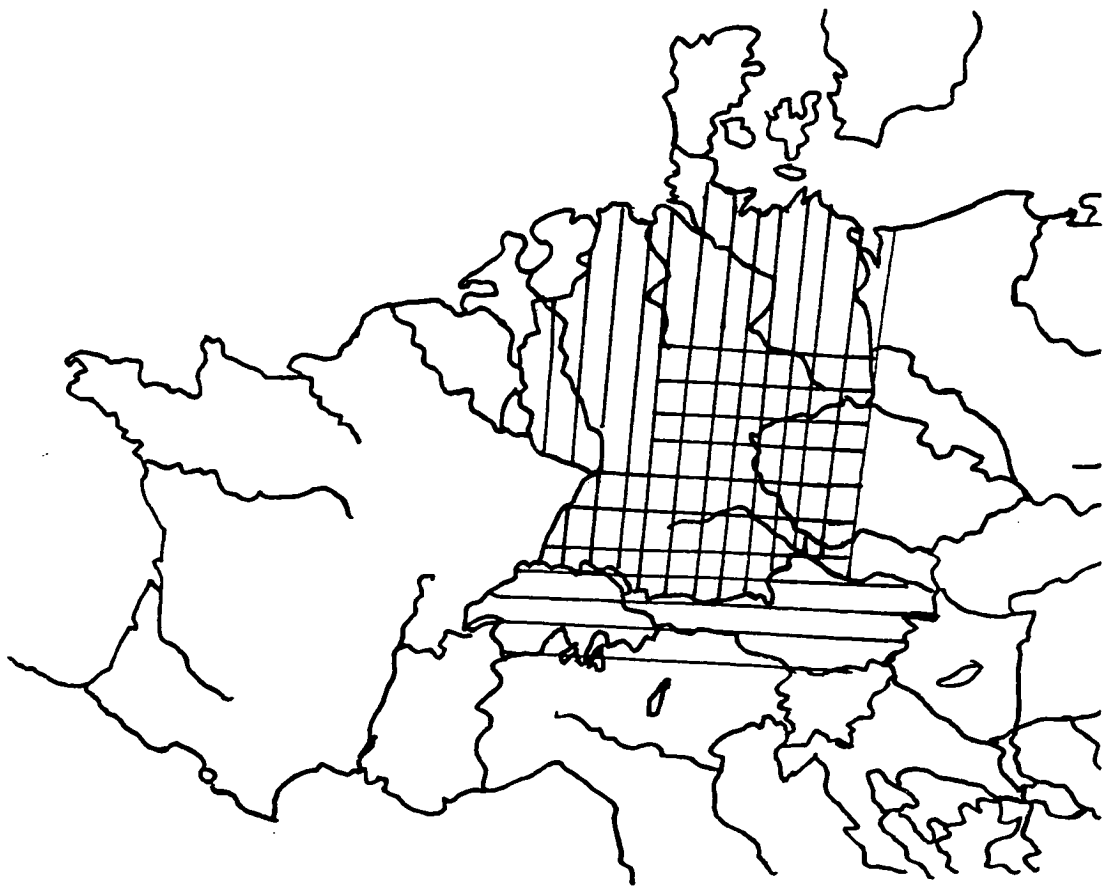
[2]Waschnitius. For Bercht, see page 18 in Upper Steiermark; pages 39-40 in Tyrol; and pages 77-78 in Swabia. For Berhte, see pages 35 and 39 in Tyrol. For Berscht, see pages 48-50 in Neubruck in Lower Austria. For Berta, see pages 44 in Folgareit in Southern Tyrol. For Fraubert, see pages 45-46 in Southern Tyrol.

[3]Waschnitius. For Perchtlgoba, see page 18 from Kallwang bei Leoben. For Perchtl, see page 19 in Ennstal; page 24 in Gailtal; and page 30 in Alpach. For

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MAP 4

GEOGRAPHIC DISTRIBUTION OF THE PERHTE/HOLLE FIGURE



= Holle
= Perhte
= Both Holle and Perhte

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of the name. This seems to be a fairly consistent characteristic of the names from some of the Austrian areas. The *l* ending is a diminutive meaning "little Perhte".

The name of the Perhte/Berhte figure can be derived from the Indo-European **bherg-t-* and Proto-Germanic**berχt-*. Cognates in the Germanic languages are Gothic *baírhts* meaning "pale, shining, clear;" Old High German *beraht* and Middle High German *berht* meaning "shining;" and Old English *beorght* meaning "bright."[4] Briget, the Irish Saint and Celtic Goddess, is probably also a cognate with Berht and Perht. Perht, Berht, and Briget all mean "the bright one, the shining one, or the white one."

Motz believes that the name of the Perhte/Berhte figure is related to the Modern German word *Berg* meaning "mountain."[5] This is an interesting hypothesis because the name would be equivalent with the derivation of the Holle figure's name, but it unfortunately does not seem to work out linguistically. The Indo-European root of *berg* would be**bhergh-* and Proto-Germanic would be **bergaz*.

Pertrababa, see page 27 from the Slavs in Karinthia. For Perchtra, see page 27 in Karinthia. For Perchega and Pertega, see page 34 in Lusern near Callonezzo. For Berchtl, see pages 39-40 in Tyrol; and pages 77-78 in Deffinger and Ellswangen. For Brechhöldere, see page 78 in Swabia. For Butzenberch, see page 78 in Swabia. For Bergda, see page 102 in Saxony and Thuringia. For Sperta, see page 68 in Egerland. For Eisenberta, see page 80 in Holzberndorf.

[4]Julius Pokorny, *Indogermanisches Etymologisches Wörterbuch*, (Francke Verlag: Bern 1955), p. 13.

[5]Lotte Motz, *The Beauty and the Hag: Female Figures of Germanic Faith and Myth, Philologica Germania* 15 (Fassbaender: Vienna 1993), p. 125, see note 46.

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Cognates in the Germanic languages would be Old English *beorg* and Old Norse *berg* meaning "hill" and Old High German *burg* meaning "fortress." The first noticeable difference is the lack of a dental in any of the cognates. The name of the Perht/Berht figure consistently has a *t* after the velar. I believe that the consistency of the "bright" cognates, which have the exact same phonetic structure as Perhte and Berhte, shows that Proto-Germanic **berχt-* is correct; not Proto-Germanic **bergaz.*

Holle. In Central and Northern Germany, the Perhte figure is called Holle. There is also a strong tradition of using variations such as Holli, Holla, Hulle, Hulli, Holl, Hollen, and Holla-Mütterly.[6] I have discussed the derivation of this name from the Indo-European root **kl-* meaning "hidden, covered, protected."[7] In some areas, she is called Holda or Hulda.[8] Holda and Hulda are from the same root as Holle but

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[6]Waschnitius. For Holle or Holla, see page 67 in Egerland; pages 88-89 in Weissenerberg in Hessen; page 90 in Hessen; page 93 in Nassau; pages 97-98 in Klaustal; pages 107-108 in Saxony and Thuringia; page 111 from Gotting Land, and pages 114-115 in the Harz. For Holli or Hulli, see page 82 in Bavaria. For Hulle, see page 82 in Bavaria; pages 80-81 in Würtzburg and Wertheim; pages 107-108 in Saxony and Thuringia; page 112 in Gottinger Land; page 113 in Steina in the Harz; page 114 from Lerbach to Klaustal in the Harz. For Hollen, see page 96 in Alraff, Lüterscheim, Volkmarsen, Flechdorf, and Twiste. For Holla-Mütterly, see pages 76-77 in Swabia.

[7]See chapter 5.

[8]Waschnitius. For Holda, see pages 92-93 in the County of Henneberg including Schleusingen, Schmalkalden, Ilmenau, and Ostheim; page 93 from Nassau; page 95 in Transylvania and Zips mountain towns; page 102 in Voigtland; page 103 from Hohenleuba and Gangloff; page 104 from Thuringia; page 108 from Kyffhäuser; and page 112 in Braunschweig and Vorsfelde. For Hulda, see page 104 in Saxony and Thuringia.

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with a suffixed *-to*: **kl-to-*. Cognates of Holle/Holda include words meaning "the underworld, hill, cave, and disguised;" and the name of the Holle/Holda figure is linguistically related to the *matronae Hludana* and the Norse goddess *Hlóðyn*.[9] The name of the Holle/Holda figure means "the covered one," "the one living underground," or "the disguised one." This would make the Holle/Holda figure a chthonic deity with ties to the underworld.

Other Names. The Holle and Perhte names are fairly standard throughout the Germanic area; however, there are several pockets of unusual names. Chlungen, Chlungere, Chlungerli, Chlungeri[10] are found in Switzerland. Gstampa, Gestampe, and Stampe[11] are from Austria. Luzia, Luz, Luzi, and Luzel[12] are from Southern Germany. Other names used for the Perhte/Holle figure are Sträggele, Werra, Gode, Harke, Weiberbrei, Sampermuada, Satzemise, Rupfe, Drud, Müterli-Wibi, and Murawa.[13]

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[9]See chapter 6.

[10]Waschnitius. For the Chlungeri names, see page 71 from Switzerland.

[11]Waschnitius. For the Gstampa names, see page 36 from Tiers; page 39 from Gumer and Eggen; page 40 in Afers in Tyrol; pages 40-41 in Nassereith in Tyrol; pages 42-43 Wälschoven, Moccheni to Fernsental in Southern Tyrol.

[12]Waschnitius. For the Luzia names, see pages 68-69 in Egerland, the Bavarian Forest, and the Bohemian Forest.

[13] For Sträggele, see pages 72-73 Switzerland. For Werra, see 103 in Saxony and Thuringia. For Gode, see pages 129-130 in Nordalmark, Priegnitz, and Mecklenburg. For Harke, see pages 128-129 from Petersberg to Halle to the Harz to Brocken to Elm. For Weiberbrei, see pages 26-27 in Karinthia. For Samermuada,

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The different names used to refer to the Perhte/Holle figure are easy to explain. Each village and district had their own traditions of the Perhte/Holle figure. In some areas, the name of the figure reflected her function, one of her characteristics, or became associated with another supernatural figure. The linguistic variations within similar names is also easily explained. German speaking Europe does not use the same dialect everywhere. There are shades and variations of vowel and consonants from North to South and East to West. The variations in spelling of Perhte's and Holle's names can be explained by these variations.

The names of the Perhte and the Holle figures have completely opposing meanings. Perhte's name appears to come from a root meaning "bright, white, shining." This makes Perhte a solar deity. She was probably originally associated with the return of the sun after the Winter solstice. Holle's name appears to come from a root meaning "underworld, cave, hill, disguised." This makes Holle a chthonic deity and associates her with the underworld, death, and regeneration.

Appearance

The Perhte/Holle figure usually appears as an individual; however, sometimes a group of individuals with the same name appears. The Hollen appear

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see pages 50-51 in Lower Austria. For Satzemise, see page 118 in Wigstadtl. For Rupfe, see page 66 in Upper Palatinate. For Drud, see 67 in Upper Palatinate at Upper Viechtach at Furth. For Müterli-Wibi, see page 73 in Switzerland. For Murawa, see page 111 in Saxony and the bordering Saxon population in Prussia.

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to be small elf-like beings without individual names; and in some stories, many Perhtes appear. In these instances, the same name could have been applied to other beings with a similar function; or the same being has become multiplied in the story for a particular reason.

The Perhte/Holle figure appears in several guises; however, she is generally either ugly or beautiful.[14] This duality of appearance can be explained in two ways. Either the nature of this deity had a duality of function, or she has been demonized by Christianity. She is usually described as old or ancient with tangled or disheveled hair.[15] She is often described as tall, strong, big, or gigantic; but in a couple of places, she is described as small.[16] Her extraordinary size can be explained by her

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[14]Waschnitius. For ugly, see page 18 from Upper Steiermark; page 67 from Egerland; page 78 from Swabia; and page 118 from Satzemrise in Wigstadtl. For beautiful, see page 19 from Ramsau at the foot of the Dachstein; page 44 from Folgareit in South Tyrol; page 56 from Salzburg; page 81 from the lower mountain at Hasloch in Bavaria; pages 88-89 from Hessen.

[15]Waschnitius. For old , see page 18 from Upper Steiermark and Kallwang bei Leoben; pages 27-28 in Karinthia; pages 29-30 from Wipptal, Pustertal, and Eisacktal in Tyrol; page 35 from Alpenburg in Tyrol; page 78 from Swabia; page 108 from Kyffhäuser in Thüringa; and page 118 from Leobschütz. For tangled hair, see pages 26-27 from Karinthia; pages 29-30 from Wipptal, Pustertal, and Eisacktal in Tyrol; pages 32-32 from Laien in Tyrol; page 39 from Wälschnoven in Tyrol; page 56 from Salzburg; pages 77-78 from Augsburg and Ellswangen in Swabia; page 90 from Hessen; and page 93 from Nassau.

[16]Waschnitius. For tall, see page 19 from Ennstal, pages 31-32 from Laien in Tyrol. For gigantic, see page 35 from Alpenburg in Tyrol. For big, see page 54 from Heidermoos in Innviertal. For powerful, see page 99 from Neidenberge near Saale. For small, see pages 29-30 from Wipptal, Pustertal, and Eisacktal in Tyrol and page 67 from Egerland.

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supernatural function. She is not human, so she does not conform to human size dimensions. She is sometimes described as deformed with humps.[17] Her disfigurement can also be explained by her supernaturalness and, perhaps, because of her vilification by the Christian Church.

When she is beautiful, she is often described as wearing a gleaming, white garment.[18] This would connect the Perhte/Holle figure with the mysterious White Woman of Germanic folklore. The White Woman often appears at mountain pools, in association with lost treasure, caring for new born children, and in connection with royal families.[19] The White Woman; the Perhte/Holle figure's description as wearing a gleaming, white garment; and the derivation of the name Perhte from the Indo-European root meaning "bright" testify to Perhte having been a solar deity.

In many accounts, the Perhte/Holle figure has an extremely or strikingly long nose.[20] In a few areas, she is described as having an iron nose.[21] An iron nose

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[17]Waschnitius. For limping, see pages 39-40 from Eggental in Tyrol. For humps, see page 71 from Switzerland and page 108 from Kyffhäuser in Thuringia.

[18]Waschnitius. For wearing a long white garment, see page 54 from Heidermoos in Innviertal and page 82 from Bavaria. For wearing a pale, shining, gleaming garment; see page 56 from Salzburg. For wearing a long white garment with a veil, see page 81 from Bavaria. For wearing a chalk white sheet, see page 114 from the Harz.

[19]Donald Ward trans. ed., The German Legends of the Brothers Grimm (Institute for the Study of Human Issues: Philadelphia 1981), see legends 4, 10, 123, 224, and 268.

[20]Waschnitius. See page 19 from Ramsau at the foot of Dachstein and Ennstal; pages 29-30 from Wipptal, Pustertal, and Eisacktal in Tyrol; page 35 from a

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suggests that the nose was solid and hard. The long nose and iron nose of the Perhte/Holle figure sound suspiciously like a bird's beak. Some of the masks and costumes used during the *Perchtenlauf* appear very bird-like. The *Schnabelpercht*, in Rauris, wears a beak of cloth.[22] The *Vogelpercht* in the area around Salzberg wears a long robe of feathers and a beak. (Figure 12) In the area around Salzberg, one the Perhte figures in the *Wilden Jagd* wears a long dark robe with a complete head covering bird mask with a huge beak. (Figure 13)

As Motz has noted, several Scandinavian giantesses are also known for their avian features. The giantess Margerðr of *Hjalmþes saga ok Ölvis* had a nose and claws of iron. In *Völsunga saga*, the daughter of the giant Hrímnir turns herself into a crow. In *Hjálmþes saga*, the giantesses Skinnhúfa and Vargeisa turn themselves into vultures with beaks and claws of iron.[23]

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poem written in Tyrol area; page 39 from Tyrol and the Southern Bavarian Areas; pages 39-40 from Reggelbergern in Eggental in Tyrol; pages 40-41 from the district of Nassereith in Tyrol; pages 45-46 from Ronchi at Ala in Southern Tyrol; page 56 from Salzburg; page 64 from documents written by a preacher at Amburg; and page 104 from Luther's writings in Thuringia.

[21]Waschnitius. See page 35 from a poem in Tyrol and page 64 a fifteenth century catechism.

[22]Lotte Motz, "The Winter Goddess: Percht, Holda, and Related Figures," *Folklore* 95:ii (1984): 159.

[23]Lotte Motz, "The Divided Image: A Study of the Giantesses and Female Trolls in Norse Myth and Literature," *The Mankind Quarterly* 1987, pp. 467-468, 478 note 69.

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FIGURE 12

VOGELPERCHT FROM THE AREA AROUND SALZBERG, AUSTRIA



Source: Adapted from a photo in Karl Zinnburg, *Salzburger Volksbräuche* (Salzburg: Verlag der Salzburger Druckerei). See photo page 19.

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FIGURE 13

PERHTE FIGURE FROM THE *WILDEN JAGD* FROM THE AREA AROUND SALZBERG, AUSTRIA



Source: Adapted from a photograph in Karl Zinnburg, *Salzburger Volksbräuche* (Salzburg: Verlag der Salzburger Druckerei). See photo page 35.

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The Perhte/Holle figure's long nose or beak and the appearance of the *Schnabelperchte* suggest that before the advent of Christianity, one of the epiphanies of the Perhte/Holle figure was a bird. As mentioned in chapter 2 and 4, Freyja had a feathered form and the Valkyries were often portrayed as having an avian form. Many female fairy tale figures turn themselves into birds in times of difficulty including the heroine in "Fletcher's Bird," "The White Bride and the Black Bride," and "The Three Little Men in the Woods."[24]

The appearance of the Perhte/Holle figure has many similarities with Scandinavian goddesses, mythological figures, and the White Woman of Germanic folklore. Her appearance and connections with these other figures clearly indicate that she was considered a deity in pre-Christian times.

Time of Appearance

The Perhte/Holle figure appears in the winter. She is most frequently seen between Christmas and the sixth of January, but she can be seen as late as Easter. These days are important holidays in the Christian Church, and these Christian holidays were probably superimposed on pre-existing pagan holidays. The significance of these dates is that they all approximately fall between the beginning of winter, December 21, and the beginning of spring, March 21. The period between Christmas and Easter is the season of winter. It was cold and dark, and often there

[24]See chapter 3.

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was little food to eat. Everyone looked forward to the warmer weather in spring when the sun would remain in the sky longer each day. Spring is also the beginning of the growing season when new crops were planted, so there would be food for the rest of the year.

In some areas, the Perhte/Holle figure appeared during Advent.[25] Advent is the four Sundays prior to Christmas. Christmas or Christmas Eve was a very popular time for the Perhte/Holle figure to appear.[26] New Year's Eve was also a time that the Perhte/Holle figure sometimes appeared.[27] Another very popular time of appearance for the Perhte/Holle figure was the sixth of January or the evening before the sixth. The sixth of January is the Tweleth Day of Christmas or Three Kings Day, which is called the Epiphany in the Church Calendar. It was the day that

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[25]Waschnitius. On Advent, see page 57 in Pongaus, Pinzgaus, St. Johann, Gastein, Krimml, and Zell a. See in Switzerland.

[26]Waschinitus. On Christmas, see page 20 in Lower Steiermark; page 36 in Achental in Tyrol and Villnös near Bosen; page 38 Upper Liez and Virgen; pages 40-41 in the district of Nassereith in Tyrol; page 42 in Gummer and Eggen in Tyrol; pages 48-50 in Neubruck in Lower Austria; page 54 in Heidermoos in Innvertal in Austria; page 71 in Switzerland; 73 from Entlebuch in Switzerland; 80 from Holzberndorf in Bavaria; page 81 on the lower mountain at Hasloch in Bavaria; pages 89-90 in Hessen; pages 94-95 in Transylvania and the Zips mountain towns; page 108 in Schwartzburg-Sonderhausen; page 111 in Götting Land and Saxony; 120 in Olmitz and Egerland in Czechoslovakia. For Christnacht, see page 36 in Tyrol; page 57 in Salzburg and Pinzgau; pages 80-81 in Würzburg; page 96 in Bergheim; and page 108 in Schwartzburg and Sonderhausern. For Kindltag, see pages 55-56 in Hundsdorf in Muhlviertal in Austria.

[27]At New Years Eve, see page 71 in Switzerland; page 102 in Voigtland and Orlagau; page 111 in Götting Land; and page 116 in the South Harz at Molmerschwende.

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the Christ Child was presented to the Magi. This day and the evening before are called different names in some areas. It is called *Perhtennacht*, *Frau Hollenabend*, Holy Eve of the High New Year, *Rachnacten*, and *Goemacht*.[28] *Fasching* or Carnival takes place before Lent, which is the forty weekdays before Easter.[29] The Perhte/Holle figure also appeared on various Saints' days.[30]

The Perhte/Holle figure appeared between Advent and Easter or from mid-December to about mid-March. This period includes the culturally significant days

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[28]Waschnitius. On Three Kings Day, see page 19 in Ramsau at the foot of the Dachstein; page 23 in Mölltal at Karinthia; page 27 in Rosental in Karinthia; page 29 from Upper Krain, Gailtal, Kanaltal, Rosental, and Virgen in Karinthia; page 30 in Alpach in Tyrol and Hechenblaichen in Alpenburg; pages 32-33 in Virgental bei Windischmatrei in Tyrol; page 38 from Villnös in Tyrol; 39 from Fieberbrunn at Kitzbühel, Reggelbergen in Eggertal, and Wälschnoven; page 57 in Salzburg; page 65 in Müldorf in Upper Bavaria; pages 97-98 in Lerbach at Klaustal and Köstritz on the Elster at Gera; page 99 in Neidenberg on the Saale, Sorge at Neustadt, and Gau in Saxony and Thuringia. For Perhtennacht, see page 18 in Kallwang bei Leoben; page 19 in Ennstal; 25 from Gailtal in Karinthia; page 33 in Gailtal; pages 55 and 57 in Salzburg; and page 64 in Amberg. For Frau Hollenabend, see page 106 in Rhulsborn and on the left bank of the Salle; and pages 112-113 in the Harz. For the Holy Eve of the High New Year, see page 102 in Reichenfels. For the eve of the Epiphany, see page 65 in Traunstein. For Rachnachte, see pages 31-32 in Laien; page 40 in Aflers in Tyrol; pages 48-49 in Wardhofen an Ybbs and Zehenthof at Neubruck in Austria; and pages 50-51 in Lower Austria. For Goemacht, see page 31 and page 35 in Alpenburg in Tyrol.

[29]Waschnitius. At Carnival, see page 37 from Tyrol; 71 from Canton Bern in Switzerland; and pages 76-77 in Swabia. At Easter, see pages 72-3 from Meerenschwand, Freienamte, Luzernei Land in Switzerland.

[30]Waschnitius. At Klausenabend, see pages 77-78 in Deffinger in Schwabia. For Luzientag, see pages 68-69 in bayrischer Wald and Bohemian Wald. For the Eve of Vinzentag, see page 28 in Wocheiner Festritz in Kärnten. For Saint Thomasnacht, see page 67 in Eggerland. For Silvesternacht, see page 71 in Switzerland.

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of the Advent, winter solstice, Christmas, Three Kings Day, New Year, and Carnival. This was a very sacred and pivotal time of year. In most areas, her visits were concentrated on Christmas and Three Kings Day.

Control of Weather

The Holle figure's association with winter is indicated by her ability to control winter weather. In central Germany, Frau Holle is responsible for snowfall. It is a common folk saying in Central Germany that "When it snows, Frau Holle makes/shakes her bed." In the Harz mountains, her bed is said to be a certain rock formation. There, when she opens her white garment/robe; it snows.[31] In Karinthia, Perhte lives in deep lakes and in winter retires inside mountains and produces snow.[32] She gives rain and fertility. In Karinthia they say: "Wectra Baba gib uns Regen/Wir geben dir Flachs ein dickes Bund" (Wechtra Baba give us rain/We give you flax in a thick bundle).[33] These folk sayings credit the Frau Holle figure with control of winter weather.

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[31]Waschnitius. See pages 92-93 from Schleusingen, Schmalkalden, Ilmenau, Ostheim, and Meiningen in Hessen. See page 93 from Nassau. See page 96 from Münden in the Principality of Waldeck. See pages 111-112 from Thuringia and the Götting Land. See page 113, from Lerbach at Klaustal in the Harz. Also see Donald Ward, *The Legends of the Brothers Grimm*, legend 4.

[32]Waschinitius. Pages 26-27.

[33]Waschnitius. pages 26-27.

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The familiar shower of feathers that erupts from feather comforters and mattresses is compared to falling snow. This association is natural since the appearance of floating feathers and falling snow is similar. What interests us is that the task is performed by Frau Holle and emphasizes her affiliation with winter. Frau Holle has power over the weather. Her control over the elements is probably a remnant of her status as a pre-Christian deity.

Holle's control over winter weather can be compared to the association with snow and cold of the giantesses of Scandinavian myth. Giantesses in Scandinavian myth are usually said to live in the north. Motz has cited several instances where giantesses are said to live in the far North or in artic cold regions including the Polar lands, Greenland, Finnmark, Hálogaland, and the shores of the White Sea.[34] Some giantesses are also connected with winter weather. The giantess Tögld sent a storm and fog to draw Illugi to her shore; when troll women approach Grímr's boat, it begins to snow; and Þorgerðr sent a hail storm to help her human friend in battle.[35] Motz suggests that the names of several Norse giantesses mean "snow," "frost," or

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[34]Lotte Motz, "The Divided Image: A Study of the Giantesses and Female Trolls in Norse Myth and Literature," *The Mankind Quarterly,* 1987, p. 472.

[35]ibid., p. 471-472. She cites *Illuga saga Tagldarbana, Gríms saga loðinkinna,* and *Jomsvikínga dráþa.*

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designate a winter month.[36] It also must be remembered that the goddess Skaði was called the "Snowshoe Goddess" and was associated with high mountains and snow.[37]

These instances are a clear indication that the Perhte/Holle figure and many Scandinavian giantesses were associated with winter weather and often had control over the weather. Both Frau Holle and several Scandinavian giantesses could summon a winter storm. Many Scandinavian giantesses have name associations with winter or cold weather. This control of winter weather or association with winter weather is circumstancial evidence for a pre-Christian goddess whose main rites took place in the winter months and whose association with winter was so strong that it survived into Christianity in a demonized form. Frau Holle's association with winter and the time of the appearance of the Perhte/Holle figure in December through March appear to strongly suggest that rites and sacrifices of winter were presided over by a goddess in pre-Christian times.

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[36]Lotte Motz, "The Winter Goddess: Percht, Holda, and Related Figures," *Folklore*, v. 95, 1984, p. 162. The names of giantesses meaning 'snow' are Fönn, Drífa, Mjöll. Many contain the word for 'frost' such as Hrímgerðr. Gói is the name of a gaintess and also the name of the Scandinavian month that fell roughly between modern January 15 and February 15.

[37]See chapter 4.

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Children

The Perhte/Holle figure performs four functions with children: she is the leader of lost souls, she kidnaps them, she punishes and rewards them, and she stores unborn children and dispenses them to women who perform certain deeds.

Troop of Dead Children. In the Southern Germanic Area, the Perhte figure is often considered to be the leader of a troop of children. These children are dead and unbaptized. Perhte wanders around the countryside leading the souls of dead, unbaptized children on Three Kings Night, which is called *Perhtenacht* in some areas.[38] People often leave a snack or offering for Perhte and her children.[39] This offering was sometimes reciprocated with a blessing or promise of prosperity. There are often two folklore motifs present in these stories: the accidential naming of one of the children and one child struggling with a jug of tears.

While I agree with Motz that Perhte's troop of dead, unbaptized children marks her as a pagan goddess; I do not totally agree with her conclusions of Perhte functions. Motz thinks that Perhte's involvement with a troop of children not her

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[38]Waschnitius. See pages 30-33, 42-43, 48-51, and 97-99.

[39]Waschnitius. For leaving a bowl of milk, see page 18 from Kallwang bei Leoben, page 48 from Wardhofen a. Ybbs in Lower Austria, and pages 50-51 from Lower Austria. For a farmer's wife being forced to cook for them, see page 31, from Tyrol. For leaving Gestampanudeln and three white gifts, see pages 42-43 from Wälschoven in Tyrol. For leaving fats for the children, see pages 48-49 from Zehenthof at Neubruck in Lower Austria.

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own makes her a nurse, and/or foster mother of these children.[40] I agree that the Perhte figure in pre-Christian times might have had the function of fostering or nursing children, but the evidence indicates that Perhte acts more like a goddess of death than a foster mother in these stories. When children are nursed or fostered, they are in a transitional stage between needing support and independence. Children that are fostered eventually become independent and strike out on thier own. Perhte's band of dead children remain dead and continue to wander with her. It is significant that the children in her troop are unbaptized. Baptized, dead children would belong to the Christian God. Perhte only recieves beings that are unable to join the Christian God at death.

Perhte was the leader of unbaptized, dead children. This means that she was in charge of the non-Christian dead since adults were baptized. Since she was considered the leader of the non-Christian dead in Christian times; in pre-Christian times, Perhte probably had dominion over all of the dead. With the advent of Christianity, her power was reduced to the leader of the non-Christian dead. The time of her wandering is important. Perhte and her children are out on Three Kings Night, which is the last night of the Twelve Days of Christmas. This period between the end of one year and the beginning of another was very dangerous and the souls of the dead often were able to injure the living at this time. Perhte's position as the

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[40]Lotte Motz, *The Beauty and the Hag*, p. 129.

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leader of the non-Christian dead and the time of her wandering mark her as a goddess of the dead.

Kidnapping Children. The Perhte/Holle figure was accused of kidnapping children. Sometimes she would take unbaptized, new-born children or women still in the childbed and leave a child of her own in exchange.[41] Any abnormality in a child's behavior or appearance could be attributed to it being a changeling. The changeling folklore made birth defects, retardation, and disease easier to accept, and it gave an explanation for the inexplicable.

The Perhte/Holle figure took children without leaving any to take their places. She took unclean, disobedient or lazy children and kept them herself.[42] In other places, this figure is said to entice and steal children, but no reason is given.[43] This threat of kidnapping made the Perhte/Holle figure the "boogeyman" of the Germanic Area. Parents and guardians could threaten children with her possible appearance when children did not perform their assigned chores or follow the rules of appropriate behavior.

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[41]Waschnitius. See page 40-41 from the district of Nassereith in Tyrol, page 96 from the Principality of Waldeck.

[42]Waschnitius. For stealing disobedient or bad children, see page 54 from Heidermoos in Innviertal, pages 80-81 from Würtzburg and Wertheim in Bavaria, and page 113 from Lautental in the Harz.

[43]Waschnitius. See pages 41-42 from Moccheni to Fersental in Tyrol, and pages 124-125 from Scharfenberg at Brilon and Grevenbrück in Westphalia.

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The Perhte/Holle figure was not the only threat to children's welfare. In some areas, there were female beings by other names who also kidnapped children. On Wonder Mountain near Grödich, Wild Women emerged from the mountain and stole a boy who was sitting on a horse.[44] In Mark Brandenburg, the Nursemaid-in-the-Rye hid in the grain fields, so children were afraid to enter them. In Altmark, noisy children were told, "Shut up, or the Rye Woman with her long black teats will get you!" In the area around Brunswick and Lüneburg, the Grain Wife might steal children when they were picking corn flowers. In Saalfeld, the Earth Woman was able to kidnap a new-born baby that was brought to the fields, and replace it with her own.[45] In Dessau, a woman fell into a deep sleep after giving birth, and two women from the Underground exchanged her child for one of their own.[46]

The abundance of stories about the kidnaping of children and the names and habitations of the women who steal the children all point to a belief in a woman or women who have control over the life and death of children. The names the Rye Woman, the Nursemaid-in-the-Rye, and the Grain Wife suggest that this woman was associated with cultivated fields. This woman might also be associated with the Underground since some of these women are said to be from a mountain, from the Underground, and one is called the Earth Woman. These kidnaped children are

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[44]Donald Ward, *The Legends of the Brothers Grimm*, legend 50.

[45]ibid., legend 90.

[46]ibid., legend 91.

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often never seen again or are only occasionally spotted in the distance by an acquaintance. For all intents and purposes, these children are dead to their families. These kidnappings might be interpreted as offerings or sacrifices to a goddess associated with fertility of the fields or with the underworld.

Punishment and Reward. The Perhte/Holle figure meted out punishment to bad children and bestowed gifts on good children. She either punished children by beating them with a rod or opened up the stomach or intestines of the children and stuffed them with straw and/or pebbles.[47] In Swabia, Franconia, and Thuringia obstinate children were told, "Be silent or Wild Bertha will come."[48] The gifts that the Perhte/Holle brought to good children were usually nuts, dried fruit, apples, and sometimes Christmas trees.[49] These stories like the ones discussed about kidnapping children were probably used to limit the behavior of children with threats and promises. The ability to punish and reward again places the Perhte/Holle figure in the supernatural realm.

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[47]Waschnitius. For beating children with a rod, see pages 77-78 from Deffinger in Swabia; pages 80-81 from Würzburg; and pages 89-90 from Hessen. For cutting out the stomach or intestines of children, see page 27 from Rosental in Karinthia; page 33 from Tiers in Tyrol; page 65 from the area around Traunstein; pages 68-69 from Egerland and the Bohemian Forest; and page 120 from Olmütz and Bohemia.

[48]Donald Ward, *The Legends of the Brothers Grimm*, legend 269.

[49]Waschnitius. See page 27 from Rosental in Karinthia; pages 77-78 from Deffinger in Swabia; pages 80-81 from Würzburg; pages 89-90 from Hessen; pages 92-93 from Schleusingen, Schmalkalden, Ilmenau, Ostheim, and Meiningen; and page 120 from Olmütz and Bohemia.

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Unborn Children. The Perhte/Holle figure had a connection to unborn children. She kept them in vats of water or in a cave. If you wanted a child, then you went to her.[50] In the Meißen Mountains in Hesse, Mother Holla has a pond. Women who climbed into her spring were made healthy and fertile. She was also said to deliver new born children from her well.[51] The Perhte/Holle figure stored unborn children in water or earth. Women who could not concieve went to her sancuary; a pond, mountain, or lake; to become fertile. In these stories, the Perhte/Holle figure is the giver of human life. She decides who will recieve a child and who will not. This function again marks her as a pre-Christain deity.

The Perhte/Holle figure is intimately connected with children. She keeps unborn children and dispenses them to worthy women; she punishes naughty or lazy children, and she rewards good children; she kidnaps unbaptized or bad children; and she travels with a troop of dead, unbaptized children. She has dominion over the birth and death of children.

The Perhte/Holle figure has so much dominion over children, especially unbaptised children, because children are not yet considered Christian beings. Children have not yet accepted the teachings of the Church because they are too young to understand what they mean. When they reach the age where they can

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[50]Waschnitius. For keeping unborn children in water vats in the mountains, see page 34 from Lusern in Tyrol. For living in a cave with small pure children, see page 35 from Lusern in Tyrol.

[51]Donald Ward, *The Legends of the Brothers Grimm*, legend 4.

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understand the teachings of the Church, they are old enough to be confirmed in the church and become adults. These facts make children vulnerable to non-Christian forces.

Food Offerings

A fifteenth century manuscript about the Ten Commandments, the *Casuistischer Traktat*, states "Thus people on *Perchnacht* leave their food or drink to Perchk."[52] Food offerings were left for the Perhte/Holle figure during the period between Christmas and mid-January. The offerings were usually made on Three Kings Eve or Night and usually consisted of a bowl or bowls of milk, which was sometimes called *Berchtelmilch* or *Perschtmilch*; cake; eggs; and noodles, which were sometimes called *Gstampanudeln.*[53] Three white gifts described as eggs,

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[5252]Waschnitius p. 64, Cod. g. Mon. 632 f 5b. , Schm 270. *"So die Menschen an der perchnacht der perchk lassen sein essen oder trincken."*

[53]Waschnitius. For offerings of milk, see page 18 in Kallwang bei Leoben and Upper Steiermark; and page 48 in Lower Austria at Waidhofen an Ybbs; pages 50-52 in Lower Austria. For offerings of cake, see page 36 in Villnös bei Bozen; pages 42-43 in Gummer and Eggen; page 57 in Salzburg (donuts); page 36 in Pustertal, Tiers, and Villnös near Bozen (donuts); page 24 in Mölltal in Karinthia (bread). For eggs, see page 36 in Villnös bei Bozen; and page 43 in Wälschnoven. For noodles, see page 24 in Mölltal in Karinthia; page 36 in Villnös bei Bozen; page 43 in Wälschnoven. For bowls of food without specifying the food, see pages 20-21 in Steiermark; page 21 in the Fischbach Alps; page 28 in Wochein Feistritz in Karinthia; For a farmer's wife forced to cook a meal for Perhte and her troop, see page 31 in Alpenburg in Tyrol. For leaving her left overs from a meal; see page 36 in Pustertal and Alpach in Tyrol. For leaving food with lots of fat, see pages 48-49 in Zehehthof in Neubruck.

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butter, and salt were also left in some areas.[54] The offerings were all things that are easily obtainable in the winter months.

The offerings were usually placed on the table, near the window, or on the roof.[55] Offerings on the roof suggest that the Perhte/Holle figure could fly through the air, and this might be related to her association with birds and the avian aspects of her appearance. The placement of the offerings on a table or near a window in the house suggest that the Perhte/Holle figure was able to mysteriously enter the house without being seen or heard by the occupants. The ability to fly and the ability to go undetected are both abilities of supernatural beings.

The offerings often had a reciprical return from the Perhte/Holle figure. If the food was touched or gone; then she would bless the house, it would be a good year, she would remain in a good mood, or it was a good sign.[56] The offerings of food seem to have been offerings to the deity of prosperity for continuance of good fortune in the coming year.

If certain foods were not eaten on certain days or if certain rituals were not performed with certain meals, then the Perhte/Holle figure punished the offenders.

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[54]Waschnitius, page 43.

[55]Waschnitius. For on the table, see page 24 in Mölltal in Karinthia and page 57 in Salzburg. For near the window, see pages 42-43 in Gummer and Egggen and page 57 in Salzburg. For on the roof, see page 36 in Villnös bei Bozen.

[56]Waschnitius. For blessing the house, see page 18 in Kallwang bei Leoben. For a good year, see page 24 in Mölltal in Karinthia. For remaining in a good mood, see pages 42-43 in Gummer and Eggen. For a good sign, see page 57 in Salzburg.

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In Pinzgau, each farmer and his family consumed *Bachlkoch* with the domestic servants on Christabend. If they did not, Perht would be offended. In Saxony and Thuringia, people ate *Strötzel* and herring, or Perhte would cut open their stomaches. In the Voigtland, *Poise*, a porrigde of flour and water, had to be eaten on Three Kings Day or Frau Holla would tear out the offender's stomach.

In Gau, Perchtha cut open the stomach of people who did not eat *Zemmede*[57] on Three Kings Eve. She took the other foods out of their stomaches, and then filled them up again. Perchtha used a plowshare as a needle and chain as thread to sew up their stomachs. In Egerland, the youngest of the domestic servants had to carry the fish bones remaining from the meal on Christmas Eve into the garden and lay them under a fruit tree. On that night, Sperte opened up the stomaches of those who did not obey and hung their intestines on the garden fence.[58]

The punishment of the offender who did not participate in the ritual was swift and severe. The ritual was concerned what one ate and when one ate it, and the punishment meted out to those who did not follow the ritual add credence to the Perhte/Holle figure's status as a pre-Christian deity.

In some areas, the rituals were much more involved and complicated. In Waidhofen an Ybbs, the household left milk in bowls overnight with spoons stuck in

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[57]*Zemmede* is a food baked in a frying pan from flour and milk or water.

[58]Waschinitius. See page 57, *Bachlkoch* is *Mehlkoch* with a honey layer; page 102; page 99, and page 68.

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the bowls. If, in the morning, the spoons were covered with cream; then Perhte and her children had been there. In the morning, each member of the household drank some of the milk. Then, the milk was given to the chickens and cows to insure that they would lay many eggs and give ample milk.[59] This ritual drinking of the sacrificial offering insured the health and fertility of the people within the household and the animals of the farmstead.

The same sort of thing might be going on in the example from Transylvania and the Zips mountain towns. Whatever remained in the bowl from the *Mohnspeise* on Christmas Eve was called Frâ Holden's share. When one came back from church, one said "Now we will eat with Frâ Holden."[60] The eating of the deity's food or sharing the food with the deity made the food very powerful.

Offerings were also made to elf-like beings called Hollen. They appear to have been a group of nameless beings who lived away from humans. They are included in this study because their name is the plural of Holle. In the principality of Waldeck, Alraff, Lütersheim, Volksmarsen, Flechtdorf, and Twiste; when little children were sick; the parents brought wool and bread to a juniper bush and said: "You Hollen and Hollinnen, I bring to you something to spin and something to eat.

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[59]Waschnitius, page 48 in Lower Austria at Waidhofen an Ybbs.

[60]Waschnitius, pages 94-95.

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You should spin and eat and forget my child."[61] The parents made offerings to these beings in an attempt to cure their child of illness. Considering the close ties to children that the Perhte/Holle figure had, these beings, when unhappy, might have revenged themselves on the community by harming the children of the community.

Offerings in fields were also apparently made to the Perhte/Holle figure. In Kerstlingerode at Götting, the last handfull of wheat was not cut. One twisted together the stalk and said: "That is for Fru Holle."[62] Leaving the last handfull of wheat in the field is another form of ritual sacrifice. This associates the Perhte/Holle figure with the fertility of the fields and harvest for the next year.

Ritual offerings of food were left for the Perhte/Holle figure usually on Three Kings Night. The offerings usually consisted of milk, noodles, cakes, or porridge. These offerings were then left on the roof, on a table, or near a window. In return for the food, the Perhte/Holle figure often blessed the house and remained in a good mood for the coming year. In some places, the people of the house and/or the farm animals ate or drank the offering after the Perhte/Holle figure had a chance to eat it. In these passages, the Perhte/Holle figure is offered food sacrifices in return for good fortune in the coming year. Here she is portrayed as a goddess of prosperity. She must be appeased with ritual, annual offerings.

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[61]Waschnitius p. 96, from L. Curtze *Volkssagen aus dem Orlagau* (Altenburg 1838), p. 373 n. 15; *"Ihr Hollen und Hollinen, hier bring ich euch was zu spinnen und was zu essen. Ihr sollt spinnen und essen und meines Kindes vergessen."*

[62]Waschnitius. page 112.

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Work and Spinning Prohibitions

The Perhte/Holle figure had the power to punish lazy workers and to enforce work prohibitions on certain days. These prohibitions and punishments were particularly concerned with spinning and the emptying of the distaff. Prior to the nineteenth century, most women spent the majority of their time making cloth. Any moment when they were not working in the fields, cooking, cleaning, or doing any other activity; they spun or wove. The production of cloth was very labor intensive. The thread was spun from flax or wool and then woven into cloth. This time-consuming and integral part of a woman's life was regulated by rules enforced by the Perhte/Holle figure.

The Perhte/Holle figure mainly punished young girls and women for working or spinning on Holy Days or for not completing work by certain days. Women were not supposed to spin on certain evenings especially during the Twelve Nights of Christmas and certain Saint nights.[63] These nights were apparently considered to be very special, and no work was done. The Perhte/Holle figure became angered when work was not completed. She appears to have been very concerned that all of the distaffs were emptied on *Frau Hollenabend* or Three Kings Night, New Year's Eve,

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[63]Waschnitius. For not spinning during the Twelve Nights, see pages 53-54 in the district of Zwettl in Lower Austria and Gutenberg near Halle. For not spinning on Saint Thomas Night, see page 67 in Egerland.

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Saturday evenings, and Sundays.[64] This was probably a form of sympathetic magic. Sympathetic magic took place when there was a "symbolic likeness in cause and effect."[65] In this instance, the spinning should be completed and the distaff emptied before the next year or week began, or the troubles and cares of the last year or week would follow into the next like the uncompleted spinning would.

A story that seems to underscore the importance of finishing work at a certain time is from the area near Horsel Mountain. Mother Holla checks the distaffs at Christmas and says, "As many hairs as I can see/ So many good years will there be." On Three Kings Night, she checks the distaffs again and says, "As many hairs as I can see/ So many bad years there will be."[66] The punishments for not following the prohibtions of the Perhte/Holle figure usually consisted of the offender

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[64]Waschnitius. For emptying the distaffs on New Year's Eve, see pages 65 in Berge; page 102 in the Voigtland; and page 111 in the Götting Land. For emptying the distaffs before Frau Hollenabend or Three Kings, see page 83 in Rhöngebirge; pages 97-98 between Bucha and Wilhelmsdorf; page 106 in Phulsborn; page 108 in Schwarzburg-Sondershausen; and page 113 in the Harz. For emptying the distaff on Saturday evening, see page 81 near Hasloch on the lower mountain. For emptying the distaff on Sunday, see page 83 in Rhöngebirge; and page 113 in the Harz. For not sweeping the house clean on Christmas Eve, see page 20 in Steiermark.

[65]Richard Kieckhefer, *Magic in the Middle Ages* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1995), p. 13.

[66]Donald Ward, *The Legends of the Brothers Grimm*, legend 5.

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having her stomach cut open and filled with sweepings and/or hair curlers, being beaten with rods, or having the flax that remained on the distaff tangled and soiled.[67]

In these passages, the Perhte/Holle figure functions as a diety. She designates times and days when work should not be performed and when work must be completed. She also punishes girls who do not adhere to her demands. The Perhte/Holle figure's intimate association with spinning might stem from two different reasons: the Perhte/Holle figure might have been connected with spinning from pre-Christian times, and spinning can be seen as a form of magic since an essential for life, thread, is produced from seemingly useless materials.

The Perhte/Holle figure once had many more functions, and spinning was only one of several areas that she controlled. That the Perhte/Holle figure had many functions is evident from the many divisions of this chapter. She was involved in children, death, weather, and prosperity to name a few besides spinning. After the Germanic Area was converted to Christianity, her hold on many of her spheres of influence was disrupted since the Christian God also had control over the same areas. The Perhte/Holle figure was able to maintain control over the area of

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[67]Waschnitius. For cutting open the offender's stomache and filling it with sweepings and/or curlers, see page 20 in Steiermark; and page 65 in Berge. For the offender being beaten with rods, see page 67 in Egerland. For the flax on the distaff being soiled and tangled, see page 65 in Berge; page 83 in Rhöngebirge; pages 97-98 between Bucha and Wilhelmsdorf; page 102 in the Voigtland; page 106 in Phulsborn; page 108 in Schwarzburg-Sondershausen; page 109 in Gutenberg near Halle, Pfützental, Rothenburg, Näglitz, and Löbejun near Eisleben; page 111 in the Götting Land; and page 113 in the Harz.

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spinning because it was considered women's work and the male-hierarchied Christian Church had little or no interest in it.

Meeting

An accidental meeting with the Perhte/Holle figure could be advantageous or disastrous depending on the circumstances. Meetings with Perhte/Holle almost always took place on the road at night near Three Kings Night or *Perchtenacht* and New Years. If a person performed a service for Perhte/Holle, then the person was rewarded. The services performed fall roughly into two categories: naming a child in her retinue and fixing her wagon or plow.[68] The reward was always something worthless, generally shavings, that turned into gold on the way home.

If a person hid from the Perhte/Holle figure, laughed at her or her children, or eavesdropped on her; then Perhte/Holle punished the offender. Punishment was usually an axe or nail through the body in the leg, arm, or head.[69] The offender had

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[68]Waschnitius. For the naming of a child, see p.18 from Kallwang bei Leoben. For fixing a plow or wagon, see pages 19 from Ramsau at the foot of the Dachstein, 97-8 from Saxony and Thuringia in Preswitz, 102 from Hohenleuben and Gangloff Kirchberg, and 104 from Tiefenort and Kainberge. For fixing her wagon, see also Donald Ward, *The Legends of the Brothers Grimm*, legend 8.

[69]Waschnitius. For hiding and axe in the leg, see pages 32-3 from Virgental bei Windischmatrei in Tyrol. For eavesdropping and an axe in the body, see page 39 form Lower Eisacktal in Tyrol. For a nail in the head, see page 79 from Baden. For an axe in the shoulder, see page 98 from Colba, Kaulzendorf, Presswitz, and Landberg in Saxony and Thuringia. For laughing and blinding, see page 99 from Neidenberge near Saale in Saxony and Thuringia.

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to come back to the same place the next year at the same time, and Perhte/Holle would remove the object. Sometimes she would blind the offender for a year.[70] The ability of the Perhte/Holle figure to reward and punish and the bizarre annual nature of the punishments emphasize her once divine status and the annual nature of her appearance.

In some areas, the Perchte/Holle figure was the personification of death. In this guise, she searched for people and houses that were not protected by the sign of the cross.[71] She attempted to kill these unprotected people. This usually happened between New Year's Day and Three Kings Day. Sometimes she dropped a garment. If anyone picked up the garment, then they would die in the coming year.[72] Her touch was not always fatal. In some areas, if the Perchte/Holle figure touched a part of your body; then that part would turn black.[73] In these passages, the Perhte/Holle figure's ability to kill people or cause death and destruction is emphasized. When compared with her retinue of dead, unbaptized children, Perhte/Holle's ability to kill and maim reiterates her function as a goddess of death.

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[70]Waschnitius. Page 99 from Neidenberge near the Saale.

[71]Waschnitius. See page 34 from Virgin and Praegarten in Tyrol.

[72]Waschnitius. See page 33 from Ling to Kufstein in Tyrol.

[73]Waschnitius. See pages 113-114 from the Harz.

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Processions

In many areas of Germanic Europe, traditional processions and ceremonies featuring Perhte took place annually. The *Perchtenlauf* has been documented from the sixteenth century and is probably much older. In several areas of the Alpine Region, some form of the *Perchtenlauf* still takes place today.[74] The *Perchtenjagen*, *Perchtenlauf*, and *Perchtenspiel* (the Perhte hunt, run, and play) took place at Advent, Christmas, *Perchtetag* or Three Kings Day, Carnival, or Easter depending on the traditions of the village and area.[75]

While each village and area had its own traditions, the basic ritual seems to have consisted of several key elements: young unmarried men dressed up in animal skins and masks or dressed up as women; wild running from house to house and village to village; as much noise as possible was made by whips, cow horns, cow and goat bells, and yelling; gifts were given either to the men in the procession or to the

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[74]Leopold Schmidt, *Perchtenmasken in Österreich* (Vienna: Hermann Böhlaus Nachf. 1972), pg. 18.

[75]Waschnitius. On Advent, see page 57 from Pongaus, Pinzgaus, St. Johann, Gastein, Krimml, and Zell a. See in Switzerland. On Christmas, see pages 38 Upper Liez and Virgen; 73 from Entlebuch in Switzerland; 80 from Holzberndorf in Bavaria; 120 from Olmitz and Egerland in Czechoslovakia. On Perchtenacht, see pages 24 from Mölltal in Karinthia; 25 from Gailtal in Karinthia; 59 from Salzburg. On Three Kings Day, see pages 29 from Upper Krain, Gailtal, Kanaltal, Rosental, and Virgen in Karinthia; 38 from Villmös in Tyrol; 39 from Fieberbrunn at Kitzbühel in Tyrol. At Carnival, see pages 37 from Tyrol and 71 from Canton Bern in Switzerland. At Easter, see pages 72-3 from Meerenschwand, Freienamte, Luzernei Land in Switzerland.

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occupants of the houses; and young unmarried women were singled out for particular harrassment.

The participants of the processions were always young men. They dressed up as beautiful or ugly Perhtes. The beautiful Perhtes often were not masked and wore the traditional costume of the area or woman's clothes.[76] The ugly Perhtes usually wore wooden masks that were carved with animal and devil faces. Some had horns, fangs, muzzles, and beaks. The ugly Perhtes often wore animal furs or skins and had cow bells around their necks or on belts around their waists.[77]

The Perhtes or sometimes one Perhte with a retinue ran round and through houses in a village and on to the next village. In the late eighteenth century, as many as two to three hundred young men would take part in a district.[78] In some places, it was important for the Perhtes to jump over fountians and wells.[79] Some processions appeared to have been orderly and others seem to have had a frenzied

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[76]Waschnitius. For young men dressed in women's clothes, see page 29 from Asslinger Gereint. With ribbons and trimmings, see page 37 in Tyrol. For young men in native costume with young men in girl's clothes at their sides, see page 59, from Salzburg, Pongau and Pinzgau.

[77]Waschnitius. For descriptions of ugly Perchtes, see page 24 from Mölltal in Karinthia; page 29 from Upper Krain, Gailtal, Kanaltal, Rosental, and Vigau in Karinthia page 37 from Lienz in Tyrol; page 39 from Fieberbrunn in Kitzbühel in Tyrol; page 57 from Pongaus and Pinzgau in Switzerland; pages 73-74 from Entlebuch in Switzerland; and page 80 in Holzbergendorf in Bavaria.

[78]Waschnitius. Page 59.

[79]Waschnitius. Pages 37-38.

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atmosphere. In some areas, the Perhtes were expelled or chased from a town or district.[80]

Several layers of magic seem to be enacted in these rituals. The expulsion or chasing of Perhte is probably the chasing away of winter and hardship, so spring and prosperity can come again. Tied up with this idea is the idea of light. When winter begins, the nights are extremely long and the days are short and cold. By the time of Easter, the days are noticeably longer and often warmer. The wild running through and around houses and villages would chase away winter and darkness and any demons that might be associated with these.

Gifts were sometimes given to the children or occupants of the house. These gifts usually considered of fruit and nuts. More often the Perhtes were given gifts, which usually consisted of produce. In Kärten, the Perhtes threaten that they will not leave until they are given children or bacon.[81] The gifts to the Perhtes, especially considering the threat of stealing children, are probably a form of offering or sacrifice to the Perhtes for a good spring.

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[80]Waschnitius. Page 29.

[81]Waschnitius. In Mölltal in Karinthia, Perchte will not leave without bacon or children - page 24. In Tyrol, beautiful Perchtes distribute gifts - page 37. In Salzburg, Pongau, and Pinzgau, the Perchtes receive gifts of natural produce but no money - page 57-8. In Salzburg and Pongau, the Perchtes receive gifts for their dance - page 59. In Holzberndorf in Bavaria, Eisenberta gave apples, pears, and nuts to good children and punished bad children - page 80. In Hanna, Olmütz, and Bohemia; Sperchta drills the stomachs of bad children and fills them up with straw.

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Young unmarried women were particularily harassed during these processions. They were sometimes beaten with linen, wrapped in baby rags, forced to run around the house, or roughly awoken in the night.[82] The element of the unmarried males harrassing young unmarried females in a ritual fashion probably involves sex and fertility magic. The frenzied action of the Perchtes in many areas brings to mind the ritual spring orgies that took place in more ancient times. The release of youth, pursuit of the opposite sex, and sanctioned sexual activies were all important in the ritual magic of the spring renewal of the fields.

De Vries states that the *Perchtenlauf* has been explained in two different ways. One line of thought is that the Perhtes are fertility demons enacting the fight between the old and new year. The other theory is that it is a procession of the dead.[83] Both themes are present. The procession probably symbolizes the beginning of the agricultural year. Soon, it will be spring and the days will be longer and warmer. This includes the expulsion of the forces of winter and the old year. The time of the ceremony is usually between New Year's Day and Three Kings Day, but it can take place between Advent and Easter. The beginning of winter, especially the time between Christmas and Three Kings Day is a very dangerous time. The

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[82]Waschnitius. For participants who have designs on adult young women, see page 24 from Mölltal in Karinthia. For participants hitting young women with linen shell and wrapping baby rags around them, see page 59 from Salzburg, Pongau, and Pinzgau. For waking young women from sleep by a masked rough lover, see page 72 from Meerenschwand in Switzerland.

[83]Jan de Vries, *Altgermanische Religionsgeschicte,* v. 1, §308.

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dead are known to walk the earth and fly through the air in hordes. The participants in the *Perchtenlauf* probably symbolize the dead. I agree with Moser that the *Perchtenlauf* probably symbolically represented an assemblage of the dead demanding fertility for the coming year since this theory encompasses both death and fertility which seem to be recurring themes in the folklore of the Perhte/Holle figure.[84] Perhte was both a goddess of fertility and death.

Animals

There is a connection between animals and the Perhte/Holle figure. Dogs are often associated with her. Dogs either accompanied Perhte and her troop of children during their wanderings on Three Kings Night, or the dogs were considered to be the unbaptized children of Perhte.[85] The substitution of dogs for the souls of dead unbaptized children is interesting. Dogs have long been associated with death, often guard the underworld, and act as companions to the goddess of death. During the expulsion of Perhte, dogs were often loosened.[86] A black shaggy dog was left full

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[84]Hans Moser, *Volksbräuche im geschichtlichen Wandel: Ergebnisse aus fünfzig Jahren volkskundlicher Quellenforschung*, in *Forschungshefte - Herausgegeben vom Bayerischen Nationalmuseum München*, vol. 10 (Munich: Deutscher Kunstverlag 1985) p. 35.

[85]Waschnitius. For dogs traveling with Perchte and her children, see pages 31-32 from Laien in Tyrol. For the dogs as the children, see page 31 from Eisacktal and Laien in Tyrol.

[86]Waschnitius. See page 29 from Upper Krain, Gailtal, Kanaltal, Rosental, and Vigau in Karinthia.

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bowls of food on certain nights. When a farmer once ate the food himself, Berscht appeared as a small black dog that turned into a monster, and the farmer barely escaped with his life.[87] Motz mentions that the name of the Perhte/Holle figure in Styria is Pudelmutter or "Poodle Mother."[88]

Crickets also play a part in the stories.[89] The Perhte/Holle figure is sometimes depicted as having a cricket on her nose or surrounded by sounding crickets.[90] In the area surrounding Gangloff, and Maulwurfsgrille in Saxony and Thuringia, the names Holle and Werre are used interchangablely. Here crickets are called *Werre*.[91] Her association with chirping crickets might be explained by the fact that the more crickets chirp, the warmer the weather is; in fact, the temperature in Fahrenheit can be accurately determined by counting the number of chirps of the field cricket in 15 seconds and adding 38.[92] The question is why the Perhte/Holle

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[87]Waschnitius. See page 21 from Upper Steiermark.

[88]Lotte Motz, *The Beauty and the Hag*, p. 131.

[89]For imformation regarding cricket in song and folk tradition in Greece see J.C.B. Petropoulos, *Heat and Lust: Hesiod's Midsummer Festival Scene Revisted* (Lanham, Maryland: Brown & Littlefield Publishers, Inc, 1994), pp. 47-68.

[90]Waschnitius. For a cricket on her nose, see page 19 from Ramsau at the foot of the Dachstein. For Perchte surrounded by noisy crickets, see page 98 from Saxony and Thuringia.

[91]Waschnitius. See page 103.

[92]Lucy W. Clausen, *Insect Fact and Folklore* (The MacMillan Company: New York 1954), pages 62-63.

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figure, who appears in the winter, is associated with chirping crickets when crickets chirp in warm weather. The explanation might be that the expelling of Perhte/Holle coincides with the eventual return of the sun and longer and warmer days.

Summary

The Perhte/Holle figure is a pre-Christian deity who has been demonized and whose powers have been greatly diminished and limited. The name Perhte probably means "bright, white" and is a cognate of the Irish Saint Briget. Perhte's name and some of the stories attached to her also connect her to the White Woman of Germanic legend. The name Holle probably means "underground, protected, disguised" and is a cognate to the *matronae Hludana*, the Norse goddesses *Hlóðyn* and *Hel*, and the Norwegian *huldre*. Other words that are linguistically related to Holle are hell, hill, and hall. The many supernatural cognates attached to the names of Perhte and Holle show a relationship between supernatural figures and these beings.

The appearance of the Perhte/Holle figure points to a divine origin. The figure can be ugly or beautiful. This dichotomy can be explained by the figure having more than one aspect or function. The figure is often described as having an extremely long nose or an iron nose. This sounds like a beak; and in some processions, the Perhte is protrayed as a bird with a beak and feather robe. The goddess Freyja had an avian form and the ability to fly. The Norse Valkyries, were

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sometimes pictured as birds of prey and had the ability to fly. In Germanic folklore, witches could fly and several protagonists in fairy tales could transform themselves into birds. This long tradition connecting female power with birds is another piece of evidence that points to the divine origin of the Perhte/Holle figure.

The Perhte/Holle figure's ability to control the weather, punish and reward, the food offerings left for her, and the days named for her all indicate her once divine status. The question is what type of deity was she, and what were her powers. These questions lead to a more hypothetical disscussion of the evidence.

The Perhte/Holle figure seems to be almost universally associated with the household, prosperity, and death. The Perhte/Holle figure in pre-Christian times had power over death and the dead. The time of her appearance is winter, especially between Christmas and Three Kings Day, when the dead were supposed to walk on the earth. In many stories surrounding the Perhte/Holle figure, she has a bird-like appearance with a striking long or iron nose. Birds and especially owls have a long association with death in European folklore.

The Perhte/Holle figure travels with a troop of dead, unbaptized children. In these passages, she seems to be in control of a portion of the dead. In some areas, the Perhte/Holle figure targets homes and people not protected by the sign of the cross and kills them. One of the animals associated with her is the dog. Sometimes, dogs replace the children in her retinue. Dogs have long been associated with the goddess of death and often are the guardians of the underworld.

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The Perhte/Holle figure was also probably a goddess of prosperity. Frau Holle travels the countryside in her wagon bringing fertility to the land. Other stories mention the wagon of the Perhte/Holle figure, but they do not state what she is doing with it. The time of her appearance in the dead of winter and the chases and hunts that expel her in the Alpine Area indicate that her appearance coincides with the eventual return of sunlight, warmth, and spring.

The offerings left for the Perhte/Holle figure and the expected reciprocal blessing for a good year are concrete evidence that this figure functioned as a goddess of prosperity. The reward of shavings that turn into gold, which she gives to those who help her, also associates her with wealth and prosperity. Her association with chirping crickets, who only chirp when it is warm are also indicative of her power. The Perhte/Holle figure's powers as a goddess of death and prosperity make her comparable to the Scandinavian goddess Freyja.

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VIII. FUNCTIONS AND CHARACTERISTICS

Female deities in pre-Christian Germanic Europe had several functions. They controlled death and the dead; had bird-like characteristics; used sexuality to promote fertility and prosperity; protected individuals and whole tribes; acted as the ancestresses of individuals, villages, and tribes; had rites connected with winter; controlled the life and death of children; and had connections with the sun. Not all deities did all things at all times, but the continuity of the evidence from our earliest written records to practices in the nineteenth century speaks for the importance of these deities in the daily lives of ordinary people.

Death and the Dead

The evidence indicates a definite relationship between powerful female figures and death and the dead. This relationship often took different directions. Sometimes the female figures appear as the selector or leader of the dead, sometimes they exult in death and carnage, sometimes they cause death, sometimes they demand sacrifice, and sometimes they appear to send the dead off on their final journey.

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Selection of the Dead. *Gylfaginning* states "Half the slain every day she [Freyja] chooses and Oðinn has half."[1] Freyja is presented as the overseer of half of the dead. Freyja is the one who decides who will die and when. Stanza 6 of the poem *Darraðarljóð* states, "Only the Valkyries can choose the slain."[2] In this passage, a different tradition is preserved. Here the Valkyries decide who will die when. Although the two different passages indicate that different beings are in charge of the dead in Norse mythology, they both preserve the idea that it is a feminine power that is in charge of the dead. Even in passages that depict Oðinn as the arbitrator of death, it is the Valkyries who do the dirty work of going to the battlefield and selecting those chosen to die.

Leader of the Dead. In several passages, the female figure does not appear to make a conscious choice of who dies; but she does seem to have a retinue of the dead. In *Gylfaginning*, Gefjun appears to have a following of servants that are dead. In *Gylfaginning*, Snorri states "women who die unmarried serve her [Gefjun]."[3] In chapter 87 of *Egils Saga*, a kenning for death appears to be "to sup with Freyja."[4] In

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[1]See above chapter 3, pages 99-101. *The Prose Edda of Snorri Sturluson*, trans. Jean I. Young, p. 53.

[2]See above chapter 5, pages 187-191. *Njal's Saga*, trans. Magnus Magnusson and Hermann Pálsson, p. 350.

[3]See above chapter 4, page 133. *The Prose Edda*, trans. Jean I Young, p. 59.

[4]See above chapter 4, pages 99-100. *Egil's Saga*, trans. Hermann Pálsson and Paul Edwards, p. 203.

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these two passages, both Gefjun and Freyja are portrayed as having an intimate connection with death. Both apparently theoretically oversee different aspects of death and dying.

A thousand years later in the Southern Germanic Area, Frau Perhte is presented as the leader of a troop of dead, unbaptized children.[5] Frau Perhte is portrayed as moving around the countryside usually during the Twelve Nights with her train of dead children's souls. The portrayal of Perhte as the leader of the non-Christian dead makes a good case for her being the goddess of death or one of the goddesses of death in pagan times. After the advent of Christianity, all of the baptized dead would go to the Christian God. The remaining dead, those who died unbaptized, would still remain under the guardianship of Perhte.

While Freyja and the Valkyries are blatantly selectors of the dead, the kidnapping of children by Frau Perhte, Frau Holle, and other like figures appears to be related to the selection of the dead and the leadership of the dead.[6] When a child was kidnapped by one of these figures, he or she was often never seen or heard from again. Sometimes a distant, brief sighting was made; but the child was too far away to be rescued. The existence of female figures who kidnap children would explain the disappearance of children due to accident or foul play. It might also explain the sudden death of infants and toddlers. The child's "soul" would be stolen and just the

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[5]See above chapter 7, pages 245-247.

[6]See above chapter 7, pages 247-249.

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shell left. The death of infants and young children was a common occurrence before the advent of modern medical technology. Female figures who "stole" and "kept" children, who never appeared again, might have had the same function as Freyja and the Valkyries, who choose who is to die, and as Frau Perhte, the leader of dead children's souls. These figures functioned as bringers of death and leaders of the dead. In other words, they were goddesses of death.

Exultation in Death. In the poem *Darraðarljóð*, the Valkyries portrayed are very bloodthirsty and appear to exult in and enjoy the carnage of war and death.[7] They are weaving the destinies of men, battle, and nations on a loom. The loom weights are the severed heads of men, and the weft and the warp are the intestines of men. In this gory tapestry, they sing about their power to choose who will die and who will win. The depiction of these Valkyries is very disturbing and sinister. They seem to take lives with gleeful abandon.

Almost as disturbing as the depiction of the Valkyries is the ogress in chapter 81 of *Haralds saga Sigurðarsonar*.[8] In this chapter, one of Harald's warriors has a dream about a future battle. He dreams that he sees an ogress riding a wolf in front of the opposing army. In the mouth of the wolf is a dead human carcass. After the wolf eats the carcass, the ogress feeds him another from the battlefield. As she approaches, the ogress sings about the defeat of Harald's army and how she will feed

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[7]See above chapter 5, pages 187-189.

[8]See above chapter 5, pages 189-191.

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her wolf the flesh of fallen warriors. The ogress like the Valkyries seems to take pleasure in death.

In both of these passages, powerful female figures take joy in death and battle; they appear almost crazed. Both passages are pieces of powerful poetry, yet they also seem to contain a kernel of Norse belief. It is powerful female beings who preside over death and decide who dies when.

Ability to Kill. In some areas, the Perhte/Holle figure appears to be the personification of death.[9] In this guise, she searched for people and houses that were not protected by the sign of the cross. She then attempted to kill these unprotected people. In other areas, she would drop a garment, and whoever picked it up would die in the coming year. In these areas, the Perhte/Holle figure had the ability to kill people. The Perhte/Holle figure actively searched for people unprotected by Christianity and killed them.

Death in the form of pestilence is often personified as a woman in folktales. In Norway, the Pest came to Fyr Lake by Svarteland and called for a ferryman. The ferryman took her across the lake and asked for his life in exchange for passage. She checked her book, and he was listed in it. She could not spare his life, but she pointed her staff at him, and he died an immediate and easy death.[10] In this instance

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[9]See above chapter 7, page 260.

[10]Reimund Kvideland and Henning K. Sehmsdorf, eds. *Scandinavian Folk Belief and Legend* (Minneapolis, MN: University of Minneasota Press 1988) #60.2, pg. 345. Collected by Hans Ross in Fyresdal, Telemark (Norway). Ms. in NFS Ross

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the female personifying death does not seem to have control over who dies. She appears to only be the instrument of death. In Vinje in Telemark, the plague took the likeness of a tiny woman. She always carried a broom. Wherever she walked in and swept in front of a door, everyone died. At farms where some were to survive, she would knock on the door with the broom handle as many times as there were people due to die.[11] Here disease travels in the guise of a woman, who methodically kills those destined to die. Once again it is a female being who is intimately bound to death and has control over who dies and how.

Demands Sacrifice. Several female beings appear to demand sacrifice. There are at least two instances that sound suspiciously like sacrifices in the temple of the *dís* or *dísir*.[12] In chapter 29 of *Ynglinga Saga* in *Heimskringla*, King Aðils died while attending the sacrifice to the *dís* in the hall of the *dís*. The king was riding his horse around the hall when the horse stumbled and fell. The king was thrown from the horse, and he hit his head on a rock. The king's skull broke open, and his brain spilled out.[13] The death of a king in the hall of a female deity during a

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17, 105.

[11]Simpson, *Scandinavian Folktales*, (New York: Viking Penguin 1988) pp. 52-53. From Reidar Th. Christiansen, *Norske Sagn*, Oslo (1938) pp. 36-7. Reidar Th. Christiansen, *Migratory Legends* 7085.

[12]See above chapter 5, pages 192-194 and 196-198.

[13]*Heimskringla*, trans. Lee M. Hollander, p. 33-34.

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sacrifice sounds suspiciously like a human sacrifice. Another suspicious event in the hall of the *dísir* takes place in chapter 7 of *Hervarar Saga*. After King Harald dies in battle, his wife goes to the hall of the *dísir* and kills herself. The ritual suicide of a wife after the death of her husband is an Indo-European ritual of great antiquity. This passage sounds suspiciously like ritual suttee offered in sacrifice to the *dísir*. These two passages when taken together suggest that at one time the *dísir* might have demanded human sacrifice.

The death of Þiðrandi is told in two different sources.[14] It is the feast of the winter nights. Þiðrandi's father and other members of his family have converted to Christianity. After the feast, a wise man warns everyone not to answer the door during the night. After everyone is asleep, there is a knock on the door. Þiðrandi opens the door and sees nine armed women clad in black galloping towards him. From the opposite direction, he sees nine armed women clad in white. The women in black reach him first and kill him. The wise man that is present interprets these events to mean that the women in black were *dísir* representing the old religion and the women in white were *dísir* representing the new religion. The black *dísir* killed Þiðrandi as compensation because Þiðrandi's family was converting to Christianity. His death became a last sacrifice to them. Unlike the earlier passages which are

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[14]See above chapter 5, pages 196-197. In chapter 46 of *Njals Saga* and in chapter 23 of *Þiðrandi Þáttr ok Þórhalls*, the *Flateyjarbók* version of *Óláf Saga Tryggvasonar*.

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ambiguous, these passages specifically state that the *dísir* demanded human sacrifice.

The *dísir* were not the only beings to demand human sacrifice. In Eastern Iceland near Middledale in a canyon with clefts up into the mountainside, an ogress lived in a cave. She carried off the best man in Springdale each Christmas. A church was built at the bishop's suggestion as close to the canyon as possible, and the ringing of the church bells drove the ogress away.[15] In this story, a chthonic deity takes an annual human sacrifice at the beginning of winter until the advent of Christianity.

Hundreds of bog bodies, most of which appear to indicate ritual sacrifice, have been found in Germanic Europe.[16] The bog bodies and the evidence of the Nerthus episode in Tacitus might indicate that the bog bodies were sacrificed to a female deity or deities of fertility and peace. The bog bodies, folktales, and the stories surrounding the *dísir* appear to support the existence of a powerful female deity or deities who have the power to demand human sacrifice from the populace.

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[15]Kvideland and Sehmsdorf, eds. *Scandinavian Folk Belief and Legend*, #55.15 "The Church at Ketilsfield," pg. 311. Collected in 1847 by Magnús Grímsson, minister at Mosfelli from schoolboys from Eastern Iceland. Printed in Jón Árnason, *Íslenzkar þjóðsögur og æfintýri* 1 (1862), 151. Reprinted in new edition 1 (1954), 145.

[16]See above chapter 2, pages 55-66.

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Warning of Death. There were beings that appeared to warn a person of impending death. A man's *fylgja* could act as a premonition of death.[17] In *Helgaqviða Hjörvarðzsonar*, a troll-woman who is riding a wolf with snakes for reins meets and exchanges words with Helgi's brother. Helgi's brother tells Helgi about the incident. Helgi interprets the incident to mean that his brother has met Helgi's *fylgja*. This means that Helgi will die soon. In another instance in *Hallfreðar Saga*, Hallfreðr becomes ill at sea. As he slowly dies, a woman appears walking on the water. Hallfreðr realizes that it is his *fylgjukona*, and he ends his relationship with her. In *Draumr Þorsteins Siðu-Hallssonar* and chapter 36 of *Vatnsdœla Saga*, two different Þorsteinns are warned by women in a dream that someone is plotting their deaths. In each of these instances, a female being appeared to these men and either warned them that someone was plotting their deaths or the appearance of the female being itself was a warning of impending death.

Other Connections with Death. Freyja could raise the dead.[18] In *Sörla Þattr*, Oðinn blackmails Freyja by stealing her necklace. He will not return her necklace until she insured perpetual war between two kings. As each warrior was killed, she used her charms to bring the dead back to life. In this way, the battle will rage forever. In this passage, Oðinn, who is considered the most powerful of the gods, can not raise the dead himself. He must resort to blackmail to force Freyja, who has

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[17]See above chapter 5, pages 200-201.

[18]See above chapter 3, pages 100-101.

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the power to raise the dead, to do it for him. Again, it is a powerful female figure who has control over death.

Iðunn has a slight connection with death.[19] She keeps death at bay. Iðunn is the keeper of the apples that the gods eat to give them eternal youth and insure that they do not die of old age. As the keeper of the apples, Iðunn prevents the gods from dying. Iðunn like Freyja appears to have the ability to cheat death.

In *Gylfaginning*, the giantess Þökk has a connection to death.[20] Þökk is the giantess who refuses to cry Baldr out of Hel. After Baldr's death, Hel states that if everything in the world will cry for Baldr, then Baldr can return to the living. Everything in the world cries for Baldr except Þökk. She demands that the dead remain dead. Here Þökk acts as the gatekeeper of death where one can only enter and never exit.

The *matrona Nehalennia* also has a connection with death.[21] The name *Nehalennia* is probably related to the Greek noun *νεκυς* meaning "death," the Latin verb *necare* meaning "to kill," and the Greek word *νεκρός, νέκυς* meaning "corpse."[22] This interpretation would closely connect *Nehalennia*'s name with

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[19]See above chapter 4, pages 138-140.

[20]See above chapter 4, page 155.

[21]See above chapter 6, page 223.

[22]Edgar C. Polomé, "Two Etymological Notes," *Sprachwissenschaftliche Forschungen*, pp. 313-314 and Ferd Detter, "Nahanarvali," *Zeitschrift für deutsches Altertum*, vol. 31, 1887, p. 207-8.

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death. *Nehalennia's* name could mean something like "the dead one." *Nehalennia's* connection with ships and dogs emphasize her relationship with death and the dead. In *Atlamál in groenlenzco*, Gunnar's *dísir* are called "dead women."[23] Both *Nehalennia* and the *dísir* appear to be dead female beings who still have power over the living.

Funerals and the Journey of the Soul. Powerful female figures whether they are goddesses, giantesses, valkyries, troll-women, or ogresses have the power to control death and the dead. Another aspect that they control is the sending of the dead on to the next world. The giantess Hyrrokkin is the only being who can send Baldr's funeral ship on its last journey.[24] All of the Æsir attempted to launch Baldr's ship, but they could not budge it. The *Æsir* send for Hyrrokkin to do the job. She arrives riding a wolf with snakes for reins. She shoves the funeral ship; and with one push, she sends it on its journey. The first half of Hyrrokkin's name is related to the Old Norse noun *hyrr* which means "fire."[25] The second half of her name is probably related to the past participle of the Old Norse verb *rjúka* meaning "to emit smoke, to reek." The name *hyrr-rokinn* probably means something like "fire that has smoked or cooled off." Her name is most likely related to the funeral pyre which smoldered. Hyrrokkin's ability to launch Baldr's funeral ship and her probable relationship with

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[23]See above chapter 5, pages 197-198.

[24]See above chapter 4, pages 162-164.

[25]Lotte Motz, *The Beauty and the Hag*, p. 82.

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the funeral pyre connect her to funerals and the sending of the soul into the next world.

Hyrrokkin's mode of transportation -- a wolf with snakes for reins -- is also used by the troll-women who is Helgi's *fylgja* in *Helgaqviða Hjörvarðzsonar*, and the ogress in *Haralds saga Sigurðarsonar*.[26] The ogress rides a wolf, but there is no mention made of the snakes for reins. There is an engraved image on a stone in Hynnstad in Skåne in southern Sweden of a woman riding a wolf with snakes for reins.(Figure 14) Each of these figures is related to death. Hyrrokkin sends Baldr's funeral ship on its journey, Helgi's fylgja foretells his death, and the ogress feeds the dead to her wolf. The recording of this image in four different sources means that there must have been a belief in a terrifying female figure that rode a wolf with snakes for reins who personified death in Norse tradition.

Hyrrokkin is not the only female figure who seems to be in charge of the funeral and the transcendence of the soul. An Arabic account exists of a funeral of a Rus chieftain on the Volga River. The funeral took place between June 921 and May 922 C.E. The Rus were Scandinavian Vikings that had set up minor kingdoms on the major Russian rivers during the tenth century C.E. The chronicler of the funeral was Ahmed ibn Fadlan, who was on a diplomatic mission for the caliph of Baghdad. Although the Arabs saw the Rus as barbaric savages, there is no reason to doubt the validity of the account.

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[26]See above chapter 5, pages 189-191 and 200.

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At the death of the chieftain, one of his serving girls volunteered to die with him. An old crone called the "Angel of Death" was in charge of the logistics of the funeral. A ship was brought ashore, the dead man was placed on the ship, and an assortment of animals were sacrificed. The serving girl was ritually lifted three times over a structure which resembled a door frame. She stated that she saw her mother, father, and her master in paradise calling for her. The girl was placed on the ship and handed two cups of strong drink to swallow. She was then dragged to her master's side and laid down beside him while held by her hands and feet. The Angel of Death knotted a rope around the girl's neck and handed the ends of the rope to two men to pull. With a broad-blade dagger, the Angel of Death stabbed the girl in the ribs as the two men strangled the girl with the rope until she died. The ship was then set afire.

In the Arabic account, the Angel of Death is in charge of the chieftain's funeral and the ritual sacrifice of the girl. Both the funeral and the sacrifice were apparently needed to send the soul of the chieftain on its final journey. Although more graphic and repelling than the funeral over which Hyrrokkin presides, both Hyrrokkin and the Angel of Death appear to have the same basic function: to insure that the soul of the god/chieftain is set free on its journey to the afterlife.

The connection between powerful female figures and death spanned at least 1000 years. This connection could probably be pushed back further with the inclusion of the deaths of Nerthus's slaves after her annual journey and the bog

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bodies. Female divinities selected who died when, were leaders of the non-Christian dead, could kill people or demand sacrifice, were considered dead, staved off death, and coordinated funerals. The multiplicity of roles played by female divinities in regard to death and the dead and the time span of the belief reinforce the idea that female deities were intimately connected with death and the dead. Before the advent of Christianity in the Germanic Area, the deity that presided over death and the dead was female.

The Bird Woman

The evidence clearly indicates the existence of a female deity or deities who were either part human and part bird, could transform themselves into birds, or could fly through the air.

Feather Coats and Swan Skins. We are told in *Þrymskviða* and *Skáldskaparmál* that Freyja has a feather coat.[27] Although we never hear of her using it, she does allow other deities to borrow it. Þórr and Loki have to borrow her feather coat when they want to transform themselves into birds because they do not possess one themselves. Freyja's feather coat seems to have been some kind of garment that when worn, it transformed the wearer into a bird. Another name for Freyja is Mardöll.[28] The name Mardöll could be related to the Old Norse noun *marr*

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[27]See above chapter 3, pages 101-102.

[28]See above chapter 3, page 119.

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which can mean "mew." A mew is a type of sea gull. This would give Freyja the ability to turn herself into a bird, and one of her names would be the name of a bird.

Freyja is not the only powerful female figure with a feather coat.[29] The Valkyries in *Völundarkviða* have swan skins that they can take off. Three men find three Valkyries sitting on the shore of a lake weaving flax with their swan skins lying beside them. The men take the Valkyries swan skins, and the Valkyries go home with them. In the poem *Helreið Bryhildar*, Brunhild talks about her and her sisters' feather cloaks. The *Hávamál*, which is a collection of wise and witty sayings, mentions a similar type of skin. The author states that he can sing spells that send witches who are sailing through the sky off their course because they lose their skins. This seems to mean that witches, like Freyja and other powerful female figures, are believed to have some type of skin or piece of clothing that allow them to fly. A similar motif is found in the folktale "The Drummer." In "The Drummer," a man finds three pieces of linen lying beside a lake; and he takes one home with him. That night, an enchanted princess begs the man to return her little blouse, so she can fly back to the mountain with her sisters. The Valkyries, Brunhild, the witches, and the enchanted princess appear to have the same type of garment as Freyja.

This tradition of a powerful female figure owning a piece of clothing that transforms her into a bird seems to be widespread in the sources. The feather cloak,

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[29]See above chapter 3, pages 102-105.

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feather coat, or swan skin seems to be the "logical" explanation why certain women can fly and have an avian form and others can not. There might also be another connection with this idea of a magic cloak or skin. The *matronae Saitchamiae*'s name might mean something like "the ones with the magical skin."[30] This would create a tenuous relationship with this matronae and Freyja, the Valkyries, Brunhild, the witches, and the enchanted princess mentioned above. All would possess a magical garment that could transform a person into a bird.

Women with Avian Characteristics. There are female figures that have other avian characteristics. Frau Perhte and Frau Holle are both described as having a strikingly long nose which is often described as an iron nose.[31] A long iron nose sounds suspiciously like a beak. The masked processions in the Alpine Area often include *Schnabelpercht* "beaked Percht" and *Vogelpercht* "bird Percht." The existence of these masked beings reinforce the relationship between the Perhte/Holle figure and birds. The giantess Margerð[32] in *Hjalmþes saga ok Ölvis* has a nose and claws of iron. Like Perhte's and Holle's iron nose, this sounds like a beak and talons. Again there seems to be a tradition of powerful women who had beaks like birds.

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[30]See above chapter 6, page 219.

[31]See above chapter 7, pages 237-239.

[32]The name Margerð, like the name Mardöll, might be related to the Old Norse noun *marr* meaning "sea gull." This would also link Margerð with birds.

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Transformation into Bird Form. There are several stories about women who turn themselves into birds. In one set of stories, a hunter shoots a goose or duck.[33] When the hunter finds where the shot bird fell, he finds a wounded woman. The implication in these stories is that the women were witches who had turned themselves into birds; and when they were shot, they reverted back to human form.

In Icelandic Sagas, a tradition of women being able to turn themselves into birds exists. In *Völsunga saga*, the daughter of the giant Hrimnir turned herself into a crow; and in *Hjálmþes saga*, the giantesses Skinnhúfa and Vargeisa turned themselves into vultures. In these sagas, giantesses are able to transform themselves into birds and fly.

In the folktale "Fletcher's Bird," the heroine escapes the clutches of a serial killer by rolling in honey and feathers.[34] In this disguise as a bird, she is able to escape the house and even meets the killer on the street; but he does not recognize her. In the two folktales "The White Bride and the Black Bride" and "The Three Little Men in the Woods," a queen transforms herself into a duck as she is drowning. Later in the story, the bird is either beheaded or has a sword swung over its head; and the queen reappears in the bird's place. In these stories, women are able to transform themselves into birds in times of trouble and danger and are able to escape .

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[33]See above chapter 3, pages 105-106.

[34]See above chapter 3, pages 112-118.

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Birds and Death. The existence of the belief of powerful female beings who could turn themselves into birds or who were partially bird-like is evident from the above passages. Much of the evidence indicates that these bird-like women had a tangible connection with death. Freyja controls half of the dead and owns a feather coat. Valkyries have swan skins and choose who dies when. Frau Perhte has a long, iron nose; and she is the leader of a troop of the souls of dead, unbaptized children. In the folktale, "Fletcher's Bird," a girl disguises herself as a bird after she resurrects her two sisters by piecing together their scattered body parts and placing a skull in the window wearing a crown of flowers to fool the evil villain and the townspeople into thinking it is she. In the two folktales "The White Bride and the Black Bride" and "The Three Little Men in the Woods," the queen transforms herself into a duck as she is drowning. She is transformed back into a woman either when the duck's head is cut off or when a sword is swung over the duck's head. The multiplicity of the connections between female bird beings and death indicates a strong and continual association between powerful female beings who could turn themselves into birds at death.

Sexuality, Fertility, and Prosperity

Sexuality, fertility, and prosperity are all related. Prosperity is wealth. In agricultural societies, wealth is abundant food to eat with enough left over to stock up for the winter and to trade or sell for other goods. Abundant crops and healthy farm animals that produce milk, eggs, wool, and offspring make a farm prosperous.

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The production of abundant crops and healthy and numerous farm animals are all aspects of fertility. Farms are also prosperous if they have healthy, strong, and low-cost labor. The more sons one had for working the fields and tending livestock and the more daughters one had for milking, making cheese and yogurt, drying, pickling, curing, and making cloth the more prosperous the farm became. The land, animals, and people of the farm had to be fertile. It is impossible to be fertile without sex. Sexuality and fertility lead to prosperity in an agricultural society.

Sexuality, fertility, and prosperity are three characteristics that describe many of the female deities in the Germanic Area. Freyja has been accused of rampant sexuality that has nothing to do with fertility.[35] I think that the separation between fertility and sexuality is a late twentieth century phenomenon and not an aspect of the sources. We live in a time where effective birth control is easy, cheap, and readily available. While there were probably techniques and herbs used with the hope of preventing conception, nothing was very certain or continually effective in the past. In other words, until the late twentieth century; sex often led to conception and children. Sex and fertility were always linked. One reason that Freyja's sexuality is mentioned a lot but nothing is mentioned of fertility is partially a problem of our sources. It must be remembered that we only have a small amount of information about Norse religion. Most of what we do know has been filtered

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[35]Lotte Motz, *The Beauty and the Hag*, pp. 100-101.

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through a male audience who were probably more interested in hearing about Freyja's sexual escapades than about how her escapades impacted fertility.

Sexuality. Freyja is accused of incest with her brother, having sex with all of the *Æsir*, trading sexual favors for a necklace, and screwing around like a nanny goat.[36] Most of the major Norse goddesses are accused of having illicit sex. Frigg became the wife of Óðinn's two brothers when Óðinn was late in returning from a trip.[37] Gefjun is accused of having sex with a youth in return for a necklace.[38] Sif and Skaði[39] are accused of having an adulterous affair with Loki. The major Norse goddesses are portrayed as sexual beings. Their sexuality is characterized in the sources as amoral. They break the standard moral codes of incest and marital fidelity.

Fertility. There seems to be a tradition of annual processions which apparently took place in the winter. Annual journeys around the countryside apparently to promote peace, fertility, and prosperity have been periodically

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[36]See above chapter 3, pages 73-78. In chapter 4 of *Ynglinga Saga* in *Heimskringla*, stanzas 30-32 of the *Lokasenna, Sorla Þattr, and Hyndluljóð.*

[37]See above chapter 4, pages 127-128. In stanza 26 of *Lokasenna* and in chapter 3 of *Ynglinga Saga* in *Heimskringla.*

[38]See above chapter 4, page 134. In stanzas 20-21 of the *Lokasenna.*

[39]See above chapter 4, pages 146-147 and 157-158. In stanzas 51-54 in the *Lokasenna.*

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recorded in the sources since Tacitus's mention of Nerthus in the first century C.E.[40] There are several stories that mention Freyr traveling around the countryside, a statue of Berecynthia was carted around the city of Autun in France in the sixth century, and a *daemon* was taken town to town west of Cologne in the twelfth century. The deity in this wagon ritual could apparently be either male or female. The important part of the ritual was not the sex of the deity, but the presence of the deity to bless the fields, homes, and endeavors of the worshippers. As late as the nineteenth century, Frau Holle was said to annually travel around the countryside bestowing fertility on the fields.[41] Nerthus and Frau Holle are chronologically almost 2000 years apart; however, the same basic belief appears to continue.

Similar to Nerthus and Holle is the plowing of Zealand by Gefjun.[42] Gefjun carved out Zealand from Sweden and then placed the island in its present position. She created a new land.[43] This creation of land is itself a type of fertility and prosperity.

Offerings for Fertility/Prosperity. The Perhte/Holle figure was left offerings of food in the winter.[44] A reciprocal arrangement often existed between the offerer

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[40]See above chapter 2, pages 43-52.

[41]Donald Ward, *The Legends of the Brothers Grimm*, Legend #4.

[42]See above chapter 4, pages 32-33.

[43]In *Gylfaginning* and in chapter 5 of *Ynglinga Saga* in *Heimskringla.*

[44]See above chapter 7, pages 251-255.

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and the Perhte/Holle figure. If the food was touched or gone; then she would bless the house, it would be a good year, she would remain in a good mood, or it was a good sign. Sometimes the ritual was more complicated; for example, in Waidhofen an Ybbs, one had to serve the offered milk to the cows and to the chickens to insure that they would give milk and eggs in the coming year. The offerings of food seem to have been offerings to the deity of prosperity for continuance of good fortune in the coming year.

Prosperity. The Norse goddesses have several connections with wealth and prosperity. Freyja is surrounded by the imagery of opulence and prosperity.[45] She always wears the beautiful and shining *Brísingamen*. She has two daughters. Their names are Hnoss and Gersemi: both names mean jewel.[46] We are told that Freyja wept tears of gold; in fact, "Freyja's tears" is a kenning for gold. Sif has hair that is pure gold.[47] Not only is her hair valuable in its own right, the color is reminiscent of the beard of wheat or tow. The goddess Fulla has a name that means plenty and is related to abundance.[48] These goddesses are all connected to wealth and prosperity. The evidence indicates a goddess or goddesses who, when pacified, distribute all of the things that make life pleasurable and comfortable.

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[45]See above chapter 3, pages 79-80.

[46]Snorri Sturluson, *Heimskringla*, trans. Lee M. Hollander, p. 14.

[47]See above chapter 4, page 157.

[48]See above chapter 4, page 159.

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The iconography of the *matronae* is full of the imagery of abundance.[49] The goddesses often sit with baskets of eggs, apples, pears, quinces, and loaves of bread in their laps. There are usually trees and foliage on the backs and sides of these monuments. The abundance of the fields, orchards, and livestock are all prominent in the iconography of the monuments. The iconography of the *matronae* indicates that at least one of their functions was connected to the continuance of agricultural abundance.

Many of the *matronae* appear to have names that are connected with the promotion of fertility and prosperity. Several *matronae* names contain the root *gabi-* meaning "give".[50] The *matronae Gabiae, Alagabiae*, and *Garmangabis* mean "the Givers," "the Givers of Everything," and "the German Givers." One of Freyja's names is Gefn which is related to the name of the goddess Gefjun. Both Gefn and Gefjun mean "the Giver." The functions of these two Norse goddesses and these *matronae* were probably very similar. The evidence indicates a close relationship between female deities and the fertility and prosperity of fields, animals, and humans.

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[49]See above chapter 6, page 210.

[50]See above chapter 6, pages 214-217.

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Ancestors, Protection

Protection. There are many connections between powerful female figures, the ancestors, and protection. Some female figures are very protective of certain individuals, families, or areas. Some Valkyries show a special preference for a particular hero and apparently foster him and protect him in battle.[51] The hero Helgi in the poem *Helgakviða Hjörvarðzsonar* rarely spoke, did not have a name, and did not show any sign of future greatness before he met the Valkyrie Svava. She gave him his name, told him where to find his wonderful sword, and protected him in battle. After this Helgi's death, there was another hero born named Helgi, who was called Helgi reborn. This Helgi's story is told in the poems *Helgakviða Hundingsbana in fyrri* and *Helgakviða Hundingsbana önnor*. He also had a Valkyrie who protected him in battle. Her name was Sigrun. Both Helgis are protected in battle by a Valkyrie and the first Helgi is fostered by a Valkyrie.

Frigg is a protective being in some of the sources.[52] In *Gylfaginning*, Frigg attempted to protect Baldr by making everything on earth promise not to harm him after he dreamed of his own death. Although Frigg's attempt at protecting Baldr failed, the effort of the attempt marks her as a protective deity.

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[51]See above chapter 5, pages 178-186.

[52]See above chapter 4, pages 129-131.

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In some of the stories about the *dísir*, they appear in times of danger to protect an individual.[53] In both chapter 8 of *Ásmundar Saga Kappabana* and chapter 15 of *Hálfs Saga*, a warrior brags about his protective *dísir* and how they will allow him to win the upcoming battle. In chapter 22 of *Þorsteins Saga Víkingssonar*, a man lends his *dísir* to a friend to insure his friend's safety on a journey. A person's *dísir* protected him in battle and on journeys. The Valkyries of the Helgi poems, Frigg, and the *dísir* all appear to have a protective function. They all attempt to prevent harm from falling on their chosen companions or family.

Ancestors. *Fylgjas* often seem to be attached to a particular family. When an individual dies or is near death, often his *fylgja* will appear to a close male family member; brother, son, or grandson; and ask to be accepted as that person's *fylgja*.[54] This attachment to a particular family implies that the *fylgja* was hereditary and was inherited by a family member after death. In a few passages the *dísir* are called "dead women". This implies that they might be the ancestors of the person they protect.[55] Many of the *matronae* have names that reflect the name of the tribe. The *matronae* named for a particular tribe were probably considered to be the

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[53]See above chapter 5, pages 195-196.

[54]See above chapter 5, pages 199-201. In chapter 11 of *Hallfreðar Saga, Draumr Þorsteins Síðu-Hallssonar*, and in chapter 36 of *Vatnsdœla Saga.*

[55]See above chapter 5, pages 197-198. In the Eddic poem *Atlamál in groenlenzco.*

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ancestresses of the tribe.[56] Their functions were probably concerned with the protection of the tribe and the continuing prosperity and fertility of its members. The *fylgjas*, *dísir*, and some of the *matronae* appear to be the ancestresses of a particular family or tribe.

The Future

The ability to foresee the future is important in the sources, not only for deities but also for ordinary women.[57] The ability to make accurate prophecies was a talent that was respected, and the women who could make prophecies gained wealth and power. Freyja was the deity who taught the Æsir the magic of *seiðr*.[58] While *seiðr* encompasses many different practices, one of the main practices was the divining of the future. Freyja taught Oðinn the art of *seiðr*, but it was shameful for men to practice it. In chapter 7 of *Ynglinga Saga*, we are told that priestesses were taught this magic. There are several instances in the sagas where the prophecy of the

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[56]See above chapter 6, pages 211-212. *Matres Frisiavae paternae:* "Mothers of the ancestors of the Frisians," *Matres paternae Hiannanef:* "the Mothers of the ancestors of the Kannanefates," *Matres Suebae:* "the Mothers of the Swabians," *Matres Treverae*: "the Mothers of the Treveri," *Matres Vangiones*: "the Mothers of the Vangiones," *Matribus Suebis Sidinis:* "to the Swabian Sidinae Mothers," and *Matres Hamavehae*: "the Mothers of the Chamavi."

[57]See above chapter 3, pages 80-98.

[58]In chapter 4 of *Ynglinga Saga* in *Heimskringla.*

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future is mentioned. In the Norse sources, this prophecy was almost always by a *völva* who practiced *seiðr.*[59]

Other women had the ability to foresee the future, but no mention of *seiðr* is given. Frigg and Gefjun are both said to have the ability to see the future.[60] The seeress Veleda foretold the victories of the Germans over the Romans.[61] Classical authors mention Veleda, Aurinia, Ganna, and a Chattian woman.[62] All of these Germanic women supposedly were able to foretell future events. Other Germanic women were able to see the future by observing the ripples in water or in blood pouring from beheaded prisoners.[63] Gregory of Tours and Saxo Grammaticus mention several instances of women who had reputations for accurately predicting the future.[64]

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[59]In stanza 9-13 of *Völuspá*, chapter 2 of *Örvar-Odds Saga*, and chapter 3 of *Eiríks Saga Rauði.*

[60]See above chapter 4, pages 128-129 and 134-135. In the *Gylfaginning* and stanzas 20-21 and 29 of the *Lokasenna.*

[61]In chapter 8 of the *Germania* and Book 4, Chapter 65 of Tacitus's *The Histories.*

[62]In Chapter 8 of the *Germania*, Cassius Dio (67.5.3), and Chapter 14 of *Vitellius* by Suetonius.

[63]In Chapter 19 of *Julius Caesar* by Plutarch and book 7, chapter 2 of *Geography* by Strabo.

[64]*The History of the Franks*: book 8 section 31 and book 5, section 14. *Gesta Danorum*: book 9.

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Foretelling the future was not only the attribute of the deity, but it was also a skill that ordinary women could attain. Most of the women who predicted the future appear to be ordinary in every other way. These women were the functional descendants of the goddesses who had the ability to look into the future and foretell events.

Winter

Many of the female figures in the Germanic Area have rites associated with winter, appear in the winter, have control over the weather, or have names associated with winter. In Northern Europe, winter lasted a long time with a short spring and fall. The constant worry about food supplies, illness, and livestock were probably only aggravated by the constant cold, wet, and darkness. With miserable, long winters, it is not surprising that deities were worshipped for relief and a return of warmth and light.

Offerings. Offerings were made to the *dísir* in the winter months at the *dísablót*.[65] The *dísablót* or sacrifice to the *dísir* probably took place at the beginning of winter or late fall.[66] During the *dísablót* a woman seems to have presided over the

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[65]See above chapter 5, pages 193-195.

[66]In chapter 44 of *Egils Saga* and in chapter 6 of *Víga Glúms Saga*. See *The Road to Hel*, Hilda Ellis Davidson states that this *dísablót* took place at the beginning of winter (page 136) and Jan de Vries, in his book *Altgermanische Religionsgeschichte*, states that this *dísablót* took place in mid-October (§528).

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reddening of the altar with blood.[67] Feasting and drinking also seem to be an integral part of the this rite. The *dísaþing* or assembly of the *dísir* was held in Sweden in February until at least the sixteenth century. In the sixteenth century, a *þing* and market were held in the name of the *dísir* at Candlemas in February.[68]

The *dísir* are not the only beings offered sacrifice in the winter months. Until the nineteenth century, Frau Perhte and her troop of the souls of dead children were left food offerings in return for promises of a good year.[69] These offerings were usually left between Christmas Eve and the sixth of January when Frau Perhte and her children were known to be wandering around the countryside. The Perhte/Holle figure was so closely associated with winter that the sixth of January in many areas took this being's name: *Perhtennacht* and *Frau Hollenabend.* Processions through villages or whole areas also took place at this time.[70] These processions included loud noises, singing, dancing, the harassment of young women of marriageable age, and sometimes the expulsion of the Perhte/Holle figure. The rites of these processions seem to be tied up with the expulsion of winter and the hastening of spring. The offerings to the *dísir* in Scandinavia and to the Perhte

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[67]In the introduction of *Hervar's Saga.*

[68]Lotte Motz, *The Beauty and the Hag*, pp. 70-71.

[69]See above chapter 7, pages 251-255.

[70]See above chapter 7, pages 261-265.

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figure in the Southern Germanic Area indicate that there was a tradition of sacrifice to a female being or beings in winter.

Control of the Weather. Some female figures could control the weather. A common folk saying in Central Germany is "When it snows, Frau Holle makes/shakes her bed."[71] This saying and others like it credit Frau Holle with control over the weather. Frau Holle is not the only figure who can make it storm. Þorgerðr Hölgabruðr would not give her disciple Earl Hákon help in a battle until he offered to sacrifice his own son; then she caused a huge hail storm and shot arrows from every finger.[72] Due to her intervention, Earl Hákon won the battle. Motz mentions two other episodes when female figures control the weather: the giantess Tögld sent a storm and fog to draw Illugi to her shore and it began to snow when troll women approached Grímr's boat.[73] This evidence again suggests that there was a female being or beings who were connected with the winter months.

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[71]See above chapter 7, pages 242-244. Waschnitius. See pages 92-93 from Schleusingen, Schmalkalden, Ilmenau, Ostheim, and Meiningen in Hesen. See page 93 from Nassau. See page 96 from Münden in the Principality of Waldeck. See pages 111-112 from Thuringia and the Gotting Land. See page 113, from Lerbach at Klaustal in the Harz. Also see Donald Ward, *The Legends of the Brothers Grimm*, legend 4.

[72]See above chapter 4, pages 159-162.

[73]Lotte Motz, "The Divided Image: A Study of the Giantesses and Female Trolls in Norse Myth and Literature," *The Mankind Quarterly*, 1987, p. 471-472. She cites *Illuga saga Tagldarbana* and *Grims saga loðinkinna.*

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The names and characteristics of some female figures were connected with winter and snow. The names of the giantesses Fönn, Drífa, and Mjöll all mean "snow." The name of the giantess Hrímgerðr contains the word for "frost," and the name of the giantess Gói is also the name of the Scandinavian month that fell roughly between January 15 and February 15.[74] In *Gylfaginning*, the goddess Skaði lived high in the mountains, went around on skis, and was called the "Snowshoe Goddess." Skaði's name is a masculine noun meaning "loss, damage" in Old Norse.[75] The meaning of her name might be linked to the power of winter with its blizzards; food shortages; and in the northern regions, minimal sunlight.

The evidence indicates a long tradition of powerful female figures associated with winter. The offerings left for the *dísir* and the Perhte/Holle figure; the time of the appearance of the Perhte/Holle figure; Frau Holle's, Þorgerðr's, and other giantesses' control of winter weather; and the names meaning snow and associated with winter all indicate that a female being or beings were worshiped at a winter festival that was probably associated with the return of spring and the expulsion of winter. Since both the *dísir* and the Perhte/Holle figure also have many connections with death, this female being probably was associated with winter and the

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[74]Lotte Motz, "The Winter Goddess: Percht, Holda, and Related Figures," *Folklore*, v. 95, 1984, p. 162.

[75]See above chapter 4, pages 141-147.

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renewal/return of spring and fertility and with death and the chaotic return of the dead in winter.

Winter was the time of the death of vegetation, people, and animals. Those beings who could not survive the food shortages, cold, and disease perished. The dead were thought to return to earth and wander the countryside during the Twelve Nights. These facts coupled with the hope for a return of spring, light, and fertility were all embodied in the female being or beings whose festival or rites were celebrated in the winter.

Children

Children had little connection with the major Norse goddesses; however, powerful female figures were closely related to children especially the Norns and the Perhte/Holle figure. The Norns came to each child at birth and decided its fate.[76] A belief in women who came at the birth of a child must have been deep and continuous since in the eleventh century, Burchard the Bishop of Worms ordered those who believed in the *Parcae* to be punished. The *Parcae* came at the time of a child's birth and predicted the future of the child. The *Parcae* were apparently given offerings since the Bishop of Worms also forbad women to keep a covered table

[76]See above chapter 5, pages 170-172. In *Gylfaginning,* stanzas 17-18 of the poem *Völuspá* and stanzas 2-4 of the poem *Helgakviða Hundingsbana in fyrri.*

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ready for the *Parcae* at certain times of the year.[77] The *Parcae* in continental Europe and the Norns in Scandinavia seem to be extremely similar in function. Both attended a child at birth and determined the child's future.

Birth visits were not always so benevolent. The Perhte/Holle figure would sometimes come at or soon after the birth of a child.[78] She would then exchange the healthy, unbaptized child for one of her own.[79] The Perchte/Holle figure was not the only one to exchange children at or near birth. In Saalfeld and Dessau, the Earth woman and two women from the Underground exchanged their children for newborns.[80]

The Perhte/Holle figure had a connection with unborn children.[81] Unborn children were kept by the Perhte/Holle figure in vats of water or in a cave. A woman who wanted a child but could not conceive went to her.[82] Another "fertility clinic" was located at Mother Holla's pond in Hessen. Women who climbed into her spring

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[77]See above chapter 5, page 174. Jan de Vries, *Altgermanische Religionsgeschichte* v. 2, § 530.

[78]See above chapter 7, pages 247-249.

[79]Waschnitius. See page 40-41 from the district of Nassereith in Tirol and page 96 from the Principality of Waldeck.

[80]Donald Ward, *The Legends of the Brothers Grimm*, legends 90 and 91.

[81]See above chapter 7, pages 250-251.

[82]Waschnitius. For keeping unborn children in water vats in the mountains, see page 34 from Lusern in Tirol. For living in a cave with small pure children, see page 35 from Lusern in Tirol.

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were made healthy and fertile. Holle was also said to deliver new born children from her well.[83] The Perhte/Holle figure in these passages is portrayed as a giver of fertility. She keeps unborn children in suspended animation until they are born.

After the children had been born and baptized, there was still the possibility that they would be taken by the Perhte/Holle figure or other like beings. If children were lazy, disobedient, or obstinate; they were threatened with the possibility of being kidnapped or punished by the Perhte/Holle figure.

Frau Perhte was the leader of a troop of dead children.[84] These children died without being baptized. Offerings were sometimes left for Perhte and her children in exchange for a promise of a good year. The Perhte/Holle figure's control over the lives of children is probably a weak reflection of the power she once wielded over the lives of all humans. Children, who were not old enough to accept the teachings of the church, were not yet considered Christian beings and were more vulnerable to non-Christian forces such as the Perhte/Holle figure.

Motz[85] has suggested that the Perhte/Holle figure functioned as a nursemaid, and this may be true to some extent; however, the nursemaid argument is only effective for Perhte's punishment of bad children and reward of good children. This

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[83]Donald Ward, *The Legends of the Brothers Grimm*, legend 4.

[84]See chapter 7, pages 245-247.

[85]"Surrounded by a group of children, not her own, she [Perhte] functions as a nurse and a foster-mother to the young, the kind of being that in Greek tradition bears the name: Kourotorphos." Lotte Motz, *The Beauty and the Hag*, p. 129.

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figure kept groups of children who were unborn and who were dead.[86] Children, who had yet to be born or who had only lived a short time and had died, stay with her. The implication might be that these children who have died young have the potential to be born again. Children are potentiality. Children who die young have not had a chance to use that potentiality. The Perhte/Holle figure might provide a way to recycle the unspent potentiality of the dead children. The Perhte/Holle figure was not fundamentally a nursemaid. She was a deity in charge of the continuous cycle of birth-death-birth.

Solar

A few of the female figures in the Germanic Area appear to function as solar deities. Both Perhte and Gerðr have aspects of their behavior or characteristics that seem to reflect a connection with the sun and light. The name of the Perhte/Berhte figure can be derived from the Indo-European **bherg-t-*. Cognates in Germanic languages are Gothic *baírhts* meaning " pale, shining, clear"; Old High German *beraht* and Middle High German *berht*, both meaning "shining"; and Old English *beorght* meaning "bright". [87] The name Perhte is probably related to the name Briget, the Irish Saint and Celtic Goddess. Both Perhte and Briget probably mean "the bright one, the shining one, or the white one." Perhte's appearance in the winter

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[86]See above chapter 7, pages 245-251.

[87]See above chapter 7, pages 229-233 and 237.

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is usually on or around Three King's Day (January 6) near the winter solstice, which is the time when the sun shines for the fewest hours in the year.[88] Her annual appearance, the offerings left for her, and the processions connected with her while related to death and prosperity are also related to the solar cycle. The beautiful Perhtes probably represent in one aspect the expected return of the sun; and by sympathetic magic, the Perhte processions probably insure the return of "the bright one" --the sun-- for the coming year.

Related to Perhte in many ways is the White Woman of Germanic folklore. In some legends, the White Woman is even given Perhte as a first name or called Frau Holle.[89] The White Woman almost always is either dead or enchanted. Her ghostly appearance is sometimes connected to unclaimed treasure. She promises the secret to great treasure if a person can undo the enchantment that holds her. In other stories, she is the nursemaid to royal children. The White Woman's name, her connection with death, her promises of treasure, and her connection with children all link her closely to the Perhte/Holle figure. Both appear to be related reflections of a previous deity who controlled the cyclic aspect of human life, agricultural life, and the seasons. In other words, she was both winter and the sun; and she controlled death, birth, and rebirth.

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[88]See above chapter 7, pages 239-242.

[89]Donald Ward, The Legends of the Brothers Grimm, Legends #4 and 268.

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In Norse mythology, the goddess Gerðr seems to be a solar deity.[90] She is described as lighting the sea, the sky, and the world by raising her arms. To reach Gerðr, one had to ride through a ring of fire.[91] It has been argued that her name means "enclosure."[92] This has led to interpreting her as a fertility deity of the field.[93] Nothing in the myth that we have about Gerðr has anything to do with fertility or prosperity; in fact, Gerðr has to be continually threatened with unbearable torture and a life of misery before she will agree to have sex with Freyr. While I agree that Gerðr's name means "enclosure," I do not interpret it to mean that she is a fertility deity. I think that the enclosure alluded to is the enclosure of the ring of fire around her domain. She is the fiery sun, who lights the sky, the sea, and the earth. She is the solar goddess who marries the fertility god.

Conclusions

The functions of pre-Christian Germanic female deities are all intimately related to one another. Even seemingly totally opposite functions and rites are actually fundamentally related. It is difficult to pull apart these functions and categorize them without losing perspective on how the functions are interrelated.

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[90]See above chapter 4, pages 147-154.

[91]In stanzas 6 and 8 of *Skírnismáll* and in *Gylfaginning*.

[92]Jan de Vries, *Altnordisches Etymologisches Wörterbuch*, p. 164.

[93]ibid., p. 164.

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The easiest explanation of the functions of the pre-Christian Germanic female deities would be LIFE. Life meaning the ecosystem of the earth and its relationship and influence on human and agricultural life. This answer, however, understates the complexity of these deities.

These deities controlled the weather and sunlight on the earth. By controlling the weather and sunlight, they controlled the agricultural cycle. The agricultural year is symbolic for human life and death. A person is born from darkness into a world of light. As a child, a person grows quickly and is full of delight at the world. A person marries and has children and provides for his children with food, warmth, and protection. As a person grows older, he slows down, is ill frequently, loses friends and family to death, and finally he dies perhaps to be reborn again. A more elegant description of the pagan conception of life is found in book 2, chapter 13 of Bede's *The History of the English Church and People*. Bede compares a pagan life to a bird flying through the hall. A bird comes out from the cold and flies into a hall. In the hall, there are light, warmth, friendship, and happiness. As the bird flies through, he leaves out of another window into darkness and cold. People are born from darkness into light and then they die into darkness. Since the seasonal cycle repeats itself endlessly, the human cycle was probably perceived as an endless cycle of birth - death - birth.

The aspects of these deities that have been best preserved after centuries of Christianity are those relating to death. While the other functions are definitely

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represented in our sources, the deity's many connections with death are unquestionable. The reasons why this connection with death continued even after others had faded are many. First of all, Christianity took over the functions of life. Christ and the saints were turned to to provide basic sustenance and for emotional support. Secondly, death is a continuing factor in life. While today we are usually only confronted with death occasionally, the shorter life span, danger of childbirth, high infant and child mortality rate, and the lack of modern medical knowledge made death a frequent occurrence in every life. The relatively frequent deaths of friends and family had to be reconciled in some way. Someone or something had to be blamed. Instead of blaming the Christian God for tragedy, many still clung to a pagan conception of death where powerful female beings were to blame. Thirdly, the dead are dangerous to the living. They must be treated correctly and certain rituals must be observed. The rituals of death within a family or village were very conservative as to not annoy or disturb the dead.

The interrelationship of these beliefs can be seen in the functions of these deities. They are both the winter and the sun. They control death, yet they monitor birth. The deities that appear in the darkest point of winter were probably also the signal of the coming spring and the renewal of life. At the same time, these beings also represented death in all of its aspects and controlled the dead. Offerings to these deities provided fertility and prosperity in the coming year. These deities were both benevolent and merciless. They were generous givers and at the same time the

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brings of death, disease, and loss. The multiple facets of these deities make them difficult to pin down and to simply state their functions.

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IX. ORIGINS

Where did belief in the female figures discussed in this work originate? At least three possibilities exist. They could be part of the Germanic inheritance from Indo-European culture and religion. They could be the remnants of the Old European female oriented religion of Eastern Europe. They could be the result of centuries of contact, trade, and intermarriage with the neighboring Celtic tribes, who had a strong and continuous female element to their religion.

Indo-European Inheritance

Are these female figures inherited from Proto-Indo-European culture according to the classical Dumézilian model? In his book *Archaic Roman Religion*, Dumézil analyzes the function of the Indo-European goddess as an entity "who assumes and reconciles all three [functions], and who constitutes the very ideal of woman in society."[1] This definition of the functions of the Indo-European goddess is all inclusive. She is apparently everything. She encompasses all three functions of the tripartite divisions of Indo-European society: sovereignty or the priestly/legal function, military or the warrior function, and fertility or the herder/cultivator

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[1]Georges Dumézil, *Archaic Roman Religion*, trans. Philip Krapp, (Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 1970), p. 300.

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function. Within the context of Germanic religion, this is difficult to conclusively argue.

The main Germanic goddesses exhibit characteristics of sexuality, prosperity, and fertility that place them firmly in the third function of Dumézil's system. This would include the overt sexuality of Freyja and her many connections with prosperity and wealth; the sexual peccadilloes of Frigg, Gefjun, Sif, and Skaði; and the prosperity implied in the names Gefjun, Gefn, *Gabiae, Alagabiae*, and *Garmangabis*.[2]

While several Germanic female figures have connections with death, only a few have specific connections with war. Freyja receives half of the battle dead each day, but she does not appear to have any control over warriors or war itself. Only in one obscure story does Freyja incite war between two fractions, and she does this at the instigation of Óðinn.[3] The Valkyries control who lives and dies in war and often support particular warriors over others. The same function appears to be filled by the *dísir* of particular individuals.[4] The connection of these beings to the second function in Dumézil's triad is tenuous.

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[2]See above chapter 3, pages 73-80; chapter 4, pages 127-128, 134-135, 146-147, and 157-158; and chapter 6, pages 214-215.

[3]See above chapter 3, pages 99-101.

[4]See above chapter 5, pages 175-192 and 192-199.

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All of these figures are, in general, more concerned with the death aspect of war or an ancestral or familial relationship with a particular warrior than with the fighting or war itself. The connections with death are much more evident than those with war. Aside from Freyja, the Valkyries, and the *dísir* mentioned above; Hel was the goddess of the underworld, Ran received all of the people who drowned, women who died unmarried went to Gefjun, the Perhte/Holle figure could kill people, and the goddess Nehalennia's name might be a cognate of words meaning "death" and "corpse."[5] Instead of connecting these beings to the military/warrior function, this connection with death only emphasizes their third function identity since death is a natural aspect of fertility and part of the continual agricultural and life cycle.

The first function of Dumézil's tripartite system is the legal/priestly function. It could be argued that the practice of *seiðr* and the tradition of prophecy connected with this tradition might be related to the priestly function. Freyja taught *seiðr* to the *Æsir* and to women. Women who practiced *seiðr* appear to have mainly functioned as seeresses. There is a long tradition in Germanic culture of women who are able to foretell the future or have visions.[6] This aspect of female Germanic religion might be associated with the first function of Indo-European religious practices especially since *seiðr* and its practices are related to Óðinn, and Óðinn is the Germanic epitome

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[5]See above chapter 4, pages 154-155 and 133; chapter 7, page 260; and chapter 6, page 223.

[6]See above chapter 3, pages 80-98.

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of the first function. The legal function might be indicated by some of the *matronae* names denoting oaths or places of court. The evidence relating these female figures to the legal/priestly function is meager.

Other than these tentative correlations, there is not a neat or comprehensive fit of the Germanic goddesses into Dumézil's pattern. That the Germanic goddesses reflect the ideal woman in society is arguable, but perhaps closer to the truth. The goddesses Nanna, who throws herself on Baldr's funeral pyre, and Sigyn,[7] who holds the bowl over Loki's head, both reflect the ideal woman who is beautiful, dutiful, and whose identity is centered on her husband. These two goddesses are only mentioned a few times in our sources and do not appear to be important parts of the religion. It is, however, difficult to see Freyja, Gerðr, Skaði, or Gefjun as the ideal woman in Germanic society. All are beautiful, but they all have strange ideas about marriage and men. Freyja is presented as married to a man who is always away. Even though she is married, she has sex with other men including her brother and all of the rest of the gods.[8] Gerðr has to be blackmailed with extreme torture before she will acquiesce and have sex with Freyr.[9] Skaði and her husband Njörðr can not agree on a place to live and eventually separate.[10] Gefjun is presented as a virgin, but we are

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[7]See above chapter 4, pages 155-156.

[8]See above chapter 3, pages 73-79.

[9]See above chapter 4, pages 147-154.

[10]See above chapter 4, pages 143-144.

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also told of her affair with a youth.[11] If anything, these goddesses present a picture of what a woman should not be or do.

If the Indo-European goddess fulfills all three functions, then she must be very powerful and play an instrumental role in Indo-European religious practices and iconography. Unfortunately, this does not seem to be the case. In fact, it is difficult to find female iconography or reconstruct a clear identity for a Proto-Indo-European goddess. The archaeological record of the Indo-Europeans, especially the Indo-Europeans of Northern Europe, does not show any particular traits, iconography, or ritual that indicates the worship of an all inclusive, powerful goddess.

Indo-European Culture

To prove or disprove Dumézil's supposition, a known and studied culture must be identified as Indo-European; and evidence of the worship of an all-inclusive goddess must be found. It is generally accepted that the Proto-Indo-Europeans had a pastoral economy with some mixed farming, used horses and wheeled vehicles, were organized in small petty kingdoms or chiefdoms, and had a kinship system based on patrilineal descent of identity and inheritance with patrilocal marriage where land, goods, and honors were passed down from father to son.

Battle Axe or Corded Ware Culture. In Northern Europe, the Battle Axe, Corded Ware, or Single Grave Culture; which is dated from about 2800 B.C.E., has

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[11]See above chapter 4, page 134.

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been identified as Indo-European.[12] The Corded Ware Culture encompassed the area of the Vistula, Elbe, and Oder river basins; modern Denmark; and the southern Swedish peninsula. See Map 5 for the location of the Corded Ware Culture.

The economic base of the Corded Ware Culture appears to have been pastoral with some mixed farming. Around 2800 B.C.E., large areas of forest were cleared to create permanent pastures and heathland. Pollen analysis shows that the main crop was barley. There are only a few known settlements. These settlements consist of clusters of three to four small houses, which is typical of a semi-nomadic pastoral lifestyle. The horse, wheeled vehicles, and trackways appear for the first time in Northern Europe with this culture.[13]

Burials occurred in a circular pit. A single person was usually placed in a wooden coffin and covered with grass or heath turf. Later burials were often added on top of an existing mound and then covered with a new layer, but the previous burials were always respected.[14] Burial goods for men usually consisted of battle axes and a beaker with an alcoholic drink. Burial goods for women were usually amber ornaments. According to the grave goods in the burials, twenty-five percent

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[12]Marija Gimbutas, *Civilization of the Goddess: The World of Old Europe* (HarperCollins Publishers: San Francisco 1991), pp. 392-393; and J.P. Mallory, *In Search of the Indo-Europeans*, p. 108.

[13]Kristian Kristiansen, "Ideology and Material Culture: An Archaeological Perspective," *Marxist Perspectives in Archaeology* ed. Matthew Spriggs (Cambridge University Press: New York, 1984), p. 82.

[14]ibid., pp. 82-83.

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MAP 5

LOCATION OF CORDED WARE CULTURE ABOUT 2800 B.C.E.



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of the burials are women. Kristiansen interprets the burial evidence as emphasizing the individual and his property. This emphasized the dead person's status in life and insured his status in the afterlife. After examining the economic base, the burials, and looking at ethnographic models; Kristiansen hypothesizes that the Corded Ware Culture's social system consisted of a "ranked system of competitive local lineages... the competitive and warlike nature of the system is shown by the 100s of battle axes in burials."[15] This culture is too early to be called Germanic, but it definitely appears to be Indo-European because of its economy, social structure, and burials.

Rock Art. The Corded Ware Culture is the culture responsible for the rock engravings of Southern Scandinavia. These engravings are located in several areas throughout Southern Scandinavia including Rogaland in West Norway; the area near Oslo in East Norway; Bohuslän in Western Sweden; Uppland, Norrköping, Småland, and the islands of Öland and Bornholm in Western Sweden; and the Danish island of Zealand.[16] Map 6 indicates where the rock engravings have been found.

These engravings are generally found on the faces of smooth, slightly sloping rocks that face arable land. The engravings rarely appear on vertical rock faces, and usually are close to the ground. Most of the engravings are in the open air, but a few are on the walls of burials. While many of the engravings are

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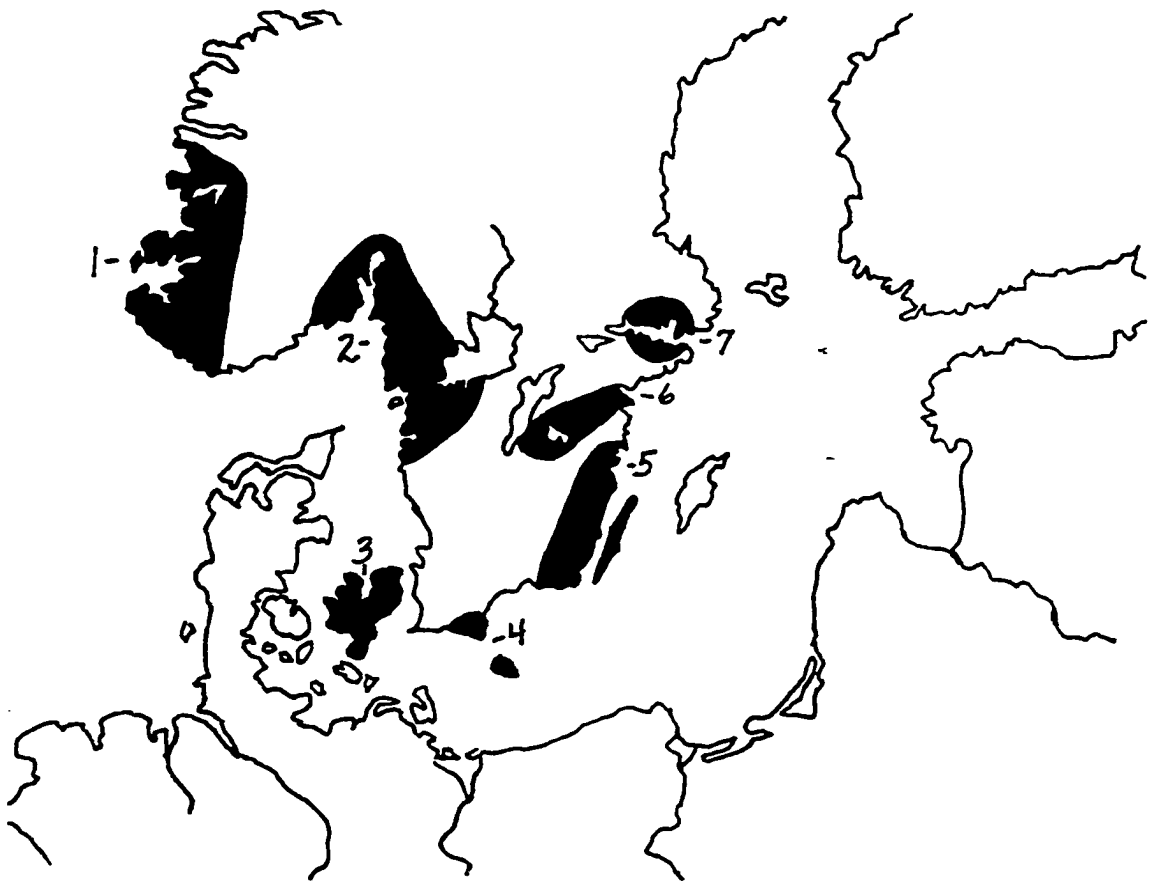
[15]ibid., p. 84.

[16]Peter Gelling and Hilda Ellis Davidson, *The Chariot of the Sun: and Other Rites and Symbols of the Northern Bronze Age* (Frederick A. Praeger, Publishers: New York, 1969), pp. 1-3.

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MAP 6

LOCATIONS OF BRONZE-AGE SCANDINAVIAN ROCK DRAWINGS



1. Rogaland, Norway
2. Oslo Area, Norway; Bohuslän, Sweden
3. Zealand, Denmark
4. Bornholm, Sweden
5. Småland & Öland, Sweden
6. Östergötland & Norrköping
7. Uppland & Enköping

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impossible to date, the engravings are generally dated to the Bronze Age due to the depiction of weapons in the engravings and similar weapon designs found in dated archaeological contexts. The engravings have been roughly dated between 1500-400 B.C.E.[17] These engravings are apparently depictions of deities, offerings to deities, ritual behavior, or incorporate all three functions. If goddesses were important in Indo-European religion, then they should at least be equally represented in the rock drawings as the male deities.

Gro Mandt[18] has analyzed these drawings for the presence of female deities and can only come up with tentative unsubstantiated theories. These drawings represent few figures that have obviously female attributes: breasts and vulva. Most of the human figures could be male or female. Many of the figures are obviously male and sport erect phalluses. There are several figures that are larger than the rest and are very well-endowed males. The few figures without phalluses and with apparently long hair have been interpreted as female, and they are usually a part of a scene apparently depicting sacred marriage. Many of these scenes take place on

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[17]ibid, pp. 3-8.

[18]Gro Mandt, "Searching for Female Deities in the Religious Manifestations of the Scandinavian Bronze Age," *Words and Objects: Towards a Dialogue Between Archaeology and History of Religion*, ed. Gro Steinsland (Norwegian University Press: New York, 1986), pp. 111 - 126. Peter Gelling documents a few cases where the "eye goddess" might be present in the Scandinavian rock engravings. *The Chariot of the Sun*, pp. 106-111.

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boats with several couples apparently copulating at once. These figures do not seem to represent deities, but they do appear to represent participants in ritual.

Mandt hypothesizes that the female deity was not depicted and that her presence was signified by the depiction of things related to her. Mandt suggests that the many pairs of foot prints, wagons, boats, and solar disks featured in the rock art might represent the female deity. All of these items could represent a female deity instead of a male deity as is usually suggested. Feet are not inherently male or female and obviously could signify one or the other. Mandt emphasizes Nerthus's relationship with wagons and Nehalennia's relationship to boats to support her arguments. Unfortunately, both Nerthus and Nehalennia are continental deities. The Scandinavian deity most associated with wagons is Freyr; with boats Njörðr. While Mandt's hypothesis might contain some truth, it is impossible to prove. There is not enough evidence to definitely decide if these items represent a male, female, or pan-sexual deity.

The cup marks that are ubiquitous throughout the rock drawings have often been interpreted as associated with female divinity. Some scholars have associated these cup marks with the vulva of the goddess, especially when they are present in the genital area of a figure.[19] Many of these cup marks appear either in groups or singly without apparently being part of a specific drawing. There is no way to date the cup marks; and they could be of Neolithic origin, modern origin, or anywhere in

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[19]ibid., p. 121.

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between. These cup marks remain inexplicable. They could simply be where ritual liquid was poured as an offering to a deity.

Since Norse religion was not codified and the rock art was drawn over an extended period of time by different people in different parts of Scandinavia, it is entirely possible that the same image meant different things to different people at different times in different places. One of the problems with attempting to interpret the rock art is our ignorance of ritual and myth during this period. In general, the drawings offer no overt representation of a female deity.

During the same approximate period as the rock art, female figurines were ritually deposited in bogs in Scandinavia. The figurines, which were described in detail in chapter one, have usually been interpreted by scholars as goddess figurines. (Figures 1-5) Their nude or nearly nude states, the way they touch or emphasize their breasts, and their usually enthroned positions all seem to emphasis their divinity. These figurines do suggest the worship of female deities.

The problem is then to equate the sacred offerings of the figurines with the sacred offerings of the rock art. One has an absence of goddess figures, and the other has an abundance. If the female deity could not be represented in human form then what are the figurines? Why do male figures dominate the rock art and female figures the ritual deposits? The answer may be that Indo-European male gods were sky oriented. The rock art was in places where the male sky gods could see and appreciate the offering. The female deities were associated with water and earth.

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The perfect place to leave an offering for a female deity would be a bog or lake. This might explain the dichotomy in the evidence.

It is possible that the female deity was worshiped or conceptualized in naturally deteriorating substances such as wood or was present in nature itself and did not need to be represented in any other way. Unfortunately, we only are left with what we physically have to interpret this culture. Based on the physical evidence, the goddesses of the Corded Ware Culture did not have much status in society in comparison to the male deities.

Indo-European Origins? The emphasis of the sexual organs of the female figurines and their deposition in wet places seems to associate these figurines with fertility. This would indicate that Indo-European female divinities were concerned with fertility and prosperity. The abundance of solar imagery of the rock art and comparison with other Indo-European cultures[20] suggest that the Germans also had a female solar deity. This role was filled by Gerðr. She lights up the sky and the world. Her name means "enclosure, protection" and may relate to the ring of fire around her.[21] Another possible solar deity is Perhte, whose name means "bright."[22] After examining the evidence for the Indo-European origins for the female divinities

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[20]Miriam Robbins Dexter, "Dawn-Maid and Sun-Maid: Celestial Goddesses among the Proto-Indo-Europeans," *The Indo-Europeanization of Northern Europe* eds. Karlene Jones-Bley and Martin E. Huld, pp. 228-246.

[21]See above chapter 4, pages 147-154.

[22]See above chapter 7, pages 229-233.

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in this study, I think that there is evidence for a female deity associated with earth and fertility and perhaps a female solar deity.

Old European Remnants

If the majority of the characteristics of the female figures presented in this study do not originate in Indo-European Culture, then it is possible that they originate from Old European Culture. The term Old European was coined by Marija Gimbutas; and it refers to the cultures extant in Europe before the Indo-European language, culture, and religion was introduced into Europe. Gimbutas's research on Old European culture, especially the cultures of Eastern Europe, indicates that the culture was agricultural, roughly egalitarian, peaceful, and probably matrilocal.[23] The religion of these cultures was dominated by a Great Goddess or Goddesses, who controlled all aspects of life and death. Although these cultures were concentrated in Southeastern Europe, especially in the Balkans, the migrations of the Indo-Europeans into Europe displaced these cultures. Some of these cultures migrated north and west to reform and evolve into different cultural groups. Map 7 indicates the geographic locations of these groups and their directions of migration.

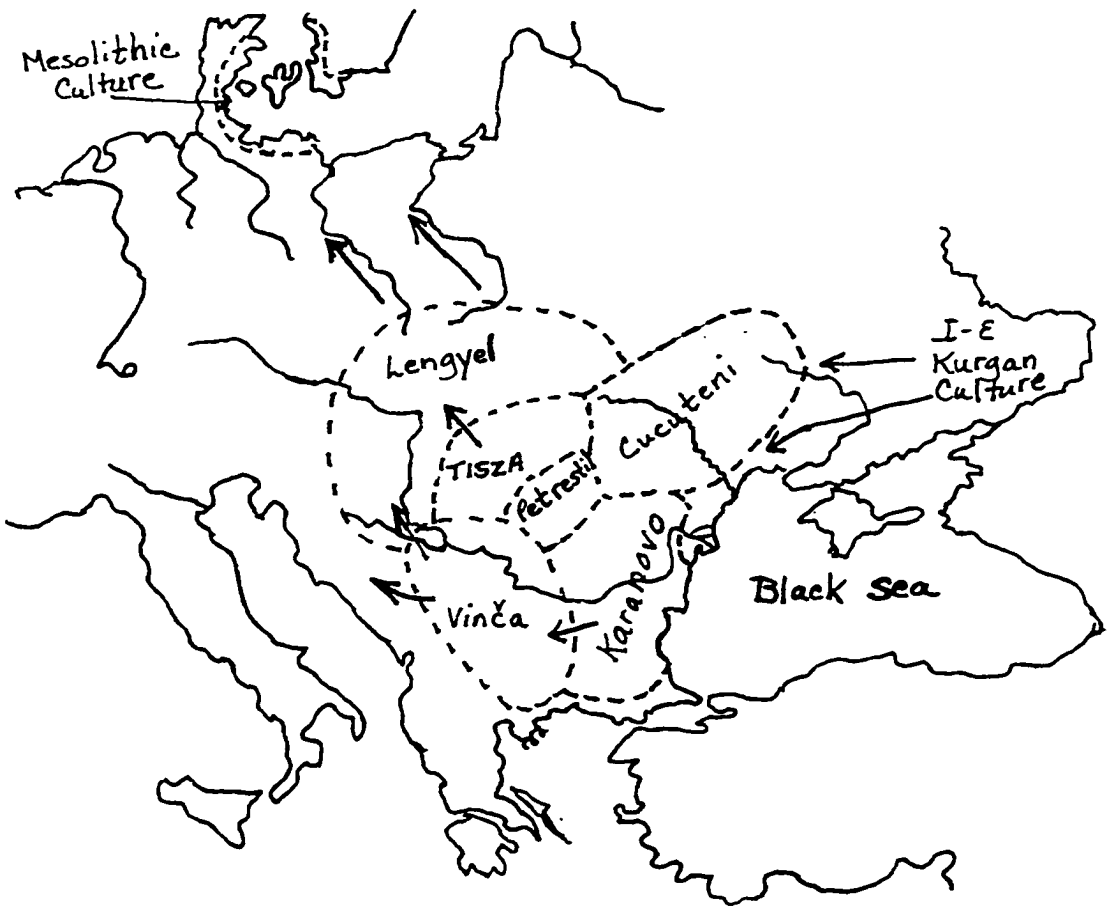
Old European Cultural Groups. The Karanovo Culture thrived between 5500-4500 B.C.E. in Thrace, Eastern Macedonia, Bulgaria, and Southern Romania. There is evidence for at least 1000 villages indicating a large population. Many

[23]Marija Gimbutas's conclusions are controversal.

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MAP 7

NEOLITHIC OLD EUROPEAN CULTURAL GROUPS
AND DIRECTION OF MIGRATIONS



After Marija Gimbutas, *The Civilization of the Goddess*, p. 53; and "The Beginning of the Bronze Age in Europe and the Indo-Europeans: 3500-2500 B.C." in *The Kurgan Culture and the Indo-Europeanization of Europe*, p. 138.

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settlement sites are tell sites which indicate that the settlements were used continuously for long periods of time. The Karanovo Culture is famous for its distinctive, beautifully ornamented, and finely made pottery.

The Cucuteni-Tripolye Culture was north and east of the Karanovo Culture. The Cucuteni-Tripolye Culture covered the area of modern Romania, Ukraine, and Moldova; and it dated from 4800-3500 B.C.E. This culture contained large, densely populated settlements. A frequent figurine from this culture had no head, but it did have a long neck. The slender torso was bent forward at about a 45 degree angle. This angling caused the massive buttocks to jut out in the back of the figurine. The legs are slender and together. At the shoulders are stubby projections that could either continue in arms or wings. The overall effect of the figurine's shape is reminiscent of a bird's body plan. (Figure 14)

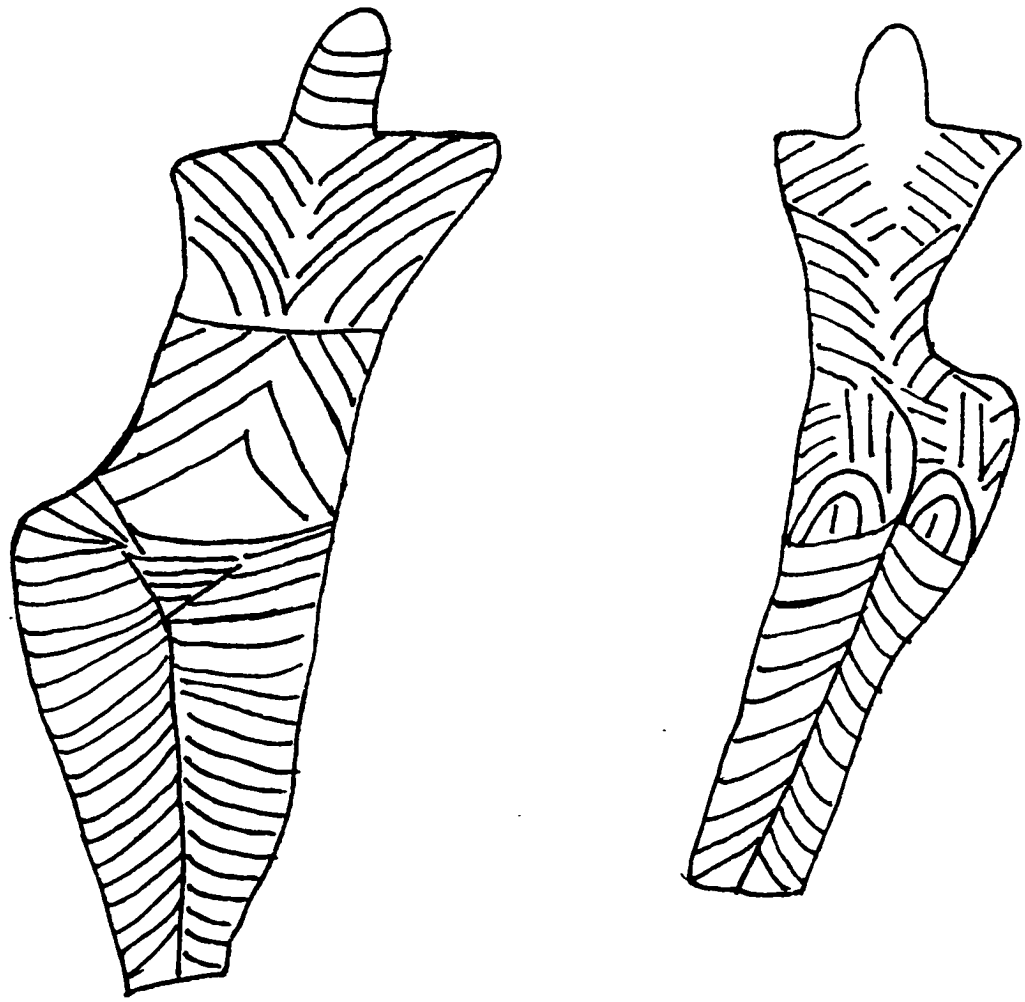
West of the Karanovo Culture in the Central Balkans including Moravia, the former Yugoslavia, and Albania; the Vinča Culture thrived from 5400-4300 B.C.E. Over 650 sites exist. The population of the settlement sites has been estimated between 200-2000 depending on the size of the site. Many of the sites are tell sites indicating long-term settlements.

The Vinča Culture is famous for its figurines. One type of figurine is half bird and half woman. It has a large nose or beak and no mouth. The eyes are large and shaped in a half circle. The face appears to be a triangular shaped mask because of the holes located near the sides of the face and the raised quality of the face. The

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FIGURE 14

NEOLITHIC BIRD-GODDESS FIGURINE
FROM THE CUCUTENI-TRIPOLYE CULTURE IN THE BALKANS



FRONT BACK

Source: Adapted from a photograph in Marija Gimbutas, *The Civilization of the Goddess*, see figure 3-72.

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figure has small breasts and stubby arms or wings jut out from its shoulders. The torso is slightly bent forward and its small buttocks protrudes in the back. Gimbutas calls this figure the Bird Goddess. (Figure 15)

North of the Vinča Culture and south of the Cucuteni-Tripolye Culture was the Tisza Culture. The Tisza Culture was located in the Tisza River basin northwest of the Transylvanian Alps in Hungary from 5400-4400 B.C.E. The settlement sites indicate long term use.

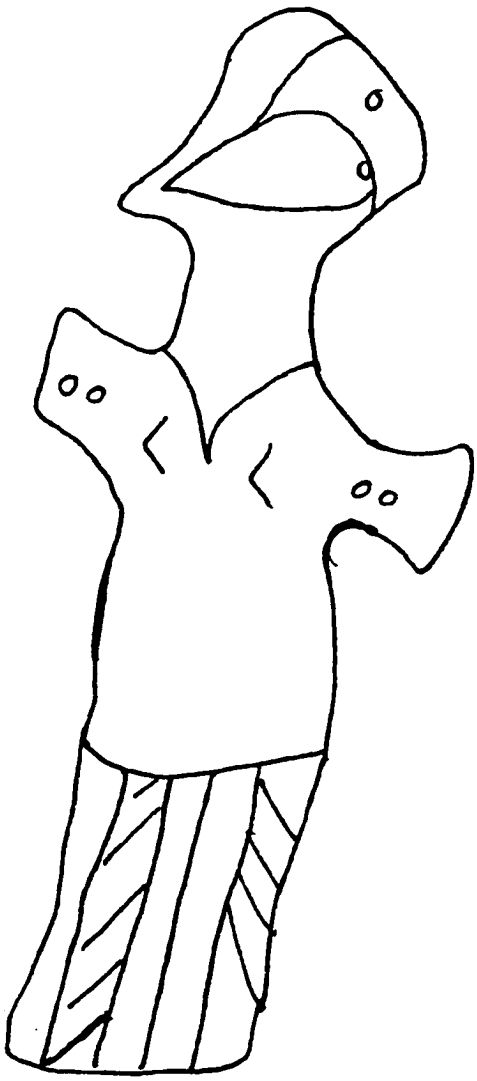
The Lengyel Culture was located North of the Vinča Culture, southwest of the Cucuteni-Tripolye Culture, and west of the Tisza Culture in the middle Danube basin in modern Hungary, Eastern Austria, Slovakia, Northwest Yugoslavia, Moravia, and Southern Poland from 5000-3900 B.C.E. The main housing style was trapezoidal long houses. The characteristic figurine of this culture was half bird and half woman. Its head was small and round and was dominated by a large pinched nose or beak. The slender torso had small breasts with stubs jutting upward from the shoulders as either arms or wings. The torso was bent slightly forward emphasizing the huge buttocks in the rear. (Figure 16)

The figurines from the Cucuteni-Tripolye Culture, the Vinča Culture, and the Lengyel Culture all appear to be of the same basic motif. They all appear to represent a half bird and half female figure. The shape of the body, the emphasis on the buttocks, and the position of the stubby arms or wings are all similar. The quantity of these figurines, their distribution across cultural lines, and the longevity

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FIGURE 15

NEOLITHIC BIRD-GODDESS FIGURINE
FROM THE VINČA CULTURE IN THE BALKANS

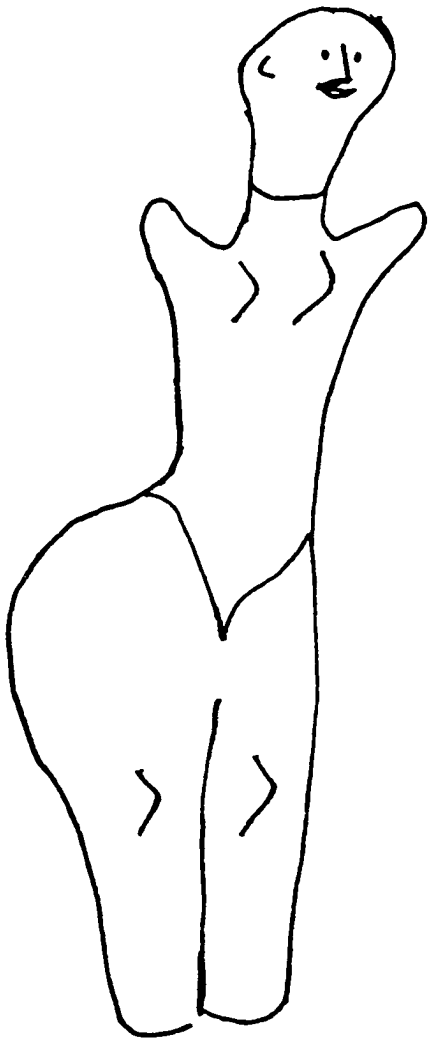


Source: Adapted from a photograph in Marija Gimbutas, *The Civilization of the Goddess*, see figure 3-19.

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FIGURE 16

NEOLITHIC BIRD-GODDESS FIGURINE
FROM THE LENGYEL CULTURE IN THE BALKANS



Source: Adapted from a photograph in Marija Gimbutas, *The Civilization of the Goddess*, see figure 3-37.

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of their production indicate a long and active belief in a goddess that is either half bird and half woman or in a goddess that can transform herself into a bird.[24] Gimbutas interprets this figure as the goddess in control of birth, death, and regeneration.[25] The idea of a half-bird/half-woman figure with special powers is familiar from the myths and fairy tales of Germanic Europe. How did a belief held in the Balkans in the Neolithic reach Northwestern Europe? The answer seems to be that these Balkan Neolithic cultures were destroyed and/or displaced by Late Neolithic and Bronze Age invaders from the East.

Gimbutas's Waves. Numerous places have been suggested as the homeland of the Proto-Indo-Europeans.[26] Marija Gimbutas places the homeland in the Eurasian Steppes between the Dnieper and Volga Rivers at about 4500 B.C.E. She identifies the Indo-Europeans with what she called the "Kurgan Culture."[27] This culture utilized horses and wheeled vehicles, had mainly a pastoral economy, and

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[24]Marija Gimbutas, *The Goddesses and Gods of Old Europe*, p. 142.

[25]Marija Gimbutas, *The Civilization of the Goddess*, pp. 230-248.

[26]Gimbutas's theory is not the only one to be taken seriously. Several other theories exist and have their proponents. The most prominent theories are by Colin Refrew, Igor Diakonov, and Thomas Gamkrelidze and Vjačeslav Ivanov. Refrew would place the homeland in early Neolithic Anatolia. Diakonov would place the homeland in the Balkans. Gamkrelidze and Ivanov would place the homeland in Armenia.

[27]For an overview of her theories, see Marija Gimbutas, *The Kurgan Culture and the Indo-Europeanization of Europe*. This volume shows the evolutions of her theories and contains all of her major papers on the subject.

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buried important men under huge mounds with expensive goods, animal sacrifices, and apparently human sacrifices.

Gimbutas hypothesized that different groups of Indo-European speaking groups infiltrated Europe in three successive waves. These bands sometimes displaced existing cultures, sometimes assimilated existing cultures, and sometimes annihilated the existing cultures. Each wave pushed Indo-European culture and language farther into the interior of Europe. The first wave took place about 4400-4300 B.C.E., the second wave took place about 3500 B.C.E., and the third wave took place about 3000-2800 B.C.E.

The first wave of Indo-Europeans is distinguishable from other cultures by the extensive use of the horse as a riding animal in iconography and in burials. Prior to the Indo-Europeans, the horse was unknown in Europe. The graves of the Indo-Europeans also differ from the graves of other neighboring populations. About 4500 B.C.E. the Dnieper-Donets Culture disappears and is replaced by an entirely different culture (Sredny Stog). This new culture appears to have Indo-European characteristics.[28] Evidence of the horse, typical Indo-European weapons, and burial practices continues to move westward in the next millennia.

Between 4500-4400 B.C.E., the Karanovo Culture disappears and remnants of the culture seem to appear in the west in caves in the Transylvanian Alps in

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[28]Marija Gimbutas, "Primary and Secondary Homeland of the Indo-Europeans: Comments on the Articles of Gamkrelidze-Ivanov Articles," *The Kurgan Culture*, p. 306; and J.P. Mallory, *In Search of the Indo-Europeans*, pp. 197-203.

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Romania and on islands in the Danube. This dislocation of the Karanovo Culture seems to set off a chain reaction in the Old European Cultural Area. The Vinča Culture moved into Western Hungary, Croatia, Bosnia, and Slavonia. After 4300 B.C.E., the cultural continuity of the Vinča Culture tells abruptly ends. The Lengyel Culture is thrust north and west along the Danube and into Poland, where its characteristic ceramic industry continued. In the place of long-term village settlement on river plains, hill forts were constructed on strategic high river banks along the Middle and Upper Danube Basin in Hungary, Austria, Western Slovakia, Moravia, Bohemia, and Bavaria.[29]

According to Sherratt between 4700-4000 B.C.E. the Lengyel Culture and the Rossen Culture encroached on and eventually fused with the Mesolithic Cultures of the North European Plain along the Vistula, Oder, and Elbe Rivers and in Jutland and Southern Sweden forming the Funnel-Necked Beaker Culture or TRB *(Trichterbecher)* Culture.[30]

Funnel-Necked Beaker Culture. The Funnel-Necked Beaker Culture's economy, like the economy of the Lengyel Culture, was based on wheat production. Fields were cleared and tilled using plows. Funnel-Necked Beaker Culture settlements, like the Mesolithic Culture settlements, were usually along waterways,

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[29]Marija Gimbutas, *The Civilization of the Goddess,* pp. 363-366.

[30]Andrew Sherratt, "The Genesis of Megaliths: Monumentality, Ethnicity and Social Complexity in Neolithic North-west Europe," *World Archaeology* 22 (June 1990) : 157-158.

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close to fields, and near good fishing. Settlements usually consisted of small communities of long houses or u-shaped huts.[31] Trapezoidal long houses were characteristic of the Lengyel Culture, and u-shaped huts were characteristic of the Mesolithic Culture. The melding of the characteristics of both cultures becomes the Funnel-Necked Beaker Culture. Map 8 indicates the location of these cultures.

Megalithic Monuments. The most interesting aspect of the Funnel-Necked Beaker Culture is the megalithic monuments. It has been estimated that 10,000 megaliths survive in the North European Plain and Scandinavia, and many more were probably destroyed over the centuries.[32] Megalithic monuments in several different styles were built by the Funnel-Necked Beaker Culture. Some of the monuments are timbered or stone earthen long barrows usually in a trapezoidal shape, others are long or round dolmens, and still others are passage graves. There seems to be a rough chronological order to these changes in monumental form; however, some forms coexist and sometimes the form of an existing monument was changed over time. These megalithic monuments sometimes contain single burials, multiple burials, or act as ossuaries or bone houses.[33]

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[31]Kristian Kristiansen, "Ideology and Material Culture: An Archaeological Perspective," *Marxist Perspectives in Archaeology* ed. Matthew Spriggs (Cambridge University Press: New York), p. 78.

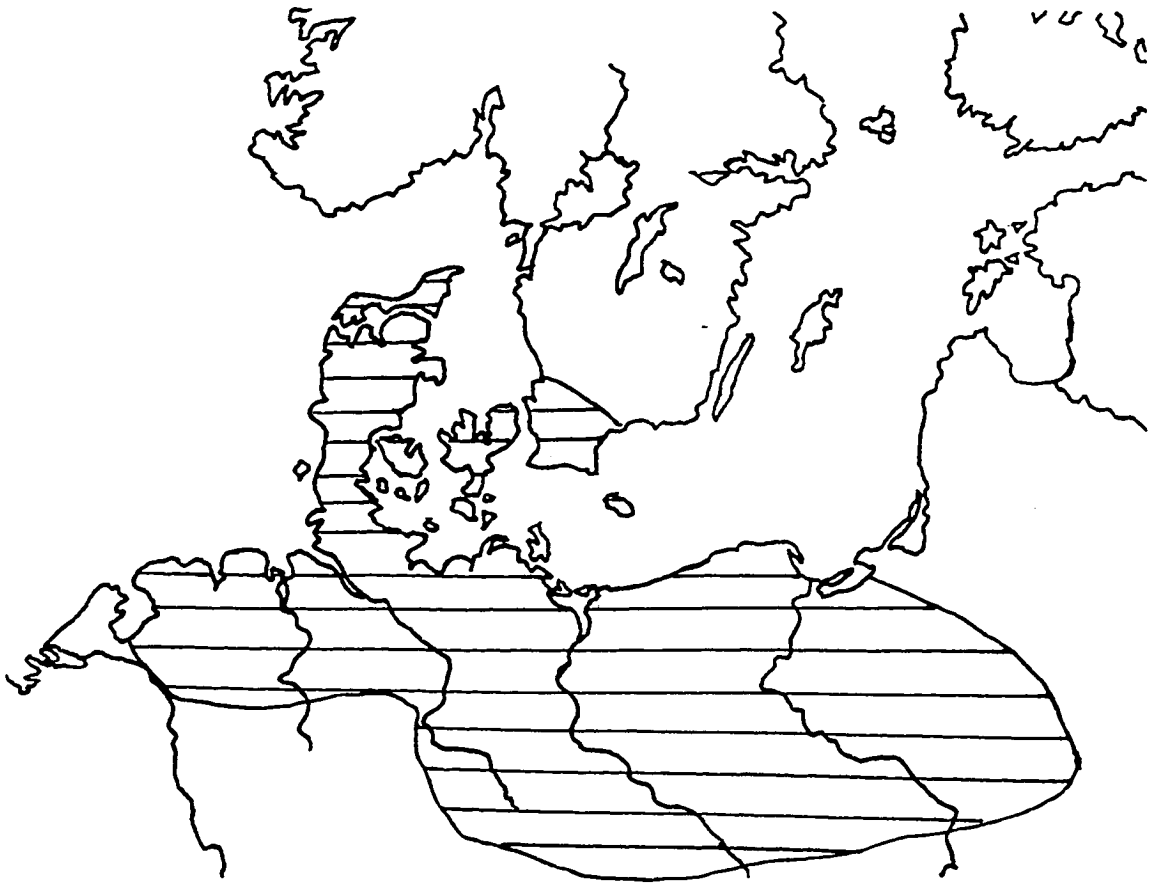
[32]Sherratt, pp. 164

[33]Kristian Kristiansen, "Ideology and Material Culture: An Archaeological Perspective," pp. 78-79; and Andrew Sherratt, "The Genesis of Megaliths: Monumentality, Ethnicity and Social Complexity in Neolithic North-West Europe,"

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MAP 8

LOCATION OF FUNNEL-NECKED BEAKER CULTURE
FOURTH MILLENIUM B.C.E.



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The earliest monuments appear to have been stone and earthen long barrows that were trapezoidal in shape. These would have mimicked the traditional house style of the newly migrated Lengyel Culture. These huge monuments in the shape of traditional Lengyel Culture houses would have been a statement of power, permanence, and community to the new immigrants and natives alike. Overtime, the expression of cultural identity of the new invading culture became less necessary and the Mesolithic native culture expressed its own preferences in the rounding of these monuments into dolmens and eventually passage graves which reflected their own u-shaped huts.[34]

The best guess for the purpose of these monuments is that they are an expression of community and a permanent place of ritual. They expressed the ownership or control of a section of land, the right of possession through the expression of monumentalilty, an ancestral continuity, and probably a closeness to divinity. Like the great cathedrals of the Middle Ages, these monuments simultaneously expressed the wealth, piety, and continuity between the past and future in a community.[35]

There were probably never many people buried in these monuments. At most, one burial a generation was made. The early long barrows and the dolmens

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World Archaeology, 1990, v. 22, p. 150.

[34]Sherratt, pp. 147-167.

[35]Sherratt, pp. 148-149 and Kristiansen, pp. 80-81.

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often seem to contain burials of individual family units.[36] The later passage graves were usually ossuaries where the bones of the deceased were stored. The grave goods accompanying the dead in dolmens and passage graves were pots, flint axes, and occasionally battle axes and amber.[37] The people buried in these monuments were probably considered important ancestors of a leading lineage, the village, or the larger community.

Old European Origins? The Funnel-Necked Beaker Culture was assimilated into the Globular Amphora Culture (3400-3200 B.C.E.) in the East, but it continued in the West until the invasions of the Corded Ware Culture c.2800 B.C.E. The invasions of the Corded Ware Culture encompassed the areas of the Globular Amphora Culture and the Funnel-Necked Beaker Culture. As mentioned above, the Corded Ware Culture was almost certainly an Indo-European Culture.[38]

A simplified chronology of the migrations, invasions, and merging of cultures can be found in TABLE 6. The Old European cultures of Southeastern

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[36]Kristiansen, pp.79

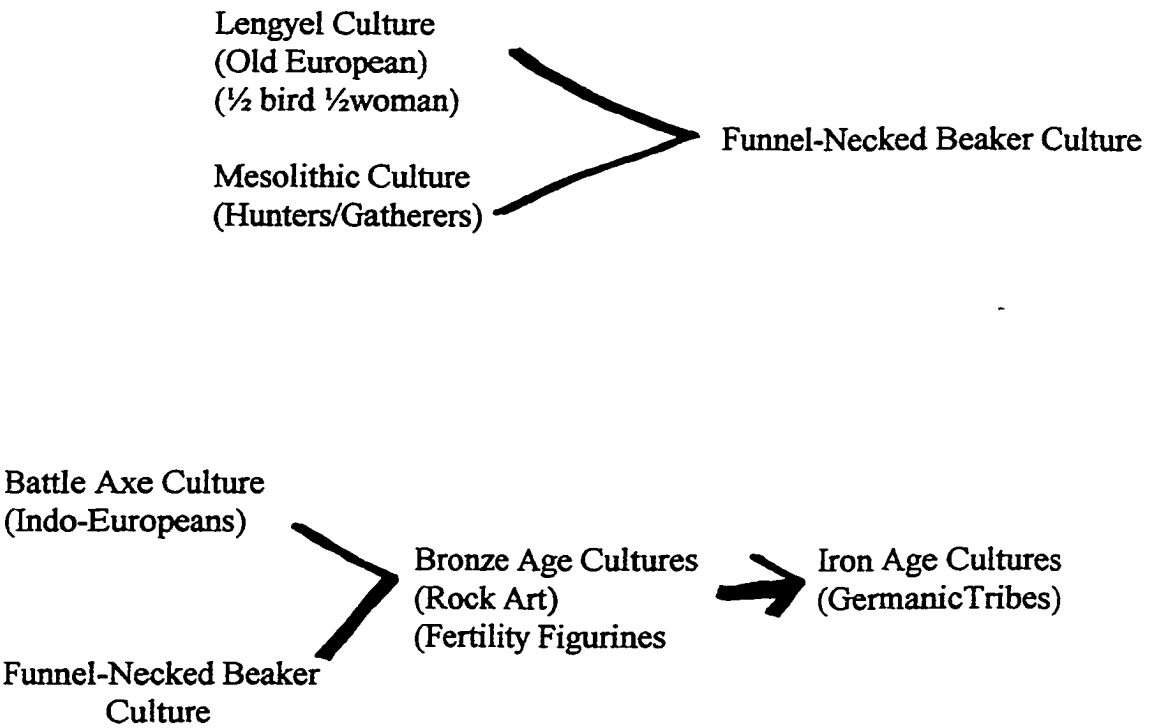
[37]Kristiansen, pp. 79

[38]The origin of the Corded Ware Culture is hotly debated. Mallory, pp. 247-248 isolates four different viewpoints. Ulrich Fischer, Alexander Häusler, and Karl Jazdzewski prefer a western origin between the Rhine and the Vistula. Dmitry Kraynov, Raisa Denisova, and Miroslav Buchvaldek prefer an origin between the Vistula and the Dnieper. Ivan Artemenko, I.K. Sveshnikov, V.P. Tretyakov, Sofia Berezankaya, and N. Bondar prefer an origin in the Middle Dnieper region. Gustav Rosenberg, P.V. Glob, Karl Struve, Marija Gimbutas, Alexander Bryusov, and Valentin Danilenko prefer a steppe origin.

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TABLE 6

SIMPLIFIED TIME LINES



Source: Primary

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Europe had a female-oriented religion including portrayal of a half bird-half woman being who was apparently associated with death. When bands of Indo-Europeans invaded Southeastern Europe, some remnants of the Old European cultures migrated. The Lengyel Culture migrated north and west up the Danube River into Poland and Northern Germany. In this area, the Lengyel Culture met and gradually assimilated with the native Mesolithic Culture. The merging of the Lengyel and the Mesolithic cultures is called the Funnel-Necked Beaker Culture.

The Funnel-Necked Beaker Culture spread through Southern Scandinavia and Northern Germany. In Poland, the Globular Amphora Culture invaded and overtook the Funnel-Necked Beaker Culture. In the West, the Funnel-Necked Beaker Culture continued until the invasions of the Corded Ware Culture.[39] The Corded Ware Culture apparently assimilated the people of the Funnel-Necked Beaker Culture as an underclass while the Corded Ware Culture ruled. There were no other significant invasions or migrations into Northern Europe after the Corded Ware Culture.

Some beliefs of the Lengyel Culture must have survived into the time of the Corded Ware Culture. Even though the Lengyel Culture migrated and merged with the Mesolithic Culture, several aspects of the Lengyel Culture are evident in the

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[39]Kristian Kristiansen, "Prehistoric Migrations - the Case of the Single Grave and Corded Ware Cultures," *Journal of Danish Archaeology* 8 (1989) pp. 211-225. Kristiansen presents a summary of the arguments for and against the migration of the Single Grave Culture into Denmark. He interprets the evidence as being in favor of migration.

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many similarities between the Lengyel Culture and the succeeding Funnel-Necked Beaker Culture. The later Corded Ware invaders seem to have formed an aristocratic ruling class on top of the native Funnel-Necked Beaker Culture. Slowly the economy, social structure, and religion changed and was reordered more along the lines of the Corded Ware Culture.

It is certainly possible that some religious beliefs, especially those concerned with important life functions, survived from the Lengyel Culture into the Bronze Age and beyond. While there are no half bird-half woman figurines after the displacement of the Lengyel Culture in c. 3500 B.C.E., the survival of myths, rituals, and stories is possible.

It is possible that the myths, stories, and rituals inherent in the long lasting and wide-spread tradition of a half bird-half female being who is portrayed in the Neolithic figurines of Southeast Europe survived the dissolution and migration of the Lengyel Culture into Northern Europe and the subsequent reordering of cultures until modern times. One reason for the possible continuance of tradition for several millennia is that this being was considered necessary for the health, welfare, or continuance of the family, clan, or tribe.

Since in Germanic myth, these figures seem to be linked with death and rebirth, the conservative nature of the traditions may be the prime reason for the longevity of the tradition. While the continuance of tradition through millennia is

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possible, five to six thousand years is a long time for sustained belief and tradition without any outside reinforcement of belief.

Celtic Influence

The female figures presented in this study could have originated in a neighboring culture and be a borrowing. The culture in the closest and most continuous contact with the Germans was the Celts. The Germans and Celts were neighbors for at least a thousand years. Like Germanic, Celtic is an Indo-European language, and Celts have an Indo-European culture. On this basis alone, there are many similarities in Germanic and Celtic culture, religion, and language.

The emergence of the Proto-Germanic language is usually assigned to the Jastorf Culture (600-300 B.C.E.) of the Northern Iron Age.[40] The Jastorf Culture extended approximately from the Weser River in the west to the Oder river in the east. This encompassed the areas of Jutland, the Danish Islands, Schleswig-Holstein, Mecklenburg, Western Pomerania, and portions of Brandenburg and Lower Saxony. This area appears to have been undisturbed by outside immigration or invasions since the arrival of the Battle Axe Culture in the Late Neolithic. While the ancestors of the people who spoke Proto-Germanic probably lived in the same

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[40]E.C. Polomé, "Who are the Germanic People?" *Proto-Indo-European: The Archaeology of a Linguistic Problem*, S. Skomal and E. Polomé (eds.), (Washington, D.C.: The Institute for the Study of Man, 1987), pp. 219-220.

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general area for about 2000 years, the time depth is too great to call the Battle Axe Culture "Proto-Germanic."

The emergence of Proto-Celtic is assigned to the La Tène Culture (450-370 B.C.E.) of the Central European Iron Age. The La Tène Culture stretched approximately from the Marne river to Bohemia. This same area and the area to the south of it was occupied by the Hallstatt Culture (750-450 B.C.E.) in the Early Iron Age. There is clearly cultural continuity from the Hallstatt Period through the La Tène Period.[41] The time depth of the Hallstatt culture is too great to call it Proto-Celtic, but it is definitely Indo-European. Map 9 indicates the postions of the Celtic and Germanic cultures.

The Jastorf Culture of the Proto-Germanic speakers and the late Hallstatt Culture and the subsequent La Tène Culture of Proto-Celtic speakers were concurrent. The La Tène Culture was more advanced than the Jastorf Culture, and aspects of the La Tène Culture were probably imitated and assimilated into the Jastorf and later Germanic Iron Age Cultures. The ancestors of the Proto-Germanic and Proto-Celtic languages lived near each other and intermingled for at least a thousand years. After the La Tène and Jastorf Cultures these peoples would be intermixed in the Germanic Migrations and Invasions that pushed the Germanic

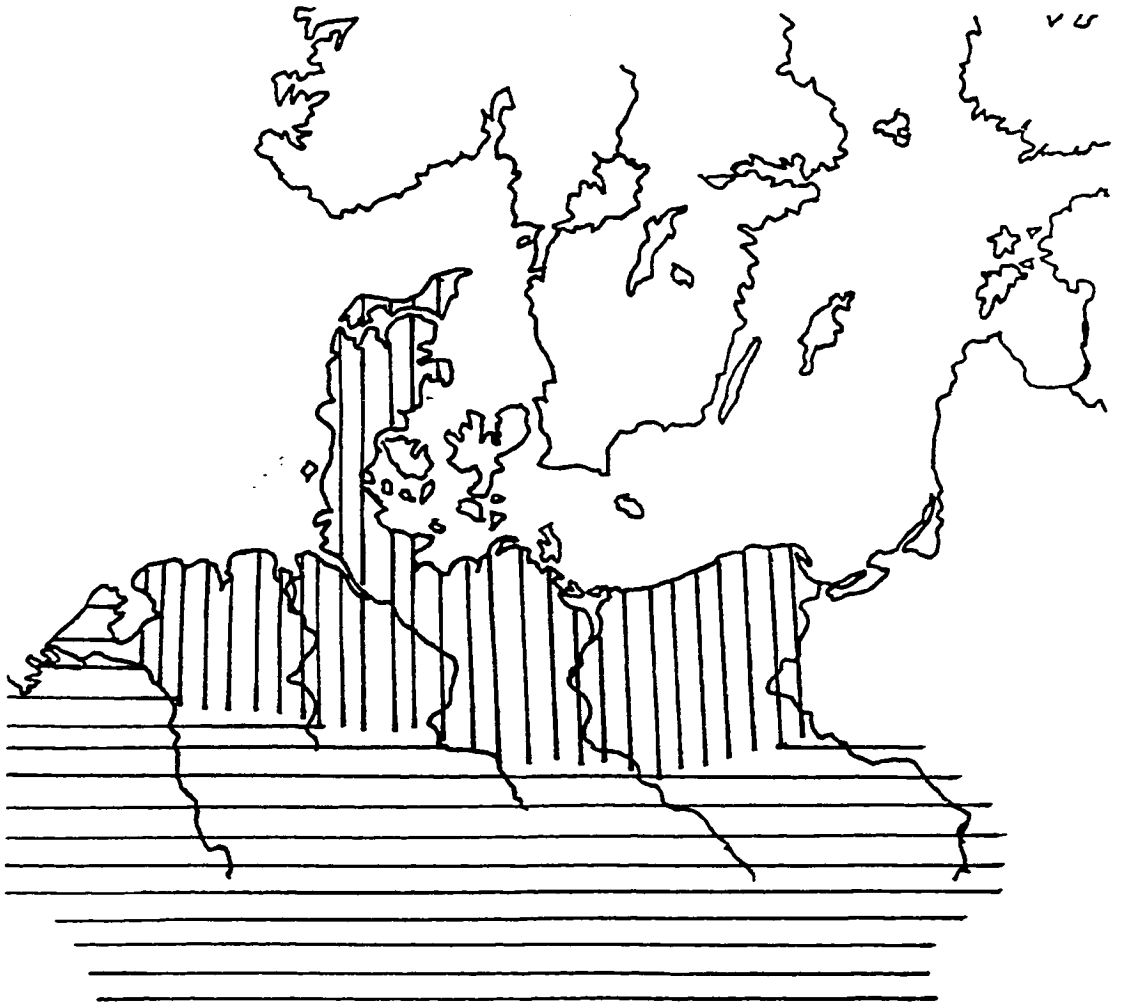
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[41]Barry Cunliffe, *The Ancient Celts* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1997), pp. 63-64.

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MAP 9

APPROXIMATE LOCATIONS OF PROTO-GERMANIC
AND PROTO-CELTIC SPEAKING CULTURES



Proto-Germanic Area is lined vertically, and Proto-Celtic is lined horizontally.

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tribes up to and into the Roman Empire in the Late Iron Age. Along the way, the Germans assimilated several Celtic speaking areas.

Cultural Intermingling. The origin of the female figures discussed in this paper might be found in the influence of the Celtic tribes on their Germanic neighbors. The Germanic and Celtic tribes lived near each other, traded among one another, intermarried, and fought each other for centuries. The Germanic and Celtic peoples probably had a great deal of contact between each other especially during the Iron Age. It must be remembered that no national borders between states or tribes existed. A tribal chief or war band leader had a fluctuating sphere of influence which expanded and retracted depending on the strength of his army, the strength of neighboring chiefs, the availability of plunder, and the charisma of the leader.

The Germanic and Celtic tribes living on the cultural fringes would have had constant contact with each other. The southern parts of Europe including France, Switzerland, Austria, and Northern Italy would have been predominately Celtic in speech and culture. The northern parts of Europe including Southern Sweden, Denmark, Poland, and Northern Germany would have been predominately Germanic in speech and culture. The area in between including the Netherlands, Belgium, and Southern and Central Germany would have been a vast intercultural zone.

This area might be compared to modern Northern Mexico and the Southwest United States. Both English and Spanish are spoken or at least understood by the majority of people in both areas. Workers from both cultures work alongside or for

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people of both cultures. They eat each other's food, celebrate each other's holidays, and marry each other's children. Most of the United States is white and speaks only English. Most of Mexico is Hispanic and speaks only Spanish, but in Northern Mexico and the Southwestern United States the population is more balanced between the two peoples.

In Central Europe, the Celtic and Germanic peoples would have traded luxury goods. One example is the Gunderstrup Cauldron, which was found in a Danish peat bog but has Celtic pictorial details.[42] The Germanic and Celtic peoples would have raided each other's settlements. They would have stolen goods, cattle, horses, and women. These goods and slaves would have been sold or traded again and again further spreading the other's cultural influence. The Celtic and Germanic peoples would have intermarried. For millennia, women have been used to form peaceful alliances between two warring tribes, areas, or settlements. Through this trading, raiding, enslavement, and intermarriage the opposite culture's mores, rites, religion, and characteristics would have been haphazardly adopted by each culture.

Contemporary sources had a difficult time distinguishing between tribes of Celtic and Germanic descent, and modern scholars have not had it any easier. Scholars still argue over the cultural background of the Macromanni, the Cimbi, the

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[42]Barry Cunliffe, *The Ancient Celts*, p. 125. The Gunderstrup cauldron has distinctive Celtic pictorial details and distinctive Thracian craftsmanship. It is possible that it was a gift to a Celtic king from a Thracian king, it was a symbol of lasting friendship between the two peoples, or it could have been made by a Thracian craftsman for a Celtic patron.

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Chatti, the Ubi, and other lesser known tribes.[43] The difficulty in distinguishing between the two peoples probably is due to this cultural intermingling. To add to the problem of distinguishing between the two peoples, the Germanic tribes overran the Celtic tribes in Southern Europe and Germanized them in the *Völkerwanderung*.

Similarities Between Germanic and Celtic Female Figures. From the Germanic evidence, three main characteristics of the female figures stand out: their ability to transform into birds; their connections with death; and their connections with sexuality, fertility, and prosperity. Female figures from Celtic mythology and folklore also have these same qualities. The names and the exact functions of these figures in the stories are different in the Germanic and Celtic traditions; however, the basic characteristics or qualities of the female figures are very similar.

Many Germanic female figures had a "feather coat" or "swan skin" that allowed them to transform themselves into a bird. Other female figures were able in times of imminent death to transform themselves into birds. This tradition lasted from at least the Middle Ages and perhaps from the Neolithic into the nineteenth century. The longevity of this tradition speaks for its importance to and in the culture.

In the Celtic tradition, some female beings are transformed into birds as a punitive measure or are enchanted by others and are unable to transform themselves

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[43]Colin Wells, "Celts and Germans in the Rhineland", in ed. Miranda Green, *The Celtic World* (Rutledge: New York 1996), pp. 603-620.

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back into human form. In the *Tale of Math*, Blodeuedd is created from blossoms of different plants specifically to be the wife of Lleu, who is a god. After the marriage, Blodeuedd plots with her lover Goronwy to kill Lleu, her husband. As Lleu is killed, he transforms himself into an eagle. Lleu as an eagle seeks revenge, and he urges his relatives to seek compensation. Goronwy is killed, but Blodeuedd can not be killed because she is not human. Her punishment for plotting Lleu's death is transformation into an owl. She must live and hunt only at night and be shunned by all the other birds.[44]

In the "Dream of Oengus", the god Óengus falls in love with a mortal woman named Caer. Caer has been enchanted with a shape-shifting spell which alternately transforms her into a swan and back into human form every other year on the Feast of Samhain (31 October and 1 November). Óengus asks her father for Caer's hand in marriage, but he is refused. To be with Caer, Óengus transforms himself into a swan, and Caer and Óengus fly off together.[45] In both of these stories a wife of a divinity is transformed into an avian form without her permission. In both stories, the male divinity willing transforms himself into avian form for survival or for love.

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[44]*The Mabinogion*, trans. Jeffrey Gantz, (New York: Penguin Books, 1976), pp. 111-116.

[45]*Early Irish Myths and Sagas*, trans. Jeffrey Gantz, (New York: Penguin Book, 1981), pp. 108-112.

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In the *Book of Taliesin*, Ceridwen was a sorceress and the keeper of the Cauldron of Inspiration and Knowledge. While she was brewing a potion to make her son wise, she had a young boy, named Gwion, watch over the boiling cauldron. A drop of the potion splashed on Gwion, and he licked it off. This gave all the wisdom to Gwion and not to Ceridwen's son. Ceridwen was furious and chased Gwion. During the chase Ceridwen transformed herself and Gwion subsequently into a greyhound and a hare, an otter and a fish, hawk and a bird, and finally a hen and a grain of corn. As a hen, Ceridwen swallowed Gwion; and nine months later, Gwion was reborn. In this story, the goddess figure is able to kill and bring about the rebirth of an enemy by transforming herself into a bird.[46]

In many Celtic myths, female beings are mentioned in connection with battles. The figures mentioned the most often are the Morrigán, who can be either an individual or a triad; Badbh; Macha; and Nemhain. Like the Valkyries of Germanic myth, these female figures support a warrior or an army on the battlefield. They often appear on a battlefield as carrion birds: crows and ravens.[47] These birds pick the flesh of the dead after the battle is over. Cormac, a ninth-century commentator, glosses Macha as "crow," and Badbh's name frequently appears as

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[46]Miranda Green, *Celtic Goddesses: Warriors, Virgins and Mothers* (George Braziller: New York, New York 1996), p. 68.

[47]Miranda Green, *Celtic Goddesses: Warriors, Virgins and Mothers*, p. 42.

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Badbh Catha meaning "Battle Crow".[48] These figures appear at battles as carrion birds and either support or terrify one side or the other during a battle. These figures appear to be capricious by nature and change sides at will. In the Ulster Cycle, the Morrigán incited both Ulster and Connacht to war by leading each side to believe that it would be the victor.

There are many instances when divine female figures are associated with birds. In *The Mabinogion* in "The Tale of Branwen" and in "The Tale of Culhwch and Olwen", Rhiannon is said to have birds that "wake the dead and lull the living."[49] Cliodna, the goddess of the Irish Happy Otherworld, is associated with three brightly colored birds. After her affair with the mortal Tadg, Cliodna lent him her birds to soothe and comfort him when he left her and her realm.[50] In these stories, the divine figure does not transform herself into avian form, but birds associated with her have the healing and tranquilent effect of the divine figure herself.

Like the Germanic women who transform themselves into birds, these Celtic women also have some connections with death. The Morrigán, Badbh, and Macha can transform themselves into birds, and they are battle deities who decide which side will win. Inherent in this decision is who will die. The battle deities are

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[48]ibid., p. 43.

[49]*The Mabinogion*, trans. Jeffery Gantz, pp. 79-82 and 156.

[50]Miranda Green, *Celtic Goddesses*, p. 87.

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represented by scavenger, corpse-picking birds whose presence on the battlefield denotes death. Blodeuedd avoids death in her transformation into an owl.

The duality of avian and female human form exists in both the Germanic and Celtic traditions. The collaboration between powerful female figures, death, and birds is not as prominent in Celtic myth and folklore as it is in Germanic myth and folklore. The emphasis on death in the Germanic tradition might be inherent in the darker Germanic world view.

There is a strong connection between sexuality, fertility, prosperity, and the land itself in Celtic myth and folklore. The divine female figures such as Mebd seem almost to be the humanized portrayal of the land or kingdom. This figure takes a succession of lovers or husbands. Each male becomes king and his rule is legitimatized by marriage and sexual relations with this female figure. While the men grow old, she can be either young and beautiful or a total hag. This divine female chooses the best man for the land, country, or kingdom. She rejects and casts off men that become weak or indicate an inherent character flaw. The sexuality of this female figure and her sexual union with the king apparently has a direct collaboration with the fertility and prosperity of the land.[51] While there are faint hints in Germanic myth of the connection between female sexuality and the prosperity of the land, there is not the blatant portrayal of it as there is in Celtic myth.

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[51]ibid., p. 73.

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In the Celtic tradition, some women are transformed or transform themselves into birds. There is some connection between powerful females and death, and there is a strong connection between powerful females and the fertility and prosperity of the land. Many Celtic myths are centered around powerful women and goddesses while in Germanic myth, women and goddesses are on the periphery of the action. It is possible that during the centuries of trade, raids, and intermarriage, some of the stories and traditions of the Celtic goddesses were transferred to their Germanic counterparts.

Summary

The female figures presented in this study originated from both Indo-European and Old European cultures. Since Germanic culture is unique because of its own blend of Indo-European and substrate influences, this fact should not be startling. What is startling is the continuity of form of these figures from the Neolithic into the modern era.

Some of the Neolithic figurines from the Old European cultures such as Cucuteni-Tripolye, Vinča, and Lengyel had bird-like posture and features. (Figures 14-16) Gimbutas has studied these figures and has hypothesized that they functioned in the context of death and regeneration. The Norse figures such as Freyja, the Valkyries, and the giantess Margerð have avian characteristics. Freyja and the Valkyries can transform into birds by wearing feather garments. The giantess

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Margerð has an iron nose and claws that give her a bird-like appearance. Freyja and the Valkyries both have an intimate connection with death. Freyja chooses half the slain each day and the Valkyries decide who dies when on the battle field. In more modern times, the German folklore figure of Perhte/Holle has an iron nose that sounds suspiciously like a beak, and in some processions, she takes the form of a bird. The Perhte/Holle figure also flies through the night with a band of dead, unbaptized children. These dead children give her a connection with death. The Perhte/Holle figure sometimes kills people not protected by Christianity. Perhte/Holle's association with the non-Christian dead make her a pagan goddess of death. Perhte/Holle also keeps unborn children and gives them to women who perform certain rites. These connections with dead children, unborn children, and the birth of children associate the Perhte/Holle figure with the complex of death and rebirth.

In German *Märchen*, other women who have definite avian characteristics are presented. In "The Drummer", the enchanted princess has a blouse that turns her into a bird. In "Fitcher's Bird", the third sister transforms herself into a bird by rolling in honey and feathers. The third sister in "Fitcher's Bird" is also connected to death and regeneration because she resurrects her butchered sisters and is the catalyst for the deaths of the evil wizard and all of the wedding guests. In "The Three Little Men in the Wood" and "The White Bride and the Black Bride", the queen transforms herself into a bird before or as she drowns. She can not be

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transformed back into a human female until her husband either beheads her bird form or symbolically beheads her by waving his sword over her head. All of these figures are transformed into birds, and all but the princess in "The Drummer" have connections with death and rebirth.

The startling similarity of belief in form and function of these figures from the Neolithic to the modern era is striking. These figures appear to have basically the same form and function for over 6000 years. The question is how can this happen. How can the archaeological finds of the Neolithic Balkans be similar to Medieval Norse myths and modern German folklore. The answer seems to lie in the migration of peoples and in the conservation of belief.

The Old European cultures were invaded and displaced by other peoples whose culture was Indo-European. The displaced Old European cultures fled to the west and displaced other Old European cultures. The Lengyel Culture was displaced from the Middle Danube Basin and moved north and west along the Danube into Poland between 4300-4200 B.C.E. In Poland, the Lengyel Culture encroached on and eventually fused with the Mesolithic Cultures of the Northern European Plain . The fusing of these two cultures formed the Funnel-Necked Beaker Culture which stretched from the Vistula to Jutland by about 4000 B.C.E. About 2800 B.C.E., the Corded Ware Culture invaded and took over the area of the Funnel-Necked Beaker Culture.

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The Corded Ware Culture had many Indo-European characteristics. Indo-European religion emphasizes male sky gods, and their predominance can be seen in the Scandinavian rock art of the Bronze Age. While female deities do not appear in the rock engravings, figurines of female deities were deposited in bogs and watery places by this culture. The Corded Ware Culture developed into the Iron Age Germanic cultures without further outside invasions.

This longevity of belief from the Neolithic into modern times might be due to the characteristics of these female beings. Their connections with death and regeneration would have made their incorporation into each new cultural manifestation a priority. Symbolically these figures were important for the continuation of agricultural and human life. The form and function of these figures were probably reinforced by the proximity of Celtic Culture which inherited many of the same characteristic deities from the same Old European Cultures. Through cultural necessity and reinforcement from the outside, these figures were able to maintain the basically unchanged for 6000 years.

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